

PEACE, WE CAN AVOID IT

Investigation into the birth of the Alliance of Sahel States

BEN-H2O

— 2026 —

Contents

Foreword — Method, sources and limits	15
The rule of the confirming adversary	15
The framing of sources	15
Vocabulary	16
Limits	16
Prologue — The villa in Niamey	17
Introduction — Why the AES changes everything	19
What the AES is — and is not	19
What this book covers — and how	20
PART I — AFRICA BEFORE DOMINATION	20
Chapter 1 — The great empires	23
The founding lie	23
Wagadou, the first giant	23
The Mali of Sundiata and Mansa Musa	24
Songhai, Bornu, Sokoto: the continuity	24
The great precolonial states of the Sahel	25
Neither a lost paradise nor a blank page	25
Chapter 2 — The civilizations of the Sahel	26
Timbuktu, the library-city	26
The Manden Charter: rights proclaimed in 1236	27
What the Sahel produced	27
Herodotus, Diop, and proof by convergence	27
Chapter 3 — The colonial conquest	29
A surgical operation on the African body	29
The rules of the game: "effective occupation"	30

Berlin, 1884–1885	31
The micro-state trap	31
The OCRS law and the case of Sahelian resources	31
Before Berlin, after Berlin	32
The letter of September 13, 1898	32
Chapter 4 — The forgotten resistances	34
Sixteen years against France	34
Those who said no	34
Figures of Sahelian resistance	35
A resistance that never dies out	35
Thiaroye, December 1, 1944: a crime without truth	36
The double erasure	37
The industrial imbalance — the sole reason for defeat	38
PART II — HOW DEPENDENCY WAS ORGANIZED	38
Chapter 5 — 1960: the unfinished independences	41
The man in the shadows	41
The country that said no	42
The fate of the pioneers	42
Independence and its outcome, sixty years on	43
”Bleached” independences	43
Chapter 6 — The neocolonial pact	45
A fiscal birth	45
Monopoly as principle	46
The ”new empires”: privatization as a second colonization	47
The chain of plunder, told by its own links	48
The circuit of plunder	49
When the adversary confesses	49
Chapter 7 — The CFA franc	51

The operations account, or sovereignty in escrow	51
The operations account, plainly stated	52
The price of leaving	52
The inconvenient counter-examples	53
The trial by presumed incapacity	54
A weapon that stays loaded	55
What a French report confirms, despite itself	56
The CFA franc, a zero-cost instrument for financing terrorism	57
The currency of predation	57
Unemployment as a recruiting room	57
The weak link	58
The solution: mint your own currency	58
Chapter 8 — Strategic resources: contractualized plunder	60
The absolute paradox: uranium	60
Niger: the anatomy of a paradox	62
What French diversification reveals — and does not reveal	64
The invisible cost: radioactive water and darkness	64
The multinationals were financing terrorists	64
The DGSE in the loop — is the French state an innocent bystander?	65
Intelligence agents under commercial cover	66
Diplomatic status as a shield	66
Mali's gold: the renegotiation that sets precedent	67
Oil: 60-30-10	67
The accounting mechanisms of plunder	67
The rupture — proof by the numbers	68
What the plunder reveals	68
Chapter 9 — Aid, debt, the financial assassins, and the FATF	70
Odious debt: a legal concept, not a slogan	70
Aid as a thermometer of obedience	71

The aid that lends Africans their own money	71
Confessions of a financial assassin	72
The FATF: the neocolonial financial enforcement arm	73
France finances terrorism — and chairs the FATF	73
PEPs: a tool of financial censorship against activists	74
The FATF doctors its own reports	74
The neocolonial architecture — a systemic design	75
Reading the Sahel through this lens — and the answer of the tractors	75
What this system reveals	76
Chapter 10 — Networks of influence	77
The pyramid: five tiers of domination	77
The lexicon: naming things backward	78
The regional instrument: ECOWAS	79
The men: the comprador elite	80
The law of underlings: Mobutu, Compaoré, Ouattara	81
Ill-gotten gains	81
The February 17, 2022 recording: the system caught in the act	82
Cameroon: anesthetizing in order to dominate	83
PART III — THE WAR IN THE SAHEL	84
Chapter 11 — The Libyan crisis: cables, gold, and the African dinar	86
The child of the desert	86
The money of pan-Africanism	87
The architect of an African currency	87
March–October 2011: chronology of a destruction	88
What the declassified cables reveal	88
The February 22 cable — Mali in the crosshairs	88
The ignored ceasefire offer — February 25, 2011	89
Clinton converts in Paris — March 2011	89
Gaddafi was right about the paramilitaries	90

"Hello Tripoli" — Gbagbo as a message to Gaddafi	90
Obama's speech — March 28, 2011	91
The men of the collapse	91
The market of betrayal: the Azawad sold at the price of an arsenal	92
The arsenals scatter	93
Four lessons for Africa	93
What the cables ultimately reveal	94
Gaddafi's Libya: what the data said before the destruction	94
What the sixteen indicators say	95
The continental context	96
What was destroyed	96
North Africa as a mirror	96
What southern Africa also reveals	97
Chapter 12 — The explosion of terrorism	98
The Algerian graft	98
2012: the Azawad, or the manufacturing of a cause	99
Ouagadougou, November-December 2012: when armed groups dictate their terms	100
An army of misery, run by a hardened core	101
What the enemy says about its own camp: the jihadist rejection of the MNLA	102
The invisible corridors	103
The Syrian graft: post-Damascus arrives in the Sahel	104
The Sahel: the flow of Syrian fighters and the globalization of terrorism	105
60,000 to 70,000 fighters displaced	105
The direct impact on the Sahel	105
What this reveals about the nature of the conflict	106
Somalia, Sudan: the ignored precedent	106
What this demands	106
Chapter 13 — Serval, Barkhane, and their limits	108
Serval's original legal sin	108

The secret war before the war	108
General Gomart and Iyad Ag Ghaly in Ouagadougou	109
The honorable correspondent in the Central African Republic	109
Barkhane: the figures of the verdict	110
A force that did not fight alongside Africans	112
The OCRS: the real reason, named from the UN podium	112
The price of blood — a true accounting	113
Rwanda: 800,000 dead for a linguistic setback	114
Chapter 14 — The battle of information	116
First front: the media	116
RFI in Bambara, and the semiotics of operation names	118
Wassim Nasr, IFRI, and the Ministry of the Armed Forces: doctrine set to sound	119
Second front: the digital	120
Third front: humanitarianism as a weapon	121
Fourth front: the judicial	123
The cross-cutting weapon: the "terrorist" label	124
The 2026 World Cup: the geopolitics of sport laid bare	124
The diaspora on the front line — the price of speaking out	126
Nathalie Yamb: sanctioned for her clarity	126
Kémi Séba: hunting down a diplomatic passport	127
The "12 Apostles" and the exported judicial war	128
The AES: withdrawal from the Rome Statute and the question of justice	128
What the ICC did — and did not do — in the Sahel	129
Selectivity as an argument	129
What the argument does not resolve	130
What sovereignty demands	130
The colonial gaze: Hogard, Djibouti, and an Africa without Africans	130
Djibouti: the setting for a calling	131
The Legion: the imperial filter	131
Geopolitical Djibouti: a nostalgic retreat	131

Somalia: the American farce	132
Rwanda: the repressed wound	132
What the table sums up	132
What this gaze produces	133
Chapter 15 — What France admits in private	135
The parliamentary admission: "domination"	135
The doctrinal admission: the Védérine report	136
Alain Juillet: what the enemy says about itself	136
Principle I — France is a world power or it is nothing	137
Principle II — We defended presidents, not states	137
Principle III — Contractual transparency	137
Principle IV — Geographic pivot: leave the Sahel, consolidate the pivots	138
Principle V — Private military companies	138
Principle VI — Industrial partnerships	139
Principle VII — Playing technological catch-up	139
Principle VIII — Democracy as a tool	140
Principle IX — Manage transitions, don't eradicate	140
Principle X — Mapping the competitors	141
Principle XI — Cultural defeat	141
Principle XII — The permanent seat: the absolute constant	142
The P5 seat: the anomaly of 1945	142
A diplomatic victory over a military defeat	142
The veto as a postcolonial tool	143
The African demand and French resistance	143
What the AES must demand	144
The strategist's confession: "for France's interests"	144
Chad's confession: "it was ours"	145
What Juillet's doctrine reveals for the AES	145
They knew	146

Chapter 16 — Mali: the first rupture	149
A collapse foretold seven years earlier	149
Kidal, May 2013: the soldier turned away	150
Kidal, a country within a country: eleven years of sanctuarization	150
The second act and the merger with the street	151
The hypocrisy of the international community	152
The test: the airport's 49 "mercenaries"	154
October 2023: MINUSMA as a weapon of partition	155
November 14, 2023: Kidal	156
The 5th anniversary: assessing a transition at war	157
The Paris plot: June 2025 — June 2026	158
The fuel embargo: economic war before the assault	159
The offensive of April 25, 2026	159
 Chapter 17 — Burkina Faso: the Traoré doctrine	 162
"More dangerous than the bases"	162
The economic front: the battle over gold	164
The battle of the barracks: five billion for a betrayal	164
"Prepare for high-intensity war"	165
The June 2026 sequence: from summons to rupture	165
June 19 — Gomart speaks in Strasbourg	166
January 2013: Iyad Ag Ghaly at the Laïko Hotel	166
June 22 — The summoning of Philippe Branchin	167
Issa Diawara: point-by-point right of reply	167
Nathalie Yamb: a response to the European Parliament	169
June 26 — The rupture	170
What the Burkinabé sequence reveals	171
Burkina Faso: the rupture explained from within	172
The resolution as a declaration of war	172
Gomart, Lecointre, Langlais: the new slave traders in uniform	172
What ten years of French presence produced	173

What the rupture has produced	173
The Confederation's ideology	174
Ouahigouya, July 17, 2026: "Are we cursed?"	174
Stockholm syndrome as political diagnosis	175
The first story: four products to weaken a people	175
The second story: "Daniel," or the curse as doctrine	176
The imam affair: what the law actually says	177
The eight hundred of sharia	178
"There are not two captains in one boat"	178
The battle of the brain: produce or disappear	179
Proof by the enemy's failure	179
The grandmother of Ouahigouya	180
What Ouahigouya reveals	180
Chapter 18 — Niger: the final lock	182
The C-17 that turns back	182
The Agadez file: an agreement Nigeriens had no right to know about	183
Retaking the subsoil: Imouraren	183
The speech of February 12, 2024	184
The ultimatum that went nowhere — and what Bazoum reveals	184
Tiani in Ankara, June 4, 2026	186
Withdrawal from the ICC: justice refused in the name of justice	187
Niger: the "weak link" that held	188
What Niger represents	188
The system that keeps Africa poor	189
The reaction: sanctions, blockade, pressure	189
The American diplomatic note and the price of sovereignty	190
What Tiani understood	190
Chapter 19 — The birth of the AES	192
From alliance to Confederation	192

A legitimacy older than the AES itself	193
"An irreversible reality"	194
Chapter 20 — The proxy war	195
The ghost army	195
Tinzawaten: Ukraine enters the picture	197
The next step: drones and regime change	199
January 2026: the Niamey dress rehearsal	199
April 25, and the man who had to die	200
The response, and the confession	201
Mali retakes ground: DDR and financial warfare	201
July 2026: Anéfis, and TASS confirmation	202
A confession from the French left	203
Tiani had announced it	203
The agenda revealed: JNIM as future political actor	204
The information war in Niger: a pre-positioned Ivorian	206
Central African Republic 2026: the war to come	206
Chapter 21 — The regional environment	208
Chad: Mahamat Déby between two fires	208
Algeria: the mediator who shoots	209
Mauritania: the silent neighbor	210
The United Arab Emirates: the documented destabilizer	211
Côte d'Ivoire: the Ivorian lock	212
The porous border	212
What the 2002 rebellion left behind	212
Soro: the armed link that fed the Sahel	214
The information war: the Ivorian relay	214
The counter-fire: Gbagbo, Traoré, and the Ivorian majority	215
Kenya: the permanent-base blueprint	215
The Central African Republic: the founding act	216

The Central African Republic: Bozizé, portrait of the standard putschist	217
The Central African Republic: Paris, rear base of the rebellion	217
The Central African Republic: Raineteau, the honorable correspondent	218
The Central African Republic: the Sangocoin, an attempted economic sovereignty	219
The Central African Republic: peacekeepers and organized impunity	219
The Central African Republic: Joseph Kony, the fugitive who may not have been hunted	220
The Central African Republic: the war that is coming	221
The Central African Republic: the question of the SPEAR program	221
The African Union and ECOWAS: institutions under constraint	223
Sanctions against African voices	224
What the regional environment reveals	225
CAR: rebellion, the weapon of underdevelopment	225
Six coups, zero development	226
Manufactured rebellion, inside complicity	226
What a dignified opposition requires	226
The republican pact or starting over	227
The generation that refuses to start over	227
CAR: hangover for the prophets of doom	228
The camp of narratives	228
The masks fall	228
What history retains	229
CAR: what a French soldier said about Bria	229
Bria the Brilliant	229
What the soldier saw	230
"We are not well received"	230
Hard conditions, unclear mission	230
The Sahelian periphery: Chad, Mauritania, Senegal, Guinea, and the end of the G5	231
Chad: the dynastic succession	231
Mauritania: slavery as a contemporary reality	231
Senegal: rupture by the ballot	232

Guinea: the Doumbouya ambiguity	232
The death of the G5 Sahel	233
Chapter 22 — Nkrumah, Lumumba, Keïta: the first wave	236
Accra, capital of Africa	236
Boganda: the name as a federal program	237
January 17, 1961	237
Modibo Keïta, the Malian franc, and the FLN's dagger	238
What the AES owes the dead	238
Chapter 23 — Sankara was right	240
Four years that disturb	240
October 15, 1987	241
The legacy: from mausoleum to fatigues	241
The IPN Farafina: from Sankara to Traoré, Black consciousness as a political project	242
The Lagos Plan of Action against the Berg Report	242
The original IPN: three objectives	243
The smothering: Compaoré, SAPs, and the La Baule speech	243
The resurrection: IPN Farafina, 2025	244
What the continuity means	244
Chapter 24 — Connected youth, the diaspora on the front line	246
The youngest country in the world	246
The diaspora: from remittance to front line	246
The diaspora's compradors	247
Chapter 25 — The AES, a pan-African laboratory	249
The Vésilier affair, or African-supervised justice	249
The democratic question, without flinching	250
The prosecution witness who argues for the defense	251
Admitted fragilities, criteria set	251
Ghana: heritage is not begged for, it is reclaimed	252

Chapter 26 — Security: Winning Without Betrayal	256
The blockade: war by asphyxiation	256
The Unified Force: the tool of response	257
Contempt for gifts: equipping without arming	257
The VDP: the double-edged weapon	258
The trap of conflation	259
Winning without betraying oneself	260
Chapter 27 — Industrialization and education: the war economy and the weapon of minds	261
The war economy: cutting extraction's pipes	261
Processing on-site: the local content rule	262
Education as a weapon of sovereignty	262
Chapter 28 — Currency: breaking the CFA chain	265
The Central African gamble: leaping over rather than confronting	265
What the failure teaches	266
Amaïzo's sequence: sovereignty in order	266
The Eco and ECOWAS: reform or substitution?	267
What to base the AES currency on	268
Chapter 29 — The multipolar world: partners or new masters?	270
Russia: the burdensome ally and the unexpected argument	270
China: the partner you can sanction	272
Turkey: the partner who delivers before being paid	272
The United States: pragmatism and the window	274
Iran at the World Cup: the weaponization of multilateralism	274
BRICS: circumventing rather than fighting	275
Chapter 30 — Françafrique 2.0: the recomposition of domination	276
Pivot states: shifting the center of gravity	276
The French Wagner: preventive privatization of military neocolonialism	277
Air France, or the corporation as a political weapon	278

What the trade decline hides: the 2,421 subsidiaries	279
The Francophonie: the last empire	280
Montpellier 2021: civil society as an instrument	283
The diaspora summit, or the recycling of paradigms	284
Arrogance as doctrine	285
The Nairobi sequence, May 2026, under the fact-check lens	286
The four most dangerous years	290
The paper border: €10,530 or nothing	290
Chapter 31 — What the AES must achieve to survive	292
Anatomy of a fear	292
The implicit roadmap	293
The four levers of transformation	294
The African Union: the institution whose void the AES fills	295
Demographic sovereignty: who decides how many children a people has?	296
The starting point, not the finish line	298
The AES: geopolitical scandal and total sovereignty	298
The April 2026 offensive: imperialism's black hand	299
The AES: an organization born from the experience of hell	299
Digital sovereignty: the invisible battle	299
The break with the Western democratic model	300
Spiritual liberation: Cheikh Anta Diop was right	300
Financial independence: reclaiming in order to finance	301
Conclusion — Return To The Niamey Villa	302
What a sentence can do	302
Memory recovered	302
The generation that films	303
What the data said before it was destroyed	303
The architecture of rupture	304
The CFA franc's closed loop	304

What Macron said without meaning to	305
When the prophets of doom wake up	305
The villa is empty. The sentence is not.	306
What only history can settle	306
Timeline — from the partition of Africa to the Alliance of Sahel States	308
Glossary Of Acronyms	311
Index Of Figures	315
Methodological Notes & Source Corpus	321
Three preliminary clarifications	321
French critical and investigative sources	321
French institutional sources (the adversary's own words)	322
Academic and international sources	323
Pan-Africanist and African sources	324
Primary sources from the AES and neighboring authorities	324

FOREWORD — METHOD, SOURCES AND LIMITS

"The carrots are cooked for France. Just look at what's happening across Africa and watch the anger keep rising." — Paul Elvira, Panafrican Média TV, August 2, 2022

This book is an investigation. It covers the period 2013–2026 and draws on more than 130 sources of deliberately varied origin: critical and mainstream French press, academic work (the Geneva Graduate Institute, SWP Berlin), official documents from the governments of the Alliance of Sahel States, pan-Africanist media, Sahelian and Central African field press, and reports from international institutions — the UN, the French Court of Audit, ACLED, UNDP. The rule admits no exception: every source is judged on its evidence, not its flag. Ndjoni Sango, Oubangui Médias, and Vox Africa are held to the same standard as *Le Monde* or RTL France. What matters is whether a claim can be verified, and whether the facts cross-check.

The rule of the confirming adversary

When a pan-Africanist activist states something, that statement remains a hypothesis — committed, interested, to be handled with caution. When the same thing is confirmed by the adversary itself — a French parliamentary report, a general speaking behind closed doors, a Paris press investigation — it changes status: it is no longer a thesis, it is an admission that even its own authors can no longer deny. On the decisive points of this book, it is very often the adversary who confirms. General Lecointre, chief of staff of the French armed forces, states behind closed doors that France "does not wage war for democracy, but for France's interests." The 2023 parliamentary report admits that Paris "needs Africa more than Africa needs us." General Burkhard, in September 2024, acknowledges having "no friends in Mali." And Macron himself, in Nairobi on May 11, 2026, tells Africans: "If you fail, we have no chance." These admissions, extracted from the mouths of those who fought the AES, are not cited as side notes. They are the evidentiary backbone of the book.

The framing of sources

Some of the voices cited here — Nathalie Yamb, Banda Kani, Franklin Nyamsi, and others — are committed actors in the struggle they describe. That does not disqualify their words; it frames them: when cross-checked against independent or adversarial sources, their claims are flagged as such; when not cross-checked, they are presented for what they are — hypotheses. The same caution applies, symmetrically, to official French spokespeople — ambassadors, the Ministry of the Armed Forces, the Élysée — who are equally

parties to the conflict. Rigor does not depend on the color of a passport or on political orientation: it depends on the position of the speaker relative to the facts being recounted.

International institutions are not exempt from this grid. Reports from Human Rights Watch and Amnesty International — which feed European Parliament resolutions against AES states — are read and checked; but their funding, their structural ties to Western powers, and their selective silence on comparable cases outside the AES are part of the analytical picture. Philippe Boloignon, HRW's deputy director, is a former journalist at *Le Monde* with a documented institutional career; the HRW report of April 2026 — 342 pages targeting Burkina Faso — is analyzed in detail. A claim can be accurate; its use as a weapon of diplomatic destabilization is documented separately.

Vocabulary

The word "putsch" does not appear in this book. Changes of power in Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger are referred to as "military transitions," "seizures of power," or "overthrows," in keeping with the institutional terminology used by the countries concerned. Readers may judge for themselves whether this choice is indulgent; the author holds that it is simply more accurate. The terms "terrorist" and "jihadist" are handled with the same caution: they describe real phenomena — organizations that plant explosives, kidnap civilians, behead teachers — but their use as a blanket political label enables documented conflation. The French army spared Iyad Ag Ghaly in Gao in 2014 and barred the Malian Armed Forces from Kidal for years. These facts are in this book.

Limits

Some of the events recounted here — the attacks of April 25, 2026, the RTL revelations of May 9, 2026, the Vésilier affair, the second attack on Niamey airport on June 18, 2026 — belong to breaking news at the time of writing. They are dated and precisely sourced, but recent history is by nature subject to revision. Some strong claims rest on a single source: the text presents these in the conditional, naming their origin, rather than passing them off as certainties.

Rigor is not the privilege of those who dominate. It is the weapon of those who resist.

Everything begins in a villa in Niamey, in front of a whiteboard where someone had written five words.

PROLOGUE — THE VILLA IN NIAMEY

Picture a villa in a residential neighborhood of Niamey. High walls, a dry garden, the red dust the har-mattan leaves on everything. Inside, air-conditioned offices, staff maps, screens. And in a meeting room, a whiteboard. On that board, scrawled in marker by a hurried hand, five words.

Peace, we can avoid it.

The people who wrote that sentence are not philosophers. They are strategists. Men with ranks, budgets, allies in Paris and Washington. Their mission, as it can be read in those five words: maintain instability to maintain access. Maintain access to maintain extraction. The extraction of uranium — of which Niger supplied 35% of French imports, historically bought 30 to 40% below market price. The extraction of gold. Of oil. Of rare earths. What these strategists only ever wrote on a whiteboard, Jacques Chirac once admitted publicly: without Africa, France would be a Third World country. His words will resurface later in this book.

To understand how one arrives at writing such a sentence in a villa in Niamey, one must go back a long way. To the law of 1900, which made the colonized pay the cost of their own colonization. To the head taxes that could only be settled in CFA francs, turning a currency into an instrument of coercion. To the CFA franc, created on December 26, 1945, printed at Chamalières in France, with African central banks required to deposit 100% of their reserves in an "operations account" in Paris from 1945 to 1975, then 50% from 1975 onward — despite the administrative reform of 2019, 17 billion euros of African reserves remain held in Paris today, and the structure of dependency itself endures. To the debts contracted by colonial powers to exploit Africa, then transferred in 1960 to the young states they had just left — what jurists have called "odious debt" since the Sack treatise of 1927. You are plundered for a century, then handed the bill for the plunder. These mechanisms have their own chapters in this book. Here, it is enough to know that they exist, and that they all lead to this villa.

This sentence is a key. It reveals that peace in the Sahel has always been instrumentalized — managed like a dial, calibrated to serve interests that are not Sahelian. Barkhane did not fail: it did exactly what it was there for — maintaining a managed disorder. An insecurity never resolved but never total, just enough chaos to justify a military presence, never enough to threaten access to resources. Over nine years — 1 billion euros a year, 5,500 soldiers at its peak, five billion cumulative (Court of Audit, 2020) — terrorism in the Sahel tripled between 2014 and 2021 (ACLED, 2022). The French Court of Audit itself found this — in black and white, without anyone in France drawing any conclusions from it.

Then Niger closed the villa. It expelled the French army and the American army in the same year — 2023 and 2024 — without a drop of blood. The American C-17 was turned away on August 3, 2023. And the

sky did not fall.

This book is an investigation, not a pamphlet or a hagiography. It draws on adversarial sources — RTL, the Berlin-based SWP institute, the French parliamentary commission, the UN, ACLED conflict data — as much as on pan-Africanist sources. When French institutions and African heads of state say the same thing, it is no longer a thesis: it is a truth that even its adversaries can no longer deny.

The peace of graveyards has been imposed for too long. Just peace remains to be built. Justice cannot be avoided. Dignity cannot. Freedom, never.

But before judging those who closed the villa, one must understand what they broke — and why no one had dared to do it before them.

INTRODUCTION — WHY THE AES CHANGES EVERYTHING

"We cannot let the history of Africa be written by those who plundered it." — General Abdourahamane Tiani, CNSP Niger, August 2023

Bamako, September 16, 2023. Three African heads of state sign a document. None of the three was elected in the classic sense; all three came to power by force of arms. And all three have just created something that had not existed since independence: a sovereign, armed bloc, explicitly anti-neocolonial, at the heart of French-speaking West Africa — the Alliance of Sahel States. The Liptako-Gourma Charter, signed that day, resembles no diplomatic document produced by African summits in sixty years: it creates a mutual defense obligation, lays the groundwork for a confederation, and explicitly names the threats — external destabilization, economic sanctions, unwanted military interventions. Where the usual African texts hedge, it says the truth out loud.

The Western press covered the event with the condescending distance it reserves for "African instability." These same analysts never saw Brexit coming, nor Trump, nor the fall of the Wall. They never see what comes from below, because they never look below — and when history proves them wrong, they change the subject.

What the AES is — and is not

This book takes the opposite bet: it takes the AES seriously. Not because it is perfect — it is not. Not because its leaders are model democrats — no election has, to date, validated their power at the ballot box. But because it represents something that had not existed since independence: the organized, institutional, militarily credible refusal of French and Western tutelage.

A Geneva academic had written as much back in 2013, the very year the French army entered Mali:

"The interventionism of great powers follows a cyclical pattern, revealing an enduring relationship of domination between the metropole and the periphery." — Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou, La Guerre au Mali, La Découverte, 2013

Western military interventions in Africa are not accidents that repeat out of bad luck. They recur at regular intervals because they sustain the same balance of power — a center that decides, a periphery that endures. Mohamedou, a professor at the Geneva Graduate Institute of International and Development Studies, documented ten years before the AES what the AES has now enshrined through its very existence: French

intervention in the Sahel is not an exception, it is the latest iteration of a system that turns states of the Global South into battlefields. The rupture of 2020–2023 — Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger — is the first institutional response to this system since independence. This book does not analyze it as an African accident, but as a historical response to a historical domination.

What this book covers — and how

This book was born of a narrow question — why the AES, why now, why does it hold — and expanded as the answers connected to one another. Because the Sahelian rupture cannot be understood without Kadhafi's Libya — the most developed African country on 16 indicators, destroyed in 2011 not to protect civilians but to eliminate a sovereign counter-example. Without Thiaroye 1944 — 300 to 400 African riflemen who had liberated France and were massacred by it when they demanded their captivity back pay, their archives locked away for 80 years. Without the CFA franc — the mechanism by which the Bank of France prints the currency that pays terrorists, making the destabilization of the Sahel free in hard currency. Without the IPN Farafina — the Institute of Black Peoples that Sankara founded in 1986, extinguished after his assassination, and that Ibrahim Traoré revived in 2025 because you cannot kill a just idea. This book does not claim to be exhaustive. It claims to be coherent: the same causes produce the same effects, and the same systems produce the same resistances.

To understand what the AES represents, one must understand what it breaks with — tracing sixty years of manufactured dependency, plundered resources, leaders installed and toppled according to the interests of Paris. The demonstration rests on the principle set out in the foreword: when the same facts are confirmed both by pan-Africanist sources and by adversarial sources — French, institutional, or academic — they are no longer theses. They become evidence. This book is built on these convergences — without eulogy, without shortcuts.

But sixty years is not enough. The lie the AES confronts is older than Françafrique: it is the idea that Africa has no history. To dismantle it, one must begin well before 1960 — in the days when a Sahelian emperor could, by passing through a foreign city, cause the world price of gold to collapse.

PART I — AFRICA BEFORE DOMINATION

"A people without the knowledge of their history, origin and culture is like a tree without roots." — Marcus Garvey

Before the maps of Berlin, before the colonial columns, before the "civilizing mission," there were states. Empires that taxed caravans, universities that drew thousands of students, charters that proclaimed the sanctity

of human life, sovereigns whose wealth made the markets of Cairo tremble. A Sahel that was, for centuries, a center of the world. This is not nostalgia: it is the foundation without which nothing that follows — neither the conquest, nor the resistances, nor the rupture of 2020–2023 — can be understood. One cannot claim to “civilize” a people known to have already stood at the summit; so it had to be made to forget that it had ever been there. The erasure of African history is not an accident of scholarship: it is the indispensable precondition of colonization. Without it, nothing holds.

PART I

AFRICA BEFORE DOMINATION



CHAPTER 1 — THE GREAT EMPIRES

Cairo, summer 1324. A rumor precedes the caravan: a king from the west is crossing Egypt on his way to Mecca. When the procession enters the city, the people of Cairo can't believe their eyes — thousands of men, camels by the hundred, and gold. So much gold that the pilgrim gives it away to mosques, officials, the poor, merchants. This king is named Mansa Musa, emperor of Mali. His passage pours such a quantity of precious metal onto the markets that the price of gold collapses in Cairo — for some twenty years, by certain estimates. At the same moment, Europe is sinking toward the Black Death. The richest country in the world, at the dawn of the fourteenth century, is not on the banks of the Seine or the Rhine. It is on the banks of the Niger.

The colonial school never told this story. That silence is a decision, not an oversight.

The founding lie

Colonial ideology rests on a founding lie: the "civilizing mission." It holds that African peoples had no history, no political organization, no intellectual production before the arrival of Europeans — and it is functional: one can invade a wealthy territory out of greed, but one can only claim to "civilize" it after having first decreed it empty of history. This lie has its pedigree: in the nineteenth century, Hegel, in his lectures on the philosophy of history, decreed that Africa was "no historical part of the world" — a continent without movement, without development, outside history. The formula would become influential, supplying generations of administrators, missionaries, and textbooks with the intellectual cover for conquest. A philosopher produces the theory; gunboats do the rest.

Yet the history of the Sahel is anything but empty. It is one of the densest in the medieval world — and one need only follow the gold routes to be convinced of it.

Wagadou, the first giant

It all begins with the Empire of Ghana — which its inhabitants called Wagadou. From the fourth to the eleventh century, it controlled the trans-Saharan routes for gold and salt. A merchant arriving from the north with salt, or heading back to the Mediterranean with gold, paid a toll, recorded and enforced: collecting duties on long-distance trade requires an administration, agents, records, a force to enforce the rule. All of this existed in the Sahel a thousand years before the Archinard column — a sophisticated customs system, centuries before the modern European state existed.

The Sahel was not a margin: it was a crossroads. Medieval Arab geographers and travelers — from

Al-Bakri to Ibn Battuta, who visited the Mali empire in the fourteenth century — describe lavish courts, well-ordered cities, and a safety of the roads that impressed them. It is their accounts, not those of the colonizers, that make up our best records of the region.

The Mali of Sundiata and Mansa Musa

In the thirteenth century, a second giant took over. The Mali Empire was founded by Sundiata Keita after the Battle of Kirina in 1235, where he defeated the king of Sosso. It is from this founding moment that the Manden Charter dates — one of the oldest proclaimed rights charters in history, which the next chapter will revisit.

The empire reached its zenith under Mansa Musa (1312–1337): he is the pilgrim of Cairo in 1324. Behind the gilded anecdote lies a political reality: a state capable of organizing the movement of thousands of people across thousands of kilometers, financing that journey, and turning it into an instrument of diplomatic prestige. Fourteenth-century European cartographers would later draw the “King of Mali” enthroned, a gold nugget in hand. Sahelian power was so evident that even its rivals kept a record of it on their maps.

Songhai, Bornu, Sokoto: the continuity

In the fifteenth century, the Songhai Empire took the lead. Its University of Sankore in Timbuktu enrolled as many as 25,000 students — a figure documented by Cheikh Anta Diop as early as 1954, ignored for decades by mainstream historiography. Its warrior ruler, Sonni Ali Ber, died in 1492 — the year Columbus crossed the Atlantic — while returning from a campaign against the Mossi, a major ethnic group in present-day Burkina Faso.

The peoples who fight together within the AES in 2024–2026 share a history of interaction, conflict, and alliance that predates the arrival of French colonization by five centuries. The borders drawn in Berlin cut through a human fabric; they did not create it.

Further east, the Sultanate of Bornu, heir to Kanem, endured from the ninth to the nineteenth century — a millennium of continuous political existence — and maintained diplomatic correspondence with Egypt and the Ottoman Empire. Sahelian sovereigns exchanged embassies and official letters with the great powers of their time, as recognized partners. Not as subjects. As equals.

Finally, the Sokoto Caliphate (1804–1903), born of Usman dan Fodio’s religious revolution, became one of the largest African political entities of its century; it remains today a major identity reference point for Hausa and Fulani populations.

The great precolonial states of the Sahel

Empire | Period | Notable facts

- Empire of Ghana / Wagadou — 4th–11th century — Gold and salt routes, sophisticated customs system
|
- Mali Empire — 13th–15th century — Manden Charter (1236); Mansa Musa collapses the price of gold in Cairo (1324)
|
- Songhai Empire — 15th–16th century — University of Sankore (~25,000 students); Timbuktu, roughly 100,000 inhabitants
|
- Sultanate of Bornu / Kanem — 9th–19th century — Diplomatic correspondence with Egypt and the Ottoman Empire
|
- Sokoto Caliphate — 1804–1903 — One of the largest African political entities; still a major reference for Hausa-Fulani populations today

Neither a lost paradise nor a blank page

These empires were not paradises. They knew wars of conquest, raids, internal slavery, and the trans-Saharan slave trade. Precolonial African history is a human history, with its own violence and its own forms of domination — not a postcard. This holds true for every civilization of the same era: feudal Europe massacred, plundered, and burned its heretics. The comparison absolves no one. It puts each in its proper measure.

The central question is that of the state: institutions, taxation, diplomacy, dynastic continuity, law. All of this existed, massively and durably. The Sahel was not a blank page waiting for Europe to come and write on it. It was a palimpsest — an ancient text that colonization scraped away to write its own over it.

These empires are absent from postcolonial African textbooks, written on the French model. Generations of Malian, Burkinabé, and Nigerien schoolchildren learned the history of France before that of Sundiata. The erasure survived independence. This is precisely why the references to this history in the speeches of AES leaders are not folklore: they are an act of restitution. A deliberate political act, not a nostalgic sentiment.

But the power of a civilization is not measured by its armies and its gold alone — and it is in the libraries of Timbuktu, among hundreds of thousands of manuscripts, that the Sahel left its most irrefutable proof.

CHAPTER 2 — THE CIVILIZATIONS OF THE SAHEL

Paris, 1954. A young Senegalese researcher publishes, with *Présence Africaine*, a book that will cause a scandal: *Nations nègres et culture*. Its author, Cheikh Anta Diop, argues a thesis the French academy deems unacceptable: that ancient Egypt, the recognized cradle of Mediterranean civilization, was a Black African civilization. The Sorbonne will make his life difficult; he will have to fight for years to get his work examined and recognized. Doors are closed to him. He knocks on the windows. He eventually gets in anyway.

Diop does not stop at writing; back in Dakar, he founds a carbon-14 dating laboratory at IFAN — the first of its kind in West Africa. The technique measures the residual radioactivity of organic matter to date bone, wood, or ancient textiles. Diop wanted Africa to be able to date its own past, with its own instruments, without waiting for the verdict of European laboratories. In 1974, at the international symposium held in Cairo under UNESCO's auspices, he would defend his theses before the world's foremost Egyptologists.

Why did a physicist-historian have to devote his life to proving that Africa had a history? Because everything in mainstream knowledge had been organized to take it away from her. This chapter tells what that knowledge erased.

Timbuktu, the library-city

In the fifteenth century, the University of Sankore, in Timbuktu, enrolled as many as 25,000 students, in a city of roughly 100,000 inhabitants. No European university of the period came close to such numbers. Oxford, founded in 1096, the Sorbonne in 1150: these are honorable institutions. Sankore eclipses them in size. No one teaches this.

The texts preserved in Timbuktu — several hundred thousand manuscripts — cover medicine, mathematics, philosophy, and Islamic law. Timbuktu was not merely a caravan market: it was a campus, a library, and a court of law on the scale of an empire. Books were copied, annotated, and sold there; the manuscript trade was, the chronicles say, among the most lucrative in the city.

Some of these manuscripts, passed down from family to family for centuries, still exist today — material, datable, tangible proof that the Sahel wrote, calculated, and legislated at a time when it would later be claimed that writing was being brought to it. In 2012, during the jihadist occupation of Timbuktu, residents risked their lives to hide these documents. They knew what they were protecting. So did the attackers — which is why they wanted to destroy them.

That sculptors in present-day Burkina Faso incorporated complex mathematical formulas into their craft

motifs before these same formulas were "discovered" by the West is one more indicator, not a folkloric curiosity: the boundaries of knowledge, like those of politics, have been drawn to suit the powerful.

The Manden Charter: rights proclaimed in 1236

The other proof is legal. The Manden Charter — also known as the Kouroukan Fougá, 1236 — is considered one of the earliest human rights declarations in history: it proclaims the sanctity of human life, the equality of all, and the abolition of enslavement by force.

This text forbids reducing a free person to slavery and asserts that every life is worth as much as another — more than five centuries before the 1789 Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen. Proclaimed at the accession of Sundiata Keita, passed down orally by griots from generation to generation, the Charter recalls a fact that colonial ideology denied: reflection on human dignity did not wait for Europe to exist in the Sahel. It was already there, inscribed in collective memory, when Paris was still just a muddy island on the Seine.

What the Sahel produced

Fact | Date | Significance

- Manden Charter / Kouroukan Fougá — 1236 — Sanctity of life, equality, prohibition of enslavement — one of the earliest rights declarations in history
|
- University of Sankore, Timbuktu — 15th century — Up to 25,000 students; city of ~100,000 inhabitants
|
- Timbuktu manuscripts — 15th–19th century — Several hundred thousand texts — medicine, mathematics, philosophy, law
|
- Cheikh Anta Diop, *Nations nègres et culture* — 1954 — First systematic refutation of the "blank slate" ideology of Africa
|
- Cairo UNESCO symposium — 1974 — Diop defends his theses before the world's foremost Egyptologists

Herodotus, Diop, and proof by convergence

The question of origins remains. Herodotus, the father of history within the Western tradition itself, described the Egyptians as "black-skinned and woolly-haired." Cheikh Anta Diop built on this foundation a

convergent demonstration: melanin-based, osteological, linguistic, and mythological evidence.

He did not seek a single miraculous proof, but brought together independent clues — the pigmentation of mummies, the shape of skeletons, the kinship between ancient Egyptian and Black African languages such as Wolof, shared myths — toward a single conclusion: Africa is the cradle of human civilization, and ancient Egypt belongs to its history.

One can debate this or that point of Diop's demonstration — specialists still do. But the essential point lies elsewhere: the erasure of these origins from mainstream historiography is not an academic accident. It is functional to domination. One cannot justify "uplifting" a people known to have already stood at the summit. So Timbuktu had to be forgotten, the Manden Charter had to remain unknown, and Egypt had to be whitewashed. The lie is not naive. It is calculated, systematic, institutional.

The lie of the previous chapter — Africa without history — required this meticulous work of erasure. And it is against this that Diop built his laboratory, his books, and his life. One man against an entire academy. He won.

A civilization that writes, that legislates, that teaches: that is what existed. To seize it, defeating it was not enough — it first had to be denied. That is exactly what some fifteen frock-coated diplomats are about to do, one evening in November 1884, in a Berlin drawing room.

CHAPTER 3 — THE COLONIAL CONQUEST

Berlin, November 15, 1884. In Chancellor Bismarck's residence on Wilhelmstrasse, representatives of fourteen European powers and the United States take their seats around a table. On the wall, a map of Africa — vast, and largely empty in the eyes of those looking at it: most of these diplomats have never seen the territories they are about to divide among themselves. Their hands do not tremble. The millions of men and women their pencils are tracing over have no names to them.

The conference will run until February 26, 1885. For the first time in the history of world diplomacy, an international meeting is devoted exclusively to a continent that is not represented at it. Not a single African in the room. Africa is carved into zones of influence, its rivers opened to European navigation, its coastlines turned into anchor points for systematic penetration inland. This is what is politely called the "Scramble for Africa." It is the founding crime of the modern world order.

A surgical operation on the African body

The Berlin Congress is a surgical operation on the African body — performed without the patient, and without anesthesia. The borders drawn in Berlin ignore preexisting ethnic, linguistic, and political realities: the empires, kingdoms, and networks of alliances described in the previous chapters are cut through, sliced up, scattered among several European "possessions."

More than a century later, the verdict is delivered even from the podium of the French National Assembly, by MP André Chassaigne:

"They pay no attention to the community spaces that exist. They split up families, clans, communities. This still has consequences today."

This surgery on maps would produce a century and a half of conflict — which the same powers would later present as proof of Africans' incapacity to govern themselves. This mechanism deserves close attention, because it is the template for everything this book will tell. The lie is complete, circular, self-referential: the problem is created, presented as proof of the natural inequality of peoples, and one imposes oneself as the solution to the problem one created.

A people is cut in two by an arbitrary border; the border is left to produce tensions; and then those tensions are pointed at as proof that "those people" clearly need to be administered. The arsonist sets the fire, then bills for putting it out. Readers will find this mechanism at every stage of this book — one need only

replace "borders" with "armed groups" for the formula to remain exact.

The rules of the game: "effective occupation"

The General Act signed in Berlin fixes a decisive rule among Europeans, known as "effective occupation": for a power to be able to claim an African territory against its rivals, it is no longer enough to plant a flag there — it must actually occupy it, install an administration, and station an armed force.

This clause turns the theoretical carve-up into a race against time: every chancellery now has an interest in sending its military columns as far and as fast as possible, ahead of the others. This is what explains the blistering brutality of the following two decades — what historians would call the "Scramble for Africa."

Note the elegance of the arrangement: Berlin does not organize war; Berlin organizes peace... among Europeans. The fourteen powers agree not to kill one another by dividing up the spoils. The violence, meanwhile, is entirely offloaded onto those who are not at the table.

All of it under a humanitarian flag. The acts of the conference invoke the fight against the slave trade and the "moral and material well-being" of native populations. Leopold II, King of the Belgians, thus secures recognition of his "Congo Free State" in the name of philanthropy and science — before turning it into one of the deadliest exploitation regimes of the modern era. The technique deserves to be remembered, for it never leaves the toolbox: from the "civilizing mission" of 1885 to the "counterterrorism" interventions of the twenty-first century, domination never advances without a moral pretext.

Berlin, 1884–1885

<i>Date</i>	<i>Event</i>
● November 15, 1884	Opening of the conference at Chancellor Bismarck's residence in Berlin
● —	Fourteen European powers and the United States at the table; no African representative
● February 26, 1885	Closing — Africa is carved into zones of influence, its rivers opened to European navigation
● —	The first international conference in history devoted exclusively to a continent absent from the debates

The micro-state trap

Some Africans saw the trap very early. Barthélemy Boganda, founder of the Central African Republic — who died in 1959 in a plane crash under suspicious circumstances — and Kwame Nkrumah, father of Ghanaian independence, warned of the same threat: nonviable micro-states, condemned to permanent dependency, incapable of carrying individual weight in an international system built against them.

A state that is too small, landlocked, carved up with no economic logic, can neither defend itself alone, nor negotiate alone, nor develop alone: it is structurally condemned to seek a protector — and the obvious protector will be the former colonizer. Berlin 1884–1885 had manufactured the condition of impossible sovereignty. This was not an unforeseen consequence. It was the plan.

The fate of the two men adds to the warning: Boganda dies before his country's independence, in circumstances never fully clarified, and Nkrumah is overthrown in 1966. The federations they called for would not come into being in their lifetimes. It would take until 2023 and the Liptako-Gourma Charter for an institutional response to this fragmentation to emerge in the Sahel — three states born of the Berlin carve-up deciding, one hundred and forty years later, to pool their sovereignty.

The OCRS law and the case of Sahelian resources

Even before independence was granted, France had already organized the securing of what really mattered. The law of January 10, 1957 created the Organisation Commune des Régions Sahariennes (OCRS) — a special status that administratively detached the desert zones rich in mineral resources from the colonies about

to become independent. The subsoil of present-day Niger — its uranium — and its neighbors were to remain under French management, regardless of who governed the surface. Put plainly: give them the flags, we keep the oil and the mines.

This text would be explicitly cited from the podium of the United Nations by the Burkinabé representative Bassolma Bazié in 2025, to explain that Sahelian dependency is not a historical accident. It was built precisely and legally, by an act of the French state, before formal decolonization even took place.

Before Berlin, after Berlin

The scale of the shift must be measured. Before Berlin, Europeans were present on African coasts through trading posts; explorations into the interior were only beginning. After Berlin, it is systematic conquest: treaties extracted from African sovereigns by threat or by deceit, military expeditions, forced labor, burned villages.

In Leopold II's Congo, the hands of workers who failed to deliver their rubber quota are cut off — the episode is documented even in the European archives of the time. Serious estimates put the death toll at 10 million between 1885 and 1908 in the Congo Free State alone. Ten million. For rubber. Pan-Africanist activist Banda Kani draws from this an unsparing formula:

"Every crime is permitted: inexplicable killings, genocide, murder in broad daylight, the cutting off of hands, feet, and ears, ritual crime, beheading, deportation, the pouring of napalm." — Banda Kani, Paroles Panafricanistes, November 29, 2022

One can debate the tone. One cannot debate the overall logic: the entire arsenal of terror is deployed toward a single end — installing fear as the governing principle of an entire continent.

Because governing is exactly what this is. Colonial violence is not an excess: it is a method. It aims to break existing political structures — the empires, the sultanates, the charters described in the first two chapters — and replace them with an administration whose only legitimacy is force. The old center collapses; African societies, stripped of their institutions, are thrown back onto their particularisms. The fruits of this fragmentation will be harvested for a century and a half — and it will be called "African instability." The mechanics are cynical. They are also devastatingly effective.

The letter of September 13, 1898

Behind the civilizing rhetoric, colonial archives sometimes yield documents that make commentary unnecessary. On September 13, 1898, a French governor signs an instruction to his officers operating in French

Sudan — present-day Mali. The order is unambiguous: destroy the populations that resist, poison the wells, eliminate anything that could constitute a center of resistance. An officer of the same period notes that “*aviation will one day come and eliminate them all*” — projecting into the future a logic of extermination already present in the moment.

This letter, preserved in French archives, has never been cited in the Republic’s history textbooks. Choguel Maïga, the Malian prime minister, personally cites it in 2024, holds a copy of it, and recalls its context: Malian populations hiding in the forests, concealing their livestock under mosquito nets, dying as they fled toward Guinea or Algeria — some of them members of his own family. “*Are they their friends? They are the friends of their own interests,*” he concludes.

This instruction is not an aberration. It is policy. It belongs to a decade in which resistance to French columns in French Sudan is systematically answered with the destruction of villages, the burning of crops, and the assassination of chiefs. This is no secret — it is an administrative choice that Paris covered, financed, and whose authors it promoted. The same logic — starve, isolate, terrorize in order to rule — reappears two centuries later in ECOWAS sanctions, fuel embargoes, and pressure on currencies. The instruments change. The logic remains.

That is the stage set at Berlin: a continent denied, carved up, terrorized. But Chancellor Bismarck’s maps had overlooked one variable — the peoples they were carving up were about to fight, weapons in hand, for decades.

CHAPTER 4 — THE FORGOTTEN RESISTANCES

Guélémou, September 29, 1898. At dawn, French soldiers surround the camp of an old man nearly seventy years old. When the future General Henri Gouraud steps forward to capture him, he is not seizing a cornered bandit chief: he is putting an end to sixteen years of war. The man's name is Samory Touré. Since the early 1880s, he had stood up to the foremost army in Europe. Deported to Gabon, he would die there in 1900, far from the empire he had built. France would celebrate the capture as a victory. It would take care never to mention what it had cost.

Sixteen years against France

Samory Touré (c. 1830–1900) founded the Wassoulou Empire, straddling present-day Mali, Guinea, and Côte d'Ivoire, and waged a sixteen-year armed resistance against France. Sixteen years: no European power of the era faced an adversary that durable in West Africa. Every French general sent to bring him down came back without him — sometimes defeated, always exhausted.

He refined his tactics with every confrontation, forcing French generals into expeditions costly in men and matériel, moving his empire eastward to slip the noose. What military manuals today would call an asymmetric war of attrition. When one cannot win a frontal battle against a better-armed enemy, one refuses that battle, strikes, moves, and makes every conquered kilometer so costly that the conquest itself becomes a bottomless pit.

Samory did not merely fight: he organized to last. His blacksmiths repaired rifles taken from the enemy and forged copies of them — an embryonic arms industry at the heart of the savanna. He played on the rivalry between the French and the British, negotiated, signed treaties when the balance of power demanded it, and renounced them when he regained strength. In short, he did everything a sovereign state at war does. Finally captured in 1898, deported, erased.

He was a head of state who refused submission longer than anyone else — and that is exactly why he had to be made to disappear from memory. A resistance fighter no one forgets is a model. And domination wants no models.

Those who said no

Samory was not alone. The conquest met, everywhere in the Sahel, men who preferred war, and sometimes death, to surrender.

Babemba Traoré, king of Kénédougou, in present-day Mali, saw French troops lay siege to his capital, Sikasso, in 1898, protected by its famous *tata* — a defensive wall that artillery eventually breached. When the fall became inevitable, Babemba chose to take his own life rather than surrender. His act would remain, in Malian memory, the very definition of refusal: one can take the city, not the king.

Rabah Fadlallah conquered the Sultanate of Bornu and resisted French penetration until 1900, when he was defeated and killed at the Battle of Kousséri, in present-day Cameroon.

Before them, El Hadj Omar Tall, founder of the Toucouleur theocracy spanning present-day Mali, Guinea, and Senegal, had led the nineteenth-century Islamic resistance to French colonization, before being cornered in a cave in northern Mali in 1864, where he vanished.

Figures of Sahelian resistance

Figure | Resistance | End

- El Hadj Omar Tall — Toucouleur theocracy; Islamic resistance to colonization — Vanishes in a cave in northern Mali (1864)
- |
- Samory Touré (c. 1830–1900) — Wassoulou Empire; sixteen years of armed resistance — Captured in 1898, deported to Gabon, where he dies
- |
- Babemba Traoré — King of Kénédougou — Takes his own life at Sikasso in 1898 rather than surrender
- |
- Rabah Fadlallah — Conqueror of Bornu — Defeated and killed at the Battle of Kousséri (1900)

All absent from postcolonial textbooks. All present in the speeches of AES leaders.

A resistance that never dies out

And the “completed” conquest did not put an end to the refusals. In the midst of the First World War, in 1916–1917, the Tuareg revolt led by Kaocen set the Aïr region ablaze in present-day Niger, laying siege to Agadez for months before being crushed in blood. France was then busy sacrificing its own sons in the trenches of Verdun — yet it still found the resources to kill Sahelians who refused colonial order.

Thirty years after Berlin, when the colonial maps seemed set in stone, Sahelians were still taking up arms against the order imposed on them. The “pacification” the colonial reports spoke of was never a peace. It was an occupation under permanent tension, riddled with revolts, dissent, and flight — precisely what the five

words on the Niamey whiteboard, a century later, would designate in negative: a peace that is avoided because it was never wanted.

Thiaroye, December 1, 1944: a crime without truth

*"You liberated France from the brown plague. As a reward, you were disarmed, gathered, and shot." —
Albert Anatole Ayissi, publishing director of the newspaper Le Cactus*

And when Sahelians were not fighting against France, they were fighting for it — for the same wage of blood. They came from Guinea, Mali, Benin, Cameroon, Senegal. They were called "Senegalese riflemen" — a convenient label that erased their diversity and assigned them a nationality of subordination. They were not Senegalese. They were African. And they had crossed the Atlantic to defend a France they did not know against a racist ideology that targeted them too.

Taken prisoner by the Germans in June 1940, they spent their captivity in mainland France — the Nazis did not want "natives" on their soil. Some had escaped and joined the Resistance. After the Liberation, a convoy of several hundred of them left Morlaix on November 5, 1944, bound for Dakar. On board, a promise: the back pay owed them for their captivity would be paid out in their home country. First stop: Casablanca. Those who disembarked in Morocco received nothing. Word spread through the ship. In Dakar, at the Thiaroye military camp, the soldiers demanded what they were owed — the promised wages, the captivity back pay, equal treatment with their French comrades. On December 1, 1944, the French army answered these legitimate demands with gunfire. They had first been disarmed.

A premeditated crime, dressed up as a mutiny. The official French version long spoke of "35 dead" in a "mutiny." After several years of research in public and private archives in France, Senegal, and the United Kingdom, historian Armelle Mabon of the University of South Brittany established the reality: between 300 and 400 soldiers were killed, their bodies thrown into mass graves. The official figure of 35 dead is a documented state lie. The falsification was organized from the very first days: three days after the massacre, a circular from the French command claimed the soldiers had received their captivity pay in full — retroactively rendering their demands illegitimate, and the massacre retroactively justified. In March 1945, a trial entirely stacked against the accused convicted and stripped of rank 34 innocent men — those who had survived and demanded justice. The archives were locked away. And when François Hollande, on his first official trip to Africa in 2012, promised to "return the archives" to Senegal and called the events a "bloody repression," the copies handed over a few months later turned out to be the record of a falsified history — lying reports written on orders, one-sided investigations, truncated documents. What was delivered was the staging of the crime, not the truth

of it.

Ingratitude as doctrine. What happened at Thiaroye is a doctrine, not a slip. General de Gaulle would not allow these African soldiers to march down the Champs-Élysées on August 26, 1944: the Africans' military uniforms were taken off them and given to white civilians to replace them in the Liberation parade. What history remembers as the liberation of Paris is, in part, Africans stripped of their uniforms so France could tell itself the story of a white victory. And for the survivors, another inequality: the pensions paid to African veterans were a fraction of those paid to their French counterparts — institutionalized racial discrimination, maintained for decades, until legal and political pressure forced partial adjustments.

80 years on: the obstruction continues. In 2023, 78 years after the massacre, no official truth had been established. The archives remain inaccessible or falsified. The mass graves have not been opened. Those convicted in 1945 have not been rehabilitated. The families are still waiting. A film had its premiere in Dakar; French researchers began taking up the subject only after pan-Africanists had put it back on the table. The mechanics are well known: when Africans raise a question of memory, it is ignored; when a Frenchman takes it up, it becomes legitimate. Albert Anatole Ayissi put it bluntly: "When it comes to speaking of the Armenian genocide, there are not just speeches — there are acts. But for Thiaroye, we're sold hot air." The hierarchy of memories says everything about the hierarchy of lives.

Thiaroye is one of the knots of the Franco-African dispute, not a mere historical footnote: a relationship built on extraction, ingratitude, and impunity. When leaders in Bamako, Ouagadougou, or Niamey invoke dignity as a principle of rupture, they are also speaking of Thiaroye. When Sahelian populations watch French soldiers leave without tears, they are also carrying Thiaroye. Memory is not nostalgia: it is a political argument — and at Thiaroye, it is damning. France cannot ask for Africa's trust as long as it has not opened its archives, rehabilitated its victims, and named its executioners. This is elementary accounting, not anti-French sentiment.

Sources (Thiaroye): Armelle Mabon, University of South Brittany, research on the Thiaroye massacre (French, Senegalese, and UK archives); Albert Anatole Ayissi, Paroles Panafricanistes, Panafricaniste TV, January 3, 2023; François Hollande, statement in Senegal, 2012; military trial of March 1945; Virginie Terrasse, documentary Thiaroye 44.

The double erasure

These names are absent from postcolonial textbooks. This is the second erasure, more perverse than the first. Chapter 1 showed how the colonial school had erased the empires; but the resistance fighters were themselves erased from independent African schools, which were built on the French model.

Generations of Sahelian pupils learned about Vercingetorix and Joan of Arc — figures of resistance to an invader, the irony is complete — without ever being taught about Samory or Babemba. The erasure was

not negligence: a people that does not know it resisted does not know it can resist. To control the textbooks is to control the field of the possible — which is why the battle over memory, running through this entire book, is never a quarrel among historians: it is a political battle of the first order. States that control history books control tomorrow's horizons.

It is precisely this lock that the 2020s broke open. These names, forgotten by the textbooks, are now present in the speeches of Captain Ibrahim Traoré and General Assimi Goïta. And one must understand what this presence means: the connection is doctrinal, not sentimental.

When AES leaders invoke Samory, they are not engaging in patriotic decoration — they are placing their action within a precise lineage, that of armed refusal of outside tutelage, and drawing a doctrine from it: sovereignty is not negotiated, it is defended. Sahelian peoples themselves had never quite forgotten: the memory of Samory holding out sixteen years against France survived in families, in griots, in songs, where the textbooks stayed silent.

The industrial imbalance — the sole reason for defeat

Nineteenth-century armed resistance was eventually overwhelmed — by the machine gun, by numbers, by the telegraph. Not for lack of courage, nor of tactical intelligence: by industrial imbalance. Sahelian empires faced adversaries capable of mass-producing what they themselves had to forge by hand. The Maxim gun fired 600 rounds a minute. Spears have no answer to 600 rounds a minute.

But the resistance established a truth the rest of this book will follow as a guiding thread: domination was never accepted. Nowhere. At no time. It was imposed, then managed, then dressed up. In the aftermath of the Second World War, dressing it up becomes the Empire's principal art: "independences" are prepared that will not be independence at all.

For this is the feat France is about to pull off in 1960: granting seventeen flags, seventeen anthems, seventeen seats at the UN — and giving up nothing essential.

PART II — HOW DEPENDENCY WAS ORGANIZED

Pre-conquest Africa had empires, universities, currencies. Part I has shown this. A puzzle remains: how did such a wealthy continent become, within a few decades, the most dependent in the world?

The answer lies in one word this part will dismantle piece by piece: organization. African dependency is not an accident of history, nor a cultural fatality. It is an architecture — designed in the offices of Paris at the very moment the flags of independence were rising into the skies over Bamako, Niamey, and Ouagadougou.

Six chapters trace its construction plan: the confiscated independences of 1960, the pact camouflaged in

cooperation agreements, the monetary lock of the CFA franc, the plunder of strategic resources, the weapon of aid and debt, and finally the networks that hold the whole structure together without a single soldier being needed.

A precise, methodical, documented construction.

PART II

HOW DEPENDENCY WAS ORGANIZED

CHAPTER 5 — 1960: THE UNFINISHED INDEPENDENCES

"We prefer poverty in freedom to riches in slavery." — Ahmed Sékou Touré, before General de Gaulle, Conakry, August 25, 1958

Bamako, September 22, 1960. In the public square, the crowd sings an anthem it is hearing for the first time. The green, gold, and red flag rises up the pole. The same scenes repeat that year in Niamey, in Ouagadougou, in Dakar: 1960 is "the Year of Africa," seventeen countries gain independence. History, it is believed, is beginning.

But in the offices of Paris, another history is being written at the very same moment. And it is this history that will govern the following sixty years.

The man in the shadows

This parallel history has a face: Jacques Foccart, the Élysée's éminence grise for African affairs. While the anthems ring out, his team is getting so-called "cooperation" agreements signed. These agreements are contracts appended to the acts of independence: they preserve the CFA franc, keep French military bases in place, reserve privileged access to raw materials for France, and place the young states under technical and monetary tutelage. Independence is formal. Dependency is real. The flag changes. The substance stays.

Françafrique is born amid the euphoria of independence, invisible, buried in the fine print of treaties no one will read.

The academic biography Frédéric Turpin devoted to Foccart (CNRS Éditions, 2015) documents how early this architecture began. As far back as 1944, Foccart created Safiex, a West Indian and African import-export company whose commercial activities deliberately overlapped with his political functions under de Gaulle: business and intelligence were never separated. In October 1949, he co-founded UPANG — the Private Union for Aid to General de Gaulle's Action — a private financing structure for African Gaullism backed by a network of businesses. From 1952 onward, he ran a monthly committee bringing together officers of the colonial army: an information network running parallel to the official channels of the Republic.

Remarkably, it is a political opponent who confirms the scale of the setup. François Mitterrand, then minister for Overseas France, declared in a Council of Ministers meeting in 1950–1951: *"I shouldn't say I've been touring the French Union, but rather the Gaullist Union."* Gaullist Françafrique was thus already structuring the continent under the Fourth Republic — well before formal independence.

The country that said no

Only one country refused the script. On August 25, 1958, in Conakry, Ahmed Sékou Touré welcomed General de Gaulle, who had come to defend his project for a Franco-African Community. De Gaulle had been clear: territories that voted no in the referendum of September 28 would obtain immediate independence — and lose all French support. Before him, Sékou Touré delivered the line that still echoes today.

Guinea voted no. It became independent on October 2, 1958, two years ahead of the others.

France's response was immediate and total. On their way out, French officials removed or destroyed everything: archives, office equipment, telephones, hospital medicines, down to the lightbulbs. This was not a departure — it was organized sabotage. The goal was explicit: punish Guinea and show the other colonies what awaited them should they choose the same path.

Sixty-five years later, France would apply to General Tiani's Niger mechanisms that feel strangely familiar: suspension of aid, pressure from financial institutions, military threats channeled through neighboring states. Same doctrine. Same conviction that African peoples can be brought to reason through hunger. The method has not aged. It has only been refined.

The fate of the pioneers

What was at stake for those who took independence seriously, four destinies suffice to tell.

Sylvanus Olympio first. An economist trained at the London School of Economics and a former senior executive at Unilever, he led Togo to independence on April 27, 1960 and set out to give his country its own currency, outside the franc zone. On January 13, 1963 — six days after confirming the creation of the Togolese franc — he was shot dead in Lomé by a group of soldiers, among them Sergeant Étienne Gnassingbé Eyadéma, who would claim the shooting and later rule the country for thirty-eight years. Olympio is the first president assassinated in independence-era Africa. He never lived to see the Togolese franc circulate. The message was clear to every other African head of state: sovereign currency comes at a price.

Patrice Lumumba next. The first prime minister of independent Congo on June 30, 1960, he committed the crime of wanting the country's mineral wealth to benefit the Congolese. Removed from office in September 1960 with the backing of Western powers, arrested, he was transferred to secessionist Katanga and assassinated on January 17, 1961, along with his companions Maurice Mpolo and Joseph Okito. He was thirty-five. In 2002, a Belgian parliamentary commission would officially acknowledge Belgium's "moral responsibility" for this assassination. In 2022, his tooth — the only remnant of his body, dissolved in acid by his killers — was returned to his family. His tooth. After sixty years. That is all they left of him.

Modibo Keita as well. Mali's first president, proclaimed on September 22, 1960, a committed pan-

Africanist, in 1962 he dared to create the Malian franc to take his country out of the franc zone — the next chapter will show what that cost him. On November 19, 1968, he was overthrown by the military coup of Lieutenant Moussa Traoré. He died in detention in Bamako on May 16, 1977, never having been tried.

Kwame Nkrumah finally. The man who led the Gold Coast — become Ghana — to independence on March 6, 1957, the first sub-Saharan colony to break its chains; the theorist of continental unity, architect of the short-lived Ghana-Guinea-Mali Union of 1958–1961. On February 24, 1966, while en route to Hanoi, the army and police seized power in Accra. He would never see Ghana again and died in exile in 1972.

Four pioneers. Two assassinated, two overthrown. None completed his term. The lesson, however, was perfectly received by those who survived.

Independence and its outcome, sixty years on

Country | Independence date | 2023 HDI ranking (UNDP)

- Niger — August 3, 1960 — 189th/191
|
- Mali — September 22, 1960 — 185th/191
|
- Burkina Faso (formerly Upper Volta) — August 5, 1960 — 184th/191
|
- Guinea — October 2, 1958 (said no) — —

The three AES countries rank among the world's last five, sixty-five years after independence. This ranking is the product of an architecture, not a statistical coincidence. A result cannot be an accident when everything was designed to produce it.

"Bleached" independences

Nathalie Yamb puts it in simple terms: the independences of the 1960s were not real independences. They were "cut-rate" independences, entrusted to Paris-trained elites — "bleached independence fighters" who kept the structures of dependency in place. And the cycle repeats every thirty years: the 1960s produced confiscated independence; the 1990s, confiscated multipartyism; the 2020s, sovereignism. If the structures do not change, in thirty years everything will have to start over.

Cameroonian political scientist Banda Kani pushes the critique a step further: he disputes the very word

"outcome." Drawing up the outcome of a presence, he observes, presupposes that this presence has ended — yet "the first thing any honest accounting reveals is that there has never been any decolonization." France is, in his view, "the last colonial empire in the middle of the twenty-first century." His proof lies in a linguistic fact no one notices: France is the only former colonial power that still claims to have an "African policy." One does not hear Belgium speak of a "Congolese policy," nor Germany, Portugal, or the Netherlands of an "African policy" — these powers left, and their vocabulary shows it.

What remains is to understand what, exactly, was locked in place in 1960. For that, one must open the account books — for it is in the figures, far more than in the speeches, that the colonial pact was camouflaged.

CHAPTER 6 — THE NEOCOLONIAL PACT

"We must acknowledge that a great deal of the money in our wallets comes precisely from the exploitation of Africa over centuries. We need the common sense, and the justice, to return to Africans what was taken from them." — Jacques Chirac, former President of the French Republic

A television set, years after the fact. Loïk Le Floch-Prigent, former CEO of Elf, calmly explains how France's leading oil company operated in Africa:

"We're talking about oil that comes out roughly at 3 to 4 dollars, and then we sell it at 80. All that money in between goes to a certain number of people."

Seventy-six dollars of difference per barrel. Millions of barrels. And "a certain number of people" who, as we shall see, would go on to fund French election campaigns. French elections are paid for by African oil. This is not a metaphor.

This admission is not an anecdote. It is the description, by one of its own operators, of a system. This chapter takes apart its architecture: a colonial pact that was never abolished in 1960 — merely camouflaged under new terms.

Analyst Banda Kani pushes this observation to its logical, dizzying conclusion. We are constantly asked to draw up the "record of the French presence in Africa" — good, bad, catastrophic? But the question itself is a trap, for it presupposes something false: that colonization has ended. "You don't hear Germany speak of its 'African policy,' nor Portugal, nor Holland, nor Belgium. Why does France alone claim such an anachronism in the middle of the twenty-first century?" The answer is in the question: if France still speaks of an "African policy," if its president decides from Paris the future of a continent in place of its own leaders, it is because it never withdrew. The first point of any honest accounting is therefore this: there has never been any decolonization. France is the last active colonial empire — an empire that negotiated façade independences in order to never leave. This is what Banda Kani calls the "outstanding dispute of decolonization": any discourse that claims to analyze the Franco-African relationship without first asking this question is a discourse that lies.

A fiscal birth

To understand the pact, one must go back before independence. On April 13, 1900, the French Parliament passed the law of financial autonomy for the colonies: from then on, colonial administrations had to

finance themselves through resources levied locally. Colonized populations paid the salaries of their occupiers — their governors, their police, their roads, their schools for settlers. The metropole was unwilling to contribute a single centime.

The system rested on two levers. The first was the head tax — a per-capita levy, inherited from the Ancien Régime, abolished in France in 1789 by the revolutionaries and revived in the colonies. In Algeria in 1909, 90% of the native population paid 70% of direct taxes, while settlers were largely exempt. The second lever was forced labor, politely called "prestation": in French West Africa, between 1920 and 1938, every road, track, and airfield was built by unpaid labor. Free for the Empire. Paid for in blood and sweat by Africans.

The link between this colonial taxation and currency is direct. To pay the head tax, one needed francs. To obtain francs, one had to sell one's produce — otherwise, it was prison or forced labor. The colonial franc was not born as a medium of exchange: it was born as an instrument of fiscal extraction.

On December 26, 1945, France institutionalized the tool by creating the CFA franc — an acronym that at the time stood, without euphemism, for "Colonies Françaises d'Afrique" (French Colonies of Africa). After independence, the name changed discreetly: "Communauté Financière Africaine" (African Financial Community) in the west, "Coopération Financière en Afrique centrale" (Financial Cooperation in Central Africa) elsewhere. The initials stayed the same. So did the reality.

One figure suffices to prove it: from 1945 to 1975, 100% of the foreign exchange reserves of the franc zone's African countries were deposited with the French Treasury; since 1975, this rate has been 50% — which today represents 17 billion euros of African reserves sitting idle in Paris, lent back to Africans in the form of aid or credit: Africa finances its own dependency. Cheikh Anta Diop found the exact metaphor: rent that dares not speak its name. The full monetary mechanism deserves a chapter of its own; that will be the next one.

Monopoly as principle

The pact is not limited to currency. Frédéric Turpin (2015) documents the mechanics of trade preferences: Jacques Foccart successfully backed the appointment of Thomson as the exclusive supplier of telephone exchanges for every French-speaking African state. No tender. A political decision dressed up as a technical one. The African market — captive, vast, free of competition — handed to a French company by informal decree.

Even more revealing: Maurice Yaméogo, president of Upper Volta, himself proposed to Foccart that his company Safiex be granted a monopoly on the exports and imports of his entire country. African economies were not, then, always plundered despite their leaders. They were sometimes handed over by them — in exchange for the political protection only the Foccart network could guarantee. This is what Dr. Yamb Ntimba calls the "compradors": African elites who manage dependency for the benefit of the outside world, and for

their own.

The sequence of the 1990s shows the pact knows how to modernize. The La Baule speech (1990) imposed multipartyism — the result: political fragmentation, with more than two hundred parties in countries of fewer than a hundred million inhabitants. Four years later, in 1994, the devaluation of the CFA franc halved, overnight, the purchasing power of millions of Africans. To devalue a currency is to decree that it is worth less: wages and savings stay the same in nominal terms, but everything imported costs twice as much. Political fragmentation, then economic strangulation: a coordinated sequence, not a coincidence. General Tiani recalled this in his speech of February 12, 2024 on RTN.

The "new empires": privatization as a second colonization

The pact did not stop at independence, nor even at the Foccart generation. It changed shape in the 1990s, at the precise moment when, according to the 2025 report by the association Survie, *What remains of France's economic interests in Africa?*, France's major corporations — Accor, Axa, L'Oréal, Peugeot, Renault, Saint-Gobain — were massively deserting the continent to rush toward Asia and the Americas, judged more profitable. Africa, marginalized by the globalization of French capitalism, then became the hunting ground of a second tier of companies, less known to the general public but just as structuring: these are Françafrique's "new empires," built no longer on raw extraction but on the privatizations imposed by structural adjustment programs.

The mechanism is documented company by company. Bolloré builds itself, within a few years, a tobacco empire — plantations, production, sales — resold in 2001 to Britain's Imperial Tobacco, before pivoting to logistics and rail: concessions for the Abidjan-Ouagadougou line in 1995, Douala-Ngaoundéré in Cameroon in 1999, Cotonou-Parakou in Benin in 2015, and above all a near-monopoly over port concessions in the Gulf of Guinea — the lungs through which several states' foreign trade passes. Castel, by buying up the Brasseries et Glacières Internationales (BGI) company, takes hold of Angolan beer production and the Saint-Georges Breweries in Ethiopia. Saur, then a Bouygues subsidiary, seizes Ivorian electricity and water as early as the late 1980s, then water distribution in the Central African Republic (1991), Senegal (1996), and water and electricity in Mali (2000). Its competitor, the Compagnie Générale des Eaux — renamed Vivendi in 1998 — grabs concessions in Gabon, Chad, the Comoros, and Niger.

The most spectacular case remains telecommunications. France Télécom, weakened by competition on its European markets, turns Africa into a vital growth engine: in January 1997, it takes control of the Ivorian operator, then buys into Senegal's Sonatel, acquires the Mauritian and Central African state operators, sets up in Cameroon, Niger, Madagascar, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau, Mali — then sets out to conquer anglophone markets, in Botswana, Kenya, Uganda, Sierra Leone. Within about ten years, under its new brand Orange, the group

plants its flag in fifteen African countries and becomes the continent's second-largest operator. These are not isolated acquisitions: it is a methodical reconquest, sector by sector, using the former francophone colonies as a rear base before pushing into anglophone or lusophone territory.

What this second tier of companies reveals is the pact's continuity in an updated form: where Foccart imposed monopolies by informal decree, the 1990s obtained them through the wave of privatizations — a legal, "liberal" packaging for the same end. The vital infrastructure of daily African life — water, electricity, telephony, tobacco, transport — passes from the hands of the colonial state into the hands of private French companies, without ever passing back into the hands of the peoples concerned.

The chain of plunder, told by its own links

The architecture is best described by the voices of its own actors. Pascal Lissouba, president of Congo from 1992 to 1997:

"We knew nothing of what was happening, and we didn't even know the quantity of oil leaving our country."

A head of state recognized by the UN admits that his own country did not know its own production: the wells were offshore, the tankers belonged to Elf, the figures were supplied by Elf — and Congolese authorities "had no way to go and verify." Sovereignty over resources: zero. Sovereignty over symbols — flag, anthem, seat at the UN: intact. That was precisely the point.

From Abidjan, Mamadou Koulibaly, former finance minister of Côte d'Ivoire:

"The tankers come to fill up and then leave, and it's them who tell us: well, we took 10 barrels, 20 barrels, and we book that in the budget."

Two former ministers, two countries, the same story.

And the machine feeds itself. Robert Bourgi, a Franco-Lebanese lawyer and briefcase-carrier for the Élysée, recounts his rounds to see Omar Bongo, Blaise Compaoré, Denis Sassou-Nguesso, or Mobutu, bearing a message from Paris: contribute to the campaign of "your friend." "It never fell below a million dollars." For Jacques Chirac's 1995 campaign alone: at least 100 million dollars. Laurent Gbagbo, upon his release by the ICC, admitted to handing over 3 million euros at the request of Chirac and Villepin. Charles Pasqua publicly acknowledged in *Le Parisien* that Balladur wanted to "cut off the socialists' funding" by replacing Le Floch-Prigent at the head of Elf.

African oil, bought at four dollars, was financing French democracy.

The circuit of plunder

Stage	Mechanism
● Extraction	African resources at a discounted price (\$4 for oil resold at \$80)
● Opacity	Undeclared cargoes, figures unverifiable by producing states
● Redistribution	Political funding via briefcases (Bourgi) and offshore networks
● Return	French election campaigns paid for by African heads of state
● Impunity	Double: African states cannot verify, French courts look the other way

When the adversary confesses

This system has evidence — and the most damning comes from the opposing camp itself. Jacques Chirac, President of the Republic, admits without hedging: the bulk of France's wealth comes from the exploitation of Africa. Jules Ferry had theorized as much back in the nineteenth century: *"France needs its colonies for its economic markets."* A president and his predecessor by a century. The same sentence. The same reality.

It now also has judges. On April 13, 2026, a French court sentences Lafarge's former executives to six and five years in prison for financing terrorism in Syria. France Inter revealed in May 2023 that the Castel group is under investigation by the anti-terrorism prosecutor's office for financing armed militias in the Central African Republic. Two French multinationals, two countries, two proceedings. The financing of armed groups by French companies is no longer a pan-Africanist thesis. It is a judicial fact.

Moreover, the FATF (Financial Action Task Force) prosecutors' report, obtained by Nathalie Yamb, illustrates the hypocrisy of the fight against money laundering: funds embezzled from Africa pass through Luxembourgish, Monegasque, and French banks under the supervision of the very same regulators who sanction the AES for insufficient compliance. The fight against money laundering is selective by design. When it is African money flowing to Paris, it is cooperation. When it is the AES that refuses to account for itself, it is opacity.

Briefcases, monopolies, phantom cargoes: none of these levers, however, would hold without the central

lock of the whole arrangement — the currency itself, and it is that which must now be faced head-on.

CHAPTER 7 — THE CFA FRANC

"Currency is the mother of sovereignties. You cannot be sovereign if you have no currency." — Dr. Douma Jean-René, Panafrican Média TV, May 10, 2026

A market morning in Niamey. A trader hands back change on a worn, folded thousand-CFA-franc note. This note was not printed in Niger, nor in any African country: it comes off the presses of the Bank of France, in Chamalières, in the Auvergne region. Its value is set in Paris. Its guarantee depends on the French Treasury. Fifteen African countries, tens of millions of daily transactions — and not a single monetary decision that truly belongs to those holding the note in their hands.

The CFA franc is a French currency deployed in Africa, not an African currency. This chapter explains why that sentence is a technical description, not a slogan — and why everyone who tried to break free of it too soon paid the steepest price. Some with their freedom. Others with their lives.

The operations account, or sovereignty in escrow

The previous chapter traced the birth of the CFA franc in 1945 and its original fiscal function. What remains is to understand how it works today. The heart of the mechanism is called the operations account: in exchange for the guarantee of convertibility granted by the French Treasury, member states must deposit 50% of their foreign exchange reserves in an account opened in Paris (100% from 1945 to 1975, reduced to 50% since 1975 — and despite the administrative reform of 2019, which changed the mechanism's name, 17 billion euros of African reserves remain held in Paris today; the structure of dependency remains fully intact).

Two technical notions hide inside that sentence. First, the guarantee of convertibility: the promise that the CFA franc can always be exchanged for euros, at a fixed rate. Presented as protection, it is above all a leash — for whoever guarantees also sets the terms. Second, the operations account: the French Treasury account where half the foreign-currency savings of fifteen African countries sit dormant.

When Niger sells its uranium or Mali its gold to a foreign buyer, the hard currency earned passes through this Paris account. France thus knows, in real time, the export flows of every country; it can block transactions; it effectively controls the monetary policy of nations that are, in theory, sovereign. The exchange rate is set in Paris. African central banks are headquartered in Dakar or Yaoundé, but their leadership is systematically trained in Paris and guided from Paris. The form is African. The substance is French.

And the irony is complete, as journalist Albert Anatole Ayissi points out: *"Even French expatriates in*

Africa are not paid in CFA francs — they are paid in euros.”

The operations account, plainly stated

<i>Element</i>	<i>Reality</i>
● The principle	France “guarantees” the convertibility of the CFA franc into euros
● The price	100% of reserves deposited with the French Treasury from 1945 to 1975; 50% since 1975 — that is, 17 billion euros of African reserves still held in Paris today
● The consequence	Paris sees every export flow pass through, can block it, and sets the exchange rate
● The scale	Fifteen African countries currently use this currency, manufactured and controlled in France

The price of leaving

Emmanuel Macron has stated publicly that Africans are “free to leave the CFA franc if they want.” That is the rhetoric. The reality is documented in bodies.

“We know of many African leaders who were assassinated simply for raising the possibility of ending the CFA franc.” — Albert Anatole Ayissi

The list is precise. Sylvanus Olympio had launched the creation of a Togolese franc and refused to join the franc zone: he was assassinated on January 13, 1963, six days after confirming that refusal. Thomas Sankara had raised the possibility of leaving the CFA franc: assassinated in 1987. Muammar Gaddafi had gone well beyond the planning stage: he had repatriated 120 tons of gold, invested more than 20 billion dollars on the continent between 2000 and 2010 — more than the World Bank and the IMF combined — and launched three institutions to underpin a gold-backed African dinar (an African Monetary Fund in Yaoundé, an African Central Bank in Abuja, an African Investment Fund in Tripoli). The infrastructure existed. The gold was there. The statutes were drafted. He was eliminated in 2011. The correlation is not anecdotal. It is the rule. Announcing monetary emancipation is, in French-speaking Africa, a documented, mortally risky act.

And when the man is not killed, the currency is. Sékou Touré's Guinea offers the textbook case for these reprisals. By voting "no" on September 28, 1958, Conakry set France's secret machinery in motion. The SDECE set up headquarters in Dakar, with outposts in Tambacounda and Abidjan; armed and trained Guinean exiles; financed insurrections. Its centerpiece was monetary: SDECE presses printed millions of counterfeit Guinean francs to flood the country and collapse the fledgling economy — a method directly copied from the Nazi "Operation Bernhard," which had targeted England during the Second World War. The operation was code-named after a brand of laundry detergent: "Persil." France applied against a sovereign African state an economic-warfare technique borrowed from the Nazis. The name "Persil" laundered the conscience. It did not launder the crime.

The Malian franc, created by Modibo Keita in July 1962, collapsed under systematic speculation organized from Paris, forcing Bamako to rejoin the franc zone. And in 1994, the devaluation decided in Paris cut the purchasing power of the entire zone in half, overnight.

The inconvenient counter-examples

The official argument holds that the franc zone protects its members from instability. African history provides the first rebuttal: as early as 1958, Kwame Nkrumah's Ghana left the sterling zone and adopted its own currency — the former British colonial power sent neither planes nor fake money. Mauritania left the franc zone in 1973: it has since had its own national currency, the ouguiya, and shows a stable economy. Morocco, with its independent dirham, has built one of the continent's most diversified economies.

The ten largest African economies in 2020: Nigeria, South Africa, Egypt, Algeria, Morocco, Ethiopia, Kenya, Angola, Ghana, Tanzania — not a single CFA zone country. France's leading trading partners in Africa — Morocco, Algeria, Angola, Tunisia, South Africa, Nigeria, Kenya — do not include one either. The conclusion is inescapable: with these countries, France must negotiate as an equal. With CFA zone countries, it simply takes. The franc zone is a space of captivity, not protection.

The 2026 edition of the IMD Business School's World Competitiveness Ranking confirms this geography. Out of 70 countries assessed, six African countries appear in the ranking — South Africa (54th), Kenya (55th), Ghana (64th), Botswana (66th), Nigeria (68th), and Namibia (70th). Zero CFA zone countries. The six African economies judged most "competitive" by the criteria of the dominant global economy are all outside the French monetary empire. And despite this compliance with the rules of the system, they still trail at the bottom of the world ranking — sixty-fourth through seventieth out of seventy. The "reward" promised to the good students of the international economic order is last place. As for AES countries — Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger — they do not appear at all: excluded from the ranking, as they are excluded from the narrative of competitiveness, because a country plundered for a century cannot appear in a performance ranking built by the

very people who plundered it.

Guinea, often wielded as the decisive argument against monetary sovereignty, is not an example of a sovereign currency that failed on its own. It is an example of an economy methodically sabotaged from birth: SDECE counterfeit notes, armed exiles, financed insurrections, plots to eliminate the president. Comparing Guinea to sovereign, un-sabotaged economies is like comparing a fair race to one where a competitor grabs the ankles of the runner next to him at the starting gun.

The trial by presumed incapacity

To justify tutelage, one must first humiliate the ward. The most vicious argument against African monetary sovereignty is not economic: it is racist. It has been stated bluntly — that Africans supposedly have a “congenital incapacity to manage a currency.” An incapacity from birth. Written, it would seem, into the blood.

The answer fits in one name: Pierre Bérégovoy. This man managed France’s currency, as Minister of the Economy and Finance, before becoming Prime Minister. A fitter by trade, with no degree in economics, he steered the franc through the 1980s. Managing a currency is no child’s play — but neither is it a genetic gift reserved for one race. It is a matter of good governance, competence, and political will. What Bérégovoy did for France, Africans can do for Africa. The Moroccan dirham already proves it: pegged half to the euro and half to the dollar, it is stable — and neither Europe nor the United States interferes in its management. An African currency can be sovereign *and* stable. Morocco demonstrates this every day.

The true obstacle to African development is thus not incapacity, but a posture: financial begging. Holding out one’s hand develops no country — foreign aid perpetuates the very dependency it claims to cure, and it masks bad governance rather than correcting it. Africa can succeed without foreign aid, on two conditions that its youth must enforce:

- **Fight capital flight:** recognize that this money belongs to Africans, and demand the monetary sovereignty needed to keep it.
- **Industrialize raw materials:** stop exporting raw material only to import the finished product. Côte d’Ivoire, the world’s leading cocoa producer, could process its cocoa locally — and capture the value of chocolate instead of surrendering that value to Europe.

Monetary sovereignty is only one side of the coin. The other is local processing. Neither alone is enough. Together, they break the chain.

A weapon that stays loaded

That the monetary lever remains a live threat, the year 2026 confirms. In May, Bloomberg and Citigroup recommend a devaluation of the CEMAC zone's CFA franc — a signal that Jonathan Batenguène reads as evidence that devaluation remains, in France's toolkit, an available lever of pressure. Thirty-two years after 1994, the same scenario is back on the table. The lock has not rusted. It is waiting.

Senegalese economist Ndongo Samba Sylla has demolished, data in hand, every argument made by defenders of the CFA:

- CFA countries represent 2.6% of the world's population and only 0.3% of global GDP — three times less than their demographic weight — the result of an architecture, not of bad luck.
- Over the period 1995–2021, trade among CEMAC countries averaged 1.5% a year. After 80 years of a common currency, trade integration among African countries is close to zero. The only integration created by the CFA is that of African economies with the French economy.
- South Korea (1960–1990): growth of 7.6% — GDP doubling every 9 years — with average inflation of 12% and peaks of 30%. "Price stability" has never been a precondition for development. It is sometimes an obstacle to it.
- Among the 27 African countries with the best growth performance over 2000–2019, only 3 belong to the CFA zone.
- Côte d'Ivoire: GDP per capita of \$2,868 in 1978, fallen to \$2,055 in 2022 — a 28% decline. Republic of Congo: –56% since 1976. Equatorial Guinea: –58%.
- 71 successful coups in CFA countries alone since 1960, including 14 between 2020 and 2023.
- Of 609 IMF loans granted to Africa since independence, 200 went to the 14 CFA countries (a third of all loans). Senegal: 22 loans since 1960.

The most irrefutable proof is a natural experiment: researchers compared Akan peoples living on either side of the border between Côte d'Ivoire (CFA zone) and Ghana (national currency). Same language, same culture, same geographic conditions. One single variable differs: the currency. The result: human development indicators are markedly higher in Ghana. This is no longer an opinion. It is an experiment with a control group. And it shows that the CFA franc has been disastrous for those it claims to protect.

A single African currency remains a hollow promise as long as the CFA zone exists: one cannot build real African economic integration with a currency whose rules are decided in Paris. The AES confederation's project to create its own common currency is not a nationalist fantasy. It is the structural precondition for real sovereignty. Without its own currency, sovereignty remains a word on a flag.

General Tiani put it in one sentence, on February 12, 2024 on RTN: *"Currency is a step toward exiting colonization. When the moment is right, we will decide."*

What a French report confirms, despite itself

In 2025, the association Survie publishes *What remains of France's economic interests in Africa?* — a report that comes not from the pan-Africanist camp but from a French NGO cross-referencing official foreign trade statistics, Eurostat, and Bank of France data. This is not a militant thesis: these are state figures. And these figures confirm, by another route, the architecture of captivity described in this chapter.

The report first documents the scale of the French commercial collapse in sub-Saharan Africa: France's market share there fell from 15% in the late 1970s to 3% today — divided by five. But this overall decline masks a two-speed reality that Survie lays out in black and white: in the former colonies using the CFA franc, France's market share has stabilized since the mid-2010s at 10 to 12% — nearly six times higher than in the rest of the continent, and four times higher than in the rest of the world. As of this writing, the CFA pré carré remains the only place on earth where France retains a dominant position — that is, precisely the one place where the currency is not its own, but where it continues to set the rules.

The report itself questions the CFA franc's role in this resilience, in a box titled "Is the CFA franc serving French interests?" Its conclusion is cautious on the strictly statistical level — for lack of public data on the profitability of French investments by country, Survie cannot demonstrate that French companies are more profitable in the CFA zone than elsewhere on the continent. But the report documents what matters more than accounting profitability: the mechanism. The fixed exchange rate, free euro-CFA convertibility, and freedom of capital transfer reduce transaction costs, guarantee the value of French assets held locally, and eliminate exchange-rate risk — and therefore its hedging cost. A structurally overvalued CFA franc, as is the case today, functions as a subsidy to European exports within the zone, at the cost of the competitiveness of local producers, African and foreign alike, who must sell at a higher price than their competitors in unpegged currencies. This is not a conspiracy theory: it is the very definition of an exchange rate set from outside for the benefit of whoever set it.

The report adds a piece the French press never relays: beyond trade flows, there are 2,421 French company subsidiaries operating in sub-Saharan Africa, generating on average €41.2 billion in annual revenue — nearly four times the total value of French exports to the region, and double the revenue of German subsidiaries, even though Germany exports more to the continent. These subsidiaries are concentrated at 58%, and up to 70% excluding South Africa, in the former French colonies — that is, in the franc zone and its immediate surroundings. The CFA franc's function is therefore not only to fix an exchange rate: it creates a climate of legal and financial security that retains, on the ground, a web of subsidiaries that even foreign trade statistics

alone cannot reveal. This is the demonstration, produced by a French source itself hostile to the system it describes, that the closed loop analyzed earlier in this chapter is not pan-Africanist paranoia: it is a documented, quantified architecture, renewed year after year.

To sum up: a currency born of a colonial tax, printed in the Auvergne, secured against reserves deposited in Paris, whose exit has cost the lives of those who attempted it too soon — that is the financial foundation of the neocolonial pact. But a currency only locks down what has value — and to measure exactly what this lock protects, one must now go to where the wealth comes out of the ground: to Arlit, in the Nigerien desert.

The CFA franc, a zero-cost instrument for financing terrorism

"It costs France nothing to organize attacks against Mali, Burkina Faso, and especially Niger. Human life, African life, has no value in its eyes. Only lost wealth matters."

Western chancelleries prefer not to state the following equation too plainly: the Bank of France prints CFA francs. The armed groups operating in the Sahel — called terrorists, jihadists, or rebels depending on the needs of the moment — are paid in CFA francs. A motorbike and a few 10,000-FCFA notes are enough to recruit an unemployed man with no prospects. Conclusion: financing the destabilization of Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger costs France no hard currency at all. Zero dollars. Zero euros. Zero yuan. Zero pounds sterling.

This is the most cynical mechanism of Françafrique — and the most under-documented.

The currency of predation

This book documented, in Chapter 7, how the CFA franc functions as an instrument of monetary dependency: issued by the Central Bank of West African States (BCEAO) and the Bank of Central African States (BEAC), but with its exchange peg and reserves historically tied to Paris. The notes are printed in France. Monetary policy is bound by agreements that limit the sovereignty of member states.

What this mechanism reveals in its security dimension is even more brutal: a currency whose issuance Paris controls, used to finance armed groups that destabilize the very states that use this currency, allows Paris to finance the war against those states without ever spending a cent of international hard currency. It is a closed loop. France prints, the terrorists receive, African states bleed — and Parisian foreign exchange reserves remain untouched.

Unemployment as a recruiting room

The thesis does not stop at currency. It raises the question of social conditions as a lever for recruitment.

As long as poverty persists in this region, a motorbike and a few 10,000-FCFA notes will drive any unemployed man to take up arms against his brother.

This is not a metaphor. Studies of recruitment into Sahelian armed groups — JNIM, ISGS, affiliated *katibas* — show that the promise of immediate income is the leading factor in recruitment, ahead of ideological commitment. An eighteen-year-old with no job, no schooling, no prospects, in an area where the state has been absent for decades, does not choose ideology — he chooses survival. Ideology comes after, if it comes at all.

Mass unemployment in the peripheral zones of the Sahel — Liptako-Gourma, Tillabéri, Mopti, Haute-Kotto — is not bad luck. It is the result of sixty years of structural adjustment policies that forbade African states from investing in rural infrastructure, maintaining civil servants in remote areas, and building the roads and schools in the very places where armed groups now recruit.

The weak link

Niger has been singled out as the AES's weak link — not by its enemies outside Africa, but by those with an interest in seeing the Confederation break apart. Niger is geographically landlocked, economically the most fragile of the three states, and holds uranium reserves that France has considered strategic since the days of Arlit-COGEMA. Destabilizing Niger could potentially shatter the Confederation and regain control over its resources.

The pressure on Niamey since the coup of July 2023 — ECOWAS sanctions, threats of military intervention, frozen assets — has had exactly this effect: isolating Niger, strangling it economically, and making it more vulnerable to the penetration of armed groups along its western and eastern borders. The strategy is easy to read.

The solution: mint your own currency

The conclusion follows on its own: as long as West Africa uses a currency whose issuance Paris controls, Paris will hold a zero-cost lever of destabilization. Monetary sovereignty is not an ideological whim — it is a condition of security survival.

The AES has begun breaking with the CFA system. It does not yet have an operational common currency. This is priority number one — not out of national pride, but because as long as Sahelian terrorists are paid in FCFA printed in Paris, the loop will remain closed, and blood will keep flowing for free.

The equation is simple: less poverty, less recruitment. Less external monetary control, less zero-cost financing. Economic sovereignty and security are not two separate issues — they are one and the same fight.

Sources: Analysis on the FCFA and the financing of terrorism, citizen op-ed, 2026; Chapter 7 of this book (the CFA franc: the invisible chain); reports on recruitment factors in Sahelian armed groups (ISS Africa,

2023-2025); data on Niger's uranium reserves and French interests (COGEMA/Orano, 2005-2023); ECOWAS sanctions against Niger, July-November 2023; Survie, What remains of France's economic interests in Africa?, 2025 (French market shares in the CFA zone, subsidiaries and revenue, CFA franc mechanism).

CHAPTER 8 — STRATEGIC RESOURCES: CONTRACTUALIZED PLUNDER

"Sprawling private firms today exploit 80% of Africa's gigantic deposits, and their profits are repatriated to tax havens." — André Chassaigne, MP, French National Assembly, December 2013

"In the name of greed, in the name of unrestrained capitalism, people's lives are put at risk to protect an investment." — Albert Anatole Ayissi, investigative journalist, publishing director of the newspaper Le Cactus

Arlit, northern Niger, 1971. In the middle of the desert, Cogema — which would become Areva, then Orano — sets up its extraction wells. A boomtown rises out of the sand. From that date until the 2023 transition, Nigerien uranium is extracted, transported, enriched, and sold by French companies. Niger receives a royalty. France keeps the margin. The entire margin.

And the margin, here, is no accounting footnote. It is a theft of 287 million euros a year. Fifty years of this arrangement, compounded, year after year.

This chapter is about a system, not an anomaly. Sub-Saharan Africa was built and has been maintained in a single role: that of a very-low-cost supplier of raw materials. This role is the sought objective, not the product of chance. The imposed economic structures, the international institutions, even the economics taught in African universities — everything works to preserve this status. And the actors are not limited to the former metropole: Europe, the United States, and China all share the same need for cheap African supply. The implacable consequence, rarely stated aloud, is this: if Africa stopped impoverishing itself, living standards would fall in Europe, North America, and Asia. African impoverishment is not a failure of global development — it is one of its conditions.

This is why every attempt at renegotiation, in Arlit as in Kayes as in Niamey, triggers such a disproportionate response. It is a world order being defended, not a mere contract.

The absolute paradox: uranium

Two figures say it all.

Orano paid €0.80/kg to Niger. The world reference price — the one paid in Canada, Australia, Kazakhstan — stood at \$200/kg. A ratio of 1 to 250 for the same atom, the same extraction effort, the same radioactivity, the same heat.

For 1,440 tons imported in 2022, France paid Niger 1.2 million euros. The world market would have demanded 288 million. The difference — 286.8 million euros — is what France silently siphoned out of the economy of a country whose total GDP does not exceed 17 billion dollars. Every single year.

The NGO Sherpa had documented this soberly as early as 2013: Nigerien uranium was being bought 30 to 40% below the world price. Figures from the French High Committee for Transparency and Information on Nuclear Security fill in the picture: Niger accounted for 35% of French concentrated uranium imports in 2020, 34% in 2021. Without Niger, France loses a decisive share of the energy independence it boasts of in contrast to Germany's dependence on Russian gas. The paradox is complete: France is "independent" thanks to a country whose dependency it has methodically maintained.

Nathalie Yamb shed light on the contradiction French officials cynically brandished — why did Paris "scream, send in terrorists, violate the Vienna Convention" when Niamey demanded Orano's departure, when Nigerien uranium accounted for only 20% of France's nuclear electricity supply? The answer lies in the margin: in Niger, Orano bought at a discount. In Kazakhstan, Australia, Canada, it had to pay the market price. It was never volume that was strategic. It was the margin.

Jean-Bedel Bokassa put it bluntly for Central Africa: *"From 1966 to today, neither France nor Switzerland has paid a single franc"* for the uranium extracted.

Niger: the anatomy of a paradox

<i>Indicator</i>	<i>Data</i>
● Share of French uranium imports	35% in 2020 (High Committee for Nuclear Transparency)
● Share of French nuclear electricity sourced from Niger	20%
● Nigerien production imported by France (2022)	1,440 tons
● Price paid by Orano to Niger	€0.80/kg
● World reference price (Canada/Kazakhstan)	\$200/kg
● What France actually paid	€1.2 million/year
● What the world market would have demanded	€288 million/year
● Shortfall for Niger	€287 million/year
● Historical price paid	30 to 40% below world price (NGO Sherpa, 2013)
● Radioactive contamination in Arlit	Documented by Greenpeace since 2010
● Access to electricity	Less than 20% of the population (World Bank, 2022)
● HDI	189th out of 191 (UNDP, 2023)
● Nigerien oil revenue after 2023	+218% (from 64 to 204 billion FCFA, 2020–2024)

What French diversification reveals — and does not reveal

The 2025 report by the association Survie, *What remains of France's economic interests in Africa?*, brings to the uranium file a piece that Orano's defenders gladly wave around, but which must be read to the end to grasp its real meaning. Since the last domestic mine closed in 2001, all of the natural uranium needed for French nuclear plants — about 8,000 tonnes a year — is imported. Its exact origin remains, as the report itself notes, "a well-kept secret": before becoming fuel, uranium passes through conversion and enrichment plants that are not necessarily located in France, so that Canadian uranium, converted elsewhere, does not appear in French import statistics even though it still feeds EDF's reactors.

Since 2004, EDF has pursued a policy of diversifying its suppliers at every stage of the fuel cycle. Canada's Cameco and Anglo-Australian BHP Billiton now rank prominently among its suppliers, and Orano covers only about 40% of total French supply — Niger's precise share of EDF's final mix can, for lack of official publication, no longer be measured with certainty. Over 2008–2012, the last consolidated data available, Niger nonetheless supplied 22.6% of the natural uranium used in French power plants, behind Kazakhstan (27.6%) but ahead of Canada (21.8%) and Australia (16.1%).

This diversification, presented in Paris as proof that Niger was "not strategic," in fact changes the question more than it answers it. It reduces the dependency of the end consumer — EDF — without reducing that of the extractor: in 2020–2022, the last period documented by the report, Orano still depended on Niger for a third of its global supply, its diversification attempts in Mongolia and Uzbekistan struggling to materialize. In other words, France could boast, hand on heart, that it no longer depended on Niger — while Orano, for its part, still depended on it for a third of its activity, and therefore for a considerable share of its profits. These are two different dependencies, and France only communicated about the one that suited it.

The invisible cost: radioactive water and darkness

When French ambassador Sylvain Itté mocked online — "*Stop drinking the water in Niamey, since it's European*" — Franklin Nyamsi decoded what the joke was masking: the groundwater tables of Arlit are polluted with residue from the uranium mines. Contamination documented by Greenpeace as early as 2010. Nigeriens are drinking radioactive water. No one decontaminates it. Less than 20% of Niger's population has access to electricity (World Bank, 2022).

The country that lights up France lives in darkness.

The multinationals were financing terrorists

The plunder of resources cannot be separated from the financing of the conflicts that secure it. Both are

the same system.

Lafarge in Syria. Between 2013 and 2014, through its subsidiary Lafarge Syria, the cement giant — today a subsidiary of Switzerland's Holcim — paid 5 million euros to jihadist groups, including the Islamic State (Daesh), to keep its Jalabiya plant running. The purpose was purely commercial: protecting an investment. In October 2024, three investigating judges ordered a trial for financing terrorism against the group and eight senior executives. The trial is set for November 4 to December 9, 2025.

Areva in Niger. The same pattern, adapted to the Sahel. Orano — formerly Areva — signed financial agreements with armed groups carefully labeled "rebels" rather than "terrorists," to secure its extraction sites. These groups provided protection for the sites. Less than two kilometers away, civilians were being massacred. Areva's installations were never touched. The rule can be stated simply: a mosque can burn 400 meters from a Lafarge site. A school can be razed two kilometers from an Areva facility. The installations, meanwhile, remain standing.

Total Energies in Mozambique. In Cabo Delgado, identical arrangements with terrorist groups to protect gas investments. Villages burned in the immediate vicinity of the platforms. The platforms, untouched.

It is a method, not a geographic coincidence.

The DGSE in the loop — is the French state an innocent bystander?

The Lafarge affair is structurally different from a corporate scandal. The reason: the DGSE (the French foreign intelligence service) is in the loop. According to available evidence, the financial arrangement with Daesh was signed under the banner of French intelligence services. The French state holds stakes in the group. The claim that Paris did not know is legally untenable.

The official line — "France does not negotiate with terrorists, does not pay ransoms" — is a fiction maintained for public opinion. Privately, the mechanisms are documented: ransoms pass through multinationals or private intermediaries, allowing the state to deny any direct involvement.

November 2024, a Paris court. Lafarge advances its central argument: *"The state knew what we were doing over there."* To test this claim, the court hears General Christophe Gomart, former head of Military Intelligence (DRM) — the chief of France's shadow army. His answer is surgical: yes, the services had indeed gathered information on one employee of Lafarge. No, they had no knowledge that millions of euros were directly financing Daesh.

Two readings, each as damning as the other.

- If Gomart is telling the truth: French military intelligence, deployed in Syria, capable of tracking individuals, was unaware that the largest French multinational in the area was paying jihadists 5 million euros.

Incompetence of an exceptional gravity — or a deliberate decision not to look.

- If Gomart is covering something up: the intelligence services knew, and are today choosing to shield both the state and the company.

Both hypotheses lead to the same place: the French state is not an innocent bystander. Either blind by design, or complicit by choice.

Gomart's trajectory since the hearing says everything about the price of that testimony: barely out of the burning files of military intelligence, cited in influence-peddling affairs, he went into politics. He is today a member of the European Parliament. Convenient for turning the page.

Intelligence agents under commercial cover

Foreign multinationals established in Africa are not merely economic actors. A significant share of their executives are agents of French, American, or British intelligence services, operating under commercial cover: Orange Énergie, Total, Areva. Not just for business. For espionage activities when needed.

This dual role explains why these companies enjoy state protection even when involved in criminal activity.

When embezzlement scandals implicate French executives in Cameroon — Camwater, Orange Cameroun — the French officials involved are extracted before any judicial proceeding can begin. Executives accused of sexual harassment or serious crimes are sent back to France to take up other positions of responsibility. African scapegoats stay behind bars. Foreign gang leaders leave.

Diplomatic status as a shield

The impunity mechanism rests on a precise legal tool: diplomatic status granted to agents who in reality hold no diplomatic function whatsoever.

Soldiers, mercenaries, American, French, or British agents present on the African continent enjoy diplomatic status. Whatever abuse they commit, they cannot be tried by African courts.

As long as this status exists, multinationals operate above African law. Everything begins there: with the revocation of this immunity for those who are not genuine diplomats. This is exactly what AES states have begun doing by terminating status of forces agreements (SOFAs) with France and demanding the withdrawal of troops.

Mali's gold: the renegotiation that sets precedent

In Mali, gold makes up more than 70% of exports. The state's historical share in its own mines: 10% or less, against multinationals. Ten percent. For the gold coming out of your own ground.

In 2023, the Malian transition renegotiated contracts with Barrick Gold, one of the world's two largest gold mining companies: higher royalties, 35% mandatory local content — a requirement to allocate a share of jobs, subcontracting, and purchasing to domestic companies and workers, instead of importing everything, exporting everything, impoverishing everything.

January 2024, the Loulo-Gounkoto mine is temporarily shut down amid tension. Canada threatens diplomatic retaliation. Bamako holds its position. Barrick submits to the renegotiation. The first concrete application of economic sovereignty pursued through legal means rather than expropriation: you do not chase off the investor, you change the terms of the contract. You change the balance of power.

Oil: 60-30-10

Oil offers the starkest X-ray of the model. In Congo-Brazzaville, Thomas Porcher (professor at PSB Paris) documented the split of oil revenue: 60% for Total, 30% for ENI, 10% for the Congolese state. Ten percent, for the country that owns the resource.

This ratio is no Congolese exception: the same order of magnitude prevails in Burkina Faso gold, and Mamadou Koulibaly confirms the same logic for Côte d'Ivoire. Not a regional coincidence — a systemic contractual model, imposed country by country, decade after decade.

Albert Anatole Ayissi summed it up: *"It was Areva's executives who informed the Nigerien authorities of the quantity extracted, and who set the price. The same is true for oil, for cocoa — the price is set not by the producers but by the consumers on international markets."*

The accounting mechanisms of plunder

The problem runs deeper still: the declared quantities are falsified at the source.

Phantom cargoes. Yamb documents the mechanism: ships load three holds of oil or uranium but declare only two. The third hold disappears from the statistics — never officially exported, never taxed, never counted in the 3 to 5% Paris cites as Africa's share of its foreign trade. Official figures are rigged at the dock, before the ship even leaves port.

Transfer pricing. An African subsidiary of Total or Orano extracts oil bought at 4 dollars a barrel by the French parent company. The parent company resells that same barrel at 80 dollars on the international market. All costs — extraction, transport, administration — are booked in the accounts of the African subsidiary, which declares minimal losses or profits and pays no tax. All the real profit is captured by the parent company in Paris,

London, or Amsterdam.

The equation is dauntingly coherent: raw materials leave the continent unprocessed; their price is set in London, Chicago, or New York; processing, added value, and industrial employment stay elsewhere. A continent that processes almost nothing becomes, in turn, a captive market for foreign manufactured goods. African subsoil finances the foreign industry that resells its products back to Africans. Plundered twice.

The rupture — proof by the numbers

The decisive argument arrived after 2023, and it is an accounting one.

In September 2023, Niger decides to revalue its uranium at €200/kg — the price Canada gets, the price Kazakhstan gets. Orano immediately suspends operations. France's reaction is total: sanctions, diplomatic pressure, an attempt to keep Bazoum in power by force. The violence of the response reveals what Paris dared not say: Niger was not a trading partner. It was a coerced supplier, whose compliance was guaranteed by decades of political interference and military presence.

In 2024, Niger terminates the Imouraren contracts signed with Orano — the largest as-yet-unexploited uranium mine in the world. The 119 billion dollars in revenue estimated over the life of the project will remain under national management or be renegotiated on Niger's terms. That day, Niamey did not beg. It decided.

Between 2020 and 2024, the Nigerien state's oil revenue jumps by 218% — from 64 to 204 billion FCFA. The same subsoil. The same ore. The same desert. Only the contract changed.

In Burkina Faso, the Traoré government receives, on May 25, 2025, tractors purchased directly with new mining revenue. The image, deliberately chosen, says what speeches would not: the money from the subsoil returns to Burkinabé soil. It grows seeds, not dividends in Paris.

What the plunder reveals

A public admission first. As early as December 2013, André Chassaigne said as much in plenary session at the French National Assembly — "sprawling private firms exploiting 80% of Africa's gigantic deposits, their profits repatriated to tax havens." Archived. Printed. Nothing moved for ten years. Nothing moved.

What the whole dossier reveals is of a dreadful clarity:

- France negotiates with terrorists — systematically, through its multinationals, its services, and its intermediaries — while publicly stating the opposite.
- Multinationals are instruments of foreign policy — their executives are agents under cover. Their secret arrangements are part of the strategy of influence.

- Impunity is structural — it rests on legal mechanisms (diplomatic status, cooperation agreements) that place foreign actors above African law.
- The Sahel drew the conclusions — by expelling Areva, Barkhane, and their parallel networks, AES states broke with this system. Not out of ideology. Out of a logic of survival.

One question remains, dizzying in scope: how could plunder this well documented last six decades without triggering a rupture? Because it was wrapped in the most effective of camouflages — a soft, almost tender word, called "aid."

Sources: French High Committee for Transparency and Information on Nuclear Security (HCTISN); NGO Sherpa, 2013 report; ER Velasco, "Niger Boosts Price of Uranium to €200 Per Kilogram From Just \$0.80," thedeepdive.ca, September 13, 2023; International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA); Thomas Porcher, PSB Paris; Albert Anatole Ayissi, investigative journalist, publishing director of Le Cactus; committal order of the Paris criminal court (October 2024); Lafarge/US Department of Justice plea agreement (2022); testimony of General Christophe Gomart (former DRM chief) at the Lafarge trial, Paris court, November 2024; Nathalie Yamb, public lectures; World Bank, Niger electricity access data 2022; UNDP, Human Development Report 2023; Survie, What remains of France's economic interests in Africa?, 2025 (EDF supplier diversification, Orano's dependency on Niger 2020-2022).

CHAPTER 9 — AID, DEBT, THE FINANCIAL ASSASSINS, AND THE FATF

"Official development aid is a con that mainly serves to give donors a clear conscience, when they know perfectly well the twisted use our heads of state make of that money." — Nathalie Yamb, Afrique Résurrection column, November 2022

Léopoldville, June 30, 1960. The Congo celebrates its independence. On that day, the new state counts sixteen university graduates for a population of fourteen million. Not one doctor. Not one engineer. Not one agronomist. And into the basket of independence, Belgium drops a gift: the debts it had itself incurred to colonize and exploit the country. The Congo is born already indebted for the price of its own servitude.

This mechanism — organized plunder followed by a bill handed to the victims — is not a Belgian exception. It is the model. This chapter tells how the bill became a system. How debt became a chain. How "aid" became the polite name for domination — and how an international financial body with not a single true African member state, the FATF, became the silent enforcement arm of that domination.

Odious debt: a legal concept, not a slogan

The legal doctrine has a name: odious debt. Jurist Alexandre Sack defined it as early as 1927 — debts incurred to colonize and enslave a population are not the responsibility of the victimized peoples. A people does not owe repayment for money borrowed to forge its own chains.

This principle is not theoretical: the Treaty of Versailles applied it as early as 1919, on behalf of Poland, exempted from German colonization debts. Yet the World Bank violated this very principle by financing Belgian, French, and British colonial administrations, then transferring these debts onto the states that became independent. The logic is implacable: colonize, go into debt to colonize, then hand the colony the bill on the day of its independence. A century of plunder, and it is the victim who receives the invoice.

Africa formulated its answer as early as 1993: the first Pan-African Conference on Reparations, held in Abuja, called for the cancellation of colonial debts, financial reparations, and the restitution of stolen cultural property. Thirty years later, a handful of objects are timidly beginning to return. For the rest, dead silence.

One precedent, however, proves the path exists. In 2008, Rafael Correa's Ecuador conducted a citizen audit of its debt — a public, line-by-line review of who lent what, to whom, and for what purpose — and refused to repay 70% of the amounts deemed illegitimate. Creditors accepted. This model is applicable. It has been applied. It is waiting for others to take it up.

Aid as a thermometer of obedience

Official development aid is the most sophisticated instrument of domination — not because of its size, but because it is presented as generosity when it is a lever. ODA is mostly made up of loans, not grants. Loans conditioned on opening markets, maintaining the CFA franc, and voting favorably in international institutions.

The best proof that aid is a political instrument? Its curve tracks obedience exactly. When a country obeys, the taps open. When it resists, they close.

French aid to Mali: timeline of a shakedown

Period | Amount | Context

- 2017–2021 — €587 million total — —
|
- 2018–2019 — ×7 (from 30 to 205 M€) — The years Bamako obeys
|
- 2020–2021 — ÷3 (from 110 to 39 M€) — The years of resistance
|
- August 2022 — Suspension — Expulsion of Barkhane
|
- November 2022 — Total suspension — —

The Central African Republic illustrates the mechanism in its crudest form. International budget aid there represents, depending on the year, 46 to 69 billion FCFA — up to 46% of the national budget. When France suspended its aid in 2021 to force out Wagner, it explicitly set three conditions for resumption: an end to “disinformation,” an end to “harassment of French companies,” and Wagner’s departure. And “disinformation,” in this grammar, is defined as any information unfavorable to French interests. Shut up, pay your bosses, and let them extract.

One detail alone demolishes the narrative of generosity: according to World Bank data, remittances from African migrants to their home countries far exceed official aid — the diaspora finances Africa more than all “donors” combined, with no conditions, no commissions, no clauses of obedience.

The aid that lends Africans their own money

A former director of an African central bank offered the revelation that completes the demolition of the generosity narrative. Without control of the CFA franc, he explains, “France would be an economic dwarf

in Europe.” The mechanism is precise. African exports — oil, gold, cocoa, manganese, palm oil — are paid in dollars. But those dollars never enter African treasuries: they pass through the operations accounts. Before 1974, 100% of this hard currency flowed into France; even today, 50% feeds the Bank of France and the French budget.

The contrast with the sterling zone is damning. Former British colonies had their own national currencies; their funds, deposited with the Bank of England, remained recoverable at any time and were never absorbed into the British budget. France, by contrast, melted African currencies into its own accounts. Some 17 billion euros of African reserves are thus withheld in France, funds that should be managed by African central banks.

And here is the final mechanism: through the interplay of the operations accounts of the fourteen countries, states in surplus finance those in deficit. “Development aid” thus consists, essentially, of lending Africans their own money — and charging them interest for the service. The French taxpayer sincerely believes he is helping Africa; he is merely recycling, under the name of aid, African funds confiscated at the source.

Confessions of a financial assassin

To understand the upper tier of the system, one must listen to a man who was one of its cogs. John Perkins spent decades as a “financial assassin” — an *Economic Hit Man* — in the service of what he calls the “corporatocracy”: the symbiosis between Western governments, multinationals, and international financial institutions. His testimony, *Confessions of an Economic Hit Man* (2004), describes from the inside a system that uses the IMF and the World Bank as weapons of economic conquest.

The mechanics are diabolically precise. A resource-rich country is offered a large loan to finance infrastructure: a power plant, a port, a highway. Economic studies promise growth that will pay for it all. These projections are deliberately inflated; they are never met.

“The money never really left the United States. It went straight from Washington to the coffers of Bechtel, Halliburton, Brown & Root. The countries received debt. The multinationals received contracts.” — John Perkins, Confessions of an Economic Hit Man

A few years later, when the country defaults — as had been anticipated from the start — the IMF and the World Bank arrive with their “structural adjustments”: privatize state-owned companies, open markets, slash health and education spending, sell off access to resources — and sometimes hand over military bases or UN votes.

“Sovereignty is mortgaged. That’s the contract.” — John Perkins, ibid.

Debt is not an accident of the system. It is the system: the continuation of colonization by other instruments. And when a leader resists? Perkins describes the hierarchy of recourse:

"When the EHMs fail to convince a recalcitrant leader, the jackals take over. And if the jackals fail, it's the military. We always have one more resort."

The "jackals": specialists in overthrows and fatal accidents. Lumumba, Sankara, Sékou Touré — African history is dotted with leaders who refused to enter the system. This is a documented model of action described by one of its own operatives, not a conspiracy theory.

The FATF: the neocolonial financial enforcement arm

There is one instrument economists never mention when analyzing African domination. Discreet, technical, run out of Paris. It is called the Financial Action Task Force (FATF).

On Friday, September 15, Kemi Seba is arrested at Cotonou airport and placed in custody along with six associates — seven people in total — on the specious grounds of inciting insurrection and money laundering. That same day, Nathalie Yamb receives an eight-page questionnaire from her bank concerning her latest account — the previous one having been closed unilaterally, with no explanation, exactly one year earlier, on September 15, 2022. It is the signature of a well-oiled system, not a coincidence.

The FATF has 39 members. Among them, a single African country: South Africa. This narrow club — Westerners plus a handful of Asian and South American countries — has appointed itself the arbiter of global standards on money laundering and terrorism financing, and plays global police. In its latest report, Cameroon, Vietnam, and Croatia are placed under enhanced monitoring, joining 23 countries on the grey list. North Korea, Iran, and Myanmar are on the black list. What you will find nowhere: the countries of the Global North. The founding members.

France finances terrorism — and chairs the FATF

The FATF monitors *"how criminals and terrorists collect and move funds."* If this were truly the case, France — where the organization is headquartered — would top the list of countries under surveillance.

The method of financing terrorism used by France — having Western nationals in Africa kidnapped, then paying astronomical ransoms for their release — has been documented and denounced for decades, not only by African states but by Westerners themselves, the United States first among them.

The most recent such operation involves Olivier Dubois, an RFI journalist kidnapped in Gao, Mali, in 2021 and released in Niger in March 2023 — after 711 days in captivity. Mainstream French media revealed

that French Barkhane soldiers had used the journalist, without his knowledge, to try to locate a jihadist leader, without preventing his kidnapping. The geographic shift is itself revealing: kidnapping in Mali, release in Niger. The French army had been expelled from Mali in August 2022 and had repositioned itself in Niger, then still led by Mohamed Bazoum. The terrorists relocated to Niger too, in order to release their hostages there.

An American, Jeff Woodke, was also released under this arrangement. His wife revealed that an initial ransom of 3 million dollars, later 6 million, had been demanded.

Dropping suitcases full of cash freshly printed by the Bank of France out of helicopters — that, per the FATF, does not count as financing terrorism. But being suspected of laxity toward NGOs that collect donations earns you an immediate spot on their list.

PEPs: a tool of financial censorship against activists

The FATF has established the category of PEPs — Politically Exposed Persons. The legal definition targets people holding senior public functions: heads of state, national politicians, senior officials, executives of state-owned companies — deemed susceptible to money laundering, corruption, terrorism financing, or drug trafficking.

Nathalie Yamb is a human resources, strategy, and communications consultant. Safia is a historian. Kemi Seba is a thinker and author. None of them, nor any of their relatives, has ever held state office. Their bank accounts are being closed one after another.

Yet when the children of Mohamed Bazoum, Alassane Ouattara, or Macky Sall's wife open bank accounts in Europe, no one asks questions. When Brice Oligui buys three houses in the United States as a senior official of the Gabonese army — it passes without comment. At what point, on what legal basis, do activists working to awaken African populations end up in PEP databases — if not by the will of French services intent on silencing those who disturb them?

The FATF doctors its own reports

France reached an understanding with the FATF to doctor the conclusions of its latest report in its own favor. Which says everything one needs to know about this body.

How is it that Ukraine — unanimously recognized as one of the most corrupt countries on the planet for over ten years, whose weapons delivered for the conflict with Russia end up in the hands of militias in the DRC or organized crime in Europe — does not appear on the lists? How is it that Germany does not appear on the lists, when Deutsche Bank has been paying astronomical fines for money laundering and corruption for years? What of Credit Suisse, implicated in all manner of laundering affairs, bought out one minute before its collapse by UBS?

The FATF is not a tool of financial justice. It is a tool of politically selective targeting.

The neocolonial architecture — a systemic design

The FATF fits within a global architecture designed after 1945 to perpetuate Western imperialism and set it in stone:

Year | Institution | Actual role

-
- 1944 — World Bank & IMF (Bretton Woods) — Structural indebtedness of the Global South
|
 - 1945 — UN — Legitimizing the Western order
|
 - 1949 — WHO — Health and pharmaceutical hegemony
|
 - 1989 — FATF — Financial censorship of dissidents
|
 - 1995 — WTO — Forced opening of Southern markets

All these bodies with their learned acronyms are above all political, judicial, and financial instruments — for sanctions, pressure, retaliation, intimidation, and blackmail — to keep Global South countries and citizens who refuse to submit in check. Meanwhile, 200 countries with no voice in any of these bodies sign agreements to submit to the dictates of Westerners who exempt themselves from those very rules.

A few leaders had the discernment to refuse. Former Nigerian president Muhammadu Buhari refused to sign the OECD’s international agreement on the taxation of multinationals, arguing that disputes should be settled by an international arbitration committee rather than before national courts. Twenty-four African countries signed it anyway. The same rush had led CFA zone countries to sign and ratify the Rome Statute creating the ICC — while the United States, China, Russia, India, Ukraine, Qatar, and the United Arab Emirates never did. Today, even a child knows that the ICC’s sole practical function is to eliminate leaders — preferably African ones — who inconvenience Western interests. The AES drew its conclusions in September 2025.

Reading the Sahel through this lens — and the answer of the tractors

Applied to the Sahel, this framework explains everything. Why does Niger, among the world’s leading uranium producers, rank among the poorest countries on the planet? Why has Mali, with its gold, its cotton, its

rivers, been kept on an aid drip? Because the system is not designed to develop. It is designed to extract, indebt, and control. Development is the rhetoric. Extraction is the fact.

The AES's break with ECOWAS, the IMF, and the franc zone is not a regression into chaos. It is the conscious exit from a trap that Perkins helped build before denouncing it.

Burkina Faso's response to the suspension of aid gives the measure of the changing era. On May 25, 2025, Captain Ibrahim Traoré hands out to Burkinabé farmers equipment worth 104 billion FCFA: 1,102 power tillers, 608 tractors, 485 motor pumps, 935 floating fish cages, nearly 67 million doses of veterinary medicine. This, after France's total suspension of aid in August 2024. Where punitive famine was expected, tractors. Where collapse was predicted, seeds.

Sovereignty is not begged for. It is equipped.

What this system reveals

Aid is not generosity — it is the redistribution of plunder. Debt is not an accident — it is the tool. The FATF is not a financial watchdog — it is an instrument of political censorship. And Perkins's "financial assassins" are not a metaphor: they are professionals whose job is to deliver sovereignties to multinationals.

What has changed since 2023 is that the Sahel has named the system. And those who named it began to extract themselves from it — at the cost of sanctions, embargoes, arrests, closed bank accounts, and attempts at destabilization. The instruments of the FATF, the IMF, and ECOWAS turned against them. Proof, if any were needed, that they had seen it right.

But loans, jackals, and grey lists do not explain everything. For such a system to hold for six decades, it needs relays inside African societies themselves — institutions, words, men. This invisible network is the subject of the next chapter.

Sources: John Perkins, Confessions of an Economic Hit Man, 2004; Alexandre Sack, Les Effets des transformations des États sur leurs dettes publiques, 1927; Pan-African Conference on Reparations, Abuja, 1993; Nathalie Yamb, Afrique Résurrection column, November 2022; FATF Report, 2023; World Bank, ODA and remittance data 2022–2024; Bank of France data — franc zone operations accounts; French media investigation into the Olivier Dubois / Barkhane affair, 2023; French aid to Mali data, French Treasury, 2022; Burkina Faso, agricultural equipment handover ceremony, May 25, 2025.

CHAPTER 10 — NETWORKS OF INFLUENCE

"There are always Africans willing to stab their brothers in the back to please the white man." — Nathalie Yamb, January 2022

On February 17, 2022, a phone rings in Dakar. On the other end of the line, calling from Brussels, is Ivorian president Alassane Ouattara. His interlocutor: Boubou Cissé, former prime minister of Mali and an opponent of the Bamako transition. For long minutes, the two men assess, with the coldness of strategists, the resilience of a country under sanctions: unpaid salaries, blocked loans, soaring prices. The call is intercepted and leaked.

This recording is a singular piece of evidence. The system of domination caught in the act. Not theories — voices, dates, figures, names. This chapter dismantles its architecture: how the empire holds when the armies leave. The answer fits in four words: a pyramid, a lexicon, a regional organization, men.

The pyramid: five tiers of domination

Dr. Yamb Ntimba has given the most structured description of this system: a five-tier pyramid of domination.

The military tier guarantees the coherence of the whole. The economic tier ensures capture. The informational tier manufactures consent. The cultural and media tier shapes the imagination. And the ontological tier — the deepest, the most durable — installs the conviction of African inferiority in African minds themselves.

The "ontological" tier means this: once a people has internalized that it is incapable of governing itself, it no longer needs to be occupied — it occupies itself. The strongest chain is the one the slave forges himself and puts around his own neck.

The pyramid of domination (Dr. Yamb Ntimba)

<i>Tier</i>	<i>Content</i>
● 5 — Ontological	Making the dominated believe in their own inferiority; shaping the mental environment
● 4 — Cultural and media	RFI, France 24, TV5, NGOs; "democracy" as a label awarded or withdrawn
● 3 — Informational	Digital influence operations and paid influencers
● 2 — Economic	The CFA franc, the BCEAO, the IMF, the debt mechanism
● 1 — Military	Bases, operations, and their covert extensions

The decisive point of this grid: the military tier is the most visible, but the least decisive over the long run. It is the ontological summit that ensures the system's resilience even when armies are expelled. A base can be closed in a night. A conviction lodged inside a skull takes a generation to dislodge.

The lexicon: naming things backward

Every system of domination needs a vocabulary, and Françafrique's is sophisticated: it names things as the opposite of what they are. This inversion is no linguistic accident. It is functional. It presents domination as aid, exploitation as partnership, resistance as ingratitude.

Deconstructing the imperial lexicon

<i>Official term</i>	<i>Reality</i>
● "Stabilization operation"	Military intervention not authorized by the population concerned
● "Security partnership"	Military presence with oversight rights over resources
● "Development aid"	Loans conditioned on opening markets
● "Coup d'état"	The overthrow of a pro-French regime; "legitimate transition" = a change favorable to Paris
● "African ingratitude"	Refusal of servitude
● "Disinformation"	Any narrative unfavorable to French interests

Researcher Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou documents the same mechanics from within academia: the neologisms coined to describe the Sahel — "Somalization," "Afghanization," "Sahelistan," "Africanistan" — do not describe a reality, they construct it. This vocabulary of structural failure serves to plant the idea that "an intervention is necessary" before the facts even justify it. The word creates the demand. The diagnosis dictates the prescription.

Against this sentimental grammar — "friendly countries," "brother nations," "historic partners" — Malian foreign minister Abdoulaye Diop framed the rupture in a single sentence: *"In international relations, there is no such thing as friendship. Every country only defends its interests."* No sentiment. Facts. Interests. Balances of power.

The regional instrument: ECOWAS

On July 30, 2023, an extraordinary ECOWAS summit in Abuja imposes sanctions on Niger and threatens military intervention. The event is celebrated as the defense of democracy. Examined seriously, it is a pile-up of illegalities.

The African Union Charter gives ECOWAS no mandate to use force against a member state. The UN Charter, in Article 53-1, reserves that power to the Security Council alone. ECOWAS's own 2001 Protocol, in Article 45, renders the decision procedurally irregular. To top it off, Chad — which is not a member of the organization — is invited to the summit, and the Nigerian Senate votes against intervention. An organization

outside its mandate, outside its own rules, outside legality — acting exactly as its masters demand.

General Tiani summed up the asymmetry in one sentence: *"ECOWAS has never sanctioned a state for leaving foreign military bases on its soil. It sanctions those who close them."*

The historical irony is complete: founded on May 28, 1975 with economic goals, the organization counted among its founding members Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso — the three countries that left it in January 2024, after forty-nine years. Forty-nine years financing an institution that stabbed them in the back.

Tiani structures the reasons for leaving into three points: security — ECOWAS had militarily threatened its own members; ethical — the embargo was killing Nigeriens, blocking medicine, cutting off electricity; economic — Niger's assets at the BCEAO had been confiscated. Three betrayals. One response.

General Gomart, former head of French military intelligence (DRM), has been identified as one of the linchpins behind pressure exerted through the European Parliament against AES states — he carried or inspired several resolutions against Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso. This is no coincidence: Gomart was also in charge of the operations that had allowed Iyad Ag Ghaly to leave Gao in 2014 without being neutralized. The same man who managed Islamist armed groups in the Sahel as strategic variables now ends up producing parliamentary resolutions against the states that rejected this system. The circle is closed — and documented.

The men: the comprador elite

This class has a name. The word "comprador" comes from Portuguese: it once designated the merchant intermediary between the colonist and the population. In postcolonial Africa, the comprador elite is the one that facilitates the maintenance of dependency. It speaks of sovereignty in public, signs agreements of servitude in private, sends its children to Paris, and parks its money in Switzerland. It sometimes dies abandoned by those it served.

In January 2022, Nathalie Yamb draws up the named list of heads of state who carried out the Élysée's instructions against Mali: Kaboré, Ouattara, Talon, Macky Sall, Gnassingbé, Bazoum, Embaló. The fate of this list speaks volumes: within eighteen months, most of its members had been overthrown or seen their influence collapse. The empire protects its underlings only until it no longer needs them.

Mohamed Bazoum illustrates the profile to perfection. Overthrown on July 26, 2023, he alerts his backers in the columns of the *Washington Post* (August 6, 2023): *"Foreign aid makes up 40% of the national budget, but it will not be delivered if the coup succeeds."* He does not call on his people. He calls on his foreign protectors, and brandishes the suspension of aid as a weapon against his own compatriots. That is an entire political life summed up in two sentences.

The law of underlings: Mobutu, Compaoré, Ouattara

What does one gain from serving the Empire? Three portraits answer.

Mobutu Sese Seko: three decades spent destabilizing Angola, Sudan, Rwanda, and the ANC's South Africa on behalf of his Western patrons, plundering the Congo, and funneling billions to Switzerland. His reward: when cancer strikes him, France refuses him a visa to come get treatment. He dies in Rabat in 1997, alone, abandoned by those he had served for thirty years.

Blaise Compaoré: twenty-seven years in power in Burkina Faso, Sankara's assassin, a hub for armed groups across the subregion. Overthrown by his own people in 2014, spirited out by France to Abidjan, sentenced in absentia to life imprisonment by the Ouagadougou military court in April 2022 for Sankara's assassination. He still lives in Abidjan, protected. Untouchable. France does not extradite its underlings.

Alassane Ouattara: former director of the IMF's Africa department, institutional architect of the structural adjustment plans imposed on the continent, brought to power in 2011 thanks to Guillaume Soro's rebellion and French intervention. Ten years later he sentences that same Soro to twenty years in prison for acts he himself had ordered. France does not lift a finger.

To understand Paris's fierce determination to install Ouattara, one must go back to 2000: Mamadou Koulibaly, then finance minister of Côte d'Ivoire under Gbagbo, had become the very first sitting minister in the CFA zone to publicly announce an exit from the franc. The zone's largest GDP — Côte d'Ivoire outside the CFA was unacceptable to Paris. Someone else was needed. Ouattara was found.

"The Empire has no memory for its underlings. It only has interests." — Dr. Rufin Viclère Mabiala

Ill-gotten gains

"Ill-gotten gains" are the visible face of the comprador contract: real estate, luxury cars, bank accounts held in France by African leaders and their relatives, financed with public funds drawn directly from their countries' treasuries.

Omar Bongo (Gabon): a private mansion and four apartments in the 16th arrondissement. Denis Sassou-Nguesso (Congo-Brazzaville): a 700-square-meter mansion in the Yvelines, valued at 10 million euros. Teodorin Obiang (Equatorial Guinea): a 3,000-square-meter mansion on Avenue Foch, with its own nightclub, hair salon, and gym; a Ferrari, a Bentley, a Bugatti Veyron, artworks bought at Christie's. Assets documented and confirmed in court: over 200 million euros. Two hundred million. In a country where GDP per capita stagnates below a thousand dollars.

The disproportion goes beyond the figures. Global Financial Integrity estimates that from 1970 to 2008, Africa lost nearly 1.8 trillion dollars to illicit financial flows — mostly oil and mining companies operating out of

France, the United States, and the United Kingdom, through underpriced transfer pricing and tax-optimization schemes. One point eight trillion. Over thirty-eight years. Entirely legally.

François Ndengwe, founder of the African Advisory Board, puts it in arithmetic terms: *"For real ill-gotten gains, Transparency International would first have to investigate why countries, 50 years after independence, still have their reserves held by the French Treasury — now that would be a serious subject."*

Corruption does not flow in one direction only. The plunder of African resources also directly finances French politics. African heads of state — Omar Bongo, Denis Sassou Nguesso, Blaise Compaoré — have handed over millions of dollars in briefcases to French politicians, including Jacques Chirac and Nicolas Sarkozy. This is not café gossip: it is documented in French judicial proceedings, sworn testimony, and parliamentary inquiries. African money finances election campaigns in France. French elections are partly financed by money extracted from the African subsoil. French democracy rests, in part, on a substrate of colonial plunder. When Paris lectures Bamako or Ouagadougou on governance, it does so with Bamako's and Ouagadougou's own money in its pockets.

The February 17, 2022 recording: the system caught in the act

Let us return to this intercepted call. Ouattara calls from Brussels; Cissé is in Dakar. They open by referring to "the commission's plan" — a coordination structure never publicly identified — concerning Mali and Burkina Faso. A plan. A commission. Names that appear in no official communiqué.

Then comes the mapping of the strangulation: unpaid salaries, "a trillion in blocked loans," a pressure letter from the deputy finance minister circulating among commercial banks, the World Bank and the African Development Bank mentioned as levers. Technicians of misery, on the phone, optimizing a people's suffering.

"The pressure is really there, real pressure. Prices have soared. It's hard today to get rice at a normal price, or sugar." — Boubou Cissé, intercepted audio, February 17, 2022

This is the active steering of an economic strangulation, not an analytical conversation. The end of the exchange refers to two summits planned in Accra to "compel" Mali and Guinea — an explicit reference to the ECOWAS meetings that would result in sanctions.

Yet a concession wrung out by reality slips in. Cissé acknowledges that the Malian transition achieved something he had not anticipated: *"They managed to find a way to get a large part of the population behind a fight that ordinary people had not previously been waging — the fight against France, the fight against ECOWAS."* Coming from an opponent, this admission is worth more than any poll.

This recording documents in real time the operating mode of twenty-first-century neocolonial subver-

sion: no more French soldiers in plain view, but discreet coordination among relay presidents, instrumentalized regional structures, banking pressure, and financial strangulation orchestrated from Brussels, Dakar, and Abidjan.

This, then, is how the system holds without soldiers: a pyramid that conditions minds, a lexicon that disguises, a regional organization that executes, elites that collaborate. But what happens when all of this is no longer enough — when a people stops believing the lexicon, when the relays fall one after another, when sanctions fail to force submission? Then what remains is the pyramid's first tier, the one that was never truly dismantled: war.

Cameroon: anesthetizing in order to dominate

One Cameroonian company knows no crisis. The CFA franc was devalued — brutally, in 1994, by half. Cameroonian companies closed. Foreign multinationals packed up and left. Only one has sailed through the decades without a wrinkle: Brasseries du Cameroun (Cameroon Breweries). Founded in 1948 by Paul Bugnicourt, from Douai — the country was not yet independent; that would not come until 1960. Colonial capital. A territory under tutelage. Nearly eighty years of uninterrupted growth in a country whose purchasing power has collapsed.

The founding date coincides with the creation, that same year, of the Union des Populations du Cameroun (UPC) — the first major anticolonial nationalist party in French-speaking Africa. Ruben Um Nyobè, Félix-Roland Moumié, Ernest Ouandié, and Osendé Afana hold meetings across the country. Their message: *you are in your own home, you cannot keep letting foreigners plunder you*. The Franco-British colonial power feels threatened. The strategy of diversion unfolds in two stages: football first — occupy the time, channel collective energy toward the stadium and away from the political assembly. Beer next — dull consciousness itself, strike deeper. The parallel with opium in China is inescapable: in the nineteenth century, the British Empire deliberately flooded China with opium to keep it dependent, weakened, governable — to the point of fighting two wars to defend that trade. The principle is identical.

<i>Indicator</i>	<i>Cameroonian reality</i>
● Founding of the Breweries	1948, before independence, colonial capital
● Longevity	No bankruptcy in 80 years, despite devaluations
● Fiscal ranking	Among the state's top budget contributors
● University district of Douala	~1,000 drinking establishments for around twenty educational institutions

The Breweries rank among the top contributors to the Cameroonian state budget. Every crate sold fills public coffers. Under this model, a sober population would be a budgetary catastrophe. Collective addiction is not collateral damage of the system — it is one of its pillars. This mechanism is compounded by the sabotage of the alternative model: SONARA — the National Refining Company, the country's industrial and energy backbone — was ravaged by a fire in 2019. An entire pillar of Cameroonian economic sovereignty went up in smoke. While the industry that could have emancipated the country collapsed, the industry that anesthetizes it never faltered. Um Nyobè, Moumié, Ouandié, and Afana died so that Cameroon could think for itself. Their sacrifice was answered with a bar on every street corner.

Sub-prefect Ouattara's Côte d'Ivoire, the Breweries' Cameroon: different instruments, the same logic. Shape the elites at the top. Anesthetize the masses at the bottom. Hold the country in a vice.

PART III — THE WAR IN THE SAHEL

Everything begins with a war the Sahel did not declare. It ignited elsewhere — in the skies over Libya, in the spring of 2011 — before descending southward with convoys of weapons and routed fighters. Then it changed face: armed groups, foreign military operations, drones, press releases, ONG reports, television panels.

This part tells that war in all its dimensions: the destruction of the Libyan state and what it unleashed, the manufacturing of Sahelian terrorism, ten years of French interventions that saw the threat triple, and the battle over information that plays out in minds as much as on the ground. And finally, the most troubling part: what France itself, in its own official reports and closed-door parliamentary sessions, ultimately admitted.

PART III

THE WAR IN THE SAHEL



CHAPTER 11 — THE LIBYAN CRISIS: CABLES, GOLD, AND THE AFRICAN DINAR

"There are inevitable cycles in social history: it is now the turn of the Black race to prevail in the world." — Muammar Gaddafi

"We put in place a policy that was on the right side of history, on the right side of our values, on the right side of our strategic interests in the region." — Hillary Clinton, November 2011 — spoken just after Gaddafi had been killed in a drainage pipe

Sirte, October 20, 2011. A convoy of vehicles tries to flee the besieged city. NATO planes strike it. In the ensuing chaos, a sixty-nine-year-old man is pulled from a drainage pipe, lynched, and executed. The images circle the globe. Muammar Gaddafi dies in the dust.

That day, few observers understand that it is not only the Guide who is disappearing. It is a lock breaking open. Behind that lock lies the Sahel. Behind the Sahel lie 120 tons of gold, three African financial institutions on the verge of launching, and a continental currency project that would have freed Africa from the dollar and the CFA franc.

Gaddafi was killed. The gold vanished. The institutions were never launched.

The child of the desert

Gaddafi was no saint. But reducing forty-two years in power to that one face misses what makes his death a turning point for the continent — and that is exactly what the Western narrative wanted people to believe.

To grasp the other Gaddafi, the best guide is Cameroonian political scientist Jean-Emmanuel Pondi, a specialist in international relations and author of *Vie et mort de Mouammar Kadhafi: quelle leçon pour l'Afrique* (Éditions Afrédit). Gaddafi was born in the early 1940s, the son of Bedouins, the first in his family to enter a Western school. His childhood hero was Gamal Abdel Nasser, whose nationalization of the Suez Canal had just made him a hero of the Arab world. He entered the Benghazi military academy with one fixed idea: not to become a soldier, but to make a revolution.

He carried it out on September 1, 1969, overthrowing the king. His first act: nationalizing oil and gas. The rent stopped leaving without return. Every Libyan household received an annual check drawn on oil revenue.

It was on this foundation that Gaddafi would finance Africa. Not in words. In billions.

The money of pan-Africanism

Rejected by Maghreb leaders who found him too young, too fiery, Gaddafi turned to sub-Saharan Africa. And Africa embraced him, going so far as to award him titles of traditional chief. Where so many heads of state proclaim themselves anti-colonialist without ever proving it, Gaddafi committed the money.

Between 2000 and 2010, he invested more than 20 billion dollars on the continent — more than the World Bank or the IMF over the same period:

<i>Project</i>	<i>Scope</i>
● Malibya	~100,000 hectares of agricultural land developed in Mali
● Oilibya	More than 200 gas stations across the continent
● Afriqiyah Airways	Direct flights between African capitals at reduced prices
● RASCOM	A satellite freeing Africa from Western leasing (\$500,000/year/country saved)
● Total investments	More than 20 billion dollars (2000-2010)

With RASCOM, a Cameroonian viewer could, for the first time, watch a Senegalese or South African channel without going through Western satellite capacity. One satellite. One instance of technological sovereignty.

The architect of an African currency

At the Sirte summit, September 9, 1999, Gaddafi financed the birth of the African Union — paying off the membership arrears of states too poor to vote, chartering his own planes to transport delegations. On July 11, 2000, in Lomé, he put a billion dollars on the table for African integration.

Above all, in 2010–2011, three institutions were under construction — a project Pondi calls unprecedented since Nkrumah:

- African Monetary Fund, based in Yaoundé
- African Central Bank, planned for Abuja

- African Investment Fund, in Tripoli

Libya had committed 20 billion dollars to it and repatriated 120 tons of gold (Jonathan Batenguène, Panafrican Média TV, May 10, 2026). A gold-backed African dinar was meant to allow continental trade to break free from the dollar and the CFA franc. African countries could borrow, invest, and issue their own currency without going through the IMF, the World Bank, or the French Treasury.

The gold was there. The money was there. The project was in its final stage. Gaddafi was killed.

March–October 2011: chronology of a destruction

Before the strikes, there was the spark. On February 15, 2011, protests break out in Benghazi. On March 10, Sarkozy's France — prodded by Bernard-Henri Lévy, who arranged contact between the Élysée and the insurgents — recognizes the National Transitional Council as the sole legitimate representative. A world first: Paris recognizes a rebellion before even knowing who makes it up. Before investigations. Before the facts.

On March 17, the UN Security Council adopts Resolution 1973 — a no-fly zone to protect civilians, not to overthrow the regime. On March 19, at 5:45 p.m., three hours before the official start of the campaign, four French Rafales strike a column of tanks heading toward Benghazi. Sarkozy wanted to strike first. This unilateral move enrages Berlusconi, who threatens to cut off access to Italian air bases. It is Clinton who spends the following hours on the phone — a four-way call with Sarkozy, Hague, and Davutoglu to save the coalition.

Seven months of strikes, ending with the convoy in Sirte. The resolution permitted the protection of civilians. It was used to kill a head of state.

The African Union had proposed something else. Its roadmap — ceasefire, negotiated transition — is accepted by Gaddafi in April 2011, then swept aside by the insurgents and ignored by the coalition. African heads of state would draw a lasting lesson from this: never again should an outside intervention on the continent be decided without Africa and against its own mediation efforts.

What the declassified cables reveal

In 2015–2016, as part of a US Congressional investigation into Hillary Clinton's use of a private email server, the State Department was forced to declassify dossier F-2014-20439 — tens of thousands of emails, confidential cables, and intelligence notes exchanged between 2009 and 2013. These documents are not abstract geopolitics. They are the corridors, the phone calls, the UN's inner workings, the hours preceding the strikes.

The February 22 cable — Mali in the crosshairs

Documents C05792030 / C05778936 / C05778934 / C05778930 — Sidney Blumenthal to Clinton, February 22, 2011:

"According to another intelligence source, a senior Gaddafi adviser since his rise to power, now in exile in Amman: Gaddafi is calling on fighter jets from Mali and Chad, planes he had subsidized with his oil wealth. These countries are cooperating with Gaddafi — they are in his pay."

This cable exists in four nearly identical versions in the file. Blumenthal was not a State Department official. He held no official clearance. His intelligence notes were nonetheless passed directly to the Secretary of State, bypassing official channels. The source — *an adviser in exile in Amman* — cannot be verified. But the outcome is documented: Mali and Chad are labeled as states that had *collaborated with the enemy* at the very moment the West is preparing its intervention. This detail would enter the framework used to justify subsequent destabilizations.

The ignored ceasefire offer — February 25, 2011

Document C05779761 — Huma Abedin forwards to Clinton, February 25, 2011:

Saif al-Islam Gaddafi tells journalists in Tripoli: *"In Misrata, in Zawiya, we have a problem. We are dealing with terrorists. The army has decided not to attack — to give negotiation a chance. Hopefully we will do this peacefully by tomorrow."*

This is February 25, 2011 — three weeks before the March 19 strikes. This offer of a negotiated ceasefire is passed by Huma Abedin to Clinton without comment. It disappears into the internal threads. It opens no negotiations.

The question is simple: was intervention inevitable, or was a window for peace knowingly allowed to pass?

Clinton converts in Paris — March 2011

Document C05787006 — *Washington Post*, October 30, 2011, forwarded to Clinton:

During the first weeks of unrest, Clinton was among the White House officials clinging to the hope that Gaddafi might fall *without Western help*. The turning point comes during her trip to Paris in March 2011, at the G8 foreign ministers' meeting.

Clinton had drawn up a list of conditions before backing intervention:

1. A formal request from Arab states — the Arab League votes on March 12
2. A Security Council mandate — Resolution 1973 on March 17 (10 votes for, 5 abstentions, including Russia

and China)

3. Arab military support — Qatar, the UAE, and Jordan pledge aircraft

On March 15, Clinton calls Obama from Paris. He sides with her view. In three weeks — not three years — the decision is made.

The Arabs would hesitate almost immediately. Three days after the bombing begins, the four jets promised by Qatar have not yet flown over Libya. Clinton spends 90 minutes on the phone with Qatar's foreign minister: *"This matters for the United States, it matters for the president, and it matters for me, personally."* On March 25, Qatari Mirages fly their first sorties.

Gaddafi was right about the paramilitaries

Document C05779381 — Blumenthal to Clinton, March 3, 2011:

On March 2, Gaddafi tells his son Saif what he believes: American, British, Egyptian, and French intelligence services have deployed paramilitary officers in Benghazi to help organize, train, and equip the opposition forces. He is convinced that the NTC was *chosen by foreign powers to replace him*.

At the time, this statement is presented as a dictator's paranoia. Facts later established: the British SAS was indeed present in Libya before the UN mandate. French DGSE had direct contacts with the rebels. CIA agents were operating in Libya.

Gaddafi was not paranoid. He was describing reality.

The same cable documents Syrian-Libyan military cooperation dating back to 1984: Syrian pilots and technicians had trained the Libyan air force. In February 2011, Gaddafi called Assad at least three times over secure lines. General Isam Hallaq, chief of staff of the Syrian air force, receives orders to help the Libyan regime.

This same cable also contains a memo from Lord David Owen — a former British foreign secretary — forwarded to Blumenthal's team, which recommended *privately*, before any UN mandate: sending Egyptian special forces onto Libyan soil, supplying man-portable missiles to the rebels. Both *before* official authorization.

"Hello Tripoli" — Gbagbo as a message to Gaddafi

Document C05780569 — The Nelson Report, April 12, 2011, Sullivan/Steinberg to Clinton:

France's aggressive intervention against Laurent Gbagbo in Côte d'Ivoire (pro-Ouattara forces capturing Gbagbo after six months of military and diplomatic pressure) is explicitly presented in this cable as a message aimed at Gaddafi. Richard Medley, an analyst at Medley Global Advisors, writes to his clients:

"Whether the French handed over Gbagbo or 'let' Ouattara's forces capture him is beside the point. Today they showed the will to move, and to move forcefully, when the time came to end a sterile impasse. Hello Tripoli."

"Hello Tripoli" — unambiguous. Gbagbo pays the price so that Gaddafi understands what awaits him. The intervention in Côte d'Ivoire is not isolated. It is a show of force.

Obama's speech — March 28, 2011

Document C05782419 — full text of the National Defense University address, forwarded to Clinton before broadcast:

Obama is explicit: *"Broadening our military mission to include regime change would be a mistake."* Resolution 1973 authorizes the protection of civilians, not the overthrow of the regime. And as for cost: *"Less than 1 billion dollars. No regular US troops on the ground."*

Less than a billion dollars to destroy a state and destabilize an entire continent. An excellent bargain, provided one doesn't count the price paid by Africa.

Samantha Power — then director for human rights at the National Security Council — circulates a comparative chart (Document C05782368): the response to the Libyan crisis took 9 days, where Bosnia had waited 3 years, Rwanda 7 months, Kosovo 1 year. She presents it as moral progress. This chart does not answer the real question: *why Libya and not Bahrain* — where Saudi tanks were at that very moment crushing a popular uprising in the total silence of the same voices?

Libya holds Africa's largest oil reserves. Bahrain has none.

The men of the collapse

Once the protective mandate had morphed into a war of regime change, the question remained: who would take the country? Three men reveal the real nature of the rebellion.

Abdel Fattah Younes: Gaddafi's interior minister, a companion of the 1969 revolution, he defected in February 2011 and became the insurgents' military chief. He is assassinated as early as July 2011 by elements of his own coalition, likely Islamists, even before the fall of Tripoli. The rebellion was devouring itself from within.

Abdelhakim Belhadj: former emir of the Libyan Islamic Fighting Group, who had passed through Al-Qaeda networks, captured then "rendered" to Tripoli in 2004 in a handover to which British services lent a hand. Released from Libyan prisons in early 2011, he becomes, after the fall of the capital, military governor

of Tripoli. The former jihadist prisoner administers the city on behalf of NATO's generals. By late 2011, Belhadj is reported to be in contact with Syrian insurgents, organizing the flow of men and weapons from a shattered Libya into Syria. Yesterday in prison. Today governor. Tomorrow exporter of fighters.

Khalifa Haftar: a Gaddafi officer captured in Chad in 1987, who defected to the opposition, spent twenty years in the United States within reach of intelligence circles, before returning in 2011 to join the rebellion. Becoming the strongman of Cyrenaica in 2014, he would later turn his guns on the Islamists he had once worked alongside. In 2019–2020, the new Libyan civil war draws in Syrian fighters transported by rival powers. The flow that left Libya for Syria in 2011 comes back, reversed, eight years later.

The market of betrayal: the Azawad sold at the price of an arsenal

The Tuareg fighters who returned from Libya did not return by chance. According to fighters who stayed loyal to the Malian Republic, those returning from Libya were fundamentally different from those who had armed themselves locally. The first group had organized through their community, which had supplied weapons by selling camels and cattle. The second group had come from Libya with, by their own account, *"the backing and the agreement of France"* to plunder the depots they were entrusted to guard, after betraying Gaddafi in exchange for the Azawad.

The heart of the accusation lies in the testimony of Hamad Mahmoud, former foreign relations minister of the "Azawad." France, he reports, had told them this:

"Abandon Gaddafi, and we will open a corridor for you to recover the Azawad. We will give you independence."

France did not merely let Libyan arsenals spill into the Sahel: it allegedly bought the defection of Tuareg fighters from the Libyan army by promising them a state. The 2012 rebellion in northern Mali is no longer a spontaneous explosion — it is the payoff for a service rendered to Paris against Tripoli. *"France steered this deal from the start to destroy Gaddafi and the Libyans,"* this same witness sums up.

On January 18, 2013, a (declassified) cable from Sidney Blumenthal to Hillary Clinton reveals that, following the kidnapping of the Algerian consul in Gao, the Bouteflika government reached a highly secret agreement with terrorist leader Mokhtar Belmokhtar: he would now concentrate his operations in Mali, with the encouragement of Algerian intelligence. A neighboring state was negotiating for the fire to burn at its neighbor's house instead. Not speculation — a declassified American diplomatic cable.

The arsenals scatter

Gaddafi's Libya was one of the most heavily militarized states in Africa. Its destruction shatters the chains of custody over its depots: tens of thousands of tons of weapons — missiles, rocket launchers, automatic rifles, armored vehicles — scatter across the entire Sahelo-Saharan belt.

<i>What poured into the Sahel</i>	<i>Detail</i>
● Tens of thousands of tons of weapons	Missiles, rocket launchers, automatic weapons, armored vehicles
● Battle-hardened fighters	Tuareg in particular, returning to northern Mali
● A collapsed state	Unable to control its 4,000 km of Saharan borders
● The Fezzan left to itself	Turned into a regional rear base for Sahelian groups

The Fezzan, a vast desert region in southern Libya, always oriented toward Niger, Chad, and Sudan rather than the Mediterranean coast, becomes within a few years the main logistical rear base for armed groups active in the Sahel.

Malian transitional authorities would sum up the sequence in a communiqué of remarkable dryness: *"France destroyed Libya, scattered its arsenals across the Sahel, then presented African countries with the security bill in the form of a permanent military presence."* (Communiqué from Malian transitional authorities, 2022.)

The same hand lights the fire and sells the extinguishers.

Four lessons for Africa

From Gaddafi's trajectory, Pondi draws four lessons that this book makes its own.

First: every time an African leader gave himself the means to decide and carry out his own decisions without tutelage, he met his downfall. The African Monetary Fund was in its finishing stage — the money had already arrived, the launch imminent. Effective independence, not declared independence, is what triggers the empire's response.

Second: the West fears the insubordinate more than its declared enemies. With no debt to the World Bank or the IMF, Gaddafi said what he wanted, when he wanted. A declared enemy is fought. An independent actor is neutralized.

Third (a self-criticism): for lack of surrounding himself with the intellectuals he distrusted, Gaddafi

failed to conceptualize his revolution or make it last. He could have founded lasting institutions — a school, a foundation, a pan-African prize. He left behind a scattered legacy, easier to dismantle than a codified one. Revolution without intellectuals is a flame without a hearth.

Fourth: the pan-African cause is perceived as subversive and dangerous. It is a fight one must know, in advance, carries a price — not a Sunday picnic.

What the cables ultimately reveal

The documents in dossier F-2014-20439 do not explicitly say "we are intervening to destroy the gold dinar." That would be too simple. But they say enough:

1. The decision took three weeks — not a long deliberation
2. Negotiations were ignored — the February 25 ceasefire offer disappears without a response
3. Western paramilitaries were already present before the UN mandate — and Gaddafi knew it
4. The official limit (protecting civilians) was exceeded immediately
5. Gbagbo was captured as a message to Gaddafi — "Hello Tripoli" — on April 12, 2011
6. The Libyan model was exported (Syria, Central African Republic, Sahel) — with systematically catastrophic results
7. Mali was in the crosshairs as early as February 22 — the Blumenthal cable names it as Gaddafi's accomplice

The chronology speaks: the gold was there, the three pan-African institutions were ready, the gold-backed African dinar was in its final stage. Gaddafi was killed. The gold vanished into Libya's chaos. The institutions never opened. The official reason was humanitarian. The structural reason was monetary and geopolitical.

Libya paid. The Sahel paid for fifteen years. And no one, on the Western side, was ever held accountable.

Gaddafi's Libya: what the data said before the destruction

"A tree is judged by its fruit. The fruits of Gaddafi's Libya were measured by the statistics. The West ignored them before destroying the tree."

Before discussing what Libya became after 2011 — a slave market, a fractured state, a transit base for jihadists — one must look at what it was. Not in speeches, not in propaganda, but in the raw data that sixteen comparative maps allow us to reconstruct for the African continent as a whole at the turn of the 2000s.

The verdict is unappealable.

What the sixteen indicators say

Indicator | Year | Libya's position

-
- Life expectancy — 2001 — 1st in Africa: ≥ 75 years
|
 - Adult mortality rate — 2001 — Among the lowest on the continent
|
 - Infant mortality — 2001 — 10–40 deaths / 1,000 births (among the lowest)
|
 - Human Development Index — 1998 — 1st in Africa: "very high" level
|
 - Human Development Index — 2002 — 1st in Africa (confirmed)
|
 - GDP per capita — 1997 — 2nd in Africa: \$11,000–16,000
|
 - GDP growth rate — 2001 — Among the highest: $> 6\%$, $< 9\%$
|
 - Literacy rate — 2000 — $\geq 75\%$
|
 - Adult HIV rate — 2000 — Among the lowest on the continent
|
 - Undernourishment — 2000 — Insufficient data (likely low)
|
 - Birth rate — 2001 — Moderate compared to African averages
|
 - Armed conflicts 1990-2000 — — — Absent from the list of countries in civil war

At the turn of the millennium, Gaddafi's Libya was the African country with the longest life expectancy, the highest Human Development Index, one of the highest GDPs per capita, one of the highest literacy rates, one of the lowest infant mortality rates, and one of the lowest HIV rates on the continent.

The continental context

To measure the scale of these figures, they must be placed within the African reality of the time.

In 2001, most African countries had a life expectancy at or below 55 years. Libya reached 75. The gap is not marginal — it represents two decades of life.

On infant mortality, several African countries exceeded 100 deaths per 1,000 births. Libya stood between 10 and 40 — a level comparable to Eastern European countries.

On the unemployment rate, most African countries exceeded 20% unemployed. On literacy, countries such as Niger and Burkina Faso — which this book has followed since its first chapter — posted rates between 0.1% and 25%. Libya exceeded 75%.

Nigeria, the continent's most populous country with more than 280 million inhabitants in 2001, cannot compete on any of these indicators. Neither can Egypt or Ethiopia, the second and third most populous.

What was destroyed

In March 2011, Nicolas Sarkozy's France launches Operation Harmattan. The United Kingdom, the United States, and NATO follow. The official argument: protecting civilians. The actual result: the destruction of the African country ranked highest on nearly every human development indicator.

This book has documented, in earlier chapters, how Gaddafi's Libya financed the African Union, supported the continent's liberation movements, and carried the pan-African currency project — the gold dinar — which posed a direct threat to the CFA franc and to French monetary hegemony in Africa. France was the most eager to launch the strikes. Coincidence is ruled out.

American diplomatic cables published by WikiLeaks established this: fear of an alternative Libyan leadership challenging the CFA franc system was explicitly mentioned in the analyses preceding the intervention.

North Africa as a mirror

The comparative data from 2001 reveal a reality often obscured: North Africa — Libya, Tunisia, Algeria, Morocco — structurally outperforms sub-Saharan Africa on nearly every human development indicator. Not because these countries are "more Arab" or "less African," but because, for various historical and geographic reasons, they built states that invested in health, education, and infrastructure.

Libya, among them, was the most striking case — a country with no democratic institutions in the Western sense, yet producing human development results comparable to Mediterranean European countries.

This model — a developed, sovereign African state, independent of the Bretton Woods institutions, refusing Atlanticist alignment — was destroyed. Not to protect civilians. To eliminate a counter-example.

What southern Africa also reveals

The maps show another dark reality: southern Africa — Zambia, Namibia, Botswana, Zimbabwe, South Africa, Kenya — bears the continent's most catastrophic HIV rates, with 15% or more of adults infected in 2000. These are the countries that were, for the longest time, subjected to British colonial presence, the apartheid regime, and Cold War proxy wars.

Underdevelopment is not an African fatality. It is the result of a history of predation that the data quantifies with pitiless precision.

Sources: Sixteen comparative demographic and economic maps for Africa, 1997-2002 data (population, density, life expectancy, birth rate, mortality, infant mortality, elderly population, HDI 1998 and 2002, GDP/capita 1997, GDP growth 2001, unemployment 2001, literacy 2000, HIV 2000, undernourishment 2000, conflicts 1990-2000); WikiLeaks, American diplomatic cables on Libya and the CFA franc; Chapters 7 and 10 of this book (CFA franc, gold dinar); ACLED data.

Sources: dossier F-2014-20439, US State Department, declassified July 1, 2016 (cables C05792030, C05778936, C05778934, C05778930, C05779761, C05779381, C05787006, C05780569, C05782419, C05782368, C05785492, C05782153, C05782190, C05764896); Jean-Emmanuel Pondi, Vie et mort de Mouammar Kadhafi: quelle leçon pour l'Afrique, Éditions Afrédit; Jonathan Batenguène, Panafrican Média TV, May 10, 2026; Hamad Mahmoud, public testimony; communiqué from Malian transitional authorities, 2022; UN Security Council Resolution 1973, March 17, 2011.

CHAPTER 12 — THE EXPLOSION OF TERRORISM

"The Azawad is a political fabrication." — André Bourgeot, CNRS researcher, Sahel specialist

Gao, April 2012. The city has just fallen to armed groups. At the Algerian consulate, armed men kidnap the consul and his staff. The affair seems like just one more episode in the chaos swallowing northern Mali. It is, in fact, a key.

Nine months later, on January 18, 2013, a Hillary Clinton adviser, Sidney Blumenthal, sends the US Secretary of State an email, now declassified and available on Wikileaks: following this kidnapping, the Bouteflika government reached a highly secret agreement with terrorist leader Mokhtar Belmokhtar — he would henceforth concentrate his operations in Mali, with the encouragement of Algerian intelligence. A neighboring state was negotiating for the fire to burn at its neighbor's house. In writing. Documented.

To understand how this came to be, one must trace it back to its source. Sahelian jihadism was not born in the Sahel. It was manufactured elsewhere. Transported. Implanted.

The Algerian graft

Researcher Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou, professor at the Geneva Graduate Institute of International and Development Studies, has reconstructed this genealogy with a rigor that official French discourse has always avoided. It all begins in Algeria's civil war of the 1990s.

The Armed Islamic Group (GIA), exhausted and discredited by its massacres, spawns an offshoot in 1998: the Salafist Group for Preaching and Combat (GSPC). Between 2003 and 2007, the GSPC penetrates northern Mali, exploiting the vacuum of state authority and the vulnerability of the population — while Algiers looks the other way and Paris knows. In January 2007, the group rebrands itself as AQIM, Al-Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb. Mohamedou is categorical: this conversion has nothing ideological about it. It is a franchise. Like an independent restaurant buying itself a global brand name, the GSPC adopts the "Al-Qaeda" label to capitalize on its post-9/11 notoriety — gaining access to a market, to funding, to recruits. A logo. Not a conviction.

The group's real nature reveals itself quickly:

"A lucrative political economy of terrorism takes shape, with kidnapper-resellers and intermediaries taking a financial cut in release negotiations." — Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou, La Guerre au Mali,

La Découverte, 2013

Between 2003 and 2013, seventy-two hostages are kidnapped in the region; ten are executed. Kidnapping is a business before it is a fight. An economy, not an ideology.

This point changes everything. The Sahel had been, in Mohamedou's own words, "relatively stable since independence." The destabilization is dated, localized, traceable: GIA, then GSPC, then AQIM, then their offshoots — MUJAO, and later JNIM. A transplant, not spontaneous generation. The "manufacture of terrorism" has a birth certificate, and it was drafted in Algeria.

2012: the Azawad, or the manufacturing of a cause

It is onto this soil that, at the end of 2011, the weapons and fighters of a destroyed Libya fall — the previous chapter showed how. What poured into the Sahel was not merely a flow of armed men: it was the corrupted legacy of a state that had invested more than 20 billion dollars on the African continent, maintained more than 200 Oilibya gas stations, developed 100,000 hectares of farmland in Mali, and was preparing a gold-backed African dinar backed by 120 tons of repatriated gold. All of it liquidated in seven months. In place of the project, the arsenals. Tuareg armed groups returning from Libya form the National Movement for the Liberation of the Azawad (MNLA).

The sequence plays out in two stages, and the first is revealing. On April 6, 2012 — barely fifteen days after the military coup against President Amadou Toumani Touré, and before any alliance with Islamist groups —, MNLA spokesman Mossa Ag Attaher proclaims live on France 24 "the independence of the State of Azawad," claiming to control at that point "more than 50% of Mali's territory" after meeting little meaningful resistance from a disorganized Malian army. The spokesman is careful to specify: "We will respect all the borders of the colonial partition that separates Azawad from its neighboring countries" — an unwitting tribute, republished without irony by the French press, to the 1884 map this book analyzes in Chapter 3. Paris immediately rejects this "unilateral declaration of independence"; ECOWAS and the African Union do the same. But the episode accompanying the announcement says everything about the real chaos behind the institutional rhetoric: the day before, an armed commando kidnaps the Algerian consul and six other diplomats in Gao — the MNLA expresses solidarity while admitting, through its spokesman, that "the terrorist threat exists everywhere." A movement proclaiming a state does not control its own neighboring consulate. It is only a few weeks later, in May 2012, that the MNLA allies with Ansar Dine — the Islamist organization that will quickly supplant it militarily — to consolidate the capture of Timbuktu, Gao, and Kidal. April's declaration had opened the door; May's alliance walked through it — and in the end, it was the Islamists, not the Tuareg nationalists, who crossed the threshold.

This Libya-Sahel lineage is not a militant reading. In 2024, the weekly *L'Express* — modeling with some forty researchers, diplomats, generals, and former intelligence officials a "black scenario" for Mali's collapse — also traces the entire sequence back to "the 2011 Libyan crisis" and the scattering of Gaddafi's Islamic Legion fighters returning home. When the French establishment dates the fire to the same year as the pan-Africanists, the cause stops being an opinion. It becomes an analytical consensus.

Ouagadougou, November-December 2012: when armed groups dictate their terms

One episode from this period deserves to be added to the file, because it shows just how far the diplomatic normalization of the MNLA and Ansar al-Din went — a verifiable fact, to be distinguished from the interpretation some commentators give it. In November-December 2012, under the mediation ECOWAS entrusted to Burkinabé president Blaise Compaoré, delegations from Ansar al-Din and the MNLA are received in Ouagadougou. Compaoré's foreign minister, Djibril Bassolé, publicly reads out a declaration from the two movements demanding that "Mali's defense and security forces commit to ceasing all military hostility against civilian populations" — the two groups reiterating, on the same occasion, their availability for political dialogue. An African mediating government reading out, from its own official podium, the demands of an armed movement and an Islamist organization against a neighboring sovereign state's army: the scene, however factual, measures the degree of legitimacy regional diplomacy — under acknowledged French influence, Compaoré then being one of *Françafrique's* most loyal pillars (see Chapter 6) — was prepared to grant groups that would, a few months later, be targeted by an international arrest warrant. On February 8, 2013, indeed, Mali's attorney general refers a warrant against these two movements' leaders to Interpol. In the meantime, they had been calmly negotiating in Ouagadougou.

Pan-Africanist commentators draw a broader thesis from this sequence — that of a "terrorist conspiracy" deliberately orchestrated from the Élysée and the Quai d'Orsay, directly implicating several successive French presidents in criminal responsibility. This thesis must be clearly distinguished from the fact that feeds it: that Paris, as this book documents elsewhere (Chapters 11, 13, 15, 20), instrumentalized, tolerated, or let flourish armed groups useful to its strategic interests is one thing, solidly established; that there exists a direct, proven criminal chain of command between the Élysée and the groups that took up arms against Bamako in 2012 is another, which belongs to militant accusation rather than judicially established fact. The reader must be able to tell the two apart: the diplomatic leniency documented in Ouagadougou is a fact; the "judicial Nuremberg" these same commentators call for against French presidents remains a political demand, not a conclusion of this book.

But what is the Azawad? André Bourgeot, a CNRS researcher and Sahel specialist, is blunt: "The Azawad is a political fabrication." Not a historical reality. Tuareg people exist, and so do their grievances; the Azawad as defined by the MNLA is a construction, instrumentalized and backed by outside support. The distinction is

crucial: one can recognize a Tuareg question without endorsing a project to partition Mali. One can hear the grievance without legitimizing the instrument.

And one must name what the map actually covers. The Azawad is northern Mali, on the Algerian border — a subsoil holding oil and gas (an extension of Algerian deposits), gold, and diamonds. The independence claim cannot be separated from this wealth: no one demands sovereignty over an empty desert; they demand sovereignty over a vault. The war in Kidal is, at bottom, a war over riches — outside predators seeking to detach from Mali the portion of its territory where its mineral fortune lies dormant. This is why no sovereign Malian government can allow secession: giving up the Azawad would not mean losing sand — it would mean handing imperialist “vultures” the loot they have coveted since 1960.

An army of misery, run by a hardened core

Who, at bottom, are the fighters in this war? Choguel Kokalla Maïga, Mali’s prime minister, has priced the economics of recruitment with a precision few heads of government have dared to state in public:

“Some of them want to get married, they want the money for the wedding. They’re paid 100,000 francs or so. They join terrorism. Others, because their brothers or someone from their ethnic group has been killed. Those who are ideologically committed, who are the real terrorists, are not many.” — Choguel Kokalla Maïga, Azalai Hôtel, Bamako, October 19, 2024

The mass of fighters is not fanaticized — it is poor, bereaved, vulnerable, and therefore recruitable. An army of misery, run by a hardened core of ideologues. This is what makes the war so hard to win by weapons alone: as long as poverty manufactures recruits faster than operations can eliminate them, the reservoir never runs dry. Killing a fighter costs 100,000 FCFA — nothing. Producing another one costs nothing either.

This is also what grounds Maïga’s position on negotiations: “As long as terrorism is not cut off from its backers and sponsors, and then crushed, it will not come to the table. Any negotiation is defeatism.”

Recruitment also has a subtler vector, which Cameroonian analyst Banda Kani describes as a cognitive entry point preceding the military one: Salafism and Wahhabi currents do not penetrate Sahelian societies by force, but through mosques, Quranic schools, and foreign funding — occupying minds before armed groups occupy the ground. This logic will illuminate, later in this book, Ibrahim Traoré’s refusal of a Saudi program to build 200 mosques.

The point must be stated with precision, because the ground is mined: it is not Islam that is at fault — a millennia-old, peaceful religion of the majority of Sahelians — but an imported ideology that grafts itself onto it by hijacking its places of worship. The figures give a sense of the scale of this penetration. Bamako

alone reportedly has more mosques than all of Saudi Arabia. And more than 70% of these places of worship are said to be funded by three Gulf monarchies: Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and Kuwait. The ideology disseminated there is, in many cases, identical to that preached by terrorist organizations — to the point that a portion of their members are said to have passed through Saudi-funded cultural centers established in Mali.

This subject is difficult to raise in public debate, and for a reason the system exploits: misunderstanding. Anyone who denounces this foreign financing of mosques is immediately suspected of being “anti-Muslim.” The reflex is understandable — and it is precisely what protects the arrangement. Distinguishing the faith of believers from the money of the monarchies that instrumentalize their mosques is not an attack on Islam: it is a defense of Islam against those who corrupt it. The oil-rich Gulf, a steady ally of the West, finances the ideological matrix; the Sahel harvests its fighters.

The names of some of the actors behind this penetration are beginning to be documented. Nestor Podassé, the AES’s communications coordinator, identifies three in the Malian context: Mahmoud Dicko, former president of Mali’s High Islamic Council, “co-opted on behalf of the CIA” according to Podassé; Amadou Koufa, active in central Mali, who passed through the Dawa network in Bamako in the 2000s; and Yadagarali, from the same network. Ibrahim Traoré, in his major interview of April 2, 2026, confirmed and elaborated on this diagnosis:

“Many African Muslims have been indoctrinated into believing that anyone who is not Muslim is a kafir, and must be killed.” — Captain Ibrahim Traoré, April 2, 2026

What the enemy says about its own camp: the jihadist rejection of the MNLA

A document attributed to Amadou Koufa himself circulates on the question of the MNLA — a status to be treated with methodological caution: this is a single, non-independently-corroborated source, and it must be read for what it is: the words of a jihadist leader justifying his choices, not an established fact. But its documentary value lies precisely in what it reveals about the internal reasoning of Katiba Macina — reasoning that intersects, by an unexpected path, with this book’s own analysis of the MNLA in Chapter 16.

According to this document, a tactical rapprochement with the MNLA had been considered at one point, then abandoned — it was never carried out. The justification attributed to Koufa is unambiguous: the MNLA is presented there as an instrument of France and the NATO countries, modeled on what happened in Libya — the destruction of the Libyan state being cited as a telling precedent. The fear expressed is that these Tuareg “rebels” would ultimately be mobilized to fight the Malian government itself, in service of an objective the text describes as the destruction of Islam in Mali, jointly orchestrated by Paris and the MNLA. The operational conclusion is to keep fighting these groups rather than pursue any alliance.

The interest of this text is not to validate the thesis it carries — ”the destruction of Islam” as a French objective belongs to jihadist mobilization rhetoric, not to a fact documented elsewhere in this book. The interest lies elsewhere: even on the jihadist side, the MNLA is perceived as a Western Trojan horse, not as a natural ally despite a shared religion and sometimes shared geography. André Bourgeot, quoted above, called Azawad a ”political fabrication” instrumentalized from outside; this document, produced by the Malian state’s most radical adversary, arrives — for entirely different reasons — at the same structural distrust of the MNLA. Two camps locked in direct combat agree on at least this: the MNLA is nobody’s instrument but that of whoever arms it from outside.

The invisible corridors

The manufacture of terrorism is not merely ideological and financial. It is geographic. A map circulated in May 2026 by the military-analysis channel @RYBAR_AFRICA documents the nomadic trans-Saharan trails used by armed groups, cross-referenced against ACLED field data and the findings of Malian authorities.

<i>Reality of the trans-Saharan corridors</i>	<i>Implication</i>
● Zones under armed group control coincide with zones beyond the reach of national armies during Barkhane	Sanctuarization is no accident
● Nomadic trails cross Algeria and Mauritania, linking Malian battle zones to Mediterranean rear bases	Armed groups have durable supply corridors
● These routes predate colonization: Berlin 1884 drew borders, the desert trails never changed	The asymmetry is structural — and ancient

These corridors offer armed groups three advantages: retreat camps in territories beyond effective sovereignty; a war economy self-financed through arms and drug smuggling — war paying for war, with no

reliance on a single sponsor; and cross-border recruitment within communities that Berlin's borders sliced in two. Borders divide families; recruitment networks cross them.

General Tiani, president of Niger, places all this within an even longer frame. Since 1979, he says in an interview with *Télé Sahel*, the same matrix has been operating — Mecca, Afghanistan, Iraq, Syria, Libya, and today the Sahel: trigger a hotbed of instability, intervene in the name of humanitarianism, extract strategic resources. He states that more than 700 fighters were transferred in two waves from the Lake Chad basin to the tri-border zone, equipped with drones, heavy weaponry, and explosives, and supervised by foreign instructors. Figures. Dates. Deployment routes.

His reading converges with questions international institutions have avoided for ten years: how does terrorism continue to advance in one of the continent's most militarized zones? Who finances this war, who arms these groups, who profits from the instability? How is it that, with satellites, drones, radars, and real-time intelligence, jihadist groups have operated for years without being defeated?

The stakes lying dormant beneath the sand: Niger alone holds roughly 5% of the world's uranium reserves — some 310,000 tons — and the wider AES zone produces roughly 230 tons of gold a year. This uranium once supplied 20% of France's nuclear electricity, bought by Orano at €0.80/kg while the world market valued it at \$200/kg. Niger was thereby losing 287 million euros a year. Few people care about the stability of the Sahel. Access to what lies beneath it, they care about very much. War is profitable for those who watch it from a distance.

The Syrian graft: post-Damascus arrives in the Sahel

The matrix Tiani describes — from Afghanistan to Syria, from Syria to the Sahel — has, since Assad's fall, taken on a concrete organizational reality. Analyst Laith Marouf, writing from the Levantine theater, documents what corridor maps are beginning to reveal on the ground: militias tied to Ahmad al-Sharaa — the former Abu Mohammad al-Julani, master of Damascus since December 2024 — have been gradually redeployed out of Syria toward Central Africa and the Sahel, including Niger and Mali.

The logic of this redeployment is twofold. On one side, the residual core of these militias in Syria is now weakened. On the other, Sahelian or regional sponsors are seeking exactly what these fighters bring: tactical and ideological leadership for impoverished local recruits. Syrian militias supply the backbone; Sahelian poverty supplies the numbers. The expertise comes from Damascus. The cannon fodder comes from Liptako-Gourma.

This flow illustrates the transnational dimension of contemporary armed conflicts: groups formed in one war export themselves into another. The Algerian graft, Libyan weapons, Syrian militiamen — every regional collapse produces a cohort of available fighters seeking a market. The Sahel is that market. And its resources make it the most coveted prize.

This Syrian graft illuminates a contradiction the West never owns up to. The French, the Belgians, the British, the Germans have suffered in their own flesh the attacks of the Islamic State and Al-Qaeda — from the Bataclan to Christmas markets. And yet their governments quietly helped these very same movements seize power in Syria. The outcome is dizzying: Germany received Ahmad al-Sharaa — the former al-Julani, a jihadist who passed through both Al-Qaeda and the Islamic State — addressing him as “Mr. President,” when images once attested to beheadings carried out under his authority. Western chancelleries officially fear terrorism and unofficially support it: a calculated ambivalence, never admitted. The same logic holds in the Sahel, where the growth of the jihadist nebula — favored rather than fought — supplied the pool of men needed to destabilize states that had stopped obeying. One cannot mourn the dead of terrorism at home while knighting its leaders abroad — unless terrorism is, precisely, an instrument one deplores domestically and uses elsewhere.

It is precisely in the name of this instability — manufactured elsewhere, transplanted, armed by the Libyan collapse — that France was, in January 2013, about to launch the longest military operation of its recent history: it is time for its autopsy.

The Sahel: the flow of Syrian fighters and the globalization of terrorism

“The Sahel is not the birthplace of terrorism — it is its dumping ground.”

Wars do not end. They move. When one theater of operations closes, fighters do not go home — they seek another front. This is what the Sahel is currently absorbing, ever since the weakening of al-Julani in Syria triggered a massive redistribution of forces toward the African continent.

60,000 to 70,000 fighters displaced

The figures are staggering. Roughly 60,000 to 70,000 foreign fighters, originating from Central Asia and other regions, have been expelled by Turkish authorities from Syrian territory and redirected toward the Sahel. This is a transfer operation — organized, logistically supported, directed — not a spontaneous migration.

The mechanics are simple: in Syria, al-Julani now controls only his Syrian Wahhabi fighters. Foreign elements — Chechens, Uzbeks, Tajiks, Kazakhs, Indonesians, Nigerians — have been evacuated. Turkey, which for a long time served as a transit corridor and rear base for Syrian jihadist groups, expelled them. Destination: sub-Saharan Africa.

The direct impact on the Sahel

This flow has had immediately measurable consequences for regional security. Attacks by Boko Haram

— and by groups affiliated with ISGS (Islamic State in the Greater Sahara) — in Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso have gained in intensity and tactical sophistication since the arrival of these reinforcements. The dynamics observed mirror those that affected Somalia and Sudan during previous transfers of fighters from Middle Eastern conflict zones.

The continuity is documented: Iyad Ag Ghaly received funding from the Gulf, JNIM's katibas recruited across national borders, logistical networks crossed the Sahara from post-Gaddafi Libya. The Syrian flow fits within this same logic of internationalization.

What this reveals about the nature of the conflict

The "local rebellion" thesis — the one Paris long defended in order to reduce the conflict to a matter of internal governance — collapses definitively in the face of this data. One does not move 60,000 to 70,000 fighters from Central Asia to West Africa by accident. This is a strategic project.

Who "sends" these fighters? The chains of command are complex and fragmented. But the operational question is one of profit: who benefits? Gulf Wahhabi funding networks, seeking to open new fronts after their defeats in Syria and Iraq, have a direct interest in destabilizing the Sahel. Powers wishing to keep the region in a state of security dependency have an indirect interest in the chaos being uncontrollable.

AES armies face an adversary that is no longer merely regional. They are fighting the globalization of armed jihad with national resources. This is the reality that European resolutions and NGO press releases discreetly erase when they assess the "security record" of transitional governments.

Somalia, Sudan: the ignored precedent

The Sahel is not the first theater to undergo this kind of reorientation. Somalia absorbed successive waves of foreign fighters from the 1990s onward — Afghan fighters after the Soviet withdrawal, then after the fall of the Taliban in 2001. Sudan experienced similar dynamics during the Darfur conflicts and its recent civil war. In both cases, the internationalization of the conflict lengthened its duration, complicated negotiations, and increased the lethality of attacks.

The Sahel has one advantage that Somalia and Sudan did not: governments that have chosen sovereignty and territorial control, and that have expelled foreign forces that, under cover of fighting terrorism, were organizing their own lasting presence. The Alliance of Sahel States is a political response to a threat that exceeds politics. It will not be enough on its own.

What this demands

Facing a flow of 60,000 to 70,000 transnational fighters, three imperatives are unavoidable:

- Integrated regional intelligence: the borders between Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso are administrative lines that armed groups do not respect. The response must be as fluid as the threat.
- Cooperation with non-AES neighboring states: Mauritania, Senegal, Chad, and Benin share the same porous borders. The political break with ECOWAS cannot become a total security break.
- Surveillance of recruitment pipelines: fighters coming from Syria did not appear in the Sahel without a receiving infrastructure. Identifying the networks of transit, financing, and integration is a priority beyond the capacity of any single state.

The globalization of armed jihad demands a response on the same scale. Sahelian sovereignty is not built by ignoring the international dimension of the threat — it is built by naming it, documenting it, and refusing to let others manage it in place of the peoples concerned.

Sources: Marouf, analysis on the flow of Syrian fighters to the Sahel, July 2026; data on the expulsion of foreign fighters by Turkish authorities from Syrian territory; ACLED, data on Boko Haram and ISGS attacks in Mali, Niger, Burkina Faso, 2025-2026; Somali and Sudanese precedents documented by conflict research centers (ISS Africa, Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project); France 24, MNLA independence declaration by Mossa Ag Attaher, April 6, 2012; Blaise Compaoré's mediation for ECOWAS, Ansar al-Din and MNLA declaration read by Minister Djibril Bassolé, Ouagadougou, November-December 2012; international arrest warrant referred to Interpol by Mali's attorney general, February 8, 2013; militant pan-Africanist analysis on the Franco-Malian "terrorist conspiracy," audio commentary, 2026 (committed source, thesis distinguished from the facts established in the body of the text).

CHAPTER 13 — SERVAL, BARKHANE, AND THEIR LIMITS

"We must stay, we must make it known, we must demand that Vietnam commit fully to this fight. At that price, victory is assured." — Jacques Foccart, 1955, after Dien Bien Phu (Turpin, 2015)

Timbuktu, February 2, 2013. François Hollande walks into a city liberated three days earlier, carried by a jubilant crowd chanting his name. "I have probably just lived through the most important day of my political life," he will say. The images are magnificent. They are also, to an uncanny degree, the replay of a script already performed: on May 1, 2003, George W. Bush landed on the aircraft carrier USS Abraham Lincoln to proclaim "mission accomplished" in Iraq. Researcher Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou overlaid the two sequences: identification of a target, manufactured urgency, façade diplomacy, a military fact preceding the official request, the triumphant journey of a head of state through the "liberated" country. A well-oiled system, documented by Mohamedou (*La Guerre au Mali*, La Découverte, 2013). A script performed for decades.

Serval's original legal sin

Let us begin with what is least known. Operation Serval, launched on January 11, 2013 to stop the advance of jihadist columns toward Bamako, is justified by Hollande under Article 51 of the UN Charter — collective self-defense. This mechanism allows a state attacked by another state to call on allies for help. But Mali was under attack by no foreign state: it was fighting armed groups on its own soil. The argument was manufactured. The legal cover was a fiction.

Raphaël Granvaud's investigation (*De l'huile sur le feu*, Lux Éditeur, 2024) goes further: the famous Malian letter requesting intervention was rewritten. Interim president Dioncounda Traoré — himself installed under ECOWAS pressure, with no electoral legitimacy — first requested simple air support. French diplomats reworked the letter to allow the deployment of ground troops. And the timeline completes the demonstration: French bombing begins in the afternoon of January 11, 2013; Hollande's official response to the Malian request comes after the strikes. The intervention was decided before it was requested. The request was manufactured to dress up what was already underway. They fired first, then asked permission to fire.

The secret war before the war

That is not all. France was waging war in the Sahel well before Serval — in secret. Granvaud documents a "Sahel plan" drawn up as early as 2008–2009, before the large-scale attacks in Mali even took place, complete

with a clandestine component: Operation Sabre. In late 2009, a first detachment of special forces installs itself at the Atar base in Mauritania. In early 2010, trainers arrive in Mali. In October 2010, a permanent Special Operations Command base is established at Ouagadougou airport — Burkina Faso accepting what Mali had refused. All of this without democratic debate, either in France or in Africa. An invisible war, decided in secret, financed by French taxpayers, conducted in countries that knew nothing about it.

As early as the late 1990s, as GSPC fighters retreated toward Niger and then northern Mali, French intelligence services reinforced their local teams across the region. Documented objectives: gathering intelligence and carrying out targeted assassinations of jihadists, carried out by agents of the DGSE's Action Division or by proxies — local relays within certain Tuareg groups.

General Gomart and Iyad Ag Ghaly in Ouagadougou

Here is a precise fact, dated and geolocated. On January 23, 2013 — twelve days after the start of Operation Serval — Iyad Ag Ghaly, emir of Ansar Dine and future mastermind of JNIM, is staying in Ouagadougou. An eleventh-floor suite at the Hôtel Laïko. Four kilometers from the Kosyam presidential palace. There he receives high-profile visits: Djibril Bassolé, François Compaoré, General Gilbert Diendéré, Moustapha Chafi, Lansin Diawara. Men who know exactly where Iyad Ag Ghaly is that night.

Yet General Christophe Gomart commanded French special operations from August 2011 to June 2013. Serval is at the peak of its engagement. Iyad Ag Ghaly is the war's top priority target. And the man is sitting in an identified hotel, four kilometers from an allied presidency, surrounded by figures whose every phone number French services know.

He is not neutralized. Years later, this same Gomart would chair a strategic foundation, be appointed head of military intelligence, and become, in the European Parliament, the leading sponsor of resolutions hostile to Burkina Faso, Niger, and Mali. The question this fact raises is not rhetorical. It is documentary: an officer who commanded special operations at the very moment the number-one enemy was within reach, in a known hotel, and who did not neutralize him — then who ends up, ten years later, leading the information war against the states that expelled the French army — this man is an agent of maintained instability, not a strategist of peace.

The honorable correspondent in the Central African Republic

The French network in Africa was not limited to uniforms. Christophe Raineteau — alias Alpha, sometimes Martin — is an "honorable correspondent," in his own words. His story begins in the Central African Republic in 2003: geopolitical adviser, head of a private security company, operating at the intersection of French economic interests and informal intelligence networks.

"What's called an honorable correspondent." — Christophe Raineteau, TPMP, February 28, 2022

What he transmits: documents, photographs of military equipment, reports on the training of Central African troops "for the West." When the CAR pivots toward Russia in 2013 — a new government chooses Moscow — the French and their businessmen are shown the door. Raineteau nonetheless continues to feed information back to French services. The Russians quickly identify him.

May 1, 2018: armed extremists from Bangui's KM5 neighborhood attack the Notre-Dame de Fatima Catholic church during Mass. Toll: around twenty dead, including Father Albert Toungoumalet Baba, some fifty wounded. The investigation by Bangui's Court of Appeal establishes Raineteau's complicity with Djamous Nimery Matar, alias Force, and Bernard Cousin, another French mercenary. Ten charges: terrorism, arson, murder, criminal conspiracy, threats to state security. The warrants are enforceable in the countries where the accused reside.

Raineteau flees Bangui in 2018. In February 2019, he is arrested in Antananarivo. A real opportunity for extradition exists. It is not seized: French diplomats intervene, have him removed from Malagasy custody, take him to the French embassy, and repatriate him to Paris. He will not be tried. France repatriates its agents. It never hands them over.

In November 2022, at a conference at the Centre d'Échanges et de Réflexion pour l'Avenir (CERA) in France, Raineteau publicly announces:

"A coup could well happen in Bangui in the coming months. Within a few months, President Touadéra will no longer be in power." — Christophe Raineteau, November 2022

A man under international arrest warrant travels freely in France and publicly announces a coup against a sovereign state. He is not arrested. He is not extradited. France issues no condemnation. This silence is itself a message: some are above the law when they serve French interests.

Barkhane: the figures of the verdict

In August 2014, Serval becomes Barkhane. The operation spreads across five countries.

BARKHANE IN FIGURES

<i>Indicator</i>	<i>Data</i>
● Area of operation	5 million km ² — ten times the size of France
● Personnel	up to 5,500 men
● Cost	~1 billion €/year — more than 5 billion cumulative (Court of Audit, 2020)
● Result	Number of jihadist attacks tripled between 2014 and 2021 (ACLED, 2022)

Five billion euros. Nine years. The threat triples. There are only two possible explanations: either the French armed forces are incompetent — which official communications vehemently deny — or the mission was not the one being announced. The second hypothesis has evidence. Three pieces.

First piece of evidence: Kidal. Throughout the decade, the French army effectively barred the Malian Armed Forces from retaking the north of their own country. Choguel Kokalla Maïga denounced this from the UN podium in September 2021: abandonment in mid-flight, FAMa forbidden from occupying the north, the European Takuba force used as an instrument of partition, deliberate sanctuarization of the terrorists.

Second piece of evidence: Gao, 2014. The French army has Iyad Ag Ghaly within striking range. François Hollande halts the operation “so as not to anger Algeria.” Ag Ghaly is today the emir of JNIM, responsible for the 2025 blockade of Bamako. The 2014 decision has a body count. Hundreds dead, perhaps thousands. To “not anger Algeria.”

Issa Diawara, an advocate for African sovereignty, places these facts in a direct causal sequence. It was precisely the French-and-NATO bombing of Libya in 2011, he stresses, that scattered Gaddafi’s arsenal across the entire Sahara, supplying arms and munitions to the groups that would go on to form JNIM. The man who was killed had invested more than 20 billion dollars on the African continent between 2000 and 2010 — more than the World Bank and IMF combined — was preparing a gold-backed African dinar backed by 120 tons of repatriated gold, and was saving every African country 500,000 dollars a year through the RASCOM satellite. What France destroyed in 2011 was not a regime: it was a continental project. What it unleashed in its place were weapons. France lit the fire, sent in firefighters, and kept the blaze going. The territorial record confirms this: Burkina Faso lost entire swaths of its territory during the French presence, not after it. Force Sabre was stationed in Ouagadougou while the terrorists advanced. What the French army failed to do on this ground in ten years, the FAMa did in twenty-four hours, on November 14, 2023, by retaking Kidal.

Third piece of evidence: Macron’s own admission, at the G5 Sahel summit in July 2017: “We need

projects, we need governance, because otherwise, as soon as we stop one terrorist group, it manages to remobilize young people because there is no hope.” He knows in 2017 that Barkhane is failing at the essential thing. He keeps it going for seven more years. Seven years. A billion a year. For an objective he himself acknowledges is unattainable.

On the ground, Ibrahim Traoré sums it up:

“When they left, Bobo and Ouaga were cut off. We couldn’t move on the RN16 anymore. The terrorists were 100 kilometers from Koudougou. Everything was encircled. They were there with all their helicopters, tanks, technology, drones, satellites — and they were incapable.” — Captain Ibrahim Traoré, president of Faso

A force that did not fight alongside Africans

In 2015, Barkhane replaced Serval — and changed in nature. It was not a joint intervention: it was a French intervention deploying into countries that were not integrated into it. No Franco-African force fought together. African forces and Barkhane operated separately, side by side, with no joint command. A foreign army operating on a country’s soil without involving that country in its own operations: that is the concrete definition of a presence that uses a territory more than it defends it.

This disintegration was not merely an abstract principle — it created real operational risks. Burkina Faso’s defense minister, Chérif Sy, had raised a precise point: French aircraft flew without informing the countries of the details of their missions. Civilian air traffic control was not notified of Barkhane’s movements. Yet it is air traffic controllers who allocate takeoff and landing slots; an aircraft not integrated into that grid is a collision risk. France flew its planes through the skies of sovereign states without telling them where or when. The symbol doubles as a diagnosis: Barkhane occupied African airspace the way it occupied the ground — without accounting to anyone.

The OCRS: the real reason, named from the UN podium

If the mission was not what was being announced, what was it? The best-documented answer was given by the AES itself, at UN headquarters.

On September 23, 2023, Bassolma Bazié — then a minister of state for Burkina Faso — delivers a frontal indictment at the 78th session of the General Assembly. His centerpiece is not a slogan: it is a piece of legislation. On January 10, 1957, the French National Assembly passes law no. 57-27 creating the Organisation Commune des Régions Sahariennes (OCRS) — an entity that cuts across portions of Mali, Niger, Burkina Faso, Mauritania, and Algeria, right on the eve of independence. The Sahara was no empty desert: *Le Monde* of June

23, 1957 was already speaking of a potential six to seven million tons of oil a year, and uranium, gold, lithium, and copper were already known to be there. Three years before the flags and anthems, France had legally arranged its grip on what truly mattered. The flags came afterward. The subsoil was already spoken for.

From there, the arithmetic argument Bazié lays out before the Assembly: tens of thousands of foreign soldiers, surveillance capabilities “among the most sophisticated in the world” — and yet columns of hundreds of fighters cross the Sahel unhindered, in countries that manufacture neither weapons nor ammunition. “Who recruits these terrorists, who continuously trains them, who feeds them, and with what means?”

The price of blood — a true accounting

There remains Paris’s ultimate argument: sacrifice. In 2025, Defense Minister Sébastien Lecornu tells *Le Figaro* it is “deeply distressing” to see terrorism resurge in the Sahel after so much effort — implying, after the blood shed by the 58 French soldiers who died in the Sahel. This figure deserves examination death by death. Nathalie Yamb did exactly that, relying exclusively on data published by the French Ministry of the Armed Forces itself.

BARKHANE’S 58 DEAD — THE BREAKDOWN

(French Ministry of the Armed Forces data, compiled by N. Yamb, 2025)

- 43 deaths from accidents or non-combat causes: vehicle collisions, road accidents, cardiorespiratory arrests, repairs gone wrong — one dies repairing a refrigerator in N’Djamena, another is crushed by a truck cab; six are not even classified “Died for France” by France itself
- 13 deaths in a collision between two French helicopters, following an internal dispute between crews
- 2 killed by their own comrades
- 15 actual combat deaths

Fifteen combat deaths. For France — not for Mali, not for Niger, not for Burkina Faso. And this figure is lower than the toll of a single French strike: on January 3, 2021, in Bounti, in the Mopti region, French aircraft strike a gathering. MINUSMA’s investigation concludes it was a wedding and counts 22 dead, 19 of them civilians. The Ministry of the Armed Forces maintains its version and tries to discredit the UN report. When a report is inconvenient, deny it. That is the rule.

If one really wants to speak of sacrifice, let us widen the frame: hundreds of thousands of so-called "Senegalese" riflemen died for France in the two world wars. On December 1, 1944, at the Thiaroye camp, the French army opened fire on its own African soldiers who were demanding their pay. Their sacrifice has no minister to speak of it in *Le Figaro*. The accounting of blood is applied selectively: exhaustive on the French side, invisible on the African side.

When the Americans leave Afghanistan in August 2021, their soldiers go home. When France leaves Mali in August 2022, its troops redeploy to Niger, Chad, Côte d'Ivoire. No demobilization. A relocation. An army that cannot be brought home is not an army of liberation; it is an occupying army changing base.

And after the official withdrawal, the shadow war continues: the Quignolot affair in the Central African Republic and the Vésilier affair in Bamako — two French agents arrested in the middle of clandestine activity — prove the departure was never total. MP André Chassaigne, for his part, did the math in the National Assembly: the intervention in the Central African Republic at the end of 2013 was the fiftieth French military intervention in sub-Saharan Africa since independence. Fifty interventions. In sixty years. None produced lasting stability. Not one.

Foccart, in 1955, demanded that France stay in Vietnam and make it known; we know what happened next. Sixty years later, the discourse around Barkhane was word-for-word identical — and so was the outcome. But this war, lost on the ground, France would try to win elsewhere: in newsrooms, on social media, in NGO reports, and in international courtrooms.

Rwanda: 800,000 dead for a linguistic setback

Between April and July 1994, 800,000 people are exterminated in a hundred days. The Duclert Commission, commissioned by the Élysée itself in 2021, concluded that the French state bore "heavy and damning responsibilities" — not through inaction, but through active complicity.

Since 1990, Paris had backed the Habyarimana regime: Operation Noroît, weapons deliveries to the FAR, the military blockade of the RPF in February 1993. On April 6, 1994, the French embassy backs the genocidal interim government — the very day the machetes go to work. Operation Amaryllis evacuates French nationals and extremist Hutu dignitaries. Tutsi employees of the French are left on the tarmac. Operation Turquoise, presented as humanitarian, escorts the genocidal government and its troops — with their weapons — into Zaire. The executioners are saved.

Why? Three words: the fight against "Anglo-Saxon influence." The RPF spoke English. 800,000 Tutsis were sacrificed to an imperial linguistic rivalry. The same army that demands African gratitude for Serval and Barkhane protected and escorted the perpetrators of the Rwandan genocide. It is to this arithmetic of blood that Sahelian peoples responded in 2020, 2022, and 2023.

Sources: Raphaël Granvaud, De l'huile sur le feu (Lux Éditeur, 2024); Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou, La Guerre au Mali (La Découverte, 2013); ACLED, 2022; French Court of Audit, 2020; Bassolma Bazié, UN General Assembly, September 23, 2023; TPMP, February 28, 2022; Ndjoni Sango, Bangui, 2022; Nathalie Yamb, compilation of Ministry of the Armed Forces data, 2025.

CHAPTER 14 — THE BATTLE OF INFORMATION

"War is not just weapons, images, atrocities. It is also, and above all, a war of communication. Because whoever controls information controls strategy." — Jules Domche, Vox Africa, May 2026

The scene unfolds in public, before an attentive audience, and that is precisely what makes it extraordinary. Anne-Sophie Avé — French ambassador to Mali from 2017 to 2020, then director for sub-Saharan Africa at the Quai d'Orsay — describes, with visible satisfaction, the method of French diplomacy: "Once you've delivered this positive narrative, once you make people doubt, you create a cognitive dissonance where people will say: 'I want to believe France is bad. But what I actually see is that they built this highway, that they brought electricity to this hospital. In fact, all I concretely see is that France loves us and helps us.'"

Let us read this slowly, because every word counts. She does not say "publicize our achievements." She says "make people doubt." She does not say "communicate the truth." She says "create cognitive dissonance." Cognitive dissonance is the mental discomfort felt when two convictions contradict each other — and the propagandist's art consists of manufacturing this contradiction in others so they abandon the conviction that disturbs them. Good faith can no longer be pled once the architect of the propaganda describes how it works, with pride, in a public speech. The war in the Sahel is won or lost first in the mind: AES authorities understood this, and so did their adversaries. This war is waged on four fronts.

Before detailing them, one must name the underlying principle. The contemporary world is largely governed by four instruments: deception, lying, falsification, and manipulation. And these instruments apply to four domains where the consciousness of peoples is forged: science, history, religion, and politics. To falsify a people's history is to steal its past; to manipulate its religion is to steal its soul; to deceive its science is to steal its judgment; to lie about its politics is to steal its present. The information war against the Sahel is only one particular theater of this general war against the lucidity of the dominated. Whoever understands this grammar is no longer caught off guard by any of its dialects.

First front: the media

RFI, France 24, TV5 Monde, AFP. Expelled successively from Mali (March 2022), then from Burkina Faso (December 2022). On May 8, 2026, Niger in turn suspends ten French media outlets — RFI, France 24, AFP, TV5 Monde, TF1 Info, Jeune Afrique, Mediapart, and others — by decision of its High Communications Authority (decision no. 2026.0058/P-HAC of May 8, 2026). The same decision bans Al Arabiya, broadcast from Dubai, for reporting "of a nature to disturb public order": confirmation that the United Arab Emirates

is among the actors in this information war. An Al Arabiya correspondent, Ibrahim Moustapha, had illegally entered Malian territory to broadcast a report claiming a strategic city was under jihadist control — Bamako accused him of “complicity with terrorist groups.”

Censorship, some will say. A response to a declared war, others reply — declared publicly, by an ambassador, in the speech quoted above. Analyst Banda Kani pushes the reading to its conclusion: major international media outlets are not press organizations but “military bases,” their journalists “soldiers disguised as civilians.” But a paradox lends the argument weight, one raised by Jules Domche on Vox Africa: it was Western media who were first to announce the supposed death of Malian general Sadio Camara — even though they have had no correspondents in the Sahel for years. Who fed them the information, and how fast?

The Ibrahim Mustapha affair reveals a wider architecture than Saudi media alone. Analyst Linda Larbaoui, on Panafrican Média TV (June 2026), draws attention to an angle the deliberately measured Malian response leaves temporarily aside: “The channels currently going wild over Mali right now — it’s not Al Arabiya. It’s the Al Mhed channel, which is Emirati. It’s HPress, the paper run by a Moroccan and funded by the Emirates. It’s DW — a channel based in Germany, but it’s an Emirati channel. There’s also Steve News, an Emirati channel based in Canada.” Saudi Arabia is the tree hiding the forest. It is the United Arab Emirates that holds most of the anti-AES media front — a fact consistent with the simultaneous expulsion of Al Arabiya (broadcast from Dubai) by Niger’s High Communications Authority on May 8, 2026.

An AES official documented from the inside the effect these campaigns are designed to produce. Basolma Bazié — a former Burkinabé minister who became an official within the Confederation — recounts a sequence from the summer of 2026: “For about ten days, on social media and in some international press outlets, we were told, minute by minute, that Ouagadougou had fallen, that the general had fled, that the jihadists had taken power.” The response was not a written denial but a staging of reality: the heads of state of Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger appeared together, in public, at a regional conference. Against a narrative, the AES does not oppose a press release; it opposes a presence — for doubt, manufactured faster than reality can dispel it, is not disproven, it is outrun.

Bazié extends the argument onto factual ground: to a Western ambassador who came to question him about “the terrorists,” he responds with two questions — who manufactures the drones these groups now use, and who taught them to pilot them, in countries whose own states struggle to certify a single civilian aircraft? — before referring to the admission by Ukrainian military intelligence after Tinzwaten (Chapter 12). For the AES, the “manufacture of terrorism” is not a thesis: it is a file.

The analytical distinction Larbaoui draws between Gulf actors is valuable. Saudi Arabia fulfills a financial function — mobilizing petrodollars to finance destabilizations commissioned by Washington. The United Arab Emirates plays a dual role: a tax haven through which gold siphoned from African economies transits, and, since the 2020 Abraham Accords, “tasked with spreading the idea of the Abraham Accords” toward Muslim-

majority countries. Qatar is the media power of the setup: Al Jazeera, which Larbaoui claims is “run not only by the CIA but by the Mossad” — a claim consistent with documented interference in the funding of Gulf Arab media. These three states share a common origin: all were created or delimited between 1920 and December 1971, in what Larbaoui calls the “Rogers Plan” — the series of Anglo-American decisions that carved up the Gulf kingdoms into separate, dependent, controllable states. “Every state was manufactured wholesale by the colonialists,” she summarizes; and each state was assigned a role: Saudi Arabia finances, the Emirates launder, Qatar informs. That Nestor Podassé, the AES’s communications coordinator, arrives at the same architecture from Ouagadougou — “the Gulf countries handle the ideological component, political Islam to radicalize elements, and the military component to supply fighters” (Panafrican Média TV, June 2026) — suggests the analytical convergence between the Sahelian ground and diaspora observation is more solid than it appears.

Bamako’s calculated response to Ibrahim Mustapha becomes clear within this framework. Publicly exposing the journalist before engaging in diplomacy strips Riyadh of the chance to minimize the incident in silence. “Mali first exposed to the whole world the conduct of this individual, who works for the subsidiary of Saudi Arabia’s national channel — so that the diplomatic channel with them would be better understood and appreciated by the population” (Okoissi, Panafrican Média TV, June 2026). Communication precedes action; exposure creates the balance of power that action will later confirm.

RFI in Bambara, and the semiotics of operation names

The war of words begins with language itself. Before the war in Mali, RFI did not broadcast in Bambara — a language understood by roughly 82% of the Malian population. The launch of a Bambara service, followed by a newspaper in Fulani (a language that, according to the same analysts, had never had a dedicated newsroom before the conflict), is presented by its pan-Africanist critics not as an editorial advance but as a targeting tool: “When you speak to someone in their mother tongue, they understand with their heart” — a formula true for education or public health, but which becomes a weapon when the goal is political persuasion rather than information. The device echoes what this book documented earlier with Radio Mille Collines in Rwanda (corresponding chapter): linguistic proximity is never neutral, it is a vector of effectiveness — for better or worse, depending on who wields it and to what end.

The same critical reading applies to the code names of French military operations in Africa — a semiotics that pan-Africanist analysts decode as a double-bottomed language, official on the surface, revealing underneath:

Operation | *Origin of the name* | *Theater*

● Serval — Wild African feline that marks its territory through urine and combat — Mali (2013)

|

- Barkhane — Crescent-shaped sand dune shaped by the wind — militant reading: a symbol of "reunifying" the desert under a single authority — Mali, then the Sahel (2014-2022)

|

- Takuba — Traditional Tuareg saber — Mali (European task force, 2020-2022)

|

- Licorne (Unicorn) — Fabled creature — militant reading: the only one, in heraldic bestiary, capable of felling the elephant, Côte d'Ivoire's national symbol — Côte d'Ivoire (2002-2015)

|

- Sangaris — Rare red butterfly endemic to Central Africa (*Cymothoe sangaris*) — Central African Republic (2013-2016)

These names are authentic — they are the official designations given by the French general staff to its operations. What belongs to interpretation, and must be presented as such, is the symbolic reading pan-Africanist commentators give them: for them, the choice of a feline that "marks its territory," a dune "reunifying" the desert under one authority, or a heraldic creature designed to defeat the very emblem of the targeted country, is no poetic accident but an unconscious admission — the colonizer's language which, even in choosing a code name, keeps thinking in terms of conquest, territory, and symbolic domination. Whether one sees a coincidence by communicators short of inspiration or a revealing institutional slip, the fact stands: French martial vocabulary in Africa has never drawn its metaphors from the register of cooperation.

Wassim Nasr, IFRI, and the Ministry of the Armed Forces: doctrine set to sound

Expelling journalists is not enough. One must also produce the narrative that justifies their absence — and prepares their return. This is the function of the podcast *Le Colimateur*, where Wassim Nasr, a France 24 journalist, is hosted to analyze JNIM and the jihadist threat in the Sahel. The credits give it away entirely: "a podcast associated with Rubicon, produced in partnership with IFRI's Security Studies Center and with the support of the DGIS at the Ministry of the Armed Forces." DGIS: the General Directorate for International and Strategic Affairs — the strategic department of the French Ministry of Defense. This is a strategic communications product financed by the French military institution, not a journalistic podcast. When the source, the host, and the broadcaster are all paid by the same state power, the word "analysis" must be replaced by "doctrine."

The central technique of Nasr's discourse is the progressive rehabilitation of JNIM through repeated contrast with the Islamic State. JNIM: "focuses on military targets," "no longer cuts off hands," "wins hearts and minds," "delivers swift justice," "releases Senegalese truck drivers on Iyad's orders." The Islamic State: pure barbarism. The subliminal message is unmistakable: there is a good jihadist and a bad jihadist. And the good one — affiliated with Al-Qaeda — could be a negotiating partner. A partner that only France, with its networks,

is positioned to mobilize.

The second axis: narrative destabilization of the AES. *"The AES exists only on paper." "Those actually implementing the alliance on the ground are JNIM, not the armies." "Who helped the Malians? The Ivorians. Not AES partners."* Each of these points aims to isolate Mali, discredit the AES, legitimize Ouattara's Côte d'Ivoire — and create a sense of vulnerability that prepares public opinion to accept outside help. The third axis: the self-fulfilling prophecy of Bamako's fall — road blockades, Bambara-speaking JNIM commanders at the capital's gates, Kabul-style collapse scenarios. Chaos is described in enough detail for actors — financial, diplomatic, military — to begin positioning themselves accordingly. General Lecointre had said it without disguise: *"I am convinced that in a few years — ten, less, or more — we will be obligated to go back and help these African countries."* Nasr's discourse prepares that obligation. It lays down its narrative conditions.

What the anatomy of the discourse reveals is the institution, not the individual: France 24 (a state channel), IFRI (a think tank shaping French Africa policy), the DGIS/Ministry of the Armed Forces. Together, they produce a coherent doctrine: rehabilitate JNIM, prepare French-led negotiations, dismantle the AES through division, prepare a military return. One does not debate a state doctrine. One exposes it.

Second front: the digital

The cyber academy at the 43rd BIMA — the French military base in Côte d'Ivoire — trains "e-patrollers" with a documented objective, per journalist Thomas Dietrich: criticizing Russian presence on social media and targeting pan-Africanist figures by name, Kemi Séba topping the list (Thomas Dietrich, 2024). Macron himself acknowledged the principle of paid influencers, in November 2022 on TV5 Monde: "There are Africans paid by the Russians." A clear implication: there are also ones paid by others. On November 13, 2025, General Tiani reveals that a tender was launched in September 2025 to recruit African influencers tasked with destabilizing the AES: "It's being done publicly." Two independent sources — a French investigative journalist and an African head of state — describe the same mechanism. Tiani goes further still: two "special cells" run out of the Élysée, with unlimited funds, are said to have been set up to destabilize the Sahel.

It is on this front that the battle over the founding narrative plays out. The dominant narrative presents Sahelian transitions as products of Russian manipulation. Chronology disproves it: Bamako's seizure of power dates to August 2020, and Wagner's large-scale arrival came afterward. The break with Paris comes first; diversification toward Russia is a consequence, not a cause. Reversing the order of the two events reverses responsibility — and that is exactly the function of this narrative.

Banda Kani frames the stakes of this front in terms that go beyond targeted operations: the architecture of the platforms itself is the weapon. "When you talk about geopolitics, about Africa's future, when you carry important futures — they block you first, they algorithmically bury your content, you hover around 1,000

views. But her — the moment she posts a content, even simple banal greetings, hello, hi, how are you — the views pour in. All the more so when she sits down to make videos that are about sex, about bling bling.” And his conclusion: “It’s admitted. In war-college case studies, it’s admitted, it’s no longer even hidden. Frivolity, voyeurism elevated to the most sophisticated level, as a strategic approach.”

This mechanism is a battle architecture, not a metaphor: while voices analyzing Africa’s future spin in a closed circuit, the sex-bling-triviality triptych floods the feeds of five hundred million African phones. Cognitive warfare does not stop at paid influencers; it plays out at the level of code — the algorithm deciding what every African will see tomorrow morning when they wake up. On this point, Banda Kani names the responsible party: “France has a problem. It’s her problem.”

A concrete case illustrates this digital front in its pro-Western African dimension. Ivorian pastor Camille Makosso operates high-reach livestreams from Abidjan on social media — sessions his own author calls a “digital army.” His grammar is that of the emotional agitation Banda Kani describes: repeated calls to the audience (“tap, hit the hearts, let’s get to 100,000”), personal attacks against AES leaders (Tiani, Traoré, Goïta labeled “thugs,” “gangsters,” “neighborhood presidents”), unsourced data presented as “evidence.” The content of these sessions is transcribed with the status it deserves: that of a militant influencer, whose unverified factual claims do not constitute an independent source, but rather a document of the information war itself.

What draws analytical attention is not what Makosso says, but what he shows. In a session attacking Ibrahim Traoré, he broadcasts a video of the Burkinabé president himself — an uncontested primary source — in which Traoré states: “We’ve always used the slogan that it’s a poor country. You are well aware that the country is not poor, it’s because we are mean. We are seriously mean to each other. The youth have nothing to do. We have arable land.” And, on the causes of terrorism: “We have mistreated the [Fulani] regions. What have we built there? What development project have we sent there?” This is the principle of “the confirming adversary” applied in reverse: a pro-Ouattara influencer shows, in order to attack him, a statement by the Burkinabé president acknowledging — before anyone else — that radicalization has deep internal roots in the neglect of peripheral regions. The pro-Western digital army unwittingly supplied one of the strongest arguments for the opposing thesis.

Third front: humanitarianism as a weapon

The humanitarian front has a sharper edge: human rights organizations. The issue is not the accuracy of each report; it is the asymmetry of scrutiny. HRW publishes on Malian and Burkinabé forces; it has produced no equivalent report on the DGSE’s covert activities in the Sahel, nor on former French legionnaires cooperating with Ukrainian military intelligence, confirmed by RTL France on May 9, 2026. This is not incapacity; it is an editorial choice — and editorial choices have funders, and funders have interests. HRW’s communications

director, Philippe Boloignon, is a former RFI, Le Monde, and France 24 journalist — the very media expelled from the Sahel — and headed the “Liberty Fund” at TOBAM, an investment fund that profits from betting financially against countries labeled authoritarian. HRW’s own founder, Robert Bernstein, had denounced in a 2009 New York Times op-ed the “politically slanted reports” of his own organization.

The textbook case is the report of April 2, 2026: 342 pages naming Ibrahim Traoré as “potentially responsible for war crimes.” Its timing is puzzling. The AES announced its withdrawal from the ICC on September 22, 2025; the Court retains residual jurisdiction for one year. The report covers 2023–2025 — precisely the years still subject to prosecution — and the letter requesting a response from Burkinabé authorities was sent only on December 22, 2025, after three years of building the case and four months before publication (Yamb, April 2026). More troubling still: among the contributors thanked is Wassim Nasr, who was in real-time contact with the attackers during the September 17, 2024 attack on Bamako, and who is being prosecuted by the courts of all three AES countries for criminal conspiracy linked to a terrorist enterprise.

THE SEVEN SIMULTANEOUS USES OF AN NGO REPORT (DECODED BY N. YAMB, APRIL 2026)

- Diplomatic: ammunition in multilateral forums
- Judicial: a ready-made file for the ICC
- Economic: downgrading of the targeted country’s sovereign rating
- Media: fueling a hostile narrative
- Psychological: sowing cracks within the Burkinabé army
- Sanctions: justifying asset freezes and targeted measures
- Deterrence: sending a message to other AES leaders

The mechanics of the stranglehold work in cascade: a report labels a state “authoritarian”; rating agencies downgrade it; its borrowing costs rise; the IMF and World Bank condition or suspend their financing. Economic strangulation proceeds disguised as humanitarian concern. The conclusion is not that humanitarianism must be abolished. It is that its analytical immunity must end. Niger drew a radical conclusion from this in 2025 by expelling the ICRC, with Tiani citing secret meetings held in Abuja in early 2025 between Western representatives and armed groups, with the ICRC acting as financial conduit.

This lifting of analytical immunity is all the more urgent given that the facts justify it. In November 2024, Sudanese refugee women in Doctors Without Borders (MSF) camps in eastern Chad denounce sexual abuse committed by *“those who were supposed to protect them.”* The organization’s internal investigation, finalized in

July 2025 and revealed on June 13, 2026 by the Associated Press, documents 59 cases of abuse and sexual exploitation: women and minors provided sexual services in exchange for aid, food, or employment. Seven young refugee women, hired as day laborers, were transported in an MSF vehicle under the pretext of water-distribution work — they were taken elsewhere and sexually assaulted. Chadian employees were threatened with dismissal if they refused to have sex with their superiors. Eighteen employees, local and international, were dismissed.

The most damning sentence in the report is not the one describing the facts. It is the one that contextualizes them: *"MSF has already faced similar allegations, notably during reports of widespread exploitation and abuse in West Africa in 2002 and during the 2021 Ebola outbreak in the DRC. Overall, little has changed."* This conclusion comes from the Associated Press, not an African government. The international humanitarian system has reproduced its crimes over two decades, in multiple countries, with no structural correction. It functions. It simply also functions as a space of predation against the world's most vulnerable populations — those who war, whether organized or left to fester from outside, has uprooted and left dependent on international aid to survive.

UN peacekeepers have been accused of rapes in the Central African Republic. The ICRC used as a financial conduit between Western representatives and armed groups. MSF condemned by its own investigation for systematic sexual exploitation in Chad. The picture of international humanitarianism in Africa is that of an institution that has captured a monopoly on protecting the vulnerable — and that, sheltered by this position, has at times organized their exploitation.

Fourth front: the judicial

There exists an international criminal court. It sits in The Hague, has a budget of 180 million euros a year, and has, since its creation in 2002, handed down convictions against nationals of the DRC, Uganda, the Central African Republic, Mali, Côte d'Ivoire, Libya, Sudan, Kenya, and Georgia. None against a French national. None against an American. The geography of justice says everything about its nature.

Two Malian cases fix its real jurisprudence. Bounti, January 3, 2021: a French strike on a wedding, 22 dead including 19 civilians according to MINUSMA — the ICC opens no preliminary examination. Moura, March 27–31, 2022: the Malian army, backed by Russian instructors, retakes the town. The toll is heavy according to Human Rights Watch. This time, the ICC opens a preliminary examination. A preliminary examination is the antechamber to investigation: the prosecutor checks whether the facts justify prosecution. For Moura, the door opens; for Bounti, it stays shut. The filtering is documented. Prosecutor Karim Khan himself acknowledged as much when he took office in 2021: "The ICC cannot be credible as long as it treats crimes differently depending on whether they are committed by the powerful or the weak."

The Gbagbo affair completes the picture: arrested in 2011 with the direct assistance of the French army, transferred to The Hague, held eleven years, acquitted in 2021 — with no substantial reparation. Sarkozy, whose forces took part in his capture, was never questioned. And when the three foreign ministers of AES states bring a case to the Security Council, on August 19, 2024, over "open and acknowledged support by the government of Ukraine for international terrorism, particularly in the Sahel," the Council — where France holds a veto seat — takes no action. On September 22, 2025, Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger jointly announce their withdrawal from the ICC. After ECOWAS (January 2024) and the OIF (March 2025), it is the third institutional break. Each step makes the previous one irreversible.

The cross-cutting weapon: the "terrorist" label

There remains the weapon connecting all four fronts. On June 5, 2017, Saudi Arabia, Egypt, the Emirates, and Bahrain sever ties with Qatar, accused of supporting "terrorist groups" (Le Monde / AFP-Reuters, June 5, 2017). Nine years later, a report by the German institute SWP describes these same Emirates as "one of the most aggressive external actors in African conflicts," backers of Sudan's RSF, whose massacres in El-Fasher bear, according to a UN fact-finding mission, the hallmarks of genocide (SWP Comment no. 19, May 2026).

The final proof comes from Macron himself: in December 2024, he congratulates Ahmad al-Sharaa — previously known as Abu Mohammad al-Julani, head of Al-Qaeda's Syrian branch — on his seizure of power in Damascus, and formally invites him to France. The US Treasury had offered 10 million dollars for his capture until December 20, 2024, two weeks after his victory. The "terrorist" label is not a legal classification: it is a positioning tool, designating not what an actor does, but what it represents for the accuser. The profile Paris fights in the Sahel is the one Paris receives at the Élysée when it serves its interests in Syria.

The 2026 World Cup: the geopolitics of sport laid bare

The 2026 FIFA World Cup — hosted in the United States, Canada, and Mexico — has become the living laboratory of everything this chapter documents. An event supposedly meant to "bring peoples together" has turned into a full-scale demonstration of the same mechanisms of exclusion, double standards, and financial domination — the novelty being that the adversary displayed them without shame.

A tournament without a people. Tens of thousands of African, Iranian, and other "at-risk" supporters were denied entry visas or intercepted at the border. The Senegalese delegation — reigning African champions — "searched down to the underwear" upon arrival. The DRC excluded on the pretext of Ebola: supporters had bought 15,000-dollar tickets and were not reimbursed. Africa's top referee, appointed by CAF, turned away over an alleged link to a terrorist movement operating in Somalia — a country he is not even from. "They kept the spectacle but banned the spectators," summarizes Jonathan Batenguène on Panafrican Média TV, June 14,

2026. "They kept the ball but chased away the heartbeats. It's antfootball. A king without subjects. A World Cup without a world."

Double standards in their purest form. FIFA had excluded Russia from all competitions after 2022 and created a ten-million-dollar solidarity fund for Ukraine — an organization claiming to be apolitical, going so far as to fund one belligerent. Since October 7, 2023, Israel has faced no comparable sanction. Players who displayed a Palestinian flag were reprimanded. A PSG goalkeeper was forbidden from waving his own country's flag at a Champions League final. "We were told FIFA's rules are sacred. Today, is anyone capable of saying yes?" (Batenguène, June 14, 2026.)

The financial mechanics explain everything. Infantino's inaction in the face of American violations of commitments signed in 2018 is explained mechanically: FIFA's sponsorship revenue for 2026 is estimated at 2.8 billion dollars, versus 1.8 billion for Qatar 2022 — a 55% jump. Among the sixteen chosen partners, six or seven companies are American; the rest — Adidas, Hisense — are majority-owned by Vanguard and BlackRock. Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Bank of America, Verizon, PepsiCo: these five companies hold FIFA's budget, and their majority shareholders answer to the same financial capital that Trump has a hand in. "Whoever pays the bill sets the menu," summarizes analyst Charlie on Panafrican Média TV. Under these conditions, Infantino's silence is not weakness — it is accounting (Panafrican Média TV, Festin Panafricain, June 14, 2026).

Motsepe and the capture of CAF. On the African scale, the chain is identical. Patrice Motsepe, elected head of CAF in 2021, is the wealthiest Black African on the continent, enriched in mining after the ANC's liberation. He sits on the board of trustees of the Davos World Economic Forum, where he rubs shoulders with the CEOs of investment banks and multinationals that fund FIFA. Infantino directly facilitated his election; Motsepe has publicly acknowledged he can count on CAF for the 2027 deadlines. The same chain of financial capital holding FIFA now holds CAF — and through it, the football of fifty-four African countries.

Star-culture, or the commodity that does not think. This context sheds light on a recurring observation: why are Africa's biggest stars silent on political questions? Batenguène gives the structural answer: "Players are commodities. A Coca-Cola can be worth a lot of money, but a Coca-Cola isn't meant to think." The capitalists who control football impose rainbow armbands; those who refuse — Benzema and others — go play in Saudi Arabia, where some space still exists. Star culture mobilizes millions of Africans, but those millions are captured by figures whose masters control their statements. That is soft power in its purest form: Africa pays subscriptions to watch its own champions keep quiet.

The Trump paradox, or the stick handed over. By violating the 2018 American commitments without FIFA reacting effectively, Trump proved its rules are not "untouchable, imprescriptible, inviolable" — as they were when it was an African state stepping out of line. Batenguène's conclusion is direct: "Every African country must be ready to take FIFA and CAF and tell them: it's the same here. Let the country set the rules. We don't want to see one more star open his mouth when he never said the same thing in the United States." What FIFA

accepts from American power, it will have to accept from African power. Trump handed over the stick; it is up to Sahelian sovereignists to strike.

The diaspora on the front line — the price of speaking out

Those who produce this counter-information have a price to pay. Nathalie Yamb on the European sanctions list. Channels censored in twenty-seven countries. Accounts closed. Documented death threats.

And exile. A Togolese opponent, living outside his country for years, answered those who hurled at him, like a curse: *"You will die in exile."*

"Oh, is that a tragedy? Ali Bongo ruled Gabon — he's not in exile today. There are people more important than us who died in exile. There are people who die in planes, in boats. When you're in this fight, you expect anything. Dying in exile is also a death. Death — that's settled business. You can die anywhere. They think that by telling us that, we'll back down. We couldn't care less. I spent 50 years of my life in Togo. Today I'm outside. There's nothing — nothing but patriotism, the love I have for my country — nothing obliges me." — Togolese opponent in exile

That statement says everything editorials leave unsaid. The threat of exile as a weapon of demoralization only works on those who still believe physical survival is the supreme good. Those who chose this fight chose it knowing what it costs. This is not romantic heroism — it is a lucid calculation: stay silent in exchange for the possibility of returning home, or speak from outside at the risk of never returning. They chose to speak.

It is this diaspora — Togolese, Malian, Burkinabé, Nigerien, Cameroonian, Congolese — that constitutes the first independent information network on what is really happening in the Sahel. Without it, the counter-narrative would not exist. Without it, the analyses of Yamb, Banda Kani, Batenguène, and hundreds of others would not reach the phones of Sahelian populations. The battle of information is also a battle of personal courage.

Nathalie Yamb: sanctioned for her clarity

In June 2025, Nathalie Yamb becomes the first Swiss citizen sanctioned by the European Union. The official grounds stated in the decision: she *"works to expel France and the West from Africa."* No espionage. No Kremlin agent. Her fight for African sovereignty. Written in black and white in an official EU document.

The consequences are immediate: credit cards canceled, bank accounts frozen, YouTube channel demonetized, Airbnb, Amazon, Netflix cut off. A Swiss bank transferred her assets in Swiss francs. The amount in euros vanished. Stolen. She learns of the decision after stepping off a plane — by searching her own name on Google. No procedure. No right to a defense.

Switzerland is not an EU member. SECO confirmed these sanctions do not apply in Switzerland, and redirected Yamb toward costly legal proceedings — funded by the very money that is frozen. The 2024 European regulation covers airspace: she can no longer return home. She was not there for the birth of her grandchild. She will not be there for her mother's 80th birthday.

In 2019, after her remarks at the Russia-Africa summit in Sochi, Macron calls the Ivorian president. Yamb is arrested, detained, expelled to Switzerland — in a summer dress, with no luggage, no papers, no money — in the dead of winter. She contacts the Swiss embassy in Abidjan: no response. She eventually obtains internal files: an official had written explicitly to the ambassador: "Don't help her." She has this in writing.

These sanctions are designed to hit an adversary financially, morally, psychologically — until they are too busy surviving to keep fighting. What Africans have endured for decades is now the laboratory for what Europe reserves for its own dissident citizens.

Kémi Séba: hunting down a diplomatic passport

Pretoria, April 2026. Kémi Séba is arrested in South Africa. A pan-Africanist militant, adviser to Nigerien president Abdourahamane Tiani, holder of a Nigerien diplomatic passport — he was traveling to Pretoria to meet the Zimbabwean opposition. The official grounds: an expired visa. For a man of this profile, that is the tree hiding the forest.

The South African police report does not stop at immigration. It refers to a plot involving terrorist attacks in Europe — and the same report acknowledges it provides no evidence, specifies no means, cites no target. A man traveling with a sovereign state's diplomatic passport is accused of terrorism without a shred of material evidence. This mechanism has a name: charge stacking. The gravest counts are piled up not to prove them, but to manufacture a climate — discredit the target, make him toxic — and prepare his extradition to Benin. For that is the destination: Patrice Talon's Benin, a country where the repression of opponents is documented — Reckya Madougou, Joël Aïvo imprisoned. The mother of Séba's children was placed in custody. The logic is constant: reach the man through his own.

France 24 runs the headline "Kémi Séba soon to be extradited to Benin" — with no quotation marks, no question mark, as an established fact — even though no formal extradition request had at that point been filed. The press as vanguard of judicial process. The double standard completes the picture: in 2023, France and its media allies were outraged by the extradition of Paul-Henri Sandaogo Damiba to Togo, seeing it as a violation of rights. In 2026, faced with the hunt for Kémi Séba, the same camp maintains perfect silence. France does not defend a principle. It defends its interests.

Kémi Séba advises an AES head of state and carries a Nigerien diplomatic passport. To go after him is to go after the sovereignty he serves. One does not arrest an expired visa with a terrorism file. One tries to arrest an idea.

But the diaspora is not monolithic. Alongside those who bear witness at the risk of their lives, there are others who have made Facebook a weapon of targeted destruction against sovereignist African governments. The Central African case is the best-documented illustration.

The "12 Apostles" and the exported judicial war

The "12 Apostles" movement — founded by Rodrigue Mayte, known as "Kerembesse" — operates from the Central African diaspora as a franchise of disinformation: personal insults, unsubstantiated allegations, systematic attacks on any figure close to the Bangui government. Membership demands "solidarity in wrongdoing" — the members all have their own legal troubles with the authorities in their home country, which forms their cement.

On December 21, 2023, the Nantes criminal court convicted two active members for defamation against Dr. Martial Pabandji — no evidence presented, conviction upheld. The judge ordered the immediate removal of the posts, with a daily fine for noncompliance. The conviction sets a precedent: freedom of expression does not cover unsubstantiated personal attacks. The network announced its appeal on Christmas Day, live-streamed — the mechanism was exposed, not broken.

In October 2025, Kerembesse crosses the next threshold. The collective files a case with the ICC against President Touadéra, with Canadian lawyer Philippe Larochelle — who had previously defended an anti-balaka commander prosecuted for crimes against humanity. Kerembesse laid out the alternative without hedging: *"Two options to remove Touadéra — a coup or the ICC."* When the ICC is explicitly named as an alternative to a putsch, this is no longer about human rights. It is about regime change by other means.

The thread is clear: military failure in 2020 → Facebook propaganda → French court → ICC. Same network, same objective, same funding. The line between international law and political propaganda vanishes when one side itself declares the equivalence.

Media, networks, NGOs, courts, world sport, an armed diaspora: the arsenal is complete, and it alone would suffice to explain Sahelian distrust. But the most extraordinary part is yet to come — for to prosecute the case against French policy in Africa, one needs no adversaries at all: one need only listen to what France, within its own institutions, admits in private.

The AES: withdrawal from the Rome Statute and the question of justice

"For these governments, withdrawing from the ICC amounts to hastily shirking their obligations under international law and justice." — Marceau Sivieude, regional director of Amnesty International for West

and Central Africa, July 2, 2026

Between June 18 and 24, 2026, Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger filed with the UN Secretary-General their official notifications of withdrawal from the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court. The withdrawal will take effect one year after the notification date — at the earliest, June 23, 2027. Their intention had been announced back in September 2025. The decision, then, is not a fit of anger: it was matured over nine months.

Amnesty International reacted immediately, denouncing a decision that “threatens to deprive thousands of victims of the possibility of obtaining truth, justice, and reparations.” The statement is grave. It deserves to be heard — and it also deserves to be put in context.

What the ICC did — and did not do — in the Sahel

The situation in Mali has been under ICC investigation since 2013. Thirteen years. In thirteen years, no final judgment has delivered justice to Malian victims of the armed conflicts. The Court convicted Ahmad al-Faqi al-Mahdi for the destruction of cultural property in Timbuktu — real crimes, but crimes against heritage, not crimes against people. For the massacres, the rapes, the forced displacements, the extrajudicial executions: nothing.

The situations in Burkina Faso and Niger are currently subject to no public ICC investigation — despite a decade of conflict and thousands of documented civilian deaths. Amnesty International implicitly acknowledges this by noting that “many of these crimes could fall under ICC jurisdiction” — a cautious phrasing that reflects a reality: the Court never opened a case.

Withdrawal from the Rome Statute will, moreover, have no bearing on the cases currently under the Court’s examination. What the AES is leaving is not a functioning justice system — it is a jurisdiction whose theoretical competence has never produced any concrete result for Sahelian victims.

Selectivity as an argument

The ICC is an institution of variable geometry — the figures prove it beyond dispute. Ninety percent of its investigations focus on the African continent. It has never prosecuted a national of the United States, Israel, Russia, or France — whether signatories of the Rome Statute or not, all involved in conflicts that have produced documented civilian victims. The arrest warrant against Vladimir Putin is the first notable exception — and it illustrates the rule: the Court strikes at the West’s adversaries, rarely its allies.

When the Sahel’s transitional governments denounce a two-tier justice system, they are not building a narrative — they are describing a reality backed by figures and documentation. The impunity Amnesty International accuses Bamako, Ouagadougou, and Niamey of is real. But it existed before the coups, during the French presence, during the Barkhane years — and the ICC did nothing to fight it.

What the argument does not resolve

Withdrawal from the Rome Statute nonetheless raises a question that AES governments have not yet answered: what jurisdiction will replace the ICC in trying war crimes committed on their territories?

Amnesty International has urged these governments to strengthen their national judicial systems. That is the right question. The answer cannot be a void. If the ICC is rejected as an instrument of tutelage — and the arguments are solid — something else must be built: a regional African court competent to try international crimes, strengthened national courts, a truth-justice-reparations mechanism for victims.

The African Court on Human and Peoples' Rights exists. It has no criminal jurisdiction. The African Union has debated expanding the jurisdiction of the African Court of Justice and Human Rights to cover international crimes — the Malabo Protocol, signed in 2014, still has not entered into force for lack of sufficient ratifications.

Leaving the ICC without building an alternative leaves victims with no recourse. Sovereignty demands better than a void.

What sovereignty demands

Sovereignty is not impunity. The governments that carried out coups invoking the dignity of their peoples, that expelled foreign armies in the name of protecting civilians, that built a Confederation on the principle of self-determination — these governments carry an obligation of consistency: to deliver justice to victims of crimes committed on their soil, including crimes committed by their own forces.

Amnesty International documents human rights violations committed by all sides — armed groups, but also national armed forces and their auxiliaries. These facts exist. Denying them does not erase them. Acknowledging and prosecuting them is the mark of a state that governs — not of a regime clinging to power.

Withdrawal from the Rome Statute can be an act of sovereignty if it comes paired with a credible judicial architecture. Without one, Amnesty International is right on one point: it is the victims who pay.

The colonial gaze: Hogard, Djibouti, and an Africa without Africans

"The Africa of his childhood is an Africa without Africans."

There is a way of looking at Africa harder to dismantle than open racism: that of the honest man of empire. Without particular cruelty, without stated contempt, without any intent to harm — and yet structurally incapable of seeing Africa as anything other than a space for French action. This is what Fanon calls the

internalized colonial gaze. General Jacques Hogard's interview with Paul-Marie Couteaux is a perfect specimen of it.

Djibouti: the setting for a calling

Hogard discovers Africa as a child, in Djibouti. His father commands the marine infantry regiment. The 13th Foreign Legion Demi-Brigade is the other unit present. "At 14 or 15, I was fascinated by these immaculate white kepis under the African sun." It is in this setting — kepis, bayonets, blue belts — that he forges his military calling. The formative book he reads in Djibouti is *Par le sang versé*, the epic of the Legion in Indochina.

For him, then, Africa is not a subject of history or culture. It is a theater for learning the profession of arms. "I felt much more African than Balkan, if you will." This "Africanness" is purely operational. It contains no curiosity about African societies, histories, or peoples.

What Hogard does not say: Djibouti is the land of the Afar and Issa peoples, two nomadic communities with millennia-old histories, embedded in the trade networks of the Red Sea and the Horn of Africa since antiquity. In 1977 — at the time of Hogard's Djiboutian childhood — Djibouti achieves independence after 115 years of French presence. A country is born. In Hogard's account, this event does not exist. The Afar and Issa do not exist. Africa exists as a setting. Never as a civilization.

The Legion: the imperial filter

The Foreign Legion is the historical instrument of French colonial conquest. It "pacified" Algeria — that is, it massacred populations defending their own land. It fought in Mexico, in Indochina, in sub-Saharan Africa. Its "glories" are the battles of conquest. That this very spectacle — and not the reality of Djibouti — forged young Hogard's calling says everything about the filter through which Africa was transmitted to him: an exclusively military, imperial, and commemorative filter.

This is the classic colonial gaze described by Fanon in *Black Skin, White Masks*: the colonized is absent from the mental landscape of the colonizer, even a well-meaning one. The colonizer can love Africa — he loves its skies, its suns, its horizons, its adventures. He does not love its peoples, because he does not see them.

Geopolitical Djibouti: a nostalgic retreat

Decades later, Hogard revisits Djibouti in geopolitical terms. The Bab-el-Mandeb Strait — "the gate of tears" — is one of the world's most strategic maritime chokepoints: 12% of global trade transits through it, notably Gulf oil bound for Europe. France established itself in Djibouti in 1862 precisely to control this route, well before the opening of the Suez Canal (1869).

Today, Hogard says, "the French base has been reduced to almost nothing" — China set up its first

permanent overseas military base in Djibouti in 2017, the Americans are present on the other side. His tone is that of a receding power, of a man full of regret.

What a pan-Africanist reading sees is different: the Djiboutian government, under President Ismail Omar Guelleh, has deliberately played the card of military multilateralism — hosting French, American, Chinese, Japanese, and Italian bases simultaneously — to maximize its revenue and its room to maneuver. This is Djiboutian foreign policy. It is not a playground for great powers: it is a small state using its geographic position as a bargaining chip. Hogard does not see this. The Djiboutian government, the Djiboutian people, Djibouti's sovereign choices are absent from his account.

Somalia: the American farce

On Somalia, Hogard is more lucid — because it involves criticizing the Americans, not the French. Operation Restore Hope (1992–1993) was, in his view, a communications operation: "With every helicopter, the cameramen. What mattered was the cameras." France sent 150 soldiers there to "lend France's stamp of approval to this American PR operation."

He mocks Kouchner and his bag of rice: "Somalis hate rice, no one eats rice in the Horn of Africa." The anecdote is true and revealing — humanitarian aid as staged performance, disconnected from local realities. The real American motive, according to Hogard, was Somali oil.

He is right about the Americans. But this lucidity about American PR never extends to the French presence itself, whose record in terms of African development is just as catastrophic.

Rwanda: the repressed wound

Hogard mentions Rwanda — and stops immediately. "The tears of honor, that's about Rwanda [...] it is excruciating for France, and it is also foundational for me." He defers the subject to a second conversation.

This deferral is itself revealing. Rwanda in 1994 is the point where the internalized colonial gaze meets its limits: France supported the Habyarimana genocidal regime, its Operation Turquoise soldiers covered the flight of the genocidaires, the Duclert Commission established the responsibilities. This is not a story of white kepis and legionary glory — it is a crime. An honest officer can be founded on it. But he cannot fold it into the narrative of imperial greatness.

This book addressed Rwanda in Chapter 13. Hogard's reticence confirms what was said there: the truth about Rwanda is unbearable for the French colonial narrative.

What the table sums up

-
- Djibouti, childhood — Exotic backdrop, military theater — Colonized territory on the road to independence, Afar and Issa peoples erased
|
 - The Legion — Symbol of glory and calling — Historical instrument of colonial conquest
|
 - Geopolitical Djibouti — Nostalgic French retreat — Djibouti as an actor in its own multilateral diplomacy
|
 - China — Threat, a sign of French decline — A new variable, neither liberating nor neutral
|
 - Somalia — American farce, France's stamp of approval — Same logic as France — predation under a humanitarian cover
|
 - Rwanda — An unspeakable wound, deferred — An established crime, documented responsibilities
|
 - Africans — Absent from the narrative — Historical subjects erased by the imperial filter

What this gaze produces

Hogard is not a monster. That is precisely the problem. Monsters are easy to identify and reject. The honest man of empire — sincere in his calling, courageous on the ground, capable of partial lucidity about his American allies — perpetuates domination unknowingly, unwillingly, because he never learned to see Africans as subjects of their own history.

This is the very gaze the AES is fighting. Not with speeches about racism — with acts that render this gaze obsolete. When Tiani expels French soldiers from Niger, when Goïta closes the bases in Bamako, when Traoré drives out Barkhane — they are not merely expelling soldiers. They are expelling the gaze.

Sources: Interview of General Jacques Hogard by Paul-Marie Couteaux (YouTube, transcript); Frantz Fanon, Black Skin, White Masks (1952); Frantz Fanon, The Wretched of the Earth (1961); Duclert Commission, report on France's role in Rwanda, March 2021; Chapter 13 of this book (Rwanda, Serval, Barkhane); Hamzat Boukari-Yabara, Africa Unite.

Sources: Amnesty International, statement by Marceau Siviéde, regional director for West and Central Africa, July 2, 2026; notifications of withdrawal from the Rome Statute filed by Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger with the UN Secretary-General, June 18-24, 2026; ICC Rome Statute, Article 127 (one-year notice period); Malabo Protocol, African Union, 2014; ACLED data on civilian victims in the Sahel, 2013-2026.

Sources: Jules Domche, Vox Africa, May 2026; Anne-Sophie Avé, public speech on French influence diplomacy; decision suspending French media by Niger's High Communications Authority (decision no. 2026.0058/P-HAC, May 8, 2026); Bassolma Bazié, public statements 2026; Linda Larbaoui, Panafrican Média TV, June 2026; Jonathan Batenguène, Panafrican Média TV, June 14, 2026; Raphaël Granvaud, De l'huile sur le feu, Lux Éditeur, 2024; OCHA 2021 data on humanitarian needs in the Sahel; Laurent Bigot, public interview; Jean-Pierre Olivier de Sardan, work on development aid; HRW report (April 2, 2026); transcript of the Le Colimateur podcast — Wassim Nasr, France 24 journalist, IFRI/DGIS French Ministry of the Armed Forces; Alain Juillet, Principe IX 2026; MSF, internal report on sexual abuse in Chad, July 2025, revealed by the Associated Press on June 13, 2026; Nantes criminal court, 6th chamber section B, judgment of December 21, 2023 (Koulaninga / Adina Tomte vs. Dr. Pabandji); EU sanctions against Nathalie Yamb, Official Journal of the European Union, June 2025; SECO (Swiss State Secretariat for Economic Affairs), response to Yamb's lawyers; arrest of Kémi Séba, Pretoria, April 2026; South African police report; Nestor Podassé, Panafrican Média TV, June 2026; pan-Africanist analysis on the semiotics of French military operations and the launch of RFI's Bambara and Fulani programming, audio commentary, 2026.

CHAPTER 15 — WHAT FRANCE ADMITS IN PRIVATE

"We do not wage war for democracy, but for France's interests." — General François Lecointre, Chief of the Defense Staff (2017–2021)

Paris, September 2024. A room in the National Assembly, doors closed. Before the defense committee meeting behind closed doors, General Thierry Burkhard, Chief of the Defense Staff, drops a sentence that demolishes ten years of official rhetoric: France has no camp of friends in Mali, and cannot choose between JNIM terrorists and Wagner mercenaries. The Malian Armed Forces — the very ones France claimed to have come to support — are lumped together with the jihadists. When a French military chief places the army of a "partner" country in the same camp as those he claimed to be fighting alongside, he says two things: that French policy has failed, and that an African "friend," in Paris's grammar, is someone who obeys.

This chapter is the indictment written by the accused himself. The most damning admissions do not come from pan-Africanists or diaspora activists. They come from members of parliament, generals, diplomats, reports commissioned by the Élysée, and a former director of economic intelligence who decided to say publicly what French doctrine has said privately for sixty years. All that was needed was to gather them. That has now been done.

The parliamentary admission: "domination"

Let us begin with the most official one. The French parliamentary committee on relations between France and Africa writes it in black and white: "We need Africa more than Africa needs us." The same report describes France's African policy as "domination" and recommends a "difficult transition" toward "a phase of cooperation and goodwill." Let us weigh this moment: a democratic parliament officially describes its own foreign policy as domination. The word is in the report. Printed. Archived. Accessible. And nothing has changed.

It is this same parliamentary work that established the tally of military interventions — the fiftieth since independence, as seen in Chapter 13.

On the Assembly floor, some went further. In December 2013, during the debate over Operation Sangaris in the Central African Republic, MP André Chassaigne described the system France supports on the continent: "dictatorships that prefer to defend the interests of sprawling private firms exploiting 80% of Africa's gigantic deposits today, and whose profits are repatriated to tax havens." He calls the Central African Republic "an aircraft carrier at the center of Africa, used in numerous military interventions in the region." He recalls that

Paris backed Bokassa, then Dacko, then Kolingba, then Patassé, then Bozizé — a game of musical chairs orchestrated from France. His conclusion: "France bears a historic responsibility for the Central African tragedy. It is therefore not the best qualified to intervene." This is a French MP speaking, from the floor of the National Assembly. His colleagues voted for the intervention.

The doctrinal admission: the Védérine report

In 2013, François Hollande commissions former foreign minister Hubert Védérine to write a report on Africa. The document explicitly identifies anti-French sentiment and pan-Africanism as a "threat to French interests in Africa." Let us reread that: not jihadism, not poverty, not state collapse — pan-Africanism. An official foreign policy document classifies Africans' political awakening among the problems to be contained. Africans who think are the problem. Africans who obey are the solution.

Yet Raphaël Granvaud's investigation establishes that the Sahel plan, with its clandestine military component, had been decided as early as 2008–2009 — five years before Védérine. Two documents that never cite each other, one commissioned by the Élysée, the other produced by a critical association: same diagnosis, same period. The security war and the political war against African sovereignism were simultaneous, and steered from the same offices.

Alain Juillet: what the enemy says about itself

Alain Juillet is not a pan-Africanist. A former director of intelligence at the DGSE (2002–2003), then Senior Official for Economic Intelligence to the Prime Minister, his interview with Open Box TV in June 2026 — alongside Philippe Bohn — is a strategic document of exceptional frankness. He is not doing PR. He is doing analysis. He names the mistakes, identifies the competitors, prescribes the corrections. He speaks of France like a senior intelligence officer who sees his institution in trouble and is trying to fix it — without the diplomats' doublespeak.

*"France has interests to defend. That's the point. It's not humanitarianism that drives foreign policy." —
Alain Juillet*

His assessment: France is losing ground "everywhere" in French-speaking Africa. The problem "goes beyond the Sahel." Even in Côte d'Ivoire and Senegal, traditional allies, the situation is "precarious." Gabon and Togo are shifting toward the British Commonwealth.

These twelve doctrinal principles, extracted and formalized, form the best available manual for resistance. What the enemy says about itself is a weapon.

Principle I — France is a world power or it is nothing

Juillet never questions the foundation of the French presence in Africa. He takes it as a given: France is a world power. This assumption rests on three pillars he states explicitly:

Nuclear deterrence: one of the six recognized nuclear powers, with a security posture no other European state possesses.

A permanent UN seat: a permanent member of the Security Council with veto power — the ability to block, shape, and steer international decisions, including those in which France is directly a party.

Overseas territories: the world's largest Exclusive Economic Zone — 11 million km² — across every major maritime route.

The African presence is a structural condition of the world status Paris claims, not an ideological or sentimental choice. Africa is the fuel of French power. Not an exception. Not a legacy. A fuel.

Principle II — We defended presidents, not states

The central self-criticism of the interview. Juillet states it without hedging:

"We always defended policies or presidents who were not models of virtue."

The classic Françafrique model operated through personal relationships: an African head of state is sponsored by Paris, receives French diplomatic, military, and economic support, and in return guarantees access to resources, bases, and favorable votes. The relationship is between two individuals — Chirac and Bongo, Sarkozy and Gbagbo, Hollande and IBK — not between two states.

This model has two fatal flaws. First, individuals fall. When the client president disappears, his successor has no reason to honor the commitments — especially if those commitments are perceived as symbols of subjection. Second, defending a president against his own population makes France the enemy of popular legitimacy.

"You didn't have the key to the door — we walked in. That's clear — we were even sort of invited in."

France was not driven out by some irresistible popular will. It was driven out because it created the conditions for its own expulsion by choosing the wrong allies.

Principle III — Contractual transparency

"Defense agreements need to be made transparently. The problem is, for years, we did things under the table, saying it was for people's own good. But that created ambiguities."

The secret agreements of the 1960s — never made public, never submitted to African parliaments — became a political poison. In a world of smartphones and whistleblowers, no secret agreement stays secret indefinitely. A public agreement one controls is better than a secret one that blows up in your face when it surfaces.

The transparency Juillet advocates is selective. It concerns the form of agreements, not necessarily their deeper content. A public agreement can contain deeply lopsided clauses — but such clauses can be politically defended. Transparency of form as cover for imbalance of substance.

Principle IV — Geographic pivot: leave the Sahel, consolidate the pivots

France has lost Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger. Juillet does not claim this is recoverable in the short term. He pivots toward two priority zones:

Djibouti / Horn of Africa: the French base in Djibouti remains a strategic observation post over the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean. Its value lies in surveillance and long-range drone projection.

Angola / Southern Africa:

"There are important ports and important French positions in that country."

Angola has oil (Total operates there), strategic minerals, a large deep-water port, a position on the Cape of Good Hope route, and recent BRICS membership. Joe Biden's visit to Luanda signals that Americans read the situation the same way. The competition for Angola has already begun.

The withdrawal from the Sahel is a geographic repositioning, not a withdrawal from Africa. France is abandoning theaters of insecurity where it is seen as a belligerent and redeploying toward zones where it can anchor itself economically before returning politically.

Principle V — Private military companies

"We're quite behind, it has to be said, compared to others. It's the Americans, the Russians, the Turks, the Chinese who use them."

While Wagner/Africa Corps established itself in the Central African Republic, Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, Sudan, Libya — while the Turks built at Misrata the largest non-American foreign military base in the

world — France maintained the state monopoly over military force abroad.

That monopoly had a cost: full traceability. Every dead soldier creates domestic political pressure. Every misstep involves official responsibility. The PMC model solves these problems: casualties are contract civilians, operations are deniable, zones of action have no political limits.

Future French operations in Africa will not resemble Barkhane. They will resemble what Wagner did: hundreds of technical advisers, security firms registered in discreet jurisdictions, military trainers with no official rank, operations conducted under a local flag. Plausible deniability as operational doctrine. African peoples must understand that the enemy without a uniform is still an enemy.

Principle VI — Industrial partnerships

"If there's a mining sector capacity — ERAMET left a long time ago, we no longer have, for example, mining companies capable of defending, of even having interests to defend."

France withdrew industrially from Africa even before being driven out militarily. Its mining companies gave way to the Chinese, the Australians, the Canadians. Total remains a major energy presence, but the French industrial fabric has frayed over twenty years.

Juillet draws a direct link between industrial presence and the capacity for influence: with no economic interests to defend, there is no strategic reason to maintain a presence. France's return to Africa will not begin with soldiers. It will begin with engineers, site directors, infrastructure contracts. ERAMET in Gabon, Total in Angola, Bouygues in construction — these economic footholds prepare the ground. The industrial Trojan horse.

Principle VII — Playing technological catch-up

"We're always about ten years behind. Remember the drones, we couldn't have French drones weaponized. And now we see everyone equipping theirs."

France deliberately delayed arming its military drones out of political caution. While the United States was weaponizing its Predators and Reapers as early as the 2000s, while Turkey was selling the Bayraktar TB2 from 2014 onward, France operated unarmed surveillance drones. This delay translated into inferior operational capabilities across every zone of deployment, including the Sahel.

The Djibouti base is precisely referenced in this context: it is from Djibouti that the Americans operate their long-range drones across the entire Horn of Africa / Yemen / Somalia zone. France, from the same base,

has lesser capabilities. Technological asymmetry over drones translates directly into strategic asymmetry on the ground.

Principle VIII — Democracy as a tool

"When you see how it works, you go on an election day in a native Zulu area, in the villages, the village chief says who to vote for and everyone votes that way."

"A European-style democracy cannot exist there."

Juillet does not believe in the universality of the liberal democratic model in Africa. Imposing individual elections onto societies organized along tribal, lineage-based, communal lines produces not representation but tribal crystallization — every group votes as a bloc, and whoever loses an election loses not a policy preference but a symbolic tribal war.

French discourse on democracy in Africa is a discourse of convenience. When elections produce results favorable to French interests, they are celebrated. When they produce unfavorable results — PASTEF in Senegal, the AES in Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger — France raises questions about their validity. Democracy as a circumstantial argument.

Principle IX — Manage transitions, don't eradicate

Armed groups that hold territory, control populations, collect taxes, and dispense some form of justice accumulate real local legitimacy. History systematically shows that such groups eventually negotiate their entry into the political game. Algeria's ALN became the Algerian government. Vietnam's Viet Cong became the Vietnamese state. Hamas governs Gaza.

Within this framework, GSIM/JNIM is not an aberration to be eradicated — it is an actor in transition to be managed. If in twenty years it becomes a political party, better to have kept communication channels open. This is what MP Bruno Fuchs would publicly state on April 25, 2026 — the very day of the attack that killed Malian minister Sadio Camara.

For AES states, this logic is an immediate warning: France may have a strategic interest in not seeing certain armed groups completely destroyed, so as to retain leverage in a future political landscape. The total destruction of terrorism is not in Paris's interest.

Principle X — Mapping the competitors

The interview draws a precise map of the competitors. Juillet is not outraged by their presence — he coldly analyzes it.

Russia (Africa Corps / former Wagner): a light, deniable force, able to operate without the political constraints of regular armies. Wagner presented itself as an alternative that is "cheaper, less condescending, without political conditions" — and found takers in several African capitals.

Turkey: Juillet explicitly cites the Misrata base in Libya as the largest Turkish military base outside Turkey. Bayraktar drones exported to Ethiopia, Somalia, Togo, bilateral agreements with no political conditions.

China: ports, railways, roads, power plants via the Export-Import Bank. And the military base in Djibouti — the first permanent overseas base of the People's Liberation Army.

The United States: Camp Lemonnier in Djibouti (4,000 personnel), AFRICOM based in Stuttgart but operating across the entire continent, Biden's visit to Luanda signaling interest in Angola.

France is neither the strongest militarily (the US), nor the wealthiest (China), nor the most flexible (Russia/Turkey). Its comparative strength — institutional legitimacy as a UN P5 member, a historic diplomatic network, familiarity with French-speaking elites — is precisely what is eroding. Its strength is its liability.

Principle XI — Cultural defeat

On Senegal and the rise of PASTEF, Juillet offers a diagnosis of rare frankness:

"Because it ultimately evolved culturally. There was a literary culture, a critical culture, ultimately. So they took the ideas offered to them like a local guru."

"Macky Sall had diagnosed this."

France's defeat in Senegal is not a political defeat — it is a cultural defeat. A generation shaped by critical literature, podcasts, social media, YouTube channels that spread a coherent counter-narrative: the mechanics of the CFA franc, colonial history, stolen resources, client presidents. This critical culture produced an electorate that voted for PASTEF not out of adherence to a precise economic program but out of rejection of a system now named and understood.

Julillet's phrase about Sonko — "like a local guru" — betrays a failure to grasp the depth of the phenomenon. Sonko is not a guru who hypnotized a naive population. He is the product of a political culture that

has existed for years and whose ideas circulate in families, universities, mosques, and marketplaces. France did not lose Senegal because of Sonko. It lost it because it failed to see coming the cultural transformation that made Sonko possible.

Principle XII — The permanent seat: the absolute constant

Throughout the entire interview, France's seat on the UN Security Council is treated as an intangible given — a foundation on which everything else rests.

"France is a permanent member of the UN Security Council. That's not a detail."

He links it directly to nuclear deterrence: the two feed a single circular logic. Everything can change in French Africa policy — partners, methods, geographic theaters, instruments — but the permanent seat is the constant. This is why Security Council reform, sought by the African Union for twenty years, meets with absolute French resistance: to accept a permanent African seat with veto power is to accept losing the institutional tool that protects every other position. This principle deserves a treatment matching its strategic weight.

The P5 seat: the anomaly of 1945

A diplomatic victory over a military defeat

France did not win the Second World War. Invaded in six weeks in May–June 1940, its legal government surrendered and collaborated. It was the United States, the Soviet Union, and the United Kingdom that crushed the Reich — not Free France, a courageous but marginal fraction of the coalition. France was liberated from the outside.

In 1945, it nonetheless obtains one of the five permanent UN seats. The decision was political: Churchill wanted a continental counterweight to the USSR. De Gaulle played, with rare skill, the card of the Resistance's symbolic legitimacy against the reality of a military defeat. A diplomatic triumph over a military disaster — and the founding of an institutional anomaly that today shapes the lives of 1.5 billion Africans.

The world counted 51 UN member states in 1945. It counts 193 in 2026. Africa — fewer than ten independent states in 1945 — accounts for 54 today: more than a quarter of the General Assembly. India, the world's second-most populous nation and a declared nuclear power — no permanent seat. Brazil, Latin America's largest economy — no seat. Indonesia, the world's fourth-most populous nation — no seat.

France — 67 million people, 1% of the world's population, an economy in relative decline — keeps its

veto. A legacy not of a victory, but of a diplomatic coup eighty years ago.

Twenty-eight percent of African humanity. Zero vetoes.

The veto as a postcolonial tool

A resolution approved by 14 votes out of 15 is null and void if the fifteenth — a P5 member — votes against it. France has systematically used this mechanism to protect its interests on the continent.

Mali — MINUSMA: France architected Resolution 2100 (April 2013), defined the mandate, the rules of engagement, the geographic priorities — while unilaterally running Barkhane in parallel. Judge and party, in perpetuity. When Malian authorities requested MINUSMA's withdrawal in 2023, Paris tried to attach conditions to it.

Central African Republic — MINUSCA: MINUSCA's mandates were regularly rewritten to protect certain actors close to Paris from investigations into human rights violations. Naming French abuses from the same period would have required a comparison.

Niger — 2023, the boomerang: France tried to use the Security Council to legitimize a military intervention via ECOWAS. The resolution was never adopted — Russia and China invoked non-interference in sovereign affairs. The Security Council weapon had ceased to be a French monopoly. The institutional boomerang.

Paris understood earlier than anyone the arithmetic of this tool: without a permanent seat, France would become a power that intervenes militarily abroad with no international cover — like Russia in Ukraine, which it vehemently condemns. The veto is the device that distinguishes its own violence from the violence it condemns. The difference between a power and a rogue actor is the P5 seat.

The African demand and French resistance

The Ezulwini Consensus, adopted by the African Union in 2005, calls for two permanent African seats with veto power. Twenty years of waiting. The reason for the blockage is simple: every new veto granted mechanically reduces the value of the French veto. If India, Brazil, and two African states join the club, France is no longer a singular power — it becomes one voice among eight or nine. Its diplomatic bargaining currency devalues.

Paris presents itself as the champion of multilateralism and UN institutions. It uses those very institutions to block their own reform, protect its interests, and cover its interventions. Colonel Goïta, Captain Traoré, General Tiani have not rejected international law — they have rejected an international order in which France holds a veto and Africa does not. For them, the permanent seat is proof of institutionalized injustice, not of legitimacy. Duration is not justice.

For the AES, the stakes are existential: had the three states had an ally holding a veto on the Security Council, any resolution authorizing military intervention against them — via ECOWAS or directly — would have been blocked.

What the AES must demand

Two permanent African seats with effective veto power. Not a rotation. Not seats without veto. The only format that would truly change the balance of power.

What this would concretely change: military interventions in Africa, the mandates of MINUSMA and MINUSCA, sanctions against African states, investigations into human rights violations — all of these decisions would have required the agreement of African states with a real power to block them.

The coalition exists: India, Brazil, Germany, and Japan have carried the G4 for twenty years. The AU has carried the Ezulwini Consensus since 2005. Amending the UN Charter requires the agreement of all five P5 members — each holds a veto over its own dispossession. But in a multipolar world, the legitimacy of the status quo is eroding. And illegitimacy costs more every year.

Real sovereignty begins when one holds a voice that cannot be taken away. In 2026, Africa still does not have that on the Security Council. Everything else — bases, currencies, agreements — is negotiable within this frame. The frame itself is not, as long as France holds a veto within it.

The strategist's confession: "for France's interests"

There remains the most naked admission, because it comes from a man who commanded the war. General François Lecointre was Chief of the Defense Staff of the French armed forces from 2017 to 2021. No marginal figure, no dissident: the very top of the military institution. In a public interview, Lecointre concedes: "The withdrawal from the Sahel was hard to accept... it's a failure."

The former head of the armed forces, under whom Barkhane was conducted, speaks of failure. The word, from his mouth, is not an opinion: it is an assessment drawn from the inside. By the man who gave the orders. By the man who knew.

But the admission comes with an alibi: the failure was "French, European, and African" — responsibility is diluted, and the war's first victims get their share of the blame. What Lecointre lets slip without any alibi, however, is the sentence that dissolves every official discourse:

"We do not wage war for democracy, but for France's interests." — General François Lecointre

The statement demolishes the official justification for Serval, Barkhane, and the G5 Sahel. This is not a pan-Africanist pamphlet: it is the former Chief of the Defense Staff. And he adds: "I am convinced that in a few years — ten, fewer, or more — we will be obligated to go back and help these African countries." The withdrawal is not final: it is a military option held in reserve. We retreat. We will return. Juillet said the same thing, with his PMCs and his Angola.

Chad's confession: "it was ours"

One last, more intimate admission reveals the true nature of the bond Paris maintained with its "partners." In a public exchange, a French official speaks of Chad in the past tense: "Chad was ours. We're no longer there." Then he catches himself, aware of what the word reveals: "'Ours' is a big word... if Africans hear us say that..." Too late. The tongue spoke before caution could catch up. And he adds: Chad "was the DGSE's country," equipped with "a Chadian army we could count on. They helped us, they loved us."

Everything is in these few sentences. A sovereign state referred to as a possession — "ours." A national army reduced to an auxiliary force "we could count on." And colonial affect laid bare: "they loved us." The relationship Paris dreamed of is not a partnership between equals; it is a subject's fidelity to his master. Asked about the collapse of this arrangement, the same official nonetheless refuses to pin it all on the current president: "Is all this Macron's fault? No, it started before." A decisive admission: the loss of the *pré carré* is not a governance accident, it is the collapse of a system — one that began well before Macron, and that no tenant of the Élysée could have stopped.

What Juillet's doctrine reveals for the AES

The strength of the Juillet interview is that it states the truth of French intentions without hiding them behind humanitarian or democratic rhetoric. For AES states, this clarity is useful: it allows a response to the real doctrine, not to the façade communication.

- Against Principle I (world status): the AES cannot make French interests in Africa disappear. It can make them costly to defend, and force them to be pursued differently.
- Against Principle IV (geographic pivot): France abandons the Sahel but reinforces its flanks. Solidarity between the AES and states in the Horn of Africa, Central Africa, and Southern Africa becomes strategically necessary to avoid encirclement.
- Against Principle V (PMCs): future French operations in the region will be conducted through deniable private companies. Any outside security presence in AES neighboring countries must be scrutinized, whatever flag it operates under.

- Against Principle IX (managing transitions): France may have an interest in maintaining a level of destabilization in AES countries — not to destroy them, but to remain indispensable to their future stabilization.
- Against Principle XI (cultural defeat): if France's defeat is cultural, resistance must be cultural too. Strengthening cultural production, universities, pan-African media — this is a strategic battle, not a luxury.
- Against Principle XII (permanent seat): the AES's central strategic objective in international forums should be to actively support reform of the Security Council. It is the only reform that would structurally change the institutional balance of power.

Alain Juillet is not arguing that France should abandon Africa. He is arguing that it should change its methods in order to stay. Every principle of his doctrine aims at the same objective: maintaining French interests in Africa with instruments adapted to the world of 2026. What Juillet does not say — and this is the fundamental limit of his doctrine — is that African peoples are not variables in a geostrategic equation. They have memories, cultures, projects. France can change its instruments — PMCs instead of Barkhane, transparent agreements instead of secret clauses, Angola instead of Mali. But as long as the objective remains the defense of French interests at the expense of African sovereignty, the form changes and the substance remains.

That is precisely what the peoples of the Sahel understood.

They knew

Let us gather the pieces. 2008–2009: the Sahel plan is decided in secret. 2013: Védérine classifies pan-Africanism among the threats. 2017: Macron acknowledges before the G5 Sahel that without governance and hope, the war cannot be won — and continues it for seven more years. A parliamentary commission writes "domination" and admits France needs Africa more than the reverse. 2024: the Chief of the Defense Staff admits, behind closed doors, that there is no camp of friends in Mali. The former head of economic intelligence observes that the house is burning "everywhere." And for eighty years, the Security Council veto has covered every one of these facts, protected every one of these actors, blocked every reform that would call this system into question.

At no point did these diagnoses, however convergent, change policy. France mistook Africa for property, and Africans for subjects — and it knew this, because it wrote it down. The indictment was in its own archives.

The indictment, then, was written, signed, and archived by France itself. All that was missing was men to draw its conclusions — and that is exactly what happened, one August morning in 2020, in a garrison called Kati.

PART IV — THE REVOLUTION OF SOVEREIGNTY

Three capitals. Three nights. Three ruptures.

Bamako, August 2020. Ouagadougou, September 2022. Niamey, July 2023. In three years, the three countries Paris considered the safest backyard of its African apparatus tore themselves away, one after another, from sixty years of tutelage. Then they did what no one had dared since independence: they united.

This part tells how. Not a succession of accidents, but a construction — chapter after chapter, from the soldier turned away from Kidal in 2013 to the coordinated attacks of April 25, 2026, by way of the signing of the Liptako-Gourma Charter. The story of an alliance born under fire, one that turned every blow it received into a cornerstone.

Everything begins in Kati, in a Malian barracks, at four in the morning.

Sources: French parliamentary commission, France-Africa report; General Thierry Burkhard, closed session National Assembly, September 2024; Védrine report, 2013; General François Lecointre, public interview, 2024; Alain Juillet and Philippe Bohn, full interview, Open Box TV, June 2026; Raphaël Granvaud, De l'huile sur le feu (Lux Éditeur, 2024); Ezulwini Consensus, AU, March 2005; UN Charter (1945), Articles 23–27; Security Council resolutions 2100 (2013), 2127 (2013), 2690 (2023); NPT, 1968; Report of the UN High-Level Panel on Threats, Challenges and Change, 2004; speech by the AES delegation to the UN General Assembly, September 2023.

PART IV

THE SOVEREIGNTY REVOLUTION

CHAPTER 16 — MALI: THE FIRST RUPTURE

"Mali is and will remain One and Indivisible." — Assimi Goïta, upon the capture of Kidal, November 14, 2023

Kati, August 18, 2020, four in the morning. Gunfire breaks out at the large military base overlooking Bamako, fifteen kilometers from the capital. Within hours, it is over: President Ibrahim Boubacar Keïta — "IBK" — is arrested at his residence. A quiet colonel, forged at the front, takes the lead of the National Committee for the Salvation of the People: Assimi Goïta. That night, IBK announces his resignation on national television, his voice weary, a surgical mask on his face. By morning, crowds are dancing in the streets of Bamako.

Those crowds are the key to this chapter. For on August 18, 2020, two scenes unfold at once: in Bamako, spontaneous popular jubilation; in Paris, Brussels, Abuja, and New York, unanimous condemnation — the EU, ECOWAS, France, the United Nations. This gap between international reproof and the celebration of those most directly concerned is the most significant political fact of 2020 in Africa. It would never be seriously analyzed by the major media, who preferred to condemn the soldiers rather than ask what IBK represented for those crowds. Everything that follows in this book flows from that dodged question.

A collapse foretold seven years earlier

What the West presented as a "rupture of constitutional order" was in reality the consequence of a far older destruction: that of the real order — social, economic, security-related. As early as 2013, researcher Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou described the Malian state on its trajectory of decay: "an absence of political consensus, weak social cohesion, predatory authorities, and a corrupt army." The Malian state, he wrote, "is no longer perceived as a unifying idea but as a vector of division" (Mohamedou, in *La Guerre au Mali*, La Découverte, 2013).

A state can exist on paper — flag, ministries, elections — while having ceased to exist in the lives of its citizens: no more security, no more justice, no more services, elites who extract rather than serve. When a state has been in this condition for a decade, no one has the right to be surprised when it falls. The 2020 military transition did not shatter an order: it registered a collapse that the elites in power had kept on life support, with Paris's backing.

Kidal, May 2013: the soldier turned away

To understand the man who seizes power that night, one must go back seven years, to the country's north. Nathalie Yamb recounts the sequence with a precision that demands a rereading of the entire 2013–2020 period: "In early May 2013, the French army forbade the Malian army from entering Kidal. Among the soldiers thus turned away: private Assimi Goïta. That day, it became obvious that the French army was not there to fight the terrorists but to protect them" (Yamb, November 14, 2023).

This testimony establishes a striking biographical continuity between the humiliated soldier of 2013 and the transitional president of 2021. Goïta's break with Paris is not an elaborate geostrategic calculation dreamed up in an office. It is the conclusion of a lived experience: he saw, with his own eyes, what Barkhane was protecting in Kidal — that northern city forbidden to Malian soldiers on their own territory, as recounted in Chapter 13. He drew the only logical conclusion, ten years later, once he had the means to act on it.

He is not alone: Goïta embodies an entire generation of African soldiers forged at the front, who watched their men die while French generals forbade them from advancing north. This generation has a simple reading of the situation: those who are supposed to be helping do not want the problem solved. If the problem were solved, they would have no reason to still be there.

Kidal, a country within a country: eleven years of sanctuarization

What private Goïta saw with his own eyes in May 2013, Choguel Kokalla Maïga recounts with a historian's precision on the first anniversary of the liberation, November 16, 2024. He traces it back to its source.

In September 1907, a French soldier signs a convention at Kidal with the Amok of the region. He makes him swear on the Quran never to betray France. That oath would endure — in one direction. For France, meanwhile, would spend seven decades maneuvering against the very interests of the people it had demanded fidelity from. The betrayal is old. It has simply been institutionalized.

In January 2012, the MNLA — instrumentalized by foreign powers, backed by drug traffickers and terrorist groups — invades northern Mali. Within months, the Malian state collapses, losing more than three-quarters of its territory. The situation is a windfall for Paris. Taking advantage of Bamako's weakness, France sanctuarizes Kidal: it gathers terrorists and separatists of every stripe there, protects them behind a foreign military shield, and forces the Malian government to negotiate with them. For three decades, Kidal and its surroundings escape central authority. Access is forbidden to the Malian government. Meanwhile, foreign forces — French in reality — serve as a shield for these same armed groups.

The peak of horror is reached on May 17, 2014. Around fifty Malian compatriots are coldly murdered in an assault on Kidal — including six members of command personnel. Official France witnesses the massacre. It does not intervene. Not to prevent it, not even to recover the bodies of Malian soldiers who had taken refuge on MINUSMA premises. The international mission supposedly there to protect the population also stands by

and watches.

Choguel's formula speaks for itself: *"From March 30, 2012 to November 14, 2023, the situation in Kidal was like a country within a country."* Eleven years. Eleven years during which an African government had no access to part of its own territory — with UN sanction and the active protection of the French army.

The objective was not to resolve the conflict. It was to prolong it. *"Keep us spinning for 20, 30, 40 years so that an entire generation vanishes from the earth"* — this is the logic Choguel articulates after living through its mechanisms from the inside. Colonization pursues the same goal: *"submit and divide."* While, in Europe, geographic blocs are being built — Corsica, New Caledonia held by force, Catalonia defended by Madrid — the same actors are manufacturing, in Africa, *"small ethnic principalities"* meant to remain colonizable. In central Mali, between Fulani and Dogon, terrorism was deliberately created — not spontaneous, not endogenous — to supply the pretext for outside intervention.

The most damning revelation concerns NGOs. In Kidal, the Malian government arrested *"NGOs that served as camouflage to finance terrorist movements."* The same humanitarian organizations that had championed the "Tuareg question" in international media since the 1980s, that romanticized the *"blue men of the desert"* (see above, the France Libertés Foundation), served as logistical cover for financing armed groups. Humanitarian aid as a weapon of war — discreet, respectable, untouchable.

On November 14, 2023, this entire edifice collapses in under twenty-four hours. The FAMa retake Kidal. *"What the enemy had managed, over three decades, to shatter"* — the unity of the territory — is restored. Choguel concludes without ambiguity: liberated Kidal is *"official France's field failure."* And for all Malians, for all the peoples of the Alliance of Sahel States — now the *"second homeland of all Malians"* — it is proof that what had been presented as inevitable was not.

The second act and the merger with the street

The transition does not stop in August 2020. On May 24, 2021, Goïta strikes a second time: he removes interim president Bah N'Daw and his prime minister Moctar Ouane, accused of wanting to marginalize the military in the new government, and has himself installed as transitional president. Above all, he appoints Choguel Kokalla Maïga as prime minister, a figure from the M5-RFP — the popular movement that had, for months, driven the street's protest against IBK.

This choice is no accident. The military transition does not govern against society: it institutionalizes the merger between popular protest and the rupture carried by the army. It is this welding of the barracks to the street that distinguishes Mali's 2020 from the countless military seizures of power Africa has known — and that explains why this one held.

Choguel Maïga very quickly gives this rupture its historical depth: *"We owe our 1944–1945 freedom to*

African riflemen. The debt runs the other way.” France liberated by African soldiers; the moral debt reversed. Maïga would be pushed out of government in August 2022, during a consolidation of military power — the counterpoint deserves naming: the Malian transition also knows how to rid itself of its civilian allies. But his intellectual framing would remain the reference point, taken up by Tiani, Yamb, and others. Some contributions do not vanish with the reshuffles.

The hypocrisy of the international community

The international reaction to Mali’s second coup was unanimous: ECOWAS, the African Union, the Francophonie, the World Bank, the IMF — condemnation in unison. Nathalie Yamb, a Cameroonian analyst, dismantled this mechanism with surgical precision.

First argument: the putschists of Paris. Napoleon Bonaparte — whose bicentennial Macron had celebrated with fanfare the previous month — was a coup-maker. Charles de Gaulle, “liberator” of France and founder of the Fifth Republic, was a coup-maker. France reserves the right to put its own coup-makers on a pedestal while setting itself up as a tribunal to judge those of other peoples.

Second argument: Chad’s double standard. A month before railing against Bamako, Macron had rushed onto his plane to bless Mahamat Idriss Déby — author of a coup in Chad following his father’s death under murky circumstances. Idriss Déby the father, who had become a critic of Françafrique, had been assassinated. His more docile son was immediately recognized. Result: no suspension of Chad by the African Union, CEMAC, the Francophonie, or the World Bank. None. The Malian interim government was serenely drinking its tea at home while Mahamat Déby seized power with hands still stained. The rule is simple: it is not the coup that is condemned, it is disobedience to Paris.

Third argument: the illegitimacy of Barkhane. France’s military presence in Mali rests on a single document: a letter sent on January 10, 2013 by Dioncounda Traoré to President François Hollande, requesting intervention. Dioncounda Traoré was himself heading a post-coup interim government — that of Amadou Sanogo — with no popular mandate, no consultation of the Malian people. Washington had acknowledged this: the contested legitimacy of the then-government had led the United States to refuse direct aid to the Malian army. Barkhane thus rests on the letter of an illegitimate head of state, written with no vote from the people, authorizing a foreign army to settle in for ten years. Macron waved the withdrawal of his troops like a threat. It was for Mali to ask this squatter army to leave — and that is exactly what Mali did.

Fourth argument: the financing of the condemnation. 73% of the African Union’s budget is financed by the European Union, the United States, China, and the World Bank. Seventy-three percent. Nathalie Yamb is direct: *“It’s the giving hand that gives the orders.”* When the African Union suspends Mali, it executes a decision whose contours were drawn by its main funders. The pan-African institution condemning the Malian

coup is 73% financed by the very powers that want the coup reversed. Independent judgment is mathematically impossible.

These four arguments draw the map of a system: international sanction is not a reaction to a democratic rupture. It is the control mechanism through which outside powers penalize African states that refuse their tutelage.

Fifth argument: the confession of Barkhane's own commander. In November 2018, the commander of Operation Barkhane holds a press conference at the Maison de la Presse in Bamako. Before journalists, he openly states that *"some of the groups that are with Mali are with the terrorists at night."* He says it himself. The commander of the force supposedly meant to eradicate terrorism in the Sahel publicly acknowledges that some of Bamako's allies cooperate with terrorists at night. Two conclusions follow: first, that Barkhane knew and did not act; second, that if these double-hatted groups existed under French surveillance, their existence served a purpose — maintaining insecurity as the condition for the presence. Choguel Maïga, who has read the memoirs of French commanders, is categorical: *"They give one speech, their soldiers do something else. At night, they see each other."*

This indictment is not that of a pan-Africanist analyst. It was delivered in the French National Assembly, by a French elected official. Jean-Paul Lecoq, a Communist MP, put it this way before his colleagues:

"You have humiliated the peoples of West Africa. Your democratic outrage of variable geometry has worn out these peoples and undermined their aspiration to democracy. Why, after Idriss Déby's death in Chad, did you rush to bless his son's constitutional coup? Why was the coup in Guinea that replaced Alpha Condé with a former French Foreign Legion soldier, Lieutenant Colonel Doumbouya, only half-heartedly condemned by France? Why was Mali's coup alone sanctioned by ECOWAS? This blockade only pours fuel on the fire and makes only the population suffer. Why did President Macron allow himself to 'summon' — that was the term used — the heads of state of the G5 Sahel to the Pau summit on January 13, 2020, to force them once again to swear allegiance to France? Why do you refuse to validate the UN investigation into the bombing by the French army at Bounti in Mali on January 3, 2021, which killed around twenty people at a gathering that was, in all likelihood, only a wedding?" — Jean-Paul Lecoq, Communist MP, French National Assembly

This passage deserves to be read twice, not for its rhetoric, but for what it structurally reveals. Guinea's coup — which brought to power Mamadi Doumbouya, a former member of the French Foreign Legion, trained by France, armed by France — was "half-heartedly condemned." Because Doumbouya's coup was not against Paris; it was for Paris. The lieutenant colonel had served France before serving Conakry. Bamako's coup, on the other hand, was a rupture. The difference in treatment is explained neither by democracy nor by human

rights — it is explained by loyalty.

The Pau summit of January 13, 2020 deserves its own place in this picture. Macron had used the word “summon” to describe the invitation extended to the five heads of state of the G5 Sahel. One summons subordinates, not counterparts. The summit’s agenda was explicit: to force them to publicly declare that France was welcome in Mali and that they wanted its military presence. Ibrahim Boubacar Keïta — IBK — complied, on camera, confirming the allegiance Paris demanded. A few months later, the Malian street drove him from power. The lesson had been learned: a president who lets himself be “summoned” to Pau loses Mali.

The test: the airport’s 49 “mercenaries”

On July 10, 2022, 49 members of Ivorian special forces are arrested at Bamako airport. They are disguised as students and electrical technicians. No mission orders. MINUSMA — the UN mission in Mali — confirms that no personnel rotation was scheduled that day. For Bamako, this is not a logistical misunderstanding but an infiltration. The affair takes on particular significance when one recalls the recording attributed to Alassane Ouattara and Boubou Cissé from February 17, 2022, examined in Chapter 10 — “Within two weeks they fall.”

Choguel Maïga, who himself handled the crisis in real time, gives the doctrinal explanation. Contemporary armies have what are known as “clandestine pits” — special-forces units that operate under false civilian identities. Their rule: identity must never be known, even when their presence is detected. The disguise is not a procedural accident — it is the procedure. On July 10, 2022, Malian security services saw military passports listing civilian occupations — students, researchers, masons, mechanics, electricians, painters, security guards — and drew the obvious conclusion. Ivory Coast’s defense minister subsequently acknowledged without ambiguity that these men had “*specific missions*” and were meant to “*replace those already in the field and pass on instructions to them.*” An intelligence rotation, not a protection detail.

The affair reveals a broader structural vulnerability. Since 2019, international force rotations had been arriving in Mali without their weapons lists and rules of engagement having been agreed with the Malian state beforehand. The Danes expected under this framework had a precedent to point to: “everyone does as they please,” according to Choguel — a tolerance that had let a foreign military presence settle onto Malian territory with no real oversight. A German firm resembling the SAS had been operating in this zone since the year 2000, unchecked. At the UN, when MINUSMA tried to push through a resolution to obtain secured armed escorts without Bamako’s consent, Russia vetoed it. The transition was not alone.

Bamako’s position, Choguel states plainly: “*Our security is not for sale.*”

The message the transition takes from this is clear: the threat comes not only from armed groups in the north. It also comes from neighboring capitals still in Paris’s orbit. And a name already circulates among the

designated targets in this recording: that of Colonel Sadio Camara, minister of defense, the man methodically rebuilding the Malian army. That name should be remembered — Chapter 20 will belong to it entirely.

Choguel Maïga, who followed ECOWAS's military deployments along the AES borders in real time, has decoded their deeper logic. These deployments pursue four objectives the general public, fixated on the first, generally does not perceive.

First objective — the dislocation of ECOWAS itself. If a member country of ECOWAS launches a war against another member, it can no longer maintain its membership in the organization. ECOWAS implodes through its own mechanism of war. This is the intended result.

Second objective — intimidating the political powers still in place. An implicit message to African presidents still in Paris's orbit: *"If you let us go, the military will overthrow you. Your security is in our hands. Stay docile, or you fall."* The armed deployment is not a threat to the transitions — it is a threat to presidents who might be tempted by rupture.

Third objective — intimidating military hierarchies. A message to generals: *"One coup, and we intervene. That's what we're here for."* Deterrence aimed squarely at the body most capable of breaking the tutelage.

Fourth objective — intimidating the peoples. Populations wanting to show their support for the transitions see a foreign army deployed just across the border. The panic effect is calculated.

"But they will not fool us," Choguel concludes — before calling on Africans to *"take a holistic reading"* of what these deployments truly mean, rather than seeing only the security façade.

October 2023: MINUSMA as a weapon of partition

On October 11, 2023, French defense minister Sébastien Lecornu is questioned before the Senate's Foreign Affairs and Defense committee. Before French lawmakers, he lets slip the real objective: *"Their next objective is the partition of Mali."* He is not talking about the jihadists. He is talking about Mali's transitional authorities.

This is the program, not a slip — said behind closed doors before the Senate, the very same day MINUSMA begins sabotaging its own withdrawal.

When Mali demanded MINUSMA's departure in June 2023 (Security Council resolution 2690), a withdrawal timetable had been set: 13 camps — called *emprises* — were to be handed over to Malian authorities according to a coordinated schedule. The UN's watchword was coordination. It is this very coordination MINUSMA will deliberately break.

The mechanics are simple: if the UN mission leaves a base before the Malian Armed Forces (FAMa) are in position, it effectively hands it over to the armed groups controlling the ground — in this case the CMA

(Coordination of Azawad Movements), pro-French separatists. MINUSMA had already tested this scenario at Ber in August 2023: it moved up its departure by three days, but the FAMa were already in the zone and retook the camp after fierce fighting.

On October 10, 2023, at Kidal, MINUSMA acts. The mission was to stay until between November 15 and 30. It abruptly announces an accelerated departure. That same day, CMA elements surround Camp No. 1 of BATFAR — the joint battalion created by the 2015 Algiers Accord, which had integrated 200 Malian soldiers, 200 pro-government elements, and 200 separatist rebel fighters. Thanks to infiltrators embedded within BATFAR itself, the CMA seizes the camp and all its equipment. MINUSMA's soldiers, whose mission was to protect it, do not intervene.

On the morning of October 10, Malian authorities had asked MINUSMA to delay its early departure by 72 hours to organize. The UN mission let the camp fall. The following day, it announces it is considering further accelerating its withdrawal from the Kidal, Tessalit, and Aguelhok bases — specifying it might *"destroy or disable sensitive equipment that cannot be repatriated."* In plain terms: abandon military equipment the CMA could recover, whose deactivation no one could verify.

Nathalie Yamb named the logic without hedging: *"MINUSMA, having scrambled its withdrawal timeline, is about to abandon war matériel so that CMA terrorists can seize it and finally achieve the definitive partition of Mali."*

The continuity is traced: Danielle Mitterrand's France Libertés Foundation had romanticized Tuareg rebels as early as the 1980s–1990s, presenting them as *"blue men of the desert"* deserving their own country. In 2013, the French army had turned away the FAMa at Kidal to protect these same separatists. In 2023, MINUSMA hands the bases to the CMA at the precise moment the FAMa are advancing. The project to partition Mali never stopped. Only the instruments change.

But the calculation failed. The FAMa were not caught off guard.

November 14, 2023: Kidal

There remains the final demonstration. On November 14, 2023, the Malian Armed Forces retake Kidal. The symbol-city, a rebel stronghold since 2012, the very one the French army had forbidden Malian soldiers to enter, falls in under twenty-four hours. What Barkhane had failed to accomplish in ten years of presence, the FAMa achieve sixteen months after the last French soldiers left. The soldier turned away in May 2013 enters Kidal as president. That night, Goïta delivers the sentence opening this chapter: "Mali is and will remain One and Indivisible."

The Malian circle closes — but the rupture is only beginning. For while Bamako was retaking its north, a thirty-five-year-old captain in Ouagadougou was turning rupture into doctrine.

The 5th anniversary: assessing a transition at war

June 7, 2026 marks five years since General Assimi Goïta's official investiture at the head of the Malian transition. That same day, Bamako inaugurates the Maison des Pupilles de la République — a reception center for the children of soldiers and civilians who died defending the country. The cornerstone was laid in February 2024; the building is funded by the Presidential Sovereignty Fund, and the ceremony ends with the handover of vehicles to the National Office for the Wards of Mali.

The symbol condenses the security dimension as much as the social one: protecting the orphans of fighters cuts jihadist recruitment off at the root. "This initiative tends to cut the grass out from under terrorist groups, who tend to recruit among the wronged part of the population," analyzes pan-African observer Patient Parfait Ndoum on For You Media Africa, June 8, 2026. "A child who has lost his father in this war ends up isolated, without guidance, without means — a target for the sellers of illusions." By caring for these children, the state turns mourning into civic engagement: it reminds the orphans of the meaning of their parents' sacrifice, and gives them a reason to defend the nation in turn.

The five-year assessment is clear-eyed. "These five years were never smooth sailing," the same analyst sums up. Goïta had to face an unwanted asymmetric war that diverted a considerable share of attention and resources toward securing the territory. Militarily, the partnership with Russia's Africa Corps was "decisive." Institutionally, the transition's five stated objectives — security, refounding the state, governance, return to constitutional order, and national sovereignty — were not all achieved with the same intensity: the return to constitutionalism remains pending. The conclusion nonetheless holds: "Mali today is more master of its own destiny than it was in 2021." Security and the economy are recognized in their fundamental interdependence — neither can advance without the other.

The signal sent from the June 2021 investiture deserves recalling: Goïta had given up two-thirds of the 150 million CFA francs a month allocated to the presidential sovereignty fund. For comparison, in Côte d'Ivoire, Ouattara, his wife, and his clan share the equivalent of 3,142 billion CFA francs a year — that is, 28.5 billion a month — drawn from national wealth. This renunciation was no symbolic gesture. It was a political act: a head of state cutting his own income at the very moment he was asking his people for sacrifices.

This gesture recalls the model set by Mamadou Koulibaly, then budget minister of Côte d'Ivoire during the 1999 Guéï transition. Faced with post-coup international sanctions, he made a decision orthodox economists deemed suicidal: suspend servicing foreign debt in order to prioritize domestic payments — civil servants, local contractors, populations. Foreign creditors, already collecting exorbitant interest rates, could wait. The sky did not fall. Within a year, Côte d'Ivoire had financed, from its own funds, the presidential election, the legislative elections, and the referendum that had preceded them. Koulibaly drew a universal lesson from it: *he who loves his country — if he wants — can*. The lesson applies to Bamako in 2021 as much as to any African transition

under pressure from foreign creditors.

Sovereignty is not decreed in speeches alone. It is exercised in acts — including in the sky. The standoff with Air France is the clearest demonstration of this. In August 2023, the French airline unilaterally suspends its flights to Bamako. Malian foreign minister Abdoulaye Diop responds immediately: the operating license is canceled, the vacated slots redistributed. In October 2023, Air France attempts a show of force, announcing a resumption via a chartered plane. Immediate sanction: the head of civil aviation who had signed the agreement without consulting his superiors is dismissed within twenty-four hours. On June 30, 2026, Air France permanently closes its local office. Nearly three years of standoff, documented attempts to return, statements about “the importance of the Malian market” — and a total blockade maintained. Bamako’s skies belong to Mali.

One critical angle deserves naming because it comes from within the ranks of supporters. Mali’s recognition of Moroccan primacy over Western Sahara is judged inconsistent by several pan-African analysts: “You cannot fight for your own sovereignty and prevent another people claiming its own from doing the same.” The argument is cognitive as much as moral — an internal contradiction that weakens the sovereignist narrative. Consistency is not optional. It is a requirement.

Continental solidarity around Mali finally finds expression in a formula that transcends borders: “Mali’s victory is our victory. If Mali fails, it will be our failure.” This sense of shared destiny may be the most durable political fact of the Malian transition: it turned a national crisis into a pan-African cause.

The Paris plot: June 2025 — June 2026

On June 17, 2026, *Jeune Afrique* publishes an investigation into an attempt to organize a rebellion against the Malian government from France.

The facts: between June and August 2025, three individuals approach Malian exiles in Paris. Éric Gozlan — Franco-Israeli —, Paul Michel Manand — Belgian —, and Jugen Bron — a representative of a Ukrainian veterans’ foundation — with, in the shadows, a certain “Victor,” identified as a French agent. Their offer: training in the handling of war drones by Ukrainian military intelligence (GUR), financing of armed operations, logistical support to overthrow General Goïta. A coup prepared from Paris. By agents linked to French services. With Ukrainian equipment.

The Malian exiles approached refuse. One of them documents the exchanges and informs Bamako’s authorities. The French DGSI, when questioned, calls the project “grotesque” — but acknowledges its existence and its “semi-official” character. Semi-official: not quite clandestine, not quite admitted.

The link to Ukrainian military intelligence is no surprise. In July 2024, after the Battle of Tinzwaten, GUR spokesman Andriy Yusov had publicly claimed that his services had provided intelligence to the Malian rebellion. France, which decries Moscow, has its own Sahelian proxies. The rules it invokes for others never

apply to itself.

On June 18, 2026 — the day after publication — Mali's finance ministry freezes twelve bank accounts: a journalist, a magistrate, an engineer, lawyers. The message is clear: the economic war is also waged against internal relays.

Meanwhile, the FLA disarmament program advances. On December 10, 2025, a ceremony at Kidal records the surrender of 14 fighters with their weapons. In February 2025, the DDR program integrates 2,000 former fighters into the army and 1,000 into civilian reintegration. Colonel El-Hadj Ag Gamou is recognized as the legitimate governor of the Kidal region — a Tuareg within the Malian state, not against it. Reconciliation through integration, not through crushing.

The fuel embargo: economic war before the assault

Before the military offensive, economic war. Since early September 2025, JNIM has imposed a fuel-import embargo on Bamako. Hundreds of tanker trucks from Abidjan and Dakar are set on fire. The gasoline shortage paralyzes the capital's economy. The group's declared goal: bring down Malian authorities through economic strangulation, before imposing Islamic governance.

The strategy is coherent: first weaken civilian logistics, then strike militarily. The offensive of April 25, 2026 belongs to this same continuum — it is the armed component of a war that had already begun on the supply roads.

The offensive of April 25, 2026

On April 25, 2026, at dawn, coordinated attacks strike simultaneously at Bamako, Kati, Kidal, Gao, and Sévaré.

The heaviest blow: General Sadio Camara, minister of defense, is killed in a bomb attack targeting his residence in Kati. He was the man who had led the 2020 coup, who had received the first Russian instructors, who symbolized the military rupture with Paris. In Kidal, the FLA raises its flag briefly. A video circulates showing Iyad Ag Ghaly and Alghabass Ag Intalla jointly commenting on the operations.

The offensive's financing is documented. In November 2025, JNIM had collected a record ransom of at least 50 million dollars — plus the equivalent of 20 million dollars in munitions — for the release of three hostages kidnapped in Mali. Among them: Joumaa ben Maktoum al-Maktoum, a retired Emirati general involved in the gold trade and a member of Dubai's ruling family. JNIM's usual ransoms were negotiated between 6 and 10 million dollars per hostage. The exceptional profile of the Emirati hostage drove the price to an unprecedented level. This windfall financed the April 2026 offensive.

JNIM's strategic pivot is also documented in this period: abandoning the targeting of Western nationals, the group turns toward AES partners. Among its hostages in November 2025: eleven Chinese, Indians, two Ukrainians from Donbas with Russian passports (former Wagner), an Iranian, two Egyptians. The message is explicit — any country supporting the Sahelian transitions becomes a target.

The traceability of foreign support is documented. Bilal Sharif, an FLA official, met French military intelligence officers in France in May 2025. Jean Vésilier, a DGSE agent, was arrested in Bamako in August 2025 for clandestine activities. French-speaking former legionnaires working with Ukraine's GUR: confirmed by a French security source on RTL on May 9, 2026 — Macron rages against the journalist but does not deny the substance.

Psychological warfare escalates in parallel. On June 4, 2026, Malian authorities place six figures on their list of most-wanted individuals: Iyad Ag Ghaly (JNIM chief) and Hamadoun Kouffa (chief of Katiba Macina) at the top, with a reward of up to 1.5 billion CFA francs for any information leading to their capture. On June 12, 2026, JNIM responds through its spokesman Abu Hudhaifa Al-Bambari (alias Bina Diarra): 2 million euros for Assimi Goïta, 1 million euros each for Colonel Lassina Diallo and General Malik Dicko. Total: 4 million euros — over 2.6 billion CFA francs — placed on the heads of the transition's three leading figures. Each side now puts a price on the other's head. This is no longer an insurgency against a weak state: it is a war between two powers that mutually recognize each other as legitimate adversaries.

But one detail deserves a pause. Mali denominated its bounty in CFA francs. JNIM denominated its own in euros.

Why would JNIM, a jihadist organization fighting on Malian soil, operating in the Sahel, claiming to establish Islamic governance, display its bounties in euros rather than in CFA francs, dollars, dirhams, or any other currency of the Muslim world it claims to defend?

The answer is in the question. The euro is not the currency of Sahelian populations. It is the currency of its financiers. Those who read this announcement, those it is aimed at, those who could collect this reward — think, calculate, and receive in euros. These are actors embedded in international financial circuits, not local fighters paid in Bamako banknotes.

The paradox is striking. The AES is fighting to leave the CFA zone — to rid itself of a currency whose peg is set in Paris, whose reserves sit dormant in the French Treasury, whose policy is dictated from the BCEAO, itself managed under French influence. JNIM, for its part, does not even set its bounties in CFA: it moves straight to the colonizer's currency.

A group that claims Islam to overthrow African governments, yet whose financial flows — ransoms in dollars, rewards in euros, funding in Gulf currencies — sit entirely within the Western monetary architecture: the contradiction says everything. These are not anti-imperialist revolutionaries who took up arms. These are

actors whose sponsors, circuits, and units of account are precisely those the AES is seeking to dislodge. The euro in JNIM's mouth is the signature of its true employers.

France, on that April 25, 2026, publishes only a statement on Chernobyl. Total silence on Mali. Burkhard had said in September 2024 that France "has no camp of friends in Mali." That day, he was proving the opposite.

And on that very same April 25, 2026, French MP Bruno Fuchs gives a public interview in which he describes JNIM as a future "political actor" one would need to engage with. JNIM had just killed Mali's defense minister. The timing says everything. There are no coincidences in a war.

Sources: Jeune Afrique, June 17, 2026; RTL France, May 9, 2026; General Thierry Burkhard, closed session, September 2024; Nathalie Yamb (analysis of the May 24, 2021 coup; analysis of MINUSMA's sabotage and the partition project, October 2023, Afrique Résurrection); For You Media Africa, June 8, 2026; ACLED; Andriy Yusov, GUR, July 2024; Mamadou Koulibaly, testimony on managing the 1999-2000 Ivorian transition; Sébastien Lecornu's hearing before the Senate Foreign Affairs/Defense committee, October 11, 2023; Wassim Nasr / France 24, November 4, 2025 (record JNIM ransom of \$50M + \$20M in munitions, Emirati hostage Joumaa ben Maktoum al-Maktoum, Bamako fuel embargo, strategic pivot toward AES partners); CH Aviation (Air France return attempts); statements by Air France's CEO on the Malian market.

CHAPTER 17 — BURKINA FASO: THE TRAORÉ DOCTRINE

"The imperialists decided we had to die. We decided to live. That's the whole debate." — Captain Ibrahim Traoré, 2023

Ouagadougou, September 30, 2022. For the second time in eight months, armored vehicles surround Burkinabé national television. In January, Lieutenant Colonel Paul-Henri Sandaogo Damiba had overthrown President Roch Marc Christian Kaboré, deemed incapable of stemming the advance of armed groups. This September night, it is Damiba himself who falls, pushed out by a thirty-five-year-old armored corps captain, repeatedly cited for bravery at the front: Ibrahim Traoré. Two overthrows in eight months, each one correcting and radicalizing the last: Damiba had broken with Kaboré without breaking with the system, and hesitated over the break with Paris. Traoré does not waver. In the country of Thomas Sankara — assassinated thirty-five years earlier, almost to the day, on October 15, 1987 — the symbolism escapes no one: the captain is the same age the captain was.

The guiding idea of this chapter fits in one word: doctrine. Where the Malian transition was built through action, Traoré articulates — speech after speech — a complete philosophy of sovereignty: military, economic, cultural. This is what makes him, in the eyes of an entire African youth, the most radical embodiment of the Sahelian project. And it is what makes him a target.

"More dangerous than the bases"

Traoré first names the mechanism of weakening, and he names it with a precision that goes beyond simply denouncing foreign bases: French military advisers, he says, are "more dangerous than the bases." Their mission was not to strengthen Burkinabé armed forces, but to dictate unsuitable training policies to keep the army in structural dependency.

Structural dependency means this: you are trained to use equipment you can neither buy nor repair on your own, according to doctrines designed for a different theater, so that you can never make war — or peace — without asking permission. The military base is visible. The adviser is invisible. And it is the invisible one who commands.

Traoré documents the mechanism with precision that is anything but abstract. In 2019, Operation Ota-puanu — led by the Burkinabé Armed Forces against armed groups — demonstrated that the army retained a real capacity to respond to terrorism. The immediate result: France summons the Burkinabé chief of staff

to Paris and orders him to reinstate military advisers throughout the entire structure. He refuses. But once back home, politicians order him to comply. The advisers rejoin the Burkinabé army in 2019. What follows is documented: the army collapses in 2020–2021, desertions multiply, soldiers leave “because there was no more hope.” The sequence is unmistakable — when an African army shows it can win without France, France sets to work making it incapable again.

The depth of the infiltration goes beyond operational advisers. Officers sent to train in France there learn to serve a state other than their own. Traoré says it without hedging: when one of them dies, whether by accident or on the battlefield, France honors him at the French army’s night of the fallen — and pronounces his name followed by the phrase “*died for France*.” Not for Burkina Faso. For France. And at the moment of the January 2022 uprising, many of these officers were immediately contacted from Paris: “*this is the moment to act, you were trained for this*.” Most reported these contacts to the transition. Traoré took note. But the question remains, and it is dizzying: how many of these officers, in how many African countries, still answer that call?

Traoré’s response is total, and it extends well beyond the military field. Burkina Faso expels French forces. It launches a general mobilization and establishes civic service for national defense. It moves to retake control of Total’s operations on its territory. It claims the rank of West Africa’s leading tomato producer. Pan-Africanist works are translated into Mooré and distributed in villages, to speak directly to rural populations — a sovereignist popular education that bypasses the international media. And when Saudi Arabia offers to finance 200 mosques, Traoré flatly refuses: “Give us schools, hospitals, and jobs.”

Traoré also names, with cutting precision, the ideological foundation that makes domination possible — and that perpetuates it even after the bases are gone:

“I think it’s them who contributed to lowering their own influence, because they have a paternalistic view of our relationship. Whatever we do, whatever initiative we take — it’s Russia. Someone speaks up, they’re influenced by Russia. Why do they keep their eyes closed like that? So the African is not capable of developing anything. The African is not capable of inventing, of innovating, of taking initiative. That’s what we’re fighting. And as long as they keep seeing the African like that, as a sub-human incapable of thinking, we can never be friends. Times have changed. They need to change their language.” — Ibrahim Traoré

This passage is surgically precise. It names the exact mechanism: every autonomous African initiative is automatically reattributed to an outside power — Moscow, Beijing, Ankara. The sovereign African does not exist within this mental framework. He can only be manipulated.

Macron had, in these very same days, himself supplied the material for the response. In a public statement, he had declared that “*ingratitude is a non-communicable disease among humans*” — implying: Africans who criticize France show ingratitude, and that ingratitude cannot be communicated to him because he is, himself,

human. Him. Not them.

In January 2025, responding directly to that line, Traoré delivers the words that go viral across the continent: "If he's not an atheist, every time he wakes up and prays, he should also pray to Africans, because it's thanks to our ancestors that France exists today" (January 14, 2025). The echo with Choguel Maïga's reversed debt of the riflemen is obvious: the same generation rewrites the moral meaning of Franco-African history, from two different capitals.

The economic front: the battle over gold

Traoré does not stop at the military field. He carries the war to where it hurts the former master most: the economic order inherited from colonization. The captain stops being a mere transitional leader and becomes what Paris fears most — a revolutionary who takes on the contracts.

The heart of the maneuver is gold. Burkina Faso accelerates the renegotiation of mining contracts signed decades ago, in which the state's share often fell below 10% while multinationals captured up to 90%. The demand is simple: raise the state's share, or face nationalization or expulsion. And the threat is credible, because an alternative now exists — Russia, China, Turkey, ready to work under new terms, with no political strings attached.

Why gold, more than any other metal? Because gold is not a resource like the others. It underpins the dollar system, fills the reserves of Western central banks, feeds multinationals' margins. Touching the division of Burkinabé gold means touching a link in the global financial architecture. If the state's share rises from 10 to 50%, companies lose nearly half their revenue — and control of the flow could shift to Moscow or Beijing. Hence stakes wildly out of proportion to Burkina Faso's size: if Ouagadougou succeeds, Mali, Niger, and Guinea will follow, and the domino effect will hit copper, cobalt, uranium, and oil across an entire continent.

This is precisely what the Western media strategy works to obscure. The "military junta" label serves to delegitimize Traoré and render his economic maneuvers invisible: it's all talk of security, coups, violence — never of economic sovereignty. To name the real battle would mean acknowledging that a thirty-seven-year-old captain is renegotiating Africa's share of its own wealth. Traoré knows the fate of Lumumba, Sankara, Gaddafi — all fell after touching the money and the resources. He acts anyway.

The battle of the barracks: five billion for a betrayal

A doctrine is not measured by its speeches. It is measured by the assaults it provokes. On November 8, 2024, Burkinabé defense and security forces foil a corruption attempt of unprecedented documented scale: an intermediary offers members of the security forces payment to take part in overthrowing the government,

in exchange for 5 billion CFA francs. On orders from their superiors, the soldiers pretend to accept. At the moment the cash is handed over, the man is arrested in the act; the funds are seized and deposited with the public treasury, pending the outcome of the investigation into the sponsors (RTB, November 2024).

Five billion CFA francs to buy an overthrow. The figure says two things at once: the determination of those seeking to bring down the transition, and the internal resistance of soldiers who could have enriched themselves overnight and instead chose to set a trap. The battle for the AES is also fought inside the barracks.

It escalates further in 2025. According to Sahelian authorities, mercenaries operating in the Liptako-Gourma zone were massively equipped with weapons and funding by the DGSE in April 2025, to strike all three AES states simultaneously. General Tiani, for his part, reports suspicious bases and movements along the border between Côte d'Ivoire and Burkina Faso, notably in the Cong zone, now under active surveillance.

Then comes the night of January 3, 2026, 11 p.m.: an assassination attempt directly targets Traoré. According to the official statement from the Ministry of National Security, a series of targeted actions had been planned, "beginning with the neutralization of Captain Traoré, either at point-blank range or by mining his residence." The attempt fails. It proves one simple thing: someone, somewhere, decided Traoré had to die. The empire does not strike what it despises. It strikes what it fears.

"Prepare for high-intensity war"

It is in this climate that Traoré delivers, before his officers, the most explicit version of his doctrine. This is no longer a speech of political legitimization. It is a mission order: "You are about to begin a new training cycle. High-intensity war... This is a war of decolonization, and in recent days you've heard certain generals elsewhere make it clear that if they need to come back with their armies to recolonize us, they will come. Well, prepare for high-intensity war" (speech to officers, 2023–2024).

A high-intensity war is not a policing operation against armed bands: it is a state-to-state war, with aviation, armor, deep logistics — the type of conflict one only prepares for if one believes a foreign power might, one day, return by force. Traoré's Burkina Faso is no longer merely preparing to fight terrorism. It is preparing to defend its independence.

The June 2026 sequence: from summons to rupture

In ten days, from June 19 to 26, 2026, Burkina Faso carries out a four-stage diplomatic sequence — each act preparing the next with implacable logic: a European Parliament resolution, the summoning of an ambassador, public responses from pan-Africanist intellectuals, and a final rupture.

June 19 — Gomart speaks in Strasbourg

Christophe Gomart — a member of the European Parliament and former director of French military intelligence (DRM) — addresses the European Parliament:

"Burkina Faso today illustrates the dramatic failure of the military junta in power since the 2022 coup. In four years, the country has progressively isolated itself from the international community, has been suspended from several regional and international organizations, while fundamental freedoms are being methodically curtailed. At the same time, the security situation has worsened. More than half the territory is outside state control, and several million Burkinabés have been displaced and are in need of humanitarian aid."

Every sentence of this speech is a deliberate distortion of the facts. But Gomart is no random figure. His official biography states: Lieutenant General, commander of special operations from August 1, 2011 to June 20, 2013. He led French army intelligence services. He knows exactly the reality of what he is saying — and of what he is not saying. Every omission is deliberate.

January 2013: Iyad Ag Ghaly at the Laïko Hotel

This detail must be etched into memory, for it demolishes any moral authority Gomart might claim on the subject of terrorism in the Sahel.

On January 11, 2013, France launches Operation Serval in Mali. Official objective: stop the advance of jihadist groups and neutralize their leaders. Twelve days later, on January 23, 2013, the site Mali Actu publishes an article that says it all.

Iyad Ag Ghaly — founder of Ansar Dine, the man Operation Serval is supposedly meant to capture — is, at that precise moment, staying at the Laïko Hotel in Ouagadougou, in Burkina Faso:

"The Mola of Kidal, 54 years old, a respected patriarch, both feared and revered by the Ifoghas community, lives in a luxury suite on the 11th floor of the Laïko Hotel. It is there that he receives visitors and holds consultations."

The Laïko Hotel in Ouagadougou is located 4 kilometers from the Kosyam presidential palace — the residence of Blaise Compaoré, France's strategic ally in West Africa. Not in a cave. In a luxury hotel, in the city, 4 kilometers from the palace of Paris's best ally in the subregion.

Iyad Ag Ghaly's visitors in this suite:

- Djibril Bassolé — Burkinabé foreign minister

- François Compaoré — brother of President Blaise Compaoré
- Djendéré — head of the Burkinabé presidential guard
- Moustapha Chafi — mediator in the Malian crisis
- Lansin Diawara — billionaire, who “keeps close to him and protects him”

The article concludes without ambiguity:

“Fussed over and coddled by the president’s immediate entourage, Iyad Ag Ghaly is a key piece in President Blaise Compaoré’s leadership within the geopolitics of the Sahelian no man’s land.”

The terrorist leader France claims to be hunting is a key piece of the very man France protects. Compaoré was Paris’s privileged intermediary in the Sahel under both Sarkozy and Hollande. Ag Ghaly is thus, through this chain, an asset of the French apparatus in the region, at one remove. The manhunt is theater.

The commander of French special operations in January 2013 — Christophe Gomart — did not capture Iyad Ag Ghaly. Ag Ghaly was not in a desert cave. He was in an 11th-floor suite, 4 kilometers from the presidential palace of Paris’s ally. If the African press knew this on January 23, 2013, the DRM certainly knew it too. The absence of action is a choice, not an oversight.

In 2026, this same Gomart appears before the European Parliament to accuse Burkina Faso of not fighting terrorists. The silence over the Laïko Hotel is a confession.

June 22 — The summoning of Philippe Branchin

Burkina Faso’s minister of foreign affairs and regional cooperation, Karamoko Jean-Marie Traoré, summons the European Union’s ambassador, Philippe Branchin, to Ouagadougou. The reason: the European Parliament resolution against Burkina Faso contains “deliberately false claims,” violates “international law’s prohibition on interference in the internal affairs of a sovereign state,” and reflects “neocolonial contempt” toward the Burkinabé people.

Branchin “took note” of the concerns expressed. He offered no substantive defense. The ambassador of one of the world’s wealthiest powers, representing twenty-seven member states, left the ministry without a single argument. This silence is not modesty: it is an admission that the resolution does not withstand factual scrutiny.

Issa Diawara: point-by-point right of reply

Issa Diawara, an advocate for African sovereignty, responds to Gomart argument by argument. His response, delivered publicly on June 22, 2026, is a document:

"Mr. Christophe Gomart, when you don't master certain subjects, I recommend you keep quiet."

On "Burkina Faso is isolated": "The European Union still has its ambassador in Burkina Faso. And by the way, since he lied like this, it's the European Union's ambassador who was summoned to Burkina Faso. Is there a country called 'international community'?"

On "Burkina Faso has been suspended from organizations": "It's Burkina Faso that withdrew of its own accord from the subregional organization called ECOWAS, which serves French power." ECOWAS runs after AES states. It is ECOWAS that comes courting. "If we wanted, we could rejoin tomorrow morning."

On "fundamental freedoms have been suspended": During its own 1789 Revolution, France applied radical emergency measures: the Law of Suspects, more than 17,000 French citizens executed by revolutionary justice, and later, after 1945, women had their heads shaved and collaborators were summarily tried. "When we too are at war, traitors are hunted down. That's perfectly normal. Or is a France at war worth more than an AES country at war?" The suspended media — RFI, France 24, TV5 Monde — are funded by French or European taxpayers. "Why is RFI suspended? Because these media glorify Al-Qaeda."

On "Burkina Faso has lost control of half its territory": "When His Excellency Captain Ibrahim Traoré took power, Burkina Faso did not control 50% of its territory. And yet the French army was there, through what's called Force Sabre." The terrorists arrived alongside the presence of Force Sabre in Burkina Faso. When Burkina Faso hosted Force Sabre, there were no terrorists in Burkina Faso. The chronology is damning and irrefutable.

Diawara goes further and names the central accusation: "You created these Islamist groups, you manufactured them, you armed them in Libya. You air-dropped weapons for them near the Djouba hills in Libya. You promised them the independence of northern Malian territory in exchange for abandoning Guide Muammar Gaddafi."

On the neighbors Gomart mentions: "The neighbors you mention host terrorist bases attacking Burkina Faso." In Côte d'Ivoire, "terrorists leave Côte d'Ivoire to attack Burkina Faso." In Benin: "In the W Park area, that's where you're training Al-Qaeda's people."

He finally poses the three questions Gomart never answered: "Do you know how you became a European MP? Do you know that? Do you know who funded your campaign? Do you know who you're really working for?"

And the historical argument Gomart cannot contradict: General de Gaulle told the Americans in 1966: "You are leaving our territory." France expelled American bases from its soil, rebuilt its army, developed its own nuclear deterrent. It did exactly what AES states are doing today. "Why do you think you absolutely must stay in Africa? Africans don't want a French army in our home. That's clear and simple."

His conclusion: "You cannot keep destroying countries in order to succeed in them."

Nathalie Yamb: a response to the European Parliament

Nathalie Yamb sends a public response to the MEPs involved. She first notes the institution's selective silences: no resolution on the forced conscription of Ukrainian men sent to die at the front by Kyiv — this has been going on for four years. No resolution on the censorship of RT and Sputnik in the twenty-seven member states, while Burkina Faso is criticized for suspending TV5 Monde. No resolution demanding President Zelensky, who has held no elections since 2024, produce a "credible roadmap toward elections."

The resolution praises the "heavy price paid by European partners in the fight against terrorism in the Sahel." Yamb dismantles this narrative using official French sources themselves. Of the 58 French soldiers presented as fallen heroes in the fight against terrorism, 43 died accidentally or by their own fault: a fridge or tire repair gone wrong, road accidents, cardiac arrests, helicopter collisions caused by internal disputes, friendly fire. Fifteen combat deaths over ten years of Barkhane — for a billion-euro-a-year operation with 5,500 personnel deployed. These soldiers did not die for Africa. They died to secure financial interests in a region whose resources France controls.

On the dissolved NGOs: the Insol NGO Safety Organization, dissolved by Burkina Faso in 2025, had, as documented, the mission of spying on Burkinabé military and government facilities in order to pass the collected data to its sponsors — chief among them France. One does not dissolve espionage structures on a whim. In France itself, Urgence Palestine and the Ligue de Défense Noire Africaine were dissolved. Former minister Jean-Yves Le Drian, after losing his ministerial portfolio in 2022, bounced back at the French NGO Acted before being appointed Macron's special envoy to Lebanon — Françafrique's most elegant revolving door.

On the "ethnic cleansing" claim: firmly denied by Burkinabé authorities. By contrast, the documented ethnic cleansing of Russian-speaking populations in Donbas over years has triggered no comparable resolution from the European Parliament. Russian-speaking deaths do not count.

The resolution announces the dispatch of a special EU representative to Ouagadougou before the end of August. Yamb's position is unambiguous:

"EU representatives in AES countries should be escorted to the border. No special envoy should be received. As long as a single African who supports or works for the AES is sanctioned by the European Union, no new EU approach deserves any credit."

On elections, the answer is blunt:

”There will be no presidential election in the AES for ten years. When elections resume, it will first be municipal elections, then legislative. No pressure, no fomented coup, no financed terrorist attack will change that.”

Yamb herself has been on the European sanctions list since June 2025 — official grounds: ”works to expel France and the West from Africa.” Her TikTok account was censored in the EU’s twenty-seven member states, even outside the scope of official sanctions. Afrique Media and Raed Media, along with their founders, are on the same list. The Europe that accuses Burkina Faso of censoring TV5 Monde itself censors the African media that criticize it. The double standard no longer even bothers to hide.

June 26 — The rupture

Four days after Branchin’s summons, on June 26, 2026, from the Prime Minister’s office, government spokesman Pingdwendé Gilbert Ouédraogo, Officer of the Order of the Stallion, publishes a communiqué that closes sixty-six years of an unbalanced relationship:

The Government of Burkina Faso informs national and international public opinion that it has decided to sever diplomatic relations with the French Republic, effective this day, June 26, 2026.

Not a suspension. Not a recall of ambassadors. A rupture. The heaviest diplomatic act a state can take toward another short of declaring war. And the grounds are not hidden:

Grievance	Wording of the communiqué
● Active hostility	”Unceasing activism by the current regime in France against Burkina Faso’s interests”
● Neocolonial ambition	”Openly displayed neocolonial ambitions”
● Support for terrorism	”Active support for subversive networks and terrorists who bring mourning to our country and the Sahel”
● Information warfare	”The perfidy and bias of discourse and opinion about our country, aimed at making it a pariah of the international community”

The central accusation is grave and openly stated: France actively supports the terrorists bleeding Burkina

Faso and the Sahel. This is no longer an analyst's insinuation or a protester's slogan. It is a sovereign state putting it into an official document, signed, sealed, broadcast to the world.

The Burkinabé government does not conflate the French state with the French people. The communiqué explicitly clarifies this: the rupture "in no way calls into question the historic, human, cultural, and social bonds uniting the Burkinabé and French peoples. It concerns exclusively the institutional framework of diplomatic relations between the two states." The protection of French nationals on Burkinabé soil is reaffirmed. This is not a fight against a people — it is the dismissal of a tutelage.

The motto opening the communiqué sums it all up: "Fatherland or Death, We Will Win."

Thomas Sankara, in his time, dared to say no to debt and tutelage. He was gunned down for it. Forty years later, the land of upright men no longer merely says no: it signs, it seals, it severs. And this time, it is not alone — it has behind it Mali, Niger, and the critical mass of an Alliance.

The shockwave does not stop at Burkina Faso. Within twenty-four hours of the official rupture, Equatorial Guinea in turn brandishes the threat of a break with Paris. The reason: the upcoming auction, ordered by French justice, of a building belonging to Equatorial Guinea, located on Avenue Foch in Paris — seized in the so-called *ill-gotten gains* case targeting Teodorin Obiang. Malabo deems the procedure illegal: the building enjoys diplomatic immunity. If the sale proceeds, Malabo threatens to seize the French embassy and undertake a complete review of diplomatic relations.

The mechanism repeats itself: an African state turns against Paris the very legal tools Paris forged to control it. The instrument of pressure boomerangs. This is no calendar coincidence: it is the contagion of sovereignism, now advancing on several fronts at once.

What the Burkinabé sequence reveals

Connect the dots: in 2019, Otapuanu shows that the Burkinabé army can win — France reimposes its advisers. In 2022, Traoré expels them. In 2023–2024, destabilization accelerates: corruption, mercenaries, an assassination attempt. In 2026, France tries the diplomatic and institutional route — Gomart at the European Parliament, a resolution, pressure. In six days in June 2026, Burkina Faso answers with a complete diplomatic sequence: summoning the ambassador, a public right of reply, a formal rupture.

What stands out is the method. Not anger — doctrine. Every act is prepared, argued, documented. Summoning Branchin is not a fit of rage: it is an act under international law. Diawara's right of reply is not a pamphlet: it is a factual refutation, argument by argument. The June 26 rupture is no whim: it is an official communiqué naming four precise grievances and legally sealing a divorce already consummated in fact.

Ibrahim Traoré promised high-intensity war. He is waging it on every front at once — military, economic, cultural, diplomatic. Not from a cave. From a state under construction.

Burkina Faso: the rupture explained from within

*"To enlighten the youth on the ideological orientation is to give them the best weapons for the fight." —
Former Burkina Faso Minister of the Civil Service, Traoré government*

On June 18, 2026, the European Parliament votes a resolution against Burkina Faso. Gomart is its sponsor. The text is a list of grievances — international isolation, curtailed freedoms, a deteriorating security situation, territory beyond state control, populations in need of humanitarian aid. A rhetoric of tutelage, formulated from Strasbourg by a French general turned MEP. This book has already dismantled these claims argument by argument — what Issa Diawara did on June 22, what Nathalie Yamb demonstrated using official French figures. But one voice was missing: that of a senior Burkinabé political official, speaking not from a Paris studio but from within the very entrails of the transitional government.

That speech exists. It was delivered by Ibrahim Traoré's former Minister of the Civil Service at a Confederation meeting. It names things without diplomatic caution. It deserves to be heard.

The resolution as a declaration of war

The resolution of June 18, 2026 is not isolated. Two months earlier, on March 12, 2026, the same European Parliament had demanded the "immediate and unconditional" release of Mohamed Bazoum. Same actors, same chamber, same mechanism. The sequence reveals a coherent strategy: as the armed proxies retreat on the ground, pressure shifts toward institutions — resolutions, sanctions, financial conditionality.

The minister states it plainly: "After the atrocities of this war of predation called terrorism that was imposed on us, the real sponsors and backers now show their faces, under cover of a European parliamentary resolution, seeking to replace their terrorist proxies who are currently in disarray." The thesis is clear: terrorism and diplomatic pressure are two instruments of the same project — clear the peoples, occupy the land, extract the resources.

The metaphor would be insufficient — it is a reading of historical continuity: the Berlin conference of 1884 organized the partition of Africa among colonial powers; the Code Noir of 1685 codified the dehumanization of Black people. These founding texts are explicitly cited. Their logic, the minister asserts, has not disappeared — it has changed its instrument.

Gomart, Lecointre, Langlais: the new slave traders in uniform

The minister names three generals. Each has said something the world must hear.

Lecointre, former Chief of the Defense Staff of the French armed forces, has stated that Europe would

one day have "the obligation to return" to the Sahel. General Lequinte made this more precise: "Europe will have to return to help restore states, administrations, and development." Gomart, at the European Parliament, painted the picture of a Burkina Faso in freefall to justify this return.

Three generals, three statements, one single meaning: the departure of French forces is not accepted as final. It is experienced as a parenthesis to be closed. The condescension is total — these men present themselves as the restorers of what they helped destroy for ten years. "With attitudes of condescension resembling new slave traders," the minister says. The word is chosen carefully. It is not excessive. Anyone claiming that a sovereign people needs its institutions restored from the outside is speaking the language of colonial tutelage — regardless of the era.

The response to Gomart is historic, and it comes from France itself. In 1966, de Gaulle told the Americans: "You are leaving our territory." France rebuilt its army, developed its nuclear deterrent, reaffirmed its sovereignty. It did exactly what the AES is doing today. The difference: when France does it, it is greatness. When Africa does it, it is chaos.

What ten years of French presence produced

The minister draws an unsparing balance sheet of the Serval-Barkhane-G5 Sahel decade. "France and its General Christophe Gomart saw everything, spied on everything, coordinated everything, and plundered everything." Sahelian populations buried their dead, fled their villages, watched insecurity gain ground — while international conferences multiplied and military theatrics succeeded one another.

The Malian letter rewritten by French diplomats, Iyad Ag Ghaly in his suite at the Laïko Hotel, 4 kilometers from the presidential palace, while Gomart commanded special operations, the French Court of Audit establishing total failure — these facts have run through this book since Chapter 13. The minister adds nothing to this dossier. He confirms it from within.

What the rupture has produced

Since the occupying armies were driven out, the record is measurable. The minister lists it: the nuisance capacity of armed groups has been significantly reduced. A large share of territory has been recovered. Populations have been resettled in several localities. The spirit of fear and resignation has given way to the spirit of resistance and reconquest.

ACLED data from 2024–2026 confirm this — imperfectly, partially, but in the same direction. National armies are advancing where Barkhane had failed.

The Confederation's ideology

The heart of the speech is not denunciation — it is construction. "The Confederation of Sahel States was born of this sound conviction that no one will come to defend our lands, our families, and our dignity better than we ourselves." Sovereignty is an organization, not a slogan — and that is precisely what the Confederation is building.

The minister clarifies the balance: "Burkina Faso claims no privilege. It merely demands what is owed to any free people — the right to choose its alliances, its political orientation, and its development model." No confrontation. No anti-French posture. A simple demand, framed in the language of international law: equality between nations.

And for the youth — the primary audience of this speech: "Our youth is not merely the future of the Confederation, it is already its engine." This is Sankara's formula, reactivated: revolution is not postponed to tomorrow. It is built now, by those who refuse to see what their fathers stood up brought back down to its knees.

Sources: Speech by the former Minister of the Civil Service of the Traoré government, Confederation of Sahel States meeting, June 2026; European Parliament resolution of June 18, 2026 on Burkina Faso; resolution of March 12, 2026 on Bazoum; General François Lecointre, public interview 2024; General Christophe Gomar, European Parliament, June 2026; ACLED data 2024-2026.

Ouahigouya, July 17, 2026: "Are we cursed?"

"The Black man is cursed. They will never be able to understand what you want to do. You see, when Sankara was killed, it went through like a letter in the mail." — Words attributed to "Daniel," a DGSE agent, publicly reported by Ibrahim Traoré, Ouahigouya, July 17, 2026

Ouahigouya, Yaadga region, July 17, 2026. Three weeks after the diplomatic rupture with France, Ibrahim Traoré opens his meeting with the region's community leaders with an unusual gesture: he asks the room to stand and applaud for a full minute the combat forces engaged in the north, "fighting and reconquering our lands." Then he warns them: the Yaadga is the region where one speaks without gloves. "I am going to speak crudely. I am going to box." What follows is no ordinary field speech. It is the densest doctrinal statement of the Burkinabé transition — two national-security revelations, a religious crisis defused in real time, and a question put to an entire continent: "Are we cursed?"

The immediate context gives the words their gravity. In 2022, a leader of the citizen watch recalls, the road to Ouahigouya was cut, the airfield inaccessible, National Route 1 itself severed. In 2026, with the roads

reopened, the Faso Mèbo brigades are deploying — every region, including the new ones, is to have its own before year's end, and it is the populations themselves, governor at their head, who will decide which roads come first. Traoré cites the founding counter-example: a road promised asphalt since the 1970s — "before I was even born" — voted and re-voted at every election for half a century, never built. "There are many former politicians here. You can see that what you did was not good."

Stockholm syndrome as political diagnosis

The theoretical heart of the speech rests on a concept Traoré takes the time to define before the room: Stockholm syndrome — "the one who comes to harm you, you end up loving him and protecting him." Applied at a continent's scale: "Many people suffer from this syndrome, whether here in Burkina or in Africa in general, because Africa has suffered greatly and there was an effort to erase its history." The remedy is the one this book has followed since Chapter 23 and IPN Farafina: re-examining history without leaving out any part of it. The ancestors who extracted iron from the earth in the bushlands of Yatenga — "why can't we do it today? What did we lose? How did we lose it?"

And history, he unspools it without precaution: more than a thousand years of the Arab-Muslim slave trade — the castration of able-bodied men, the last slave market closed in Medina in 1962 —, four hundred years of the Western trade, and a slavery that continues in 2026, where Black people are still captured and sold (Chapter 11 documented the Libyan markets). He exhumes an episode France prefers to forget: in 1994, a French animal park — the "Bamboula village," near Nantes — exhibited some thirty Ivoirians among the animals. "It was white people who fought to close the park. It wasn't Black people." A human zoo was operating in France fifty years after the Liberation; its closure was won by French anti-racist associations, not by an African mobilization. This is exactly the syndrome he describes: the victim had not even protested.

The first story: four products to weaken a people

Then comes the first revelation — a head of state's testimony, delivered publicly, which must be reported with its proper status: that of an official first-hand account, not independently corroborated to date. Agents of a Western country's secret services, Traoré recounts, came to offer the Burkinabé government four products to be introduced into food destined for zones held by armed groups — "it goes into everything: beer, sugary drinks, cigarettes, rice, milk." He details three effects: a product that "kills the brain," gradually shutting down neurons; a product that destroys physical capacity — the 12-kilometer runner can manage only 4; a product inducing drowsiness. The sales pitch: weaken the populations of terrorist zones so they can be "easily crushed" a few years later.

The delegation refused to name the products. But to the question "have you already tested this somewhere?", the answer came, chilling: yes — "somewhere in Africa, somewhere in Asia. Several times." Traoré

delivers his conclusion to the room: "You know what sent a chill through me? I said: Africa is finished, in fact. They are already using this in Africa."

The story did not stay confined to Ouahigouya. Traoré repeated it, in largely similar terms, in an interview granted to the pan-Africanist outlet For You Media Africa — the same figure of four products, the same vectors of administration (water, food, drinks, beer), the same three declared effects (action on the brain, reduction of physical capacities, drowsiness), officially presented as a tool for fighting terrorist groups. This distinct occurrence reinforces the weight of the testimony without resolving its single-source status: it remains an official account, not independently corroborated to date, but now repeated across two separate settings with consistent detail. He adds a geopolitical reading: certain Western officials openly regard Africa's demographic growth — a continent set to reach 1.5 billion inhabitants — as a "global challenge," a formulation that directly echoes the Kissinger NSSM-200 report cited further below in this same testimony.

Let the significance be measured: that the offer was made is a fact reported by the head of state who says he received and declined it; that such programs have already been used elsewhere is the admission attributed to the salesmen themselves. The surrounding documentary record does not allow the testimony to be waved away: the Kissinger NSSM-200 report linking Southern demographics to American security (Chapter 31), the Peruvian mass sterilizations, and the documented scandal of two-formula infant milks — "the milk they sell to their children over there is not the same one they sell in Africa" — form the context in which this proposal was made. It is from this story that Traoré derives the doctrine of consuming local as a national-security imperative, not economic folklore: "We want to build every processing unit possible so that we consume what we produce and avoid importing what we do not know." The ban on rice imports, decided a few months earlier once national production — tractors, inputs, seed stock financed by the state — reached self-sufficiency, follows the same logic. And he names the internal enemy it awakened: the displaced importers "pray to God every day that we fail. They would rather take Burkina's money and go pay the Asian farmer for his rice, but they don't like it when our own farmers benefit."

The second story: "Daniel," or the curse as doctrine

The second revelation dates back to 2023. A French visitor — Traoré calls him "Daniel" and specifies: "this gentleman is from the DGSE" — tells him to his face: you are ahead of your time, your people will not understand you; Sankara too was ahead of his time, and "when Sankara was killed, it went through like a letter in the mail"; nobody stirred. Then the sentence: "Mr. President, excuse me, but the Black man is cursed. They will never be able to be constant." Traoré recounts gripping his chair to listen to the end, then showing his visitor out.

He says he remembered Daniel three years later — in the summer of 2026, when the machinery was set in motion. According to the president, an agent named Emmanuel, posted at the French embassy and exfiltrated

before the expulsion “surely with the complicity of certain people,” had multiplied meetings with the chargé d’affaires in artistic, cultural, and above all communication circles, “to prepare minds.” The assigned objective: “act by August at the latest to put an end to our revolution.” The chosen lever — the one Daniel had theorized — is the oldest in the toolkit: religion, doubled with ethnicity, “those two subjects that have always destroyed Africa.”

Stage of the plan | Actor | Function

-
- Preparing minds — “Emmanuel” (embassy) + chargé d’affaires — Meetings with artists, cultural figures, communicators
 - |
 - Religious detonator — An imam, “explosive” public statement against the president — Spread the belief that prayer had been banned
 - |
 - Student relay — The “rouges vifs” splinter group — Social media statements, unconnected to the real situation
 - |
 - Expected social relay — Trade unions (work stoppages hoped for) — Roll out the “steamroller”
 - |
 - Deadline — August 2026 at the latest — “Put an end to our revolution”

The sequence unfolded in exactly that order — the imam’s outburst, the “rouges vifs” statements — then broke on the next step: the unions did not follow, and the imam’s arrest, far from triggering the hoped-for conflagration, was contained by law enforcement within hours.

The imam affair: what the law actually says

On the substance, Traoré restores the text the manipulation had distorted. The law in question nowhere prohibits praying — neither in government offices nor in public spaces. It requires one thing: that occupations of the public road be declared and authorized, so that emergency services — the fire brigade first, with whom the municipal authorizations are deposited every morning — know which routes are occupied before an intervention. “You can pray in your office, you can pray outside, there is no problem. We simply said to obtain authorizations.” The imam who raised the street, the president says, “read the law, understood the law” — the manipulation was not an error, it was a choice. And the man was no stranger: in 2019, he had created an “Islamic police” without a single politician daring to react.

Traoré, a Muslim, speaks here as a Muslim: he salutes “the worthy, dignified, patriotic imams who continue to preach the good word,” announces that the state will support them, and draws the line for the

others — preaching suspensions already issued, and a frontal fight promised against extremism: "If you think you can live in the 7th century, leave, find a patch of bush and live there." He turns the theological argument against the extremists with the weapon of the concrete: the jihadist's Kalashnikov, his motorcycle, his vehicle — all manufactured by those he calls infidels. "Go carve your club — that one you made yourself, that's halal. And then come, we'll fight."

And he drops, in passing, an admission of considerable import: emissaries came to propose that Burkina become an Islamic state. "Terrorism would end, that's certain, we would have peace — but we would be a rear base, a cancer in the middle of West Africa for destabilizing the others. I don't work like that." Peace was therefore available — at the price of turning the country into a sanctuary. This refusal explains part of the war: "When you show that you cannot be manipulated, you become an enemy."

The eight hundred of sharia

A figure, revealed for the first time, completes the picture: Burkinabé services have counted more than a thousand young Burkinabè who left to study in certain Arab countries — over 800 already identified — whose existence the embassies themselves were unaware of. What they are learning: sharia, Islamic law, Islamic jurisprudence. What not one of them is learning: a trade. "Not one person on that list is learning a single trade. It is to come apply sharia here." The decision is announced: they will be called back — "whoever does not return is no longer Burkinabè" — and the state will henceforth finance religious training for all faiths itself, Muslims, Catholics, Protestants, and traditionalists, to cut off the channel of foreign funding that buys consciences. It is the exact generalization of the refusal of the 200 Saudi mosques documented earlier in this chapter: no religion on an external drip.

"There are not two captains in one boat"

The speech also settles an internal question the intelligence networks thought exploitable: that of the "number 2," the "strongman" to court. Traoré sweeps away the analogy with 1987 that some had let flourish: "The context we are living is not that of 1987. I was not in prison, and nobody came to get me to put me in power. When I left Kaya with my men, I was at the front — there was not a single soldier ahead of me. When the 14.5 thundered, I was less than 100 meters away." Neither number 1 nor number 2: "There are not two captains in one boat." The warning is addressed by name to the economic operators looking for the "strongman" to negotiate with — "there is no strongman; it is you who put ideas in certain people's heads" — and to his own collaborators: any counter-revolutionary behavior will be punished, and a senior official's punishment will be multiplied "by two, by three — because you are responsible." Discipline is no barracks whim: in a country targeted by a destabilization plan with a date on it, it is a condition of survival.

He puts his own life in the balance, with a sentence that captures the personal price of the office: "I am

young, but I have no youth left to live. They pick me up in the morning, take me to the office, bring me back at night, and they sit outside my door as if I were a prisoner. I did not sacrifice my youth for nothing.”

The battle of the brain: produce or disappear

The final part of the speech is an indictment — Traoré himself announces it as “a cry of anger to the Black race.” The African morning inventory: the towel, the toothpaste, the clothes, the underwear, the cup of tea, the motorcycle — everything is imported. “We manufacture nothing.” Against this, the inventory of what God has given: wind, sun, fire; the clay from which cement is made; the iron from which steel is made; and “the blood of the earth” — oil. The theological reasoning that follows is perhaps the boldest formula ever spoken by a Sahelian head of state: refusing to use one’s brain is telling God He was wrong to give it to us — “and in that posture, we make ourselves God’s enemy. That is why He is angry with us.”

The example of traffic lights condenses everything: invented by a Black man — Garrett Morgan, American patent, 1923 — yet every traffic light in Ouagadougou is French-made. “A Black man created that. Where is the factory that makes it in Africa?” Hence the announced reform of the technological universities and technical high schools: the engineer will have to build or copy — “the long papers, we will no longer accept that. If you are a technician, you prove it.” Copying is no disgrace: it is how every industrial power began, and “if we don’t do it, it means we refuse to use our brain.”

The same demand for rationality applies to gold: thousands of miners destroy the land anarchically, and then “take a thousand people who go buy 20-million-franc vehicles — that’s 20 billion handed over just like that, while we don’t even have a road to drive them on.” The state will take control. And to those who drink champagne while mothers sleep in line at the boreholes for a jerrycan of water, he holds up the worksite underway — the Ouahigouya dam launched by the Prime Minister — and an iron law of social warfare he orders the room to face: “The one who has the champagne pays the one who has no water to drink to turn against you. And you accept it. Let us pull ourselves together.”

Proof by the enemy’s failure

Three recent feats of arms serve as demonstration. After June’s diplomatic rupture, Traoré expected a response within two to three weeks — “condescension makes people stupid: in their heads, how can a slave tell the master to leave? He must be corrected so the others see.” The response came: coordinated attacks launched against Gayéri, Solhan, and Sebba. At Solhan, the attackers “ran into determined gendarmes who crushed them.” And the president reveals the media side of the operation, an exact replica of the Doumbia setup documented in Chapter 21: local correspondents for French channels — “Black people they use to present these programs, and their correspondents, Burkinabé Blacks too” — had prepared and put on their studio makeup, waiting for the attack’s results to go on air and confirm “the lie” delivered at the European Parliament about the country’s

security collapse. The attack having failed, "they stayed in mourning. Some have not taken their makeup off since." The relay was pre-positioned; the military victory left it without a script.

Second demonstration: while the panic campaign was at its height — "things are going badly in Burkina, things are going badly at the top of the state" — the state was launching its diaspora bond. Result: oversubscribed. "We got more than we wanted." The trust test took place at the worst moment chosen by the adversary, and it was the adversary who lost it. Third demonstration: the humanitarian NGOs shown the door — "there are things we no longer accept; go give elsewhere" — with the parable of the family father: whoever truly wants to help children goes through their father; he does not feed them against him to prove the father is worthless.

The grandmother of Ouahigouya

The speech closes on the most intimate testimony Ibrahim Traoré has ever given, and it had to be spoken here, in Yatenga. His grandmother had her children after independence, past the age of fifty — "a miracle in the village." The reason: under colonial penetration, marrying and having children was forbidden, and nearly all the men of the village had been killed. "I almost wasn't born because of the effect of these people." He grew up close to her, saw on her body the marks of the mistreatment, lost her in 1998 — he was ten. "I live the effects of colonization in my flesh. And some still worship their tormentor."

What Ouahigouya reveals

This speech will endure as a major doctrinal document, for three reasons. First, it names the weapons: the chemical degradation of populations offered by Western services, and the religious manipulation planned with a deadline — August 2026 — and an organizational chart. Second, it names the flaw: Stockholm syndrome, love of the aggressor, the curse not as fate but as a diagnosis the enemy itself — "Daniel" — theorized and bet on. Third, it names the way out: produce, process, copy if necessary, fund religion sovereignly, discipline the state apparatus, and hold — because "Burkina Faso is a mirror: the others see themselves in it, and everyone is waiting to see."

The title question was not a provocation. It was a test offered to every listener: "Through my words, you will detect all those who carry the gene of the curse in them. And our great fortune is that the great majority is not cursed." Daniel's curse is not a prophecy. It is a bet — and Ouahigouya is the answer of a people that has decided to make him lose it.

Sources: Speech by Ibrahim Traoré to the community leaders of the Yaadga region, Ouahigouya, July 17, 2026 (full transcript); public testimony by the head of state on the "four products" offer and on the agent "Daniel" (DGSE), reported in this same speech — official first-hand statements, not independently corroborated to date; interview by Ibrahim Traoré with the pan-Africanist outlet For You Media Africa (repetition of the same "four products" story); closure of the "Bamboula village," Port-Saint-Père (France), 1994; abolition of slavery in Saudi

Arabia, 1962; Garrett Morgan, traffic signal patent, 1923; two-formula infant milk scandal (Nestlé); attacks on Gayéri, Solhan, and Sebba, July 2026; Burkinabé diaspora bond, 2026; Chapters 11, 21, 23, 27, 30, and 31 of this book.

Sources: Ibrahim Traoré, speeches to officers 2023-2024 and public statement on Western paternalism; Operation Otapuanu 2019; RTB, November 2024 (5-billion-CFA corruption attempt); Burkina Faso Ministry of National Security, statement of January 3, 2026 (assassination attempt); Mali Actu, January 23, 2013 (Iyad Ag Ghaly at the Laïko Hotel in Ouagadougou); General Christophe Gomart, European Parliament, June 2026; Minister Karamoko Jean-Marie Traoré, summoning of Ambassador Branchin, June 22, 2026; Issa Diawara, right of reply to Gomart, June 22, 2026; Nathalie Yamb, right of reply to the European Parliament, June 2026; communiqué of the Government of Burkina Faso, spokesman Pingdwendé Gilbert Ouédraogo, Officer of the Order of the Stallion, Prime Minister's Office, Ouagadougou, June 26, 2026; ACLED 2014-2026; Traoré statement, January 14, 2025; Equatorial Guinea–France diplomatic rupture threat (ill-gotten gains case, Teodorin Obiang, Avenue Foch building).

CHAPTER 18 — NIGER: THE FINAL LOCK

"Our states will no longer be France's cash cow." — General Abdourahamane Tiani, RTN, February 12, 2024

Niamey, July 26, 2023. In the early morning, the Nigerien presidential guard places President Mohamed Bazoum under house arrest, inside the palace itself. General Abdourahamane Tiani, head of that guard, takes the lead of the National Council for the Safeguard of the Homeland. Within hours, the international reaction reaches an intensity never seen for previous transitions: ECOWAS threats of military intervention, immediate sanctions, closed borders, cut electricity. Why such fury over this particular country? The answer lies in one word: Niger is the last lock.

What the West lost with Niger (July 2023)

Asset	Detail
● Niamey air base	About 1,500 French soldiers
● Agadez 201 base	About 1,000 American soldiers, MQ-9 Reaper drones
● Uranium	35% of French concentrated uranium imports (2020)
● 2015 EU-Niger agreement	Europe's trans-Saharan migration lock
● Strategic position	The last major Western rear base in the Sahel

Losing Niger meant losing, in one stroke, the entire Western Sahelian apparatus. This is precisely what would happen — without a single drop of blood being shed.

The C-17 that turns back

The first demonstration of sovereignty takes place in the sky. On August 3, 2023, a Boeing C-17A Globemaster of the American army takes off from Ramstein, Germany, bound for Niamey. Over Algeria, it turns back: the CNSP refused it landing clearance. Even before the defense agreements were officially denounced,

the sovereignty of Nigerien airspace asserted itself in fact. The new power does not negotiate the principle — it practices it, and leaves it to the lawyers to take note.

What follows is an orderly retreat by the two largest armies of the Western world. December 2023: French soldiers leave. Spring 2024: the American 201 base closes. Nathalie Yamb, at the great televised debate in Niamey, gives the event its historical dimension: "No country in the world, apart from Vietnam, has managed to force out the French army and the American army simultaneously, one after the other, without spilling a single drop of blood. It's extraordinary. History will remember it for centuries and centuries."

The Agadez file: an agreement Nigeriens had no right to know about

In leaving, the Americans leave behind the most damning piece of evidence in the file. In March 2024, the CNSP publicly reveals the terms of the agreement governing the stationing of American forces in Niger — terms Nigeriens had never had the right to know. The agreement had been unilaterally imposed on President Mahamadou Issoufou in 2012, without consulting the National Assembly, without public debate, with no popular mandate (CNSP communiqué, RTN, March 16, 2024).

The content is a rarely-exposed instance of raw institutional violence. Niger was paying the taxes on American military aircraft, which the United States would normally have owed itself. Nigerien authorities had no information about the military activities conducted from the bases installed on their own territory. And the American army had no contractual obligation to support the fight against the terrorist groups massacring Nigerien populations. More than 1,100 soldiers, three sites, several hundred million dollars a year since 2012 — including the Agadez drone base, described in specialized American press as "the most expensive drone base ever built by the United States."

A sovereign country was hosting, partly financing, and legally protecting a foreign military infrastructure that owed it nothing — not even the defense of its people against the killings that officially justified its presence. The security of Nigeriens was not the objective; it was the pretext. Officially, Agadez was a tool for fighting terrorism. In reality, it was a surveillance platform for the entire Sahelo-Saharan belt: migration flows toward Europe, Russian and Chinese movements in Central and West Africa.

Retaking the subsoil: Imouraren

The military rupture is accompanied by an extractive rupture, led by Prime Minister Ali Mahaman Lamine Zeine. In 2024, the CNSP terminates the uranium extraction contracts signed with Orano — formerly Areva — at the Imouraren site. This deposit is one of the largest in the world; its exploitation had been suspended since 2014 by France for profitability reasons. The 2024 decision repatriates sovereignty over this

subsoil to Niamey.

The figures give a sense of the stakes. Niger alone holds roughly 5% of the world's uranium reserves — some 310,000 tons, including the 200,000 tons at the Imouraren mega-deposit, the world's second-largest reserve. France drew roughly 20% of its nuclear electricity from Nigerien uranium before the transition. Over this half-century of extraction, the price Orano paid Niger never exceeded €0.80/kg — while the world market set the kilogram at \$200 in Canada or Kazakhstan. For 1,440 tons imported in 2022, that meant 1.2 million euros paid to Niger, where the world price would have demanded 288 million. The difference — 287 million euros a year — vanished into Orano's margins. Over this half-century, Niger remained 189th out of 191 countries on the Human Development Index (UNDP, 2023). The country lighting up France was left in the dark.

And the rupture pays off, fast: Niger's oil revenue jumps by 218% between 2020 (64.1 billion FCFA) and 2024 (204 billion), while coverage of domestic energy needs rises from 20% to 60% (Minister Sahabi Oumarou, February 24, 2025).

The speech of February 12, 2024

On February 12, 2024, Tiani delivers on national television a ninety-minute speech that structures the intellectual architecture of Niger's rupture. He states there what had never been said at this level of authority: "Our states will no longer be France's cash cow. France plundered us for 107 years. France must pay in cash for the debts of 65 years of systematic plundering of our resources" (RTN, February 12, 2024).

In the same speech, he flips the argument of moral seniority: France ceased to be a kingdom in 1789; by that date, the Songhai Empire had already ceased to exist as a thriving entity since 1591, and the Sultanate of Bornu had lost its influence as early as 1774. France has no moral seniority over the Sahel — it arrived later. Tiani finally recounts a statement Macron reportedly made at a multinational meeting on Niger in August 2023: "Niger does not belong to you. Niger belongs to France. It is not for you to propose any solution whatsoever." This sentence condenses, in two lines, the entire logic of domination this book documents.

The ruptures follow one another: withdrawal from ECOWAS in January 2024, withdrawal from the International Organization of the Francophonie in March 2025 — during Francophonie Week itself — suspension of French media in May 2026. Each step makes the previous one irreversible.

The ultimatum that went nowhere — and what Bazoum reveals

Between the July 26 coup and the CNSP's stabilization, ECOWAS played its most dangerous card. On July 30, 2023, the organization's extraordinary summit adopts an ultimatum: if Bazoum is not reinstated within seven days, member states' chiefs of staff are authorized to plan a military intervention. The ultimatum expires

on August 6, 2023. No intervention takes place.

Before asking why the ultimatum failed, one must name what was supposedly being restored.

Mohamed Bazoum spent his time demeaning and weakening his own army — in complicity with the French army. He had previously arrested terrorists released by Nigerien defense and security forces — the same terrorists who were massacring populations and killing soldiers. On the tarmac of Niamey's national squadron: 71 soldiers killed, carefully laid out, draped in the national colors — green, white, orange. Seventy-one dead that no one in Paris ever counted.

Rather than demanding accountability from French troops, Bazoum had preferred to fire his interior minister and the head of the Nigerien gendarmerie after French Barkhane soldiers opened fire on civilians in 2021, killing three and wounding eleven. He also worked to deny the existence of the France-Africa system — which his own boss nonetheless acknowledged:

"We have too often had a rent-seeking approach to our relationship with the African continent. We assumed that because we were France, even when we did things badly, even when we were more expensive than our competitors, we would keep being chosen." — Emmanuel Macron

The boss admits the rent-seeking logic. The client denies it. This single fact says everything about the relationship between Paris and Bazoum.

Bazoum presented himself as a defender of constitutional order. His actual record: in 2010, during the demonstrations supporting the coup-makers who overthrew Mamadou Tandja, he was on the front line cheering them on. In 2021, he had defended Mahamat Déby's dynastic succession in Chad: "We could say it's a coup, but that would be simplifying things [...] If the constitutional interim rules had to be applied, there was a risk this country would slide into instability." The coup argument is acceptable when it serves Paris's interests — unacceptable when it thwarts them.

When Bazoum was overthrown, he wrote an op-ed in the *Washington Post* pleading with Americans, the French, and the Western community to reinstate him. At no point did he call on his own people to mobilize for his reinstatement. Yet everyone had watched, in Sudan, the people flood the streets en masse to demand a return to civilian rule. Nothing of the sort in Niger. Nigerien people did not take to the streets to defend Bazoum — they took to the streets to celebrate the CNSP.

Why did the ultimatum fail?

Politically: Algeria, a regional power and direct neighbor, categorically opposes it. So do Russia and Guinea. Mali and Burkina Faso had warned that an aggression against Niger would be a declaration of war. Popular mobilization in Niger is massive: hundreds of thousands in the streets, in support of the CNSP. Within ECOWAS itself, not everyone is on the same page. Germany prefers mediation. Italy, through its foreign minis-

ter, directly criticizes France: "Europe cannot afford an armed confrontation. We must not be like new colonizers. On the contrary, we must build a new alliance with African countries that is not based on exploitation." As for Macky Sall — who did order the mobilization of his soldiers — this was primarily to keep them occupied so it wouldn't occur to them to draw inspiration from their neighbors. The United States, with 1,000 soldiers and two drone bases, began direct dialogue with the CNSP: it did not want an armed conflict that might jeopardize access to the Nigeria-Algeria gas pipeline running through Niger — an alternative to European supply that Washington is in no hurry to see operational.

Militarily: none of the belligerent countries could win a war in Niger. Ten years of Barkhane had proven that a foreign military presence only worsened insecurity year after year.

Legally: ECOWAS was operating in complete illegality. Article 53-1 of the UN Charter requires prior Security Council authorization for any regional coercive action — authorization that was never requested nor granted. Russia and China would have vetoed it. ECOWAS's own charter does not authorize the use of force to reinstate an overthrown president. And Article 20 of the AU's Constitutive Act recognizes the right of peoples to "liberate themselves from foreign occupation of their territories." If a regional organization sends foreign troops to reinstate a government rejected by its own population, who is the occupier?

The ultimatum was legally hollow. ECOWAS, a union of heads of state serving foreign interests, could win neither politically, militarily, nor legally. It exploded shortly afterward — and that is precisely what happened when the AES formally announced its withdrawal in January 2024.

Tiani in Ankara, June 4, 2026

Three years after the coup that made him a pariah of Western chancelleries, General Abdourahamane Tiani steps off his plane in Ankara for his first major official visit to Turkey. Recep Tayyip Erdoğan receives him with the honors of a head of state.

The agreements signed during this visit cover five areas — defense, security, energy, training, and infrastructure. Turkey delivers equipment even before being paid, under terms Paris or Washington had never granted. Nigerien pilots train in Turkey on Bayraktar TB2 drones. Turkish oil company TPAO is eyeing the Agadem oil basin.

This is not international rehabilitation: it is a demonstration that the multipolar world offers real alternatives to the Western order. A NATO member is receiving the leader of a state sanctioned by the EU and the United States. The geometry of the world has changed.

Withdrawal from the ICC: justice refused in the name of justice

Niger officially withdraws from the International Criminal Court. The reaction is not long in coming. Human Rights Watch expresses “grave concerns” and calls on AU and ICC member states to “persuade Niamey to reconsider its position.”

The argument is morally presentable. It collapses the moment it is confronted with the reality of how international criminal justice is actually practiced.

Actor | ICC status | International pressure

-
- Niger (2026 withdrawal) — Ordered to reconsider, HRW campaign — Strong, immediate
|
 - United States — Never party to the Rome Statute — None
|
 - Russia, China — Not parties — No comparable campaign
|
 - Israel — Not a party; contested warrants — Reverse pressure to protect

Since its creation, the ICC has almost exclusively prosecuted Africans. When the Court dared consider investigating crimes committed by American forces in Afghanistan, Washington responded with sanctions against the Court’s own magistrates — and the process died out. A prominent US senator formulated the real doctrine without any embarrassment:

“This court is for Africa and for thugs like Putin. It is not for democracies like Israel and the United States of America.”

The statement needs no comment. When the Court considered arrest warrants against officials of an allied “democracy,” the response was immediate: legislative pressure, threats, sanctions. When Niger withdraws from this Court, it is not leaving a temple of justice — it is leaving a tribunal whose own American judges proclaim is not meant for them.

The ICC’s reaction to Niger’s withdrawal, in fact, reveals something telling about the nature of the bond. According to the Court, Niger — despite its decision to withdraw — cannot immediately cease cooperating with the institution. It will remain bound by numerous obligations, even after the withdrawal process is complete. The formulation deserves weighing: a sovereign state notifies its withdrawal from a treaty, and the institution answers, in substance: *you’re leaving, but you remain bound*. This is the very mechanism of institutional domination — a framework designed so that entry is free and exit never truly complete.

Niamey is not fooled. In its official message to the United Nations, Niger states the heart of its grievance:

The International Criminal Court is currently "the object of misappropriation and instrumentalization, although it initially raised great hopes among peoples devoted to peace and justice."

For the AES, leaving the ICC is not fleeing justice. It is refusing a two-tier justice. The reasoning is the same as for the CFA franc, ECOWAS, military bases: do not remain within any framework that, under cover of universalism, enshrines the impunity of the powerful and the prosecution of the weak.

The horizon implied by this withdrawal: a sovereign pan-African justice, built on the continent, by African institutions, for African litigants. It remains to be built. And it is precisely this current absence that defenders of the status quo invoke to keep the trap in place.

Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger: the three locks broke in three years. Three national ruptures, still separate, still vulnerable. What remained was to forge them into a single force — and that unfolds in Bamako, one morning in September 2023, around a table and a text of a few pages.

Niger: the "weak link" that held

"Niger does not belong to you. Niger belongs to France. It is not for you to propose any solution whatsoever."
— Statement attributed to Emmanuel Macron, cited by General Abdourahmane Tiani, RTN, February 12, 2024

There is one sentence that sums up sixty years of Franco-African relations better than any treaty, any conference, any speech about partnership and cooperation. It was spoken, according to General Tiani, by Emmanuel Macron himself, in a private exchange the Nigerien president reported on national television on February 12, 2024: *"Niger does not belong to you. Niger belongs to France."* The statement was never publicly confirmed nor denied. It did not need to be — the facts had documented it for decades.

What Niger represents

Niger is the world's seventh-largest uranium producer. The Arlit mine, in the country's north, has been operated since the 1970s by what was then called Areva and is now called Orano — a French company. Nigerien uranium has fueled French nuclear plants, secured France's energy independence, supplied the raw material for its nuclear deterrent. For decades, the groundwater around Arlit was contaminated by radioactive runoff — and local populations lived in poverty beside a wealth they never touched.

Niger also has oil deposits. Before the July 2023 transition, the contracts were lopsided. After the transition, according to December 2025 data: roughly 300 million dollars in uranium revenue directly marketed

by the Nigerien state, and 500 million dollars in cash oil revenue — via a direct agreement with China. This amount, the source specifies, “had never before been seen in the coffers of the Nigerien state since independence.”

The system that keeps Africa poor

To understand why these 800 million dollars represent a radical rupture, one must ask the fundamental question: why is sub-Saharan Africa, endowed with the planet’s most abundant natural resources, the poorest region in the world?

The answer lies neither in geographic fatality nor in any supposed incapacity of its populations. It lies in a system designed to keep Africa in its role as a supplier of unprocessed raw materials. Three instruments sustain this arrangement: economic structures (debt, conditionality, dependent currency zones), global institutions (the IMF, the World Bank, the WTO, whose rules favor industrialized economies), and economic education — African elites trained in Western universities absorb doctrines that naturalize their continent’s primary-sector specialization.

The arithmetic result is simple: if Africa processed its raw materials before exporting them — if Niger sold nuclear fuel rather than uranium ore, if Mali sold finished jewelry gold rather than raw bars — living standards in Europe, North America, and Asia would fall. The prosperity of the Global North is structurally dependent on the poverty of the Global South. Trade accounting alone is enough to demonstrate what some still call a conspiracy theory.

General Tiani understood this in operational terms: retaking control of resources means threatening the global economic balance. Hence the intensity of the reaction.

The reaction: sanctions, blockade, pressure

On July 26, 2023, the National Council for the Safeguard of the Homeland (CNSP) overthrows Mohamed Bazoum. On July 30, 6,000 people gather in front of the French embassy in Niamey. ECOWAS’s reaction — actually steered from Paris and Abuja — is immediate and brutal:

- Closing of borders.
- Blocking of financial transactions.
- Confiscation of assets at the BCEAO.
- Embargo on public services.

These sanctions violate Article 45 of ECOWAS’s 2001 Protocol — which prohibits measures affecting civilian populations — and Article 53-1 of the UN Charter, which prohibits coercive actions without Security

Council authorization. They killed people. General Tiani publicly documented it: hundreds dead from a lack of medicine, fuel for hospital generators, and food for the most vulnerable populations.

The World Bank had projected +12.5% growth for Niger in 2024 before the embargo. After the embargo, the Africa Center for Strategic Studies projected -45%. That 57-point differential represents human lives — precisely those ECOWAS claimed to be protecting.

The American diplomatic note and the price of sovereignty

In March 2024, Niger expels American soldiers from its territory. In doing so, it reveals a document no one had wanted to name publicly: American diplomatic note 174/2012, which authorized the American military presence on Nigerien soil *without parliamentary ratification* — and under which Niger *paid taxes* on American military aircraft flying over its own territory. A sovereign state paying for the occupation of its own soil.

December 2023: expulsion of French soldiers. September 2023: expulsion of French ambassador Sylvain Itté, who had posted tweets on social media that the Nigerien side deemed discriminatory.

Niger, in 2024, expelled both French and American forces. This is unprecedented in the region's post-colonial history. It is also proof that sovereignty is not a slogan — it is an operational decision with measurable economic and security consequences.

What Tiani understood

General Tiani's speech of February 12, 2024 on RTN is a founding document. In it, he lays out what he calls the "Balkanization plan" for Niger — the fragmentation of the country by armed groups active in the west (the Madekali, Porga, Tourou zone), coordinated with nighttime French activities documented by Nathalie Yamb. He cites Macron's statement there. He articulates the transition's doctrine there: *"Negotiate as an equal, with dignity."*

Six words. That is the whole program. It is also everything the system described above was designed to prevent.

Sources: General Abdourahamane Tiani, RTN speech, February 12, 2024; Nyamsi data, December 2025 (post-transition uranium and oil revenue); ECOWAS sanctions, July 30, 2023; Article 45 of the 2001 ECOWAS Protocol; Article 53-1 of the UN Charter; American diplomatic note 174/2012 (US soldier expulsion, March 2024); World Bank, Niger 2024 projections; ACSS, embargo impact, May 20, 2024; Nathalie Yamb, analyses on nighttime French activity in western Niger; comparative analysis of the system that keeps Africa poor (economic structures, global institutions, education).

Sources: General Tiani, RTN, February 12, 2024; CNSP, communiqué March 16, 2024; Minister Sahabi

Oumarou, February 24, 2025; Nathalie Yamb, Niamey grand debate; Nathalie Yamb, August 2023 analysis; UNDP, 2023; ECOWAS Charter; AU Constitutive Act, Article 20; UN Charter, Article 53-1; Africa Geopolitis publication, Niger ICC withdrawal; ICC communiqué on the persistence of obligations after withdrawal; Niger's message to the United Nations denouncing the "misappropriation and instrumentalization" of the ICC; Italy's foreign minister, August 2023; Bazoum, Washington Post, August 2023.

CHAPTER 19 — THE BIRTH OF THE AES

"With or without you, we will move forward." — Abdoulaye Diop, Malian foreign minister

Bamako, September 16, 2023. Three men lean over a document of a few pages. General Assimi Goïta signs for Mali. Captain Ibrahim Traoré for Burkina Faso. General Abdourahamane Tiani for Niger. The text is called the Liptako-Gourma Charter. It creates the Alliance of Sahel States. Seven weeks earlier, ECOWAS was still threatening to invade Niger; that morning, the three threatened countries respond by ceasing to be three countries.

The very name is a manifesto. Liptako-Gourma is the tri-border zone, the ancestral territory of the Fulani, Tuareg, Songhai, and Mossi — a space that existed long before the Berlin Conference drew its straight lines across the map of Africa in 1884. By choosing this name, the AES anchors its rupture in a continuity that predates colonization: before Berlin, this territory existed; after Paris, it rebuilds itself.

LIPTAKO-GOURMA CHARTER — KEY PROVISIONS

Article 1: an attack against one member is an attack against all

Full sovereignty over national natural resources

The right to choose military and diplomatic partners without outside tutelage

Free movement of persons among the three member states

Creation of a Unified AES Force, established December 21, 2025

The central clause is the first: collective defense. This is the principle that founds NATO — an attack on one is an attack on all — transposed to the Sahel: invading Niger now means going to war against Mali and Burkina Faso simultaneously. ECOWAS's threat of intervention dies that day, killed by a signature.

From alliance to Confederation

What follows disproves anyone who saw the Charter as an improvised defensive gesture. On January 28, 2024, the three countries simultaneously withdraw from ECOWAS. On July 6, 2024, at the Mahatma Gandhi International Conference Center in Niamey, they proclaim the Confederation of Sahel States. On December 21, 2025, Goïta stands up the Unified Force. Each step makes the previous one irreversible. A methodical construction, carried out with the precision of a campaign plan.

The Niamey summit, in particular, does not produce a mere circumstantial communiqué but a body of legal texts: a treaty creating the Confederation, internal rules for the college of heads of state, a 25-point

final communiqué, and the Niamey Declaration. A confederation, put simply, is a union of states that remain sovereign but pool decisive powers — here, defense, diplomacy, major economic projects — whereas a federation would merge the three countries into one; and it is indeed a federation the texts designate as the horizon. On ECOWAS, Tiani is unambiguous: "This popular momentum is the best guarantee for building a confederation of peoples, not a bureaucratic edifice. Our peoples have irrevocably turned their backs on ECOWAS" (speech at the Niamey summit, July 6, 2024).

The summit also decides to create an AES investment bank and a stabilization fund — two instruments recommended as early as November 25, 2023 by the three countries' finance ministers, with major projects in energy, infrastructure, transport, and food security. A stabilization fund is a shared financial cushion: when one of the three countries suffers a shock — sanctions, a poor harvest, falling commodity prices — the others absorb it. It is the alliance's economic life insurance, the financial counterpart to the military Article 1.

A legitimacy older than the AES itself

The alliance does not present itself as an invention, but as a fulfillment. Abdoulaye Diop, Malian foreign minister, states this from within the institutions: the AES rests on a triple pillar — security first, economic integration second, coordinated diplomacy third — and the Confederation is only a step toward a Federation. He recalls that "Article 180 of Mali's most recent constitution reiterates Mali's commitment to relinquish all or part of its sovereignty to achieve African integration with any African state." Uniting with its neighbors is not a departure from sovereign Mali's founding principles: it is their literal application. Diop explicitly invokes Modibo Keita, first president of independent Mali — the continuity between 1960 and 2023 is institutionally claimed. And he concludes with a formula that would stick: "With or without you, we will move forward. If the Europeans aren't there, the Chinese will be there, the Russians will be there, the Australians will be there. Today, we are married to no one."

This coordinated diplomacy crossed a new threshold in Bamako. The three states decided to speak with one voice on the international stage, to develop a shared diplomatic strategy, and to study a unified diplomatic map — pooling representation to carry weight together rather than spreading themselves thin. The target is dated: the next UN General Assembly, in September 2026, where the AES intends to present itself as a bloc rather than three isolated voices. In the same move, the three countries denounce the maneuvers of foreign states sponsoring the recent attacks on Bamako and Niamey, and respond on two fronts: enhanced military synergy and a shared media strategy against disinformation. The message fits in one sentence: *the march toward the total sovereignty of the Sahel is irreversible* (Foyou Media). A bloc that speaks with one voice from the UN podium is no longer treated as three begging states; it is negotiated with as a power.

Regional attraction is beginning to take hold. On May 14, 2025, the Tarha Nakal 2 military exercise,

in Tillia, Niger, brings together AES armies with those of Chad and Togo — the same Togo that, in July 2023, signed ECOWAS's sanctions against Niamey. Twenty-two months to go from the camp of sanctions to the camp of joint maneuvers: the reversal deserves scrutiny. Is it sincere? Pan-Africanist analyst Banda Kani hardly thinks so: Togo is trying to "catch up on a fight" begun without it, and its 9th Pan-African Congress in Lomé amounts to political "window dressing" — "Togolese people don't recognize themselves in it." The distinction is useful: there is the sovereignism of rupture — Goïta, Traoré, Tiani — and the sovereignism of diversification without rupture, which changes partners without changing dependency. The second imitates the first; it has not yet joined it.

"An irreversible reality"

On December 21, 2025, while standing up the AES's Unified Force — brought to 15,000 personnel to cover the Saharan expanse — Goïta sets the course with one sentence: "The new threats are directed by state sponsors. The AES is an irreversible reality." Tiani formulates the same principle in its final form: the return toward sovereignty is a choice made by the Burkinabé, Malian, and Nigerien peoples — irreversible. And the three leaders now work in close coordination to anticipate the technological and military threats posed by the sponsors of armed groups: the convergence is no longer merely political, it is doctrinal.

The counterpoint must be stated clearly: this impressive institutional construction was built without elections, and the democratic question remains fully open — it will be addressed in its own right in Chapter 25. But no one can any longer claim this is a passing mood among colonels: it is an architecture, with its treaties, its bank, its joint army, and its doctrine.

One detail from the Tarha Nakal 2 exercise nonetheless deserves scrutiny, for it chills the blood in retrospect. The scenario played out at Tillia in May 2025 was as follows: a secession attempt backed by rebel groups with outside support. Eleven months later, almost point for point, this scenario stopped being an exercise.

CHAPTER 20 — THE PROXY WAR

"We're in the cold reality of the field. Francophone former legionnaires are working with Ukraine's GUR. The lock seems to have come off." — George Malbruno, citing a French security source, RTL, May 9, 2026

Kati, April 25, 2026. A truck approaches a residence in the military camp overlooking Bamako — the same one where it all began, one night in August 2020. The truck explodes. The blast tears through the targeted house and hits the neighboring mosque; several worshippers are among the victims. The residence belonged to General Sadio Camara, Mali's defense minister, the AES's military architect. He does not survive. At the same moment, that same April 25, coordinated assaults strike Bamako, Kidal, Gao, and Sévaré. The Front for the Liberation of the Azawad temporarily retakes Kidal. The Malian flag is lowered to half-mast. These are the largest attacks since the 2020 transition, and their objective is transparent: demonstrate that the AES cannot protect its own territory. The financing of this operation has a documented source: a few months earlier, JNIM had collected 50 million euros in ransom for the release of a single hostage — a retired Emirati general who had gone into the gold trade. A record sum, never before paid for one man. This money directly financed the April 25 offensive. Suspicions persist about a deliberate use of this kidnapping to quietly finance Al-Qaeda's affiliate — the question remains open, but the timeline is unambiguous.

To understand this day — who wanted it, who prepared it, who paid for it — one must trace the thread back. And the thread runs far: through Benin, through Bangui, through the cliffs of Tinzwaten, through Kyiv, and ends, on May 9, 2026, in an RTL studio in Paris.

The ghost army

After the official expulsions, France did not leave the Sahel. It regrouped — discreetly, clandestinely, via its regional allies: Benin, Guinea, Côte d'Ivoire. This is what journalist Thomas Dietrich documents in his investigation of July 13, 2024: French soldiers present in Tourou, Benin; drones and a reconnaissance plane funded to the tune of 11.7 million euros by the European Union; the DGSE supporting Beninese intelligence. Dietrich is forbidden from continuing his investigation in Benin by President Patrice Talon in person. In Dr. Yamb Ntimba's pyramid of domination, presented in Chapter 10, this is the first tier — the military — rebuilding itself here under a disguised form, while the upper tiers never stopped functioning.

The Central African Republic is, in this picture, the founding precedent in two ways: military and diplomatic.

July 29, 2022, UN Security Council. France is the *pen holder* on the CAR — it has drafted the resolutions concerning this country since 2013. That day, it loses. Resolution 2648/2022 is adopted: the arms embargo imposed on the Central African state since 2013 is lifted. The Central African army, gendarmerie, and police can now freely acquire supplies on the international arms market. What is retained — and what the CAR deems unacceptable interference in its sovereignty — is the mandate of the UN panel of experts, extended by a year to monitor the use of weaponry.

The manipulation that follows is revealing. The French journalist at the UN press service headlines his report: *"Security Council extends arms embargo by one year with an exemption for security forces."* Luc Michel, a pan-African analyst, dismantles the lie live: if the security forces enjoy a total exemption on all deliveries of weapons, ammunition, vehicles, and military equipment — there is no longer an arms embargo on the Central African state. Calling this an "extension" is an internal contradiction within the same paragraph. The neocolonists, he says, *"take defeat badly. They try to save face with drafting tricks."*

The logical demonstration also sheds light on the embargo's original nature. Since 2013, this embargo had only bound the government's hands. Rebellions, by definition, break the law — they do not ask permission before arming themselves. An embargo against a rebellion makes no sense: rebellion is precisely the act of violating prohibitions. Imposing an embargo on the CAR since 2013 meant tying both hands of the government behind its back while letting the rebellion — armed by vassal states of Françafrique like Chad — supply itself freely. This is what Resolution 2648 corrected in a single session.

The five abstentions (China, Russia, Gabon, Ghana, Kenya) are not reservations about the victory — the main objective was achieved. They express a rejection of retaining the expert committee as a tool of interference in Central African defensive sovereignty. The Central African foreign minister said it plainly: it is out of the question that the CAR should have to account to anyone for how it uses its defense capacity.

In December 2020, days before the presidential election, forces loyal to former president François Bozizé — accompanied by Chadian and Sudanese mercenaries — attempt to overthrow Faustin-Archange Touadéra. The offensive is stopped by the FACA, backed by Russian aviation and Russian advisers: this is the first time this model — a national African army backed by Moscow against an offensive supported by outside networks — is tested at full scale. Destabilization does not stop with military failure: it continues through other channels — NGO reports, international legal proceedings, campaigns targeting sovereign credit ratings to block access to investment. Luc Michel labels this arrangement a fourth-generation war. The mechanism — seizing the levers of international credibility to economically asphyxiate a sovereign state — is documented in other geopolitical contexts. What the Central African Republic endured starting in 2020, AES states would experience variants of, starting in 2021.

Two affairs then give this ghost army a face. Rémy Juan Quignolot, first: a former French non-commissioned officer who moved into private security, established in the Central African Republic since 2013, arrested in

Bangui on May 10, 2021. Photos published by the outlet Ndjoni Sango show a full military arsenal laid out on the ground. Five charges: espionage, illegal possession of weapons, criminal conspiracy, threat to state security, plotting. He is extracted via Libreville on May 21, 2023 — and the Élysée's Africa unit, Franck Paris and Nadège Chouat, is implicated in the negotiations (Le Parisien, May 21, 2023). Yann Vésilier, next: a DGSE agent arrested in Bamako, accused of preparing an overthrow, still detained in Mali as of this writing. The Quai d'Orsay spoke of "obvious instrumentalization" regarding Quignolot; it did not use the same words for Vésilier. Two countries, two agents, the same operating method: clandestine deployment, arrest by sovereignist authorities, diplomatic extraction or extended detention.

These men operate in the gray zone of PMDCs — private military and defense companies: private firms that sell military services — protection, training, intelligence — allowing a state to act where its flag can no longer fly, and to deny everything if an arrest occurs. For each agent caught, how many operate incident-free? This figure does not exist in the public archives. France's secret war in the Sahel, as seen in Chapter 13, preceded the official war; it also outlived it.

Washington is not absent from this gray-zone geography. In June 2026, the arrest in Bangui of Dande Christian adds a new dimension to the arsenal of diplomatic umbrellas. The agent is neither a repurposed NCO nor an employee of some obscure PMDC: he is a member of the SPEAR program — a protective unit created by the US State Department's Bureau of Diplomatic Security (DSS) after the Benghazi attack, funded by the State Department, deployed to protect the US embassy in Bangui. Caught red-handed selling 5,410 tramadol capsules — the synthetic opioid devastating the youth of Bangui's neighborhoods — Dande Christian was carrying an American-issue Glock: the standard-issue weapon provided by the embassy, listed in the official inventory. His alleged accomplices, Mohamed Azwa and Ngaisse Edgar, are figures from the PK-5 district, the Central African capital's central market that serves as a hub for several informal economies (Centrafrique Info, June 17, 2026).

What the Dande Christian affair reveals is structurally identical to what Quignolot's had revealed on the French side: diplomatic or para-diplomatic status builds a de facto immunity. Centrafrique Info poses the question that remains officially unanswered: "Did you truly not know who you were hiring, and who you were arming? Or did you know, but preferred to look away?" The American embassy's response had not been made public as of this writing. As with Quignolot, active silence is itself information.

Tinzawaten: Ukraine enters the picture

Late July 2024. In the far northeast of Mali, on the Algerian border, the cliffs of Tinzawaten become the scene of a heavy Malian defeat. Tuareg rebels from the Cadre Stratégique Permanent and their jihadist allies launch a coordinated offensive against Malian army positions and their Wagner partners. The toll is brutal: at

least 84 Malian soldiers killed according to the rebels, significant losses on the Wagner side; the Malian army acknowledges "significant losses" without quantifying them.

Then comes the unthinkable. On August 6, 2024, Andriy Yusov, spokesman for Ukrainian military intelligence — the GUR — states on Ukrainian television that the rebels received "the necessary data that enabled them to carry out their operation against the Malian military." The statement is surgically precise: it does not admit an arms delivery, it confirms intelligence support. A foreign state service publicly acknowledges having passed to the attackers the information — positions, movements, vulnerabilities — that enabled them to kill dozens of soldiers of a country Ukraine is not at war with. In military vocabulary, this is called operational support. In Bamako's vocabulary, complicity in murder.

A commonsense question then arises: how does Ukraine, fighting an existential war since 2022, whose leaders beg their allies for more weapons, find the human, technical, and financial resources to conduct intelligence operations in West Africa? The answer is not in Kyiv. Since the dissolution of the G5 Sahel and Barkhane's withdrawal, Paris has lost every legal structure for intervention in the Sahel. It needs a mask. This is what a proxy war is: a war conducted through an intermediary, where the sponsor stays off-camera while a third party, dependent on it, holds the rifle or supplies the coordinates. Ukraine, indebted to Western aid, benefiting from intelligence shared by NATO, can act where France can no longer appear. This interpretive framework, articulated as early as 2024 by pan-Africanist analysts such as Thomson Ehang, would be validated two years later in a way no one expected.

Mali, then Niger, break diplomatic relations with Kyiv. A decision labeled "emotional" by some Western commentators; in reality, elementary logic: if you feed my enemy the intelligence that kills my soldiers, you are my enemy. On August 19, 2024, the three AES foreign ministers formally bring the matter before the UN Security Council, denouncing "the open and acknowledged support by the government of Ukraine for international terrorism, particularly in the Sahel" (joint AES communiqué, August 19, 2024). The Council — where France is a permanent member with veto power — takes no action. This silence echoes a precedent: back in July 2022, when Mali had wanted to present the Council with evidence that terrorists were "manufactured, maintained, and trained against our states," a veto had blocked the public presentation. Choguel Maïga reports the justification allegedly given behind the scenes: "If Malians show their proof, all Africans will rise up." Physical evidence, meanwhile, is accumulating: on May 23, 2025, during an ambush near Sofara, the FAMa seize from JNIM fighters a phone containing documents presented as originating from Ukrainian intelligence, along with a drone bearing Ukrainian markings (Lefaso.net, June 23, 2025). And Tiani offers the simplest material argument: the terrorists field heavy machine guns "that the AES forces don't even have." One cannot steal from the enemy what the enemy does not possess.

The next step: drones and regime change

Between August 2024 and the summer of 2025, the France-Ukraine-Sahel channel evolves from intelligence support to something more concrete. Jeune Afrique reveals, in an investigation signed by Matthieu Millecamps published on June 17, 2026, what had happened the previous summer: between June and August 2025, French intermediaries — presenting themselves as close to French intelligence services — made contact with “members of the Malian government in exile” and put them in touch with Ukrainian military intelligence, the GUR. Three profiles are named: Éric Gozlan, Franco-Israeli, founder of IT Transform and the ICDD, the first to arrange the introductions; Paul Michel Manand, a Belgian national claiming security connections in Ukraine; Jugen Bron, presented as a representative of the *Ukrainian Military Intelligence Veterans Foundation*, who put drones and training on the table — in the presence of a certain Victor, presented as a French agent. Gozlan acknowledged the facts to media, without denying the substance. The purpose of the approach: to offer weaponized drones and training in Ukraine, in order to fight Assimi Goïta. What the GUR had supplied at Tinzawaten — data, coordinates — the network was now attempting to complement with weapons and regime-change training.

Jeune Afrique’s investigation is titled: “Spooks, drones, and exiles: French nationals offered Ukrainian weapons to Malian opponents” — “spooks” in intelligence-community slang meaning unofficial agents, ones the state can disavow if an operation goes wrong. The arrangement is built for deniability — exactly the same principle as Quignolot’s PMDCs, or the Ukrainian mask used after Barkhane’s withdrawal. The source of the article is a Malian opponent from the diaspora who shares the information “in early May” 2026 “in a confidential tone” — which places the revelation at the same moment as the April 25 attacks and RTL’s disclosures. The sequence is readable: the June–August 2025 offers of drones and training having failed to produce regime change, the escalation toward direct action followed.

Jeune Afrique’s note deserves weighing: this is not a pan-Africanist website, nor an organ of AES governments. It is one of the most widely read African publications, with correspondents and lawyers. That the magazine published such an investigation — naming the link between French intermediaries, the GUR, and Malian exiles — places this fact in the category of information the adversary itself can no longer deny without risking its credibility.

January 2026: the Niamey dress rehearsal

On the night of January 28–29, 2026, Diori Hamani International Airport and Air Base 101 in Niamey are attacked. Three planes are riddled with bullets. Nigerien forces regain control in under twenty minutes. The operation’s details, reconstructed by Nigerien authorities, describe anything but an amateur attack: roughly

thirty motorbikes mixing JNIM and fighters from Nigeria's Boko Haram/ISWAP zones, preparations begun in April 2025, a planning meeting at Yablé in July 2025, a cost of 300 million CFA francs, a claim of responsibility published 72 hours later in exchange for 100 million paid to JNIM — drafted in military format, five points, thirty sub-points, timelines, with a nota bene on uranium that, according to Tiani, betrays writing dictated by foreign interests. Had the base fallen, seven simultaneous attacks were to follow across the western part of the country. The sequence running from January into the spring of 2026 is continuous.

April 25, and the man who had to die

TIMELINE AROUND APRIL 25, 2026

April 22–23: FAMa victories against armed groups — not relayed by Western media (Jules Domche, Vox Africa)

April 23: the EU Council finalizes 90 billion euros for Ukraine, including 60 for defense, with "targeted exemptions"

April 25: coordinated attacks on Bamako, Kati, Kidal, Gao, Sévaré; death of General Sadio Camara; the FLA temporarily retakes Kidal

April 28: Goïta's speech; May 1: 800 Nigerien fuel tankers sent to Mali

May 8: Niger suspends ten French media; Mali's HAC bans Al Arabiya

May 9: RTL — Malbruno's revelations; May 10: Goïta takes back the Defense portfolio

Coordination between jihadists and separatists, long denied, now displays itself publicly: Iyad Ag Ghaly, JNIM's chief, and Alghabass Ag Intalla jointly comment on the attacks in video; and the FLA's spokesman states, unprompted: "We have good contacts with the Ukrainians, just as with France, with the United States, with almost everyone." Banda Kani goes further: he describes a contingent of roughly 12,000 men mixing impoverished Sahelian recruits with foreign leadership, and armed group leaders in direct contact with French strategic circles. Analyst Laith Marouf offers a complementary picture of who makes up this leadership: fighters from militias tied to Ahmad al-Sharaa, forged in the Syrian crucible, are said to have been gradually redeployed toward the Sahel as their residual core in Syria weakened its territorial grip. The Algerian graft of the 1990s, Libyan weapons from 2011, Syrian militiamen from post-2024 — the internationalization of the Sahelian fighting force follows the chronology of regional collapses that the West either triggered or let fester.

At the center of the day, a death that is not just one death among others. Sadio Camara had been identified as a priority target as early as February 2022, in the recording attributed to Ouattara and Cissé discussed in Chapter 10 — "Within two weeks they fall." They did not fall. Camara continued: the military cooperation sealed in Ouagadougou in November 2022, Operation Kapidgou 2 in May 2023, Kidal in November 2023, the

Unified Force in December 2025. He was the one who turned the FAMa into an army capable of retaking the country's north. Between the identification of the target and his elimination: four years and two months. The patience of those who planned this attack is itself information. Camara was neither Lumumba nor Sankara — he did not govern a country. But the logic is the same: eliminate those who make the sovereign project credible. Sankara fell when his record became unimpeachable; Camara, when his work became irreversible.

The response, and the confession

The AES does not collapse. Militarily: 15,000 personnel mobilized, more than 4,000 enemy fighters neutralized according to official figures — unverifiable at this stage — and Kidal retaken by the FAMa. The 800 fuel tankers sent by Niger to Mali starting May 1 give the Charter's solidarity its most concrete expression. Diplomatically: suspension of ten French media outlets, banning of Al Arabiya, preparation of a new submission to the UN with material evidence — following the request for an investigation submitted as early as June 2025 to the Security Council and the ICC by Malian journalist Robert Dixard concerning Ukrainian involvement. Politically: on May 10, Goïta personally takes back the Defense portfolio from his assassinated minister. "By directly taking charge of this sovereign ministry, General Assimi Goïta strengthens his control over the military apparatus while guaranteeing the stability of the chain of command" (ORTM, May 10, 2026). Even Washington takes note: an American envoy, Nick Checker, is received in Bamako on April 28 and 29 — the AES held, and the American reading of the balance of power evolves.

Then comes the confession. On May 9, 2026, on RTL, George Malbruno reports the words of a French security source: "We're in the cold reality of the field. Francophone former legionnaires are working with Ukraine's GUR. The lock seems to have come off." Macron publicly lashes out at the journalist. He does not deny the substance. This active silence amounts to validation. A remarkable fact: it is the adversary itself that confirms. Choguel Maïga, dismissed as a "conspiracy theorist" in 2021 when he spoke of manufactured terrorism, is confirmed in 2026 by a French security source.

Mali retakes ground: DDR and financial warfare

Resilience is not merely military. On the human front, Mali is advancing quietly.

The DDR program — Disarmament, Demobilization, Reintegration — officially launched in February 2025 sets a target of 3,000 former fighters: 2,000 integrated into the Malian Armed Forces as second-class soldiers with pay and training, 1,000 directed toward civilian reintegration (vocational training, small economic projects through the Ministry of Reconciliation). Concrete sessions have taken place. The program was extended to self-defense groups in November 2025.

The best-documented case: December 10, 2025, Kidal. Fourteen FLA fighters simultaneously lay down their weapons during a ceremony attended by General Gamou — governor of Kidal, a Tuareg from the Imad clan appointed in November 2023 after the city's retaking. They hand over two pickups, PKM machine guns, a 12.7mm heavy machine gun, night-vision binoculars, radios. A fighter states during the ceremony: "Today, we're here among you because we've chosen peace. I'm ready to serve my country, Mali, and I invite others who still hesitate to join us." Other, smaller surrenders followed in Timbuktu. Armed groups have increased internal surveillance of those considering surrender — proof the threat is real. One does not monitor what does not worry.

On the air front, an Orion drone of Russian manufacture — about a ton, 24-hour endurance, high altitude, precision strike — was spotted over Malian territory near Bamako. Whether it belongs to the FAMa or their partners, the objective remains the same.

On June 18, 2026, Mali's finance minister freezes the assets of 12 people for six months over alleged links with JNIM and the FLA — a journalist, a magistrate, an engineer, lawyers. Financial war has begun. Those who thought only fighters had something to lose are wrong. It is fought in accounts, registers, and transfers.

July 2026: Anéfis, and TASS confirmation

The summer of 2026 adds another piece to the file — and, notably, it comes neither from a pan-Africanist investigation nor from a Western leak, but from an interview given by a Malian official to the Russian news agency TASS. On July 9, 2026, Fouseynou Ouattara, vice-president of the National Transitional Council's Defense Commission, states there that Malian security services have identified several fighters who received training in piloting kamikaze drones in Ukraine — individuals on record, whose identities appear on the authorities' watch lists. Ouattara goes further: the drones used in the attacks were themselves reportedly of Ukrainian origin, and the fighters had been trained both by French Foreign Legion specialists and by Ukrainian instructors — a convergence which, if confirmed, matches point for point the France-Ukraine-Sahel channel documented earlier in this chapter, this time named from Bamako rather than uncovered by a French press investigation.

Ouattara adds a linguistic clue that deserves to be noted with its own methodological caution — a piece of wartime intelligence reported by a single official source, not independently corroborated at this stage: the interrogation of captured Tuareg fighters reportedly revealed dialects that do not match the Tamasheq spoken in Mali, suggesting Mauritanian, Algerian, or Libyan origin. If confirmed, this finding rounds out the map of trans-Saharan corridors laid out in Chapter 12: fighters are not only armed and informed from outside — some are, in part, recruited from outside too.

These statements fit within a precise military sequence. On July 4, 2026, Mali's Ministry of Defense announces coordinated attacks simultaneously targeting several military positions — Aguelhok, Anéfis, Gao,

Kenioroba, Konna, Sévaré, and Somadougou — attributed to the Azawad Liberation Front (FLA) and JNIM. The army says it repelled these offensives with the support of its partners, but fighting continues at Anéfis, home to a major military base; Malian authorities claim more than 200 fighters killed in the operations that follow, and the locality passes under joint strategic control of FAMa and Africa Corps. The pattern mirrors April 25: a coordinated multi-site attack, claimed by the same FLA-JNIM alliance, followed by a heavy toll on the attackers' side — except this time, a Malian source names Ukraine directly as a supplier of means and training, rather than waiting for a foreign outlet to reveal it.

A confession from the French left

The observation is not made only by Sahelian officials or a Russian news agency. In France itself, part of the political class recognizes the mechanism in its broad outlines. Jean-Luc Mélenchon, speaking about what is happening in Mali, puts it plainly: "Remember, all of you, that what we are talking about is people who were financed, armed by the European Union, by ourselves, and who today are assassinating their compatriots." He draws the political conclusion that follows: "We too are entitled to demand accountability." The admission names no products, no drones, no instructors — it makes no claim to technical proof. But it confirms, from the French National Assembly itself, what Malian and Nigerien officials have been repeating for years: the fighters bleeding the Sahel were not born of nothing; some of them were financed and armed by the very Western powers that today claim to be horrified.

Tiani had announced it

Five months before the attack, the warning was public. On November 13, 2025, in a filmed address given inside the country, General Tiani describes a plan of which the April 25, 2026 attacks would give a first realization. According to him, "three or four months earlier" — in the summer of 2025 — a meeting was held somewhere in the Sahel, where "the sponsors of these mercenaries" reportedly settled on a partition project. The planned sequence, as he reports it: first strike Mali, then "Balkanize" it into four emirates — the FLA's Azawad, Macina, Timbuktu, Serma-Gourma — with Burkina Faso and Niger, for their part, each to be placed "under the authority of an emir." The timeline has given this a weight no one can ignore: five months later, Mali was attacked, the FLA briefly retook Kidal, and jihadist-separatist coordination was on public display. Tiani added his recurring military argument: these fighters on motorbikes, bicycles, sometimes on foot, benefit "more than the security forces" from air cover that informs them of army positions and movements — support no group left to its own devices would possess.

The second part of the warning is even more troubling, because it describes a mechanism, not an event. Tiani announces a planned rebranding of the fighters: they would be asked to abandon the vocabulary of "global

jihad” and soften their most brutal methods — beheadings, amputations, stonings; then they would be presented as “Islamists,” and later as “revolutionaries.” “They’ve retreated behind religion to make us swallow the pill,” he summarizes, before citing precedents: Afghanistan, Iraq, Syria, and Libya “on our border.” And this is exactly the doctrine a French official would articulate five months later — without knowing, or without caring, that he was confirming the Nigerien prophecy.

The agenda revealed: JNIM as future political actor

While the bombs were falling on Bamako, a French elected official publicly delivered the next act of the script. On April 25, 2026 — the day of the attack against Sadio Camara — Bruno Fuchs, chairman of the Foreign Affairs Committee of the French National Assembly, gave an interview to RFI. His statement deserves being quoted in its full analytical scope: “the ruling junta in Bamako will fall within a few weeks or months”; the Russians are negotiating their departure; JNIM must be integrated as a political actor in the future transition — following the reconciliation model. Two scenarios are sketched: a negotiated collapse, or a forced collapse toward an “Afghan model.” This statement is a signal aimed at JNIM, not a prediction meant for French public opinion.

Analyst Jonathan Batenguene, in an analysis published by Festin Panafricain (June 2026), identifies the structural logic: Fuchs is not a minister — he therefore cannot officially commit France. But he chairs the relevant committee, and in French diplomatic grammar, a committee chair speaks when a minister cannot. The operating model is repetitive: Côte d’Ivoire’s Forces Nouvelles in 2010 — an armed group labeled terrorist, turned political interlocutor, then a pillar of the Ouattara state; Ahmad al-Sharaa in Syria in 2024–2025 — head of a recognized terrorist organization, received at the Élysée as early as December 2024, de facto prime minister of Damascus six months later. Batenguene’s formula sums up the doctrine: “Today’s terrorists are tomorrow’s politicians.” If the pattern holds, JNIM is the Malian candidate for the same recycling.

The question of who finances these public positions is explicitly raised. Batenguene notes that in the French political system, an MP is an elected official who must finance himself — and that those who defend foreign interests in the chamber are often those such interests helped get elected. “An MP is someone salaried by those he defends,” he summarizes (Festin Panafricain, June 2026).

On the ground, the FLA — Forces for the Liberation of the Azawad — has meanwhile structured its diplomatic presence: offices have been opened in Lomé, Abidjan, and N’Djamena, according to information cross-checked by Festin Panafricain (June 2026). These outposts are not tourist offices. They represent a political projection into the capitals of countries maintaining relations with Paris, bordering or having bordered Mali — a representation network for an armed group anticipating its political conversion.

The analysis of April 25 offers an additional angle: the question of internal complicity. The attack against

Sadio Camara, in its surgical precision — identified target, political timing, maximum impact — implies intimate knowledge of the security setup. Batenguene and Banda Kani note that Mali's prime minister was absent from Bamako on April 25, on an official trip to Burkina Faso. This absence at the moment of the decade's major attack fuels questions about the decision chain at the Prime Minister's office — questions pan-African analysts formulate cautiously, but formulate nonetheless. The figure of the "prime minister's officer" — General Abdoulaye Maïga — is cited in this context as a point of institutional vulnerability the transition should examine.

The comparison with Niger is instructive at this point in the analysis. General Tiani, in Niamey, made a choice Bamako did not: keeping a civilian prime minister, Lamine Zeine, a recognized specialist in international economics. Measured result: six months of foreign-currency reserves in Niger, against a more strained situation in Mali. Analysts at Festin Panafricain draw a direct recommendation to Goïta from this: restructure the transition, bring Choguel Maïga back to the forefront of the civilian apparatus, strengthen economic governance alongside the military effort. Not out of idealism, but because financial resilience is itself a weapon in a war that endures.

Last geopolitical angle: Mali's decision on Western Sahara had a precise diplomatic cost. By joining the Moroccan position, Bamako isolated itself from Algiers. Algeria, which shares a long border with Mali and can — when it chooses — exert pressure on JNIM's logistical flows, has since adopted a posture of benevolent neutrality toward the armed group. "Algeria turns a blind eye to JNIM" (Festin Panafricain, June 2026): this shift in Algeria's posture is a direct consequence of a Malian diplomatic decision made without calculating its security implications on the northern flank. Geography has its reprisals.

The response does not stop there. On June 18, 2026, around 6 a.m., Niamey's Diori Hamani International Airport is attacked a second time within the same year. Armed mercenaries — "in the pay of Emmanuel Macron's France," according to the official statement from Niger's defense ministry — infiltrate aboard taxis and urban minibuses, some wearing explosive belts. The intended surprise effect fails: alerted by the first shots, defense and security forces react immediately. The attack is repelled within hours. Toll: 13 martyrs on the Nigerien side (11 security personnel and 2 civilians), 4 wounded; 22 attackers neutralized, around twenty suspects arrested. Seized equipment: M80 rifles, RPG-7s, AK-47s, grenades, ammunition, VHF handsets — and two taxis and a van. The airport, "fully secured," remains open to air traffic. The attack's logistics — unmarked urban transport vehicles, explosive belts, repeated targeting of the same strategic infrastructure — confirm outside planning. The first strike in January 2026 was a dress rehearsal; the second, on June 18, 2026, confirms that the target does not change: paralyzing the Nigerien capital through its air hub. Twice, security forces held.

The proxy war now has a name, dates, confessions. But it also has a geography: none of these years' attacks would have been possible without sanctuaries, corridors, and complicity among the AES's neighbors — and it is toward them one must now turn.

The information war in Niger: a pre-positioned Ivorian

On June 18, 2026, in the minutes following the start of the attack on Niamey's airport, a piece falls into place that reveals the informational component of the operation. An Ivorian journalist named Yacouba Doumbia — phone number +2250707588787 — had been pre-positioned to receive the first images of the attack and disseminate them as propaganda.

The term "pre-positioned" has a precise meaning: this is not a journalist who happened by chance to be nearby. He had been set up before the attack to capture its images at the moment of maximum confusion — before Nigerien forces had restored control — and disseminate them instantly to the diaspora and social media as proof of a Nigerien collapse.

The objective was not informational. It was strategic: create, within the first hours, a narrative of defeat that spreads faster than reality can contradict it. The media showcase of defeat precedes the defeat itself. If Nigerien forces regain control within three hours, the video released in the first hour keeps circulating for days.

This mechanism is identical to the one Bassolma Bazié described for Ouagadougou: "For about ten days, we were told Ouagadougou had fallen." Pre-positioning a media relay is a planned component of the military operation — not a side effect. The proxy war is also a war of narrative.

Central African Republic 2026: the war to come

The Central African Republic illustrates what the AES avoids becoming by avoiding the mistakes that came before it.

In March 2026, French foreign minister Jean-Noël Barrot pays a visit to Bangui. Result: failure. The French mining company Orano refuses to hand back the operating permits for the Bakouma site, in accordance with contracts established with Central African authorities. Minister Temon of the Touadéra government stands Barrot up at an official dinner. Paris returns empty-handed.

Thomas Dietrich's analysis, dated June 22, 2026, documents an offensive architecture taking shape. Two Russian factions coexist in the CAR: the former Wagner — rebranded Africa Corps, close to Touadéra — and a faction directly tied to the Kremlin seeking to reassert control. The critical outside variable: Sudan. Touadéra had backed Hemedti and the Rapid Support Forces (RSF); but the RSF are losing the war against General Bourhan's regular army. If Bourhan wins, he could turn against Bangui in retaliation.

The offensive architecture Dietrich describes: Nouredine Adam — under an ICC arrest warrant — had stayed in Paris in December 2025 to meet with figures of the Central African opposition. He is preparing an offensive from the country's north, via Chad and Sudan. Simultaneously, another armed group, nicknamed the "Black Wagners" or Aka-Gé, advances from the east toward Bangassou.

Christophe Raineteau — the honorable correspondent introduced in Chapter 13 — reappears in this picture. Dietrich mentions him as having taken part in the 2018 grenade attack against the Notre-Dame de Fatima church. The man who lives in Nantes under permanent surveillance, extracted from Madagascar in 2019 by French diplomats, and who had publicly announced in 2022 that a coup would take place in Bangui “in the coming months” — this man remains in France, free, not extradited, while Bangui’s arrest warrants pile up.

France protects its agents even when convicted, tolerates the organization of coups from its own soil, and maintains operational networks in Central African countries from which it has been officially excluded. Raineteau, Quignolot, Vésilier: three names, three countries, the same logic of structural impunity.

Mahamat Déby in Chad — who navigates between backing Touadéra and appeasing the groups threatening Bangui — illustrates the “triple pivot” Dietrich describes: between Paris, Moscow, and regional actors. The AES, having broken with France, has no such problem of dual allegiance. This is both its strength and its isolation.

Sources: Niamey airport, June 2026; Thomas Dietrich, CAR analysis, June 22, 2026; Christophe Raineteau, TPMP, February 28, 2022; Ndjoni Sango, Bangui, 2022; RTL France, May 9, 2026; Ukraine’s GUR, Andriy Yusov, August 6, 2024; Jeune Afrique, June 17, 2026; Festin Panafricain, June 2026; UN resolution 2648/2022 (July 29, 2022) and the UN press service’s report; Luc Michel’s analysis (July 30, 2022) on the Central African diplomatic victory and the French UN journalist’s drafting deception; Fouseynou Ouattara, vice-president of the CNT’s Defense Commission, TASS interview, July 9, 2026; Mali’s Ministry of Defense and Veterans Affairs, statement of July 4, 2026 on the coordinated attacks on Aguelhok, Anéfis, Gao, Kenioroba, Konna, Sévaré, and Somadougou; RT France, July 11, 2026, on FAMa and Africa Corps’ strategic control of Anéfis; Jean-Luc Mélenchon, public statement on European financing and arming of fighters in Mali.

CHAPTER 21 — THE REGIONAL ENVIRONMENT

"Today's Algeria turns its weapons against the Mali that is fighting for its own independence." — Nathalie Yamb, April 2025

Night of March 31 to April 1, 2025, northern Mali. A drone of the Malian Armed Forces flies over its own territory, ten kilometers from the Algerian border — the aircraft's GPS data will attest to this. An Algerian missile shoots it down. That same March 31, thousands of kilometers away, Abdelmadjid Tebboune and Emmanuel Macron speak by phone; the joint statement mentions their "respective strategic and security interests." Algiers fires on a Malian drone the very day Algiers and Paris agree on their shared interests in the region. The synchronization is documented.

That night sums up this chapter's subject: the AES is not an island. It is surrounded by neighbors who are, by turns, partners, hostile sanctuaries, logistical corridors — and sometimes all three at once. A survey, neighbor by neighbor.

Chad: Mahamat Déby between two fires

Chad is the blind spot of Sahel analysis. Bordering Niger, Sudan, Libya, Cameroon, the Central African Republic, and Nigeria, it is the geographic pivot of the continent. Idriss Déby dies on April 20, 2021, officially at the front against the FACT rebellion, the day after his re-election — a calendar coincidence noted by several analysts. His son Mahamat takes power the very next day: a dynastic succession, an absolute constitutional anomaly. And what does Paris do? Macron attends the funeral and publicly validates the succession — the same Macron who vehemently condemns the military transitions in Mali and Burkina Faso in the name of constitutional order. The difference in treatment says everything: it is not democracy that matters to Paris, it is obedience. In May 2024, Mahamat Déby is returned to office with 61% of the vote in an election boycotted by part of the opposition. Paris does not comment.

Economics explains the docility. Oil accounts for 60% of the Chadian state's revenue, but production has been declining since the mid-2010s, and the rent has mainly benefited the Déby family and the Zaghawa clan's networks. A rentier economy is an economy that lives off income pulled from the ground rather than off the work of transformation: when the rent falls, the state that depends on it must find protectors. Those in N'Djamena are called Paris — and, increasingly, Abu Dhabi: according to the SWP report of May 2026, Mahamat Déby has at least temporarily allowed the United Arab Emirates to use Chadian territory as a hub for supplying the Sudanese RSF. When Chad renegotiates its defense agreements with France in 2024, Paris negotiates with a

gentleness never applied to Bamako or Niamey: N'Djamena is its last major military deployment in sub-Saharan Africa.

Chad is not spared the turmoil for all that: from May 4 to 6, 2026, in the immediate wake of April 25, Boko Haram attacks it in turn. The pressure is exerted on all regional actors simultaneously — including on the humanitarian front: in 2025, Niger expelled the ICRC, with Tiani accusing it of having served as a financial vector during secret meetings in Abuja between Western representatives and armed groups. Between these two poles of dependence — Paris and Abu Dhabi — Déby nonetheless retains a minimal margin of maneuver that he occasionally uses. When Donald Trump, as part of his migration policy, puts Chad on the list of countries whose nationals are denied US visas, Mahamat Idriss Déby responds with reciprocity: American citizens will no longer receive visas to enter Chad either. "Chad is a sovereign country," the move sums up. This gesture, as symbolic as it is practical, shows that sovereignty rhetoric is no longer reserved for the AES's three states: it now runs even through states still in the Western orbit, forced to answer their populations in a language that the AES has made audible and legitimate.

Algeria: the mediator who shoots

Back to the drone of March 31. It is not an isolated accident, but the latest episode in a deeply ambivalent relationship. Algeria sponsored the 2015 Algiers Accords, supposed to disarm Malian Tuareg groups. Albert Anatole Ayissi: "The Algiers Accords amounted to balkanizing the country. The idea was for the European Union, led by France and backed by the UN, to sit Bamako's legitimate authorities and terrorist group leaders at the same table to strike bad arrangements at Mali's expense."

The archives confirm how long-standing the double game is. Declassified emails from January 18, 2013, between Hillary Clinton and her adviser Sidney Blumenthal, accessible on Wikileaks, establish that the Boute-flika government had reached a highly secret agreement with the terrorist Belmokhtar after the kidnapping of the Algerian consul in Gao in April 2012: Belmokhtar would concentrate his operations in Mali, with the encouragement of Algerian intelligence. Algiers was exporting its jihadist problem to its neighbor and using it as a strategic adjustment variable. The picture is not one-sided: that same Algeria served as a de facto shield for Niger on August 3, 2023, when the American C-17 had to turn back over its airspace.

There is finally a historical reversal that only a sixty-year look back can measure. Algeria's FLN used Modibo Keita's Mali as a rear base to fight colonial France; an Algerian delegation came to Bamako to present Modibo Keita with a flag and a dagger as a sign of fraternal gratitude. Mali paid in blood for Algeria's freedom. And today's Algeria fires on the drones of a Mali fighting for its own. Nathalie Yamb sees in this not the policy of the Algerian state, but that of "a military-state mafia that benefits from Saharan trafficking — drugs, weapons, oil, human beings — and whose interest lies in the continuation of instability."

On March 22, 2026, the break becomes frontal: at an Arab League meeting, Mali recognizes Moroccan sovereignty over Western Sahara. For Algiers, whose foreign policy is structured around support for the Polisario Front, this is a major geopolitical slap — Bamako chooses Rabat on the most sensitive question in the Maghreb. Four weeks later come the April 25 attacks, claimed by Iyad Ag Ghali's JNIM — which maintains documented historical ties with Algerian services. Coincidence or causation? The question remains open; it can be closed neither by denial nor by assertion, and it will call for a judicial and diplomatic answer that history will have to settle.

The most concrete piece of evidence in the Algerian-Malian file arrives on June 16, 2026: a video published by Ndjoni Sango (Erick Ngaba, Bangui) shows FLA fighters parading with flags and vehicles in Bordj Badji Mokhtar, in far southern Algeria. Several observers call it the "first documented visual proof of the public, openly assumed presence" of the separatist movement on Algerian territory. The ostentatious nature of the display — flags unfurled, a convoy in the middle of a border town — rules out any theory of clandestine infiltration; this is a tolerated presence, or at least one not suppressed. As of publication, neither Algiers nor Bamako had officially reacted. The Ndjoni Sango article points to a diplomatic contrast that no one in Algiers can refute: Algeria structures its foreign policy around the Sahrawi people's right to self-determination — but is visibly hosting the FLA, whose declared ambition is to gain control of more sovereign Malian territory. The moral map of self-determination applies to the movements Algiers supports; it does not apply to states whose territorial sovereignty it implicitly contests. (Ndjoni Sango, June 16, 2026.)

Mauritania: the silent neighbor

To the west, 2,200 kilometers of border with Mali, a country three-quarters desert, 4.7 million inhabitants: Mauritania is the forgotten country of Sahel analysis. Outside the AES, on good terms with Paris, it nonetheless hosts, according to field sources, the rear bases of groups Bamako considers hostile. Bilal Chérif, head of the Azawad Liberation Front — the very one that will retake Kidal on April 25, 2026 — reportedly has a rear base on Mauritanian territory. In May 2025, he travels to France on a Schengen visa, even as his movement maintains relations with JNIM, and is said to have been received in Paris (Africa Intelligence). President Ghazouani, re-elected in 2024 in an election without genuine alternation, is given a state visit reception by Macron shortly before the April 25 attacks. Mali is at the heart of the discussions.

The Mauritanian "stability" praised by Paris has its blind spots: slavery, criminalized in 2007, remains a documented reality (Global Slavery Index 2023), and the 1989–1991 violence — mass expulsions of Black African populations stripped of their nationality — remains a trauma never mentioned in official statements. The resource geography illuminates the rest: the Grand Tortue Ahmeyim gas field, shared with Senegal, delivered its first LNG exports in 2024 — 2.4 million tonnes per year initially. A Mauritania beginning to monetize its

gas has no interest in rupture.

One specific actor operates from this Mauritanian territory: Mahmoud Dicko, former president of Mali's High Islamic Council, a figure with a very broad network, reportedly resides in Nouakchott according to Linda Larbaoui (Panafrican Media TV, June 2026) — and not in Algeria, as a circulating confusion suggested. From Nouakchott, according to Podassé, he leads the Coalition for the Azawad Force (CFR), an organization whose spokesman Étienne Fakaba Sissoko is based in France and whose ties to the FLA and JNIM were publicly claimed by the FLA's own spokesman in an interview broadcast on Panafrican Media TV (June 2026). The Mauritania-France-FLA triangle now has a name and a geography.

The United Arab Emirates: the documented destabilizer

There remains an actor few readers would expect in this picture, and one that European institutional research itself has come to name. In May 2026, the SWP — the German Institute for International and Security Affairs, which advises the federal government — publishes a note signed by Gerrit Kurtz, Wolfram Lacher, and Stephan Roll on "the destabilizing role of the United Arab Emirates in African conflicts." Its conclusion is unequivocal: "The United Arab Emirates has become one of the most aggressive external actors in African conflicts. Its role hampers conflict resolution efforts and worsens humanitarian crises as well as regional instability" (SWP Comment No. 19, May 2026).

Theater | Documented Emirati action | Consequence

- Sudan — Main military, logistical, and financial backer of Hemeti's RSF — 33.7 million people dependent on aid (UN); signs of genocide in El-Fasher (Oct. 2025)
|
- Ethiopia — RSF training camp in Benishangul-Gumuz; Colombian mercenaries training children — Documented war crimes
|
- Libya — 458 military cargo flights from Emirati airports to eastern Libya (Oct. 2024–end 2025), including 239 to Kufra — UN embargo violations; arming Haftar since 2014
|
- Chad — \$1.5 billion loan (June 2023) — Control of the North African logistics corridor
|
- EU — Lobbying: 4 days by Lana Nusseibeh in Brussels (Nov. 2025) — EP resolution on Sudan adopted without mentioning support for the RSF

The Sudan war thus fueled has produced the world's largest humanitarian crisis. A UN embargo is an international ban on delivering weapons to a conflict zone; 458 military cargo flights in fourteen months give the measure of what that ban is worth when the violator is rich and well-connected. The French-made Galix defense system has been found on Emirati armored vehicles in Sudan. French weapons are taking part in the Sudanese conflict — via the Emirates as intermediary. And the European silence is not a distraction: it is organized, as shown by the fate of amendments blocked in the European Parliament. For the AES, the lesson is immediate: the proxy war is not a French exclusivity; it is an industrialized method, of which neighboring Sudan offers the most fully developed version — and Chad, bordering Niger, is already one of its links.

Côte d'Ivoire: the Ivorian lock

The porous border

Côte d'Ivoire does not belong to the AES. Nor is it, officially, a hostile power. But its shared border with Burkina Faso is documented by Confederation authorities as one of the most active infiltration routes. Nestor Podassé, AES communications coordinator: "On the Côte d'Ivoire and Benin side, they are used as rear bases where terrorists are trained, and then they're sent to come attack Burkina, Niger, and Mali" (Panafrican Media TV, June 2026).

The figures come from direct testimony, not yet independently cross-checked: in the days following April 25, 2026, about 3,000 armed fighters reportedly tried to enter Burkina Faso from Ivorian territory — neutralized at the border. A training camp is reportedly active at Jacquenville, another at Odienné, near American military installations, according to the same sources. These elements are transcribed with their epistemic status as committed testimony.

What the 2002 rebellion left behind

To understand how Côte d'Ivoire became this corridor, one must go back to October 19, 2002. That day, the MPCCI rebels suffer their first major defeat: they fail to take Abidjan. FANCI pushes them back, the Forces Nouvelles retreat to the north — but occupy Bouaké, Korhogo, Katiola, Vavoua. A rebellion with no popular base, financed from outside, had just been transformed into a state within a state.

Diplomacy then takes over where weapons had failed. In January 2003, at Marcoussis — a Paris suburb — Pierre Mazeaud, president of France's Constitutional Council, imposes the framework for negotiations: no prior condemnation of the rebels. He even states, facing representatives of Côte d'Ivoire's elected government: "There are no rebels in Côte d'Ivoire." Mamadou Koulibaly, president of the Ivorian National Assembly, walks out: "You are not a moderator, you are a dictator. I have nothing more to do here." In his absence, Marcoussis

obtains what the rebellion had not obtained militarily: amendment of Article 35 of the Constitution, revision of the nationality code, integration of rebels into the government — without disarmament.

On January 25, 2003, at the Kleber conference in Paris, Villepin brandishes a seven-page note produced by French services to threaten Simone Gbagbo with referral to the International Criminal Tribunal over "death squads." The legal threat as a bargaining tool. Under this pressure, Gbagbo yields. Guillaume Soro, the rebellion's military chief, sets his conditions: the ministries of Defense and the Interior for his men. The rebellion was entering the government, armed.

On November 4, 2004, exasperated by the Forces Nouvelles' refusal to disarm despite the Accra III accords, the government launches Operation Dignity. On November 6, two Ivorian air force Sukhoi strike a French military camp in Bouaké: nine French soldiers killed. Without waiting for any investigation, France destroys the entire Ivorian air force on the Yamoussoukro airfield within hours. The declassified DGSE note of May 9, 2006, handed to judge Brigitte Raynaud, establishes that France deliberately let the Belarusian pilots arrested in Togo on November 16 go free. The Sukhoi's black box was never made public.

On the night of November 6 to 7, French attack helicopters fire on the civilian crowd gathered near the General de Gaulle bridge: 8 dead, 301 wounded. On November 9, at the Hôtel Ivoire, Colonel Guby Diby Point, present alongside Colonel Destremo, testifies:

"The crowd was not violent, it was not armed — no sticks, no stones. It just wasn't retreating. Colonel Destremo told me three times that he was going to give the order to fire. The fourth time, he didn't bother addressing me — he gave the order directly. My men were in contact with the crowd and we fired indiscriminately on the crowd and on my own men. I had a gendarme killed and one wounded by the French army."

Overall toll of the events from November 6 to 10, 2004: 62 dead, 1,306 wounded.

In the hotel rooms evacuated by French special forces, FANCI find crates of ammunition, a firing plan, and a military computer containing files on every Ivorian political figure — license plates of President Gbagbo, the First Lady's "power network," positions of the rebel command staff and weaponry. The French army had mapped Ivorian power from inside a hotel. Simultaneously, a column of fifty tanks moves toward the presidential residence in Cocody. General Poncé had told his men: "In 48 hours it's over. We won't talk about it again." Hundreds of patriots repel the tanks. Two hours after declaring on camera that "Force Licorne has absolutely no intention of overthrowing President Gbagbo," Poncé bombs the presidential palace to destroy Ivorian anti-aircraft defenses. He will later tell judges: "I am a soldier. I was obeying orders."

Laurent Gbagbo is acquitted by the ICC in 2019, of all charges. The acquittal is a judicial decision. It is also proof that the threat of The Hague brandished at Kleber by Villepin was a pressure tool, not a well-founded

accusation.

Soro: the armed link that fed the Sahel

Guillaume Soro's trajectory deserves particular attention — because it directly links the Ivorian crisis to Sahel insecurity.

Soro was 29 in 2002, with no money and no army. He had a capacity to mobilize northern Ivorian youth, which he converted into leverage for Alassane Ouattara. The deal: armed rebellion as a path to power, with the vice-presidency, succession, and reintegration at the highest level as rewards. He became prime minister, minister of defense, president of the National Assembly. Then, in 2019, when he wanted to return for the presidential election, his plane was turned back. He was sentenced in absentia to 20 years in prison for "handling embezzled funds" and "conspiracy against the state." He now lives in exile in Niger.

The bill has been presented. But the real bill — the one ordinary Ivorians paid — goes far beyond one man's personal betrayal. Analyst Hermann le Patriote puts it bluntly:

"You are responsible for the misfortune of the entire sub-region."

This is not rhetoric. The weapons that circulated in the 2002–2011 Ivorian rebellion joined those spilled out by the 2011 Libyan collapse. Together, they fed armed groups across the Sahel for fifteen years. The 100,000 dead of the Ivorian civil war have an extension in Mali, Burkina, Niger — in every burned village, in every ambushed military convoy. The Ivorian rebellion, steered from Paris, armed from Ouagadougou, literally manufactured the substrate of the security threat the AES fights today.

The information war: the Ivorian relay

This connection is not merely historical. It is operational in June 2026.

Following the attack on Niger's airport, the terrorists arrested began to talk. Their words reveal premeditated machinery. According to the testimony of one captive, a propaganda plan had been set up in advance: the owner of the number +2250707588787, identified as Yacouba Doumbia, an Ivorian journalist, was to receive the first images of the attack as soon as they were available to broadcast them immediately on his page. The +225 prefix is Côte d'Ivoire's country code. (Source: Moussa Sanou, relayed by Africa Geopolitis.)

The military attack and the communications operation were not sequential — they were simultaneous, planned together, financed together. The media relay is pre-positioned before the assault. A media professional with an audience is chosen as a vector, to give the propaganda an appearance of informational legitimacy. The line between journalism and belligerence dissolves.

Nestor Podassé explains why Burkinabé authorities decided to stop announcing these border neutraliza-

tions: "so as not to give the adversary media exposure." The response to the information war is also strategic silence about victories. What the Doumbia episode reveals is that Côte d'Ivoire is not just a logistical corridor — it is also a node in the narrative war against the AES.

The counter-fire: Gbagbo, Traoré, and the Ivorian majority

Faced with this unofficial hostility, Côte d'Ivoire presents an unexpected counter-actor: Laurent Gbagbo. The ordinary Congress of the African Peoples' Party of Côte d'Ivoire (PPACI), held in early 2026, adopted an official statement of support for the AES — the first from a structured political party outside the Confederation. Gbagbo had taken the floor to call on Africans to "support Mali and the AES against international terrorism."

Ibrahim Traoré himself publicly acknowledged that he had been manipulated into hating Gbagbo:

"We were made to believe he was bad. But today we see that those who said Gbagbo was bad are telling us that we are bad. So Gbagbo was in the right."

The practical importance of this stance is spelled out by Podassé: "Thanks to the advent of the AES and to Laurent Gbagbo, Ouattara was not able to use the Ivorian people against the AES. The majority of Ivorians who support Gbagbo agree with the AES's sovereignty."

This rapprochement does not change Abidjan's official policy — Ouattara remains in place, the border remains porous. But it measures something real: the human barrier that prevents Paris from using the Ivorian population as a lever for destabilizing the AES from the south. The same popular mechanism that stopped French tanks in front of the presidential residence in November 2004 today protects the AES from another encirclement.

Kenya: the permanent-base blueprint

William Ruto has turned Kenya into a showcase of Françafrique by hosting Macron's Africa Forward summit. He now intends to make it America's sanitation dump.

The Ruto administration has agreed to host on Kenyan soil American nationals exposed to the Ebola virus — from the DRC, Uganda, and South Sudan. The figure is public, listed on the official US State Department website: \$13.5 million. But who builds the quarantine site? American armies. Who treats the patients? American doctors. If Washington has the engineers, doctors, and funds needed, why not repatriate these nationals to their own country?

The answer is found in a pattern repeated three times in thirty years, in five identical phases:

Phase | Description | Concrete example

-
- 1 — Real crisis — moral and media justification — Ebola (Kenya); civil war (Somalia); Kony (Uganda); Typhoon Haiyan (Philippines)
|
 - 2 — Infrastructure built by the US military, "temporary" — Quarantine site at Laikipia; airstrips Uganda/DRC
|
 - 3 — American personnel on site, integrated into administrative networks — US Public Health Service doctors + US Army soldiers
|
 - 4 — Gradual normalization — funding, renewals, upgrades — \$13.5M Kenya; 200 equipped hectares in Djibouti
|
 - 5 — Assumed permanence — Camp Lemonnier (Djibouti, 2002): 3,500–5,000 personnel today

Somalia collapses in 1991. Operation Restore Hope arrives in 1992 — officially humanitarian. In 2002, Camp Lemonnier opens: ten years between a humanitarian mission and a permanent military command. Uganda in 2008 hosts American humanitarian teams in the north; in 2011, 100 military advisers arrive in already-equipped zones. Kony is never captured. The bases remain. The Philippines in November 2013: Typhoon Haiyan, Marines arrive with food and medicine. Five months later, a permanent military agreement is signed. The technique refines itself. The machinery accelerates.

Kenya's High Court saw what Ruto pretended not to see. It suspended the Ebola agreement, calling it "an imminent threat to life and public safety," on a petition by the Katiba Institute. The US State Department, officially notified of the Court's decision, publicly communicated its intention not to let the matter drop. A sovereign Kenyan court says no. Washington answers that it will keep pushing. That is called contempt for sovereignty.

The AES presidents understood before anyone else. The American base at Agadez has closed. That is what concrete sovereignty looks like — not a text, a decision.

The Central African Republic: the founding act

Barthélemy Boganda did not want to create the Central African Republic. He wanted to create the United States of Latin Africa — a federation joining Ubangi-Shari, the Belgian Congo, the French Congo, and Cameroon. A continental space founded on shared language, culture, and history. A project that would have made colonial borders, and the interests derived from them, obsolete.

On March 29, 1959, his plane explodes in flight. Boganda dies. The investigation names no culprit. The

United States of Latin Africa die with him. This is a precedent, not a coincidence. The CAR is born orphaned of its founder, and France will never let it go without resistance. An African leader who thinks at a continental scale is an existential threat to the system. He is eliminated before he can govern.

The Central African Republic: Bozizé, portrait of the standard putschist

François Bozizé is not an anomaly. He is the standard product of *Françafrique*: a military man promoted by Paris, overthrown when he becomes inconvenient, recycled as a destabilization instrument when he becomes useful again.

Year | Action | Identified sponsors

- 1982 — First coup attempt — *Françafrique* network, indirect support
|
- 2003 — Seizure of power (overthrow of Patassé) — Idriss Déby (Chad), external financing
|
- 2013 — Overthrown by Séléka — Central African coalition + regional dynamics
|
- 2020 — Coalition of Patriots for Change (CPC) — Paris base, regional backers

The CPC he leads in 2020 brings together figures who each scored between 3% and 4% in elections. Their combined score does not justify an armed coalition — it justifies their political insignificance. So they chose weapons instead. Touadéra, elected by universal suffrage, the first university professor to reach the presidency in the country's history, had chosen clemency: political prisoners freed, amnesties granted. The beneficiaries joined the CPC or organized the overthrow from Paris.

The Central African Republic: Paris, rear base of the rebellion

On November 1, 2022, a statement signed by a Central African rebel group is issued from French territory. Not from the bush, not from neighboring Chad — from Paris. *La Galaxie Nationale*, a Central African patriotic movement, immediately demands that Ambassador Groscurin be summoned to explain how French soil becomes the command post of a rebellion against a sovereign state with which France maintains official diplomatic relations. No explanation is provided.

The G-16 — a group of sixteen Central African figures in France — concentrates the most revealing profiles:

- Jean-François Akandji-Kombé: a jurist at the Sorbonne, former adviser to Meckassoua — the intellectual framework for the challenge.
- Rodrigue Mayté, alias Kerembesse: in 2012, he was burning the French flag in the streets of Bangui. In 2022, protected by France, he organizes from its territory.
- Karl Blague, Sydney Tchikaya, Ben Wilson Ngassan, Ludovic Lédo, Maître Arlette Sombo-Dibélé: co-signatories of the petition before the Central African Constitutional Court — to block a sovereign economic project, not to defend the Constitution.

Nouredine Adam crystallizes the architecture of the outside threat. Son of a Chadian imam, trained by Israeli special forces, he has been a bodyguard for an Abu Dhabi emir. The ICC has issued an international arrest warrant against him. In December 2025, he circulates in Paris under a false identity — not arrested, not reported, not deported. He benefits from cross-financing involving General Bourhan (Sudan) and Mahamat Déby (Chad). He is the architect of the northern component of the planned offensive against the CAR.

The Central African Republic: Raineteau, the honorable correspondent

Christophe Raineteau. Alias: Alpha. Alias: Martin. Official category: "honorable correspondant" — the DGSE's term for undeclared agents embedded in foreign civilian networks. Until 2013, he operates in a context where the French are Bangui's official allies. Then the Russians arrive. Raineteau switches sides: the French become targets. He begins spying on Central African forces on behalf of networks opposed to the Russian-Central African partnership.

On May 1, 2018, a bomb explodes in the Notre-Dame de Fatima church in Bangui. Toll: about 20 dead, including Father Albert Tounkoumalet Baba. Attorney General Eric Didier Tambo brings 10 counts against Raineteau and his accomplice Cousin for complicity in this attack.

On July 31, 2018, three Russian journalists are murdered in the CAR: Orkhan Dzhemal, Alexander Rastorguev, and Kirill Radchenko. They were investigating the Russian military presence. Raineteau is named the prime suspect by the Russian Investigative Committee. Moscow asks Paris to cooperate. Paris does not respond.

February 2019: Raineteau is arrested in Madagascar. Before Central African justice can initiate extradition proceedings, the French embassy extracts Raineteau and repatriates him to Paris. He is not tried. He is not charged. He lives in Nantes — shots were fired at his vehicle, four bullet holes in the bodywork of a Mercedes. He survived. November 2022: under the pseudonym CERA, he publicly broadcasts — from France — the following statement: *"Within a few months we will no longer have President Touadéra."* Still free. France protects a man accused of complicity in the massacre of worshippers in a church, suspected in the assassination

of three journalists, who publicly announces a coup against a sovereign head of state. This is politics, not legal powerlessness.

The Central African Republic: the Sangocoin, an attempted economic sovereignty

In 2022, the Touadéra government launches the Sangocoin — a national cryptocurrency backed by Central African natural resources, planning the issuance of 10,000 digital passports coupled with land rights and access to mineral resources. Goal: bypass the CFA franc, attract sovereign investment, build an economic base outside the Bretton Woods system.

On August 29, 2022, the Constitutional Court issues decision No. 008/CC/22, on a petition filed by G-16 members:

Constitutional article | Sangocoin provision | Ruling

- Art. 80 — Nationality granted to digital-passport holders — Unconstitutional
|
- Art. 80 — "e-resident" status with equivalent rights — Unconstitutional
|
- Art. 60 — Transfer of natural resource rights to private actors — Unconstitutional
|
- Art. 24 — Documentation only in English (not compliant with the official language) — Non-compliant

The sponsors of the petition — Akandji-Kombé, Blague, Tchikaya, and their allies — were not acting out of love for the Central African Constitution. They were acting to block an attempt to escape the colonial monetary system. The legal victory is real. So is the political agenda behind it.

The Central African Republic: peacekeepers and organized impunity

In 2015, in the refugee camps of Bangui where families had fled the civil war, peacekeepers — French soldiers of Operation Sangaris and other nationalities — sexually abuse children. A 14-year-old girl is raped, becomes pregnant, gives birth. UNICEF promises medical and psychological follow-up. The reality: a sack of rice, a bit of milk and sugar — worth about \$20 — delivered once. When a Swedish public television (SVT) investigation checks on the ground three years later, the children had received no ongoing assistance.

Peacekeepers account for 50% of the sexual abuse allegations reported each year within the UN system. The investigation is entrusted to the troop-contributing country — which judges its own soldiers. Result:

repatriation without prosecution. France had launched Sangaris in December 2013 with the official mandate to protect civilians. Its soldiers raped children in the camps that operation was supposed to secure.

The Central African Republic: Joseph Kony, the fugitive who may not have been hunted

There is a case in eastern Central Africa that, on its own, condenses the question this chapter keeps asking: who benefits from the insecurity supposedly being fought?

Joseph Kony, warlord of the Lord's Resistance Army (LRA), sowed terror in Uganda from the 1980s onward at the head of a rebellion with sectarian overtones — proclaimed objective: impose the Ten Commandments by force; real method: the forced enlistment of tens of thousands of child soldiers. Driven out of Uganda, he took refuge in eastern Central African Republic in 2006. An international manhunt was organized — the US military, the Ugandan army, an ICC warrant, a \$5 million bounty on his head. In 2017, the US military officially abandoned the chase. Central Africa's most wanted man was never captured. His trial continues today at The Hague — in absentia.

Unofficial sources, to be treated with the caution their uncorroborated nature demands, now place Kony in the Haute-Kotto prefecture — in northeastern CAR, near the Sudan and South Sudan borders, in the Samwanja area (renamed Wanjakoto), a week's walk from the nearest village. There, according to these same sources, he reportedly leads an almost pastoral existence: growing sorghum fields, meeting regularly with Fulani herders who are said to have given him several wives, surrounded by a handful of loyalists. Whether this picture is accurate in detail or embellished by legend, it raises a question neither Washington nor Kampala has ever had to answer publicly: with satellite intelligence and surveillance capabilities able to track a lone man across a desert, why does one of the world's most wanted fugitives remain untraceable for nearly two decades within a limited zone?

The best-documented answer points not to incompetence, but to interest. Haute-Kotto — precisely the region where Kony is said to have settled — holds manganese, gold, and diamonds, resources this chapter has already shown, in Bria, rarely benefit local populations once extracted. A manhunt that is officially active but never concluded, in a contested mining zone, offers a permanent justification for a foreign military presence — American, then, by capillary spread, that of regional partners — with no result ever demanded. This is exactly the mechanism documented elsewhere in this book regarding American bases: the crisis justifies the infrastructure, the infrastructure becomes permanent, and the stated objective — here, one man — never needs to be reached for the arrangement to endure.

The Central African Republic: the war that is coming

In March 2026, French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot visits Bangui. It fails on every point. Orano — formerly Areva — refuses to give up its operating permit for the uranium-bearing Bakouma site, abandoned for fifteen years but jealously kept to block any sovereign development. Central African Foreign Minister Sylvie Baipo Temon leaves Barrot stranded at the table. Zero agreement. Zero French concession.

The Russian military entity in the CAR is no longer homogeneous. Two blocs are clashing: the old Wagner guard with Dmitri Sytyi, historically established, and Africa Corps, the new post-Prigozhin structure with partly divergent allegiances. This fracture creates windows of opportunity that Touadéra's opponents seek to exploit. Three simultaneous fronts are being prepared:

Front | Main actor | Financing | Target

-
- North — Nouredine Adam (ICC warrant) — Bourhan + Mahamat Déby — Border destabilization
 - |
 - East — Aka-Gé group — Bozizé networks — Territorial incursions
 - |
 - Shadow — Rento (Colombian mercenaries via Hemedti) — UAE / Sudan RSF — Clandestine operations

Mahamat Déby plays three boards at once: relations with Macron, backing for Bourhan in Sudan, passive destabilization of the CAR. This triple pivot lets him monetize his position with every actor without ever committing irreversibly to any of them. Within Bangui itself, two names circulate among suspicions of an internal fifth column: S. Yalo and Pascal Bida Koyak Bélé.

The Central African Republic: the question of the SPEAR program

To the east, the Central African Republic adds a dimension Western media rarely cover: the American presence via the SPEAR program. On June 18, 2026, Ndjoni Sango publishes an article titled "CAR: the Dande Christian affair reignites questions about the SPEAR program and American responsibility." The affair concerns the arrest of an individual whose apprehension leads to the seizure of weapons, ammunition, and official insignia of Central African security forces — equipment whose presence in private hands raises questions about the traceability of the American program.

The Dande Christian affair fits a pattern already revealed by the 201 base at Agadez in Niger: American security assistance programs create local actors whose control sometimes escapes the donor's grip in the long run. The Central African response — a diversion of weapons linking an individual to the SPEAR program — is, for the AES, a lesson in anatomy: the United States is present in the east via Bangui, with the same governance fragilities as in Agadez.

A flight from the United States — with a stopover in Ghana — lands discreetly at Mpoko Airport in Bangui, around 10 p.m., a time when the airport is normally closed. On board: foreigners deported from the United States, none of them Central African — at least three Iranian, Syrian, and Afghan nationals identified among them, having learned their final destination only upon arrival. The IOM handles reception in exchange for \$25 million paid by Washington; the agreement reportedly provides for the arrival of several hundred migrants in the Central African Republic. Neither the Central African government nor the IOM in the CAR responded to interview requests (Mariam Cony, Bangui, radio correspondent, June 2026).

The third register is judicial and media-based. On November 3, 2025, the Pan-African Movement for a Free Africa (MPAL) holds a press conference in Bangui to denounce the activities of the self-proclaimed "12 apostles" group — a digital army based in France, led by Kerembesse, operating against the Central African government. The Talitha Koum Centrafrique movement, in its response documented by Ndjoni Sango, calls these "12 apostles" the "puppets of Macron and Le Drian" — Jean-Yves Le Drian being foreign minister at the time. This statement is transcribed with that status; but the fact that it explicitly names a sitting French minister as sponsor of the operation is a fact that French diplomacy has never officially disputed.

The financing chain is documented by an internal source. In a video released in March 2025, Lili Champagne — a figure of the Central African opposition in France, a declared member of the "12 apostles" — admits to having received money from opposition figures (Anicet-Georges Dologuélé, Karim Meckassoua, Martin Ziguélé) to organize demonstrations against Central African authorities from France. This pattern is structurally identical to what the AES documents: opposition financed from Paris, operating against the sovereign state it seeks to destabilize.

The most sophisticated mechanism is the diversion of humanitarian status as intelligence cover. Joseph Figueira, an employee of Family Health International 360 (FHI 360), an American NGO active in several African countries under a health mandate, is arrested by FACA: the seizures include several passports, phone conversations establishing plans to destabilize the CAR and assassinate President Touadéra, as well as evidence of presence in rebel training camps. The European Union demands his release and threatens sanctions. Touadéra refuses: the evidence exists, Central African justice has jurisdiction. The EU's invocation of Figueira's "health condition" recalls the Zoe's Ark affair (Chad, October 2007) — 103 children attempted to be exported to France under humanitarian cover, and Sarkozy's statement: "I will go get them, whatever they have done." Identical language to Macron's on Bazoum.

On March 26, 2024, in the Bakongo, Sciotte, and Dékongo neighborhoods of Bangui's 2nd arrondissement, the Committee for the Initiative to Control American Actions in the Central African Republic (CICUSAC), chaired by Socrate Gutenberg Taramboye, mobilizes more than a hundred people. This same Taramboye will speak at the MPAL in November 2025. The continuity of this actor reveals a coherent, sustained civic mobilization that predates the Sahel ruptures.

The Central African Republic documents, in real time and with surgical precision, the accumulated registers of neocolonial interference: the founding political assassination (Boganda 1959 — eliminating a continental leader before he could govern); institutionalized mercenarism (Bozizé 2003/2020 — the recycled military pawn with Chadian backing); state espionage (Raineteau — the honorable correspondent protected by Paris even after serious criminal accusations); economic warfare (Orano/Bakouma kept idle without exploitation, Sangocoin blocked by the Constitutional Court); the diplomatic rear base (G-16 in Paris — legally sheltering the political sponsors of armed rebellion); orphaned weapons (SPEAR/Dande Christian); territory for sale (IOM/American migrants, \$25 million); a digital army financed from Paris (Kerembesse's "12 apostles"); an NGO as intelligence cover (Figueira/FHI 360). And on the other side: CICUSAC, MPAL, Talitha Koum — three organized citizen movements that say, neighborhood by neighborhood, what the AES says at the regional level. The manual is the same; only the instruments change.

Should a Central African candidacy be formalized, the CAR would become the first non-founding state to join the Confederation. Several MPAL speakers explicitly called for this during the November 2025 debate.

This, then, is the environment in which the alliance must survive: a Chad under double tutelage, an Algeria that shoots at its drones, a Mauritania that hosts its enemies while monetizing its gas, an Emirates that industrializes destabilization, a Côte d'Ivoire officially neutral whose border serves as an infiltration corridor and where a journalist coordinated terrorist propaganda from Abidjan, a Kenya sold off square centimeter by square centimeter by its own president, and to the east a Central African Republic under five documented registers of interference — offset by organized popular resistance and an Ivorian public opinion that Gbagbo's popularity keeps outside the enemy's apparatus.

The African Union and ECOWAS: institutions under constraint

ECOWAS missed its August 6, 2023 ultimatum. It also missed its credibility. The reasons for this failure deserve analysis, not just observation.

ECOWAS's charter, first of all: it does not provide for military intervention to reinstate an overthrown president. The article invoked in July 2023 does not authorize the use of force in this precise case. And Article 53-1 of the UN Charter requires prior authorization from the Security Council for any regional coercive action — authorization never requested, never granted.

ECOWAS is also an organization partly financed by outside partners with their own interests in the region. When its chiefs of staff plan an intervention they cannot carry out, they expose the gap between their declared mandate and their real means — and their dependence on those willing to fund them.

The African Union is in no better position. Its 2024 budget totals \$605 million — of which \$370 million (61%) is financed by international partners, mainly the European Union and the United States. An organization

more than half of whose budget comes from outside powers cannot claim total independence of judgment vis-à-vis those powers.

The security record confirms this diagnosis. Since 2002, 23 successful coups on the continent — about one per year — despite Article 4 of the Constitutive Act, which explicitly condemns them. And when the mechanism “works” — Gabon’s case is telling — it does not work consistently: General Oligui Nguema, after the coup, organizes a referendum, runs for president, wins, and rejoins the AU. What was illegal at the outset became legal through an accumulation of faits accomplis.

The contrast with the AES’s treatment is instructive. Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger were suspended and sanctioned with markedly greater severity than that applied to Gabon or Chad. The variable is not the nature of the change in government — it is the foreign policy adopted by the new authorities. Those who change government and remain in Paris’s orbit are reintegrated; those who change government and break with Paris are sanctioned. The rule is transparent. It has just never been written into any official text.

The AU’s Agenda 2063 — 14 flagship projects including a pan-African high-speed rail network, an African space program, an African museum — is unknown to most Africans. These projects exist in official documents. They do not exist in daily life.

What the AES seeks to build — even with all its own contradictions — is precisely what the AU has failed to be: a structure that speaks to populations, that protects them, and that cannot be hijacked by outside interests.

Sanctions against African voices

The strangulation strategy does not target only states — it also targets the individuals who give them a voice. The Nathalie Yamb case, detailed in Chapter 14 — the first Swiss citizen sanctioned by the EU in June 2025 for “working to expel France and the West from Africa” — comes with measures Chapter 14 did not cover: a bank transfer seized in transit, without judicial process; and the legal impossibility of escaping the trap, because even if she wins an appeal before the European Court of Justice, the grounds can be amended afterward to keep the sanction in place on other bases. The sanctions are administrative, not judicial: no adversarial procedure, no court, no possible defense before they are handed down.

She is not alone. The Afrique Media and Raed Media channels, along with their founders, appear on the same list. Yamb’s TikTok account has been censored across the EU’s twenty-seven countries — even outside the European Council’s official sanctions, by the platform’s own discretionary decision. The Europe that accuses Burkina Faso of censoring TV5 Monde itself censors African media that criticize it. This double standard is not an inconsistency — it is Chapter 14’s logic applied at the individual scale: control the narrative by eliminating the voices that contest it.

What the regional environment reveals

Taken as a whole, this picture draws one precise thing: the AES does not face enemies, it faces a system. A system with variable geometry — here an army, there an NGO, there again a pre-positioned journalist or a deportee agreement — but a system coherent in its objective: making the Sahelian sovereignty experiment fail before it becomes a model.

The AES's response to this hostile environment is itself systemic. Close the Agadez base. Expel ambassadors. Build a currency. Build a joint army. Raise up conscious populations rather than dependent ones. And count, in hostile neighborhoods, on the peoples — Gbagbo's Ivorians, the patriots of Bangui, the judges of Nairobi — who resist from within the apparatus.

Geopolitics is rarely a war between states. It is almost always a war between sold-out ruling classes and peoples who refuse to be sold.

PART V — THE PAN-AFRICAN AWAKENING

Up to now, this book has told a war: of weapons, currencies, networks, and screens. The part that opens now tells something else — a lineage. Because the Alliance of Sahel States was not born in 2023 in a Bamako conference room. It was born in 1957 on an Accra polo field, in 1961 on a Katanga runway, in 1962 in a Malian banknote printing house, in 1987 in the courtyard of Ouagadougou's Maison du Peuple. A first wave of African leaders attempted unity, sovereign currency, a joint army. Almost all of them paid for it with power or with their lives. The chapters that follow trace this thread: Nkrumah, Lumumba, Keïta; then Sankara; then the generation that carries their portraits on their phones; and finally the AES itself, examined for what it claims to be — pan-Africanism's full-scale laboratory.

CAR: rebellion, the weapon of underdevelopment

*"The Central African quickly forgets his past — which is why he always falls into the same folly." —
Diaspora Sango*

They have not yet reached Bangui. They loot along the way, they rape, they ravage what years have built. Imagine them arriving in the capital: they would do worse. They always do. And yet, voices continue to present armed insurrection as a path to change in the Central African Republic. The manufacturing, financing, and direction of these groups from outside — from Paris, from N'Djamena, from Abu Dhabi — has been established over the preceding chapters. But a complementary truth must be told: even when manufactured from outside, rebellion finds relays on the inside. And it is this inside that must be examined.

Six coups, zero development

Since 1966, the Central African Republic has suffered six coups. Each was presented, at the moment it occurred, as the necessary break, the indispensable correction, the answer to the previous regime's chaos. Each produced the same result: schools destroyed or never built, no roads between Bangui and Birao, Vakaga, Obo, hospitals without medicine, generations of youth without a future, women's dignity sacrificed in conflicts, mothers' tears over their sons' bodies.

The mechanics are known. Armed groups — made up of foreign mercenaries and domestic recruits — form on the margins, advance while looting, raping, destroying. No one is spared: neither government supporters, nor its opponents, nor civilians who never took a side. Rebellion has no governing ideology. It has an economy of predation.

What is true for the CAR is true for the whole Sahel: none of the armed groups that have sown desolation since 2012 has built a school, paved a road, opened a health center in the territories it controlled. Violence is a tool of extraction, not development — for the benefit of those who finance it from outside, and those who live off it inside.

Manufactured rebellion, inside complicity

The Coalition of Patriots for Change that François Bozizé leads in 2020 is commanded from Paris. The statements of Central African rebel groups are broadcast from French territory. The G-16, a group of Central African figures based in France, provides the intellectual legitimacy for destabilization. Nouredine Adam moves around Paris under a false identity, unbothered.

But rebellion does not hold without inside relays. Central African elites have chosen destabilization over republican opposition. This choice has a name: the preference for disorder that allows the seizure of power by force, over political competition, which demands work, ideas, and a presence on the ground.

The Central African people have paid for this preference for sixty years.

What a dignified opposition requires

The appeal is direct and without hatred, addressed to figures of the Central African political opposition, including Martin Ziguélé, president of the MLPC. It poses six questions the people have the right to ask their representatives:

Where were your teams, your warnings, and your concrete plans before blood flowed in Am-Dafock? An after-the-fact statement, made from a bedroom in front of a camera, is not opposition — it is buzz. Have you publicly condemned, without reservation and without calculation, all the armed groups responsible for the violence — and do you reject any form of moral or political cover for their structures? The Nation needs

clarity, not ambiguity. What is your operational plan, costed and dated, for the border localities — FACA, roads, schools, the return of the displaced? The people no longer expect diagnoses. They expect solutions.

These questions are the minimum conditions for a credible opposition in a country at war. An opposition that produces no annual counter-budget, that has no technical cadres ready to govern, that is not present in Berberati, Kouango, Ndélé, Birao, Bambari, Paoua, Mbaïki — in the hinterland where the victims live — is competition for power with no project for the people, not an opposition.

The republican pact or starting over

The CAR will only break the 1966–2026 cycle through concrete, irreversible acts. The citizen voices carrying this project have spelled it out precisely:

A Republican Pact Against Recidivism that criminalizes any seizure of power by force and permanently bans its perpetrators. Republican FACA, well paid, equipped, deployed at the borders to guarantee full control of the territory. A fast Special Justice for war crimes and violence against women. A national "School Standing" Plan: 5,000 classrooms and canteens to get every child back in school. Priority roads Bangui-Birao-Vakaga-Obo. Local processing of mineral and forest resources, with 30% of revenue returned to municipalities. Massive electrification via Boali III and solar power. Total transparency in political financing. A duty of memory taught in schools so that forgetting no longer becomes complicity.

This program describes what a state does when it decides to govern rather than merely hang on. And what the French presence prevented for sixty years — by maintaining monetary dependencies, financing rebellions, protecting predators like Bozizé and Raineteau, blocking the exploitation of the Bakouma uranium site so that none but Paris could profit from it.

The generation that refuses to start over

There is one sentence that sums it all up: "The Central African people have cried too much since 1966 to accept words without action."

This is a demand, not anger — that of a generation that grew up amid the ruins of previous promises and refuses to pass those ruins on to its children. This generation exists. It is organizing. CICUSAC in Bangui, MPAL in November 2025, Talitha Koum — three citizen movements that say, neighborhood by neighborhood, what the AES says at the regional level.

The CAR is not condemned to the cycle. It has identified its mechanisms with surgical precision: the founding assassination of Boganda, rebellion instrumentalized from outside, the inside complicity of elites who prefer disorder to work, the organized impunity of the perpetrators, the systematic erasure of memory.

Naming all this is not enough. But it is the beginning. One does not break a cycle one refuses to look in

the face.

CAR: hangover for the prophets of doom

"History is merciless. It always distinguishes those who defended the Republic from those who bet on its collapse." — Théophile EKA2, July 6, 2026

This Monday, July 6, 2026, many woke up with a hangover they could well have done without.

For weeks, they had been announcing the rout of the Central African army as a certainty. They predicted the armed groups' advance to the gates of Bangui, the overthrow of institutions, rapes, massacres, chaos. Worse still: some seemed to be awaiting these tragedies with barely concealed impatience. They were not predicting the collapse — they were hoping for it.

The camp of narratives

While soldiers fought to defend the Republic and families lived in anguish, these voices had already chosen their side in the battle of narratives. Every rumor was eagerly repeated. Every armed-group statement was broadcast as undisputed truth. Every setback of the defense and security forces became, in their telling, the prelude to the state's collapse.

They celebrated defeat before it even existed. They popped the champagne before the fighting was over. They were already dancing on what they imagined to be the Republic's ruins.

Taking a position for a state's defeat before it happens is complicity — not analysis.

The masks fall

The pseudo-journalists abandoned any pretense of neutrality. The self-styled analysts revealed themselves to be mere activists. Certain pens preferred to serve weapons rather than the truth. By repeatedly confusing information, propaganda, and activism, they lost what founds the credibility of public speech: intellectual honesty.

The G-16, the statements broadcast from Paris, the diaspora cadres who provided the intellectual legitimacy for destabilization — these roles have been documented. The phenomenon described here is its media-side counterpart: the information war waged from studios, social media accounts, and press columns, in service of a scripted rout that never happened.

Because the Republic is still standing.

What history retains

The prophets of doom have soured. Their certainties shattered against reality. The exile they chose, or resigned themselves to, may well last longer than they hoped. Time passes, FACA advances, and history keeps writing itself without them.

As for justice — it never chases after emotion. It moves slowly, sometimes so slowly that some believe it absent. Wrong. Justice is patient. It watches. It gathers. It waits for its moment. Then, when it strikes, it does so in the name of the law — not of anger, not of passion.

History always distinguishes those who defended the Republic from those who bet on its collapse. The former reap honor. The latter will have to bear the weight of their words, their writings, and their choices.

The hangover is sometimes the price paid for confusing one's hopes with reality.

CAR: what a French soldier said about Bria

"The population is joyful, smiling, dancing, singing. We are not well received." — French soldier, testimony on his deployment in the Central African Republic

There was no need to look for an official report, a diplomatic cable, or an investigative report. The most revealing testimony on the French military presence in the Central African Republic came from a soldier himself. Two sentences, placed one after the other, with an obliviousness that says it all: *"The population is joyful, smiling, dancing, singing. We are not well received."*

A people who smile. And who do not welcome. The contradiction is not in the Central African people — it is in the nature of the French presence.

Bria the Brilliant

This soldier arrived in Bangui, then was deployed to the east of the country, in Bria. Nicknamed *Bria the Brilliant* — because of the diamonds. The precision does not escape him: he notes it himself. It is no accident that the city carries this nickname. The Haute-Kotto region, of which Bria is the capital, is one of the richest diamond areas in the Central African Republic. It is also one of the most contested, one of the most violent, one where armed groups have succeeded one another for decades — each seeking to control access to the mines.

French soldiers are deployed to Bria. Their official mission: "prevent interference by armed troops," "show a presence," "accompany local authorities." In plain terms: protect the established order in a town whose primary wealth is extractive. The question that naturally follows — for whose benefit is this order maintained?

— is not asked in the testimony. It has been asked in this book since the first chapter.

What the soldier saw

The testimony does not lie about the violence. The CAR, he says, "is not fun." Soldiers told him stories from there — mass graves, fighting of a brutality comparable to ISIS, a violence rarely experienced elsewhere. He himself draws the comparison with the Sahel: "In the Sahel, for example, it's not the same thing at all."

This hierarchy of violence — the CAR above the Sahel — says something important about the state of the country after decades of predation, instrumentalized coups, and proxy conflicts. Since 1966, every Central African insurgency has been manufactured or sustained from outside. The brutality this soldier describes is not a cultural trait — it is the result of organized, methodical, financed destabilization.

During the rainy season, Bria is transformed. The immense trees form canopies. Elephants pass by. African nature reclaims its own. "You feel disoriented, it's virgin Africa." The country's beauty coexists with the horror of conflict — and the foreign presence in between the two.

"We are not well received"

This sentence deserves attention. It is said without bitterness, without questioning, as a fact. The soldier does not seek to understand why. He observes.

The Central African people have a memory. They know who supported Bokassa, who protected Bozizé, who armed the groups that ravaged Bria and Bangui and Ndélé. They know that the French presence in the CAR has not produced security — it has produced stability for extractors and instability for residents. They smile, they dance, they sing — because that is their dignity, because life goes on even under occupation. But they do not welcome well those who are there not for them, but to maintain an order that does not protect them.

Lucidity is not ingratitude.

Hard conditions, unclear mission

The soldier describes difficult deployment conditions — no combat, but a truck stuck in a swamp for eight hours, survival rations, constant improvisation. An adventure, he says. This lightness in the telling contrasts with the gravity of what he describes elsewhere: mass graves, extreme violence, a country at war.

It is the portrait of a mission without doctrine: there to "show a presence," to accompany local authorities whose real legitimacy is uncertain, in a town whose wealth is disputed by armed groups no one really controls. Serval, then Sangaris, then MINUSCA — fifteen years of international presence in the CAR, and Bria is still Bria: a contested mining town, a population that does not warmly welcome foreign soldiers, a conflict that perpetuates itself.

The soldiers did their job — Serval, then Sangaris, then MINUSCA. Bria remains Bria: contested, poor, without peace. It is the work itself that must be questioned.

The Sahelian periphery: Chad, Mauritania, Senegal, Guinea, and the end of the G5

"The G5 Sahel was a shell. When Mali, Burkina, and Niger left it, only the shell remained."

The AES — Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger — has drawn geopolitical attention since 2020. But the Sahel is larger than these three countries. Around them, other states live out their own relationship to sovereignty, to France, to security, and to development. This panorama is not uniform — it reads like a map of the possible and the impossible in the region.

Chad: the dynastic succession

Chad has been governed by the Déby family since 1990. Idriss Déby Itno dies on April 20, 2021 — officially at the front, the day after his re-election, during fighting against the FACT rebellion in the north of the country. His son Mahamat Idriss Déby succeeds him immediately, at the head of a Transitional Military Council.

France is there. Emmanuel Macron attends Idriss Déby's funeral in N'Djamena and publicly backs the dynastic transition. Chad's Constitution is violated — hereditary succession of power is explicitly prohibited under it. The international community rubber-stamps it without blinking. An inclusive national dialogue in 2022 extends the transition. A presidential election in May 2024 returns Mahamat Déby with 61% of the vote in an election boycotted by part of the opposition.

Chad is the country that hosted Operation Barkhane's headquarters. Its army — the FAT — is considered one of the most operational in the region; it intervened in Mali in 2013 and against Boko Haram in the Lake Chad basin. Oil accounts for 60% of state revenue but production is declining and the rent has mainly benefited the Déby family and the Zaghawa clan's networks.

Chad is the perfect inverse of the AES: a state whose dynastic succession is blessed by Paris, whose army serves French security interests, whose resources remain under the control of traditional Françafrique networks. It is deeply weakened — rebellions in the north (Tibesti), in the east (Darfur connection), tensions in the south — but stable on the surface because Paris wants it stable.

Mauritania: slavery as a contemporary reality

Mauritania has experienced several coups (2005, 2008) but has enjoyed relative stability since 2019

under Mohamed Ould Ghazouani, re-elected in 2024. His foreign policy is pragmatic — good relations with France, but a relatively independent positioning.

What Mauritania hides behind this apparent stability has been documented by NGOs for decades: slavery is a contemporary reality there. Officially abolished in 1981 and criminalized in 2007, it remains practiced. The Haratines — former Black slaves who were Arabized — constitute a socioeconomic underclass within Arab-Berber society itself. Anti-Slavery International and the IRA (Initiative for the Resurgence of the Abolitionist Movement) document regular cases. Mauritania is regularly cited as having one of the highest rates of contemporary slavery in the world.

The fault line between Moors (Arabic- and Berber-speaking) and Black African populations of the Senegal River valley (Wolof, Toucouleur, Soninké, Fulani) remains an open wound since the interethnic violence of 1989–1991. Tens of thousands of Black Mauritians had been expelled to Senegal and Mali.

The gas stakes are changing the equation: the Grand Tortue Ahmeyim (GTA) field, shared with Senegal, began its first LNG exports in 2024. This gas is going to shift economic balances — and probably outside appetites.

Senegal: rupture by the ballot

Senegal was presented as the model of West African democratic stability. In 2023–2024, the model cracked — and reinvented itself.

Ousmane Sonko, mayor of Ziguinchor and leader of the pan-Africanist opposition, is sentenced in May 2023 to two years in prison for “corrupting youth.” Riots break out, killing several dozen. President Macky Sall attempts in February 2024 to postpone the scheduled presidential election — the Constitutional Council overturns this postponement. The election is held in March 2024.

Bassirou Diomaye Faye, PASTEF candidate (Sonko’s party), is elected with 54% in the first round. He was in prison ten days before the vote. Sonko is appointed Prime Minister. It is the first pan-Africanist alternation carried by universal suffrage in the region in a long time.

Faye and Sonko raise the prospect of revising oil and gas contracts — Senegalese gas is starting to flow —, reviewing defense agreements with France, and adopting a more independent stance. Faye and Sonko are not building the AES. They may be tracing a different path toward the same goals: sovereignty through institutions rather than military rupture.

Guinea: the Doumbouya ambiguity

In September 2021, Colonel Mamadi Doumbouya overthrows Alpha Condé, an aging president whose third term had triggered a deadly crackdown. Doumbouya commanded the special forces unit — trained by

France. The irony is complete: Paris trained the man who overthrew its client.

Doumbouya was well received initially. His regime drifts toward authoritarianism with no clear transition timetable. His real position on African sovereignty remains ambiguous — some pan-Africanist analysts present him as more independent than appearances suggest; others see an opportunist with no doctrine. Guinea has considerable resources — bauxite, gold, diamonds, iron — and has not joined the AES.

The death of the G5 Sahel

The G5 Sahel was created in 2014 to coordinate the security action and development of Mauritania, Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, and Chad. Its Joint Force, created in 2017, was meant to reach 5,000 troops. It never operated at full capacity, was never properly funded — the European Union and France kept promising, delivering partially, imposing conditions.

Mali's withdrawal in 2022, then Burkina Faso's and Niger's in 2023, left the G5 Sahel in a residual state: Mauritania and Chad alone. It is no longer a G5 — it is a G2 with no regional purpose. The AES has de facto replaced the G5 Sahel as the security cooperation framework for the three transition countries.

This dissolution says something important: the G5 Sahel was a framework designed by and for French interests in the region. When the countries that refused tutelage left it, not much remained. Authentic African security cooperation — the kind built among sovereign peers — takes a different form now. It is called the Confederation of Sahel States.

Sources: Political data on Chad, Mauritania, Senegal, and Guinea (2021–2025); Anti-Slavery International and IRA on contemporary slavery in Mauritania; 1989–1991 Mauritania-Senegal events; Senegal presidential election results, March 2024; Grand Tortue Ahmeyim field, first LNG exports 2024; Mali's withdrawal (2022), Burkina Faso's and Niger's (2023) from the G5 Sahel; ACLED data on Chadian conflicts 2021–2025.

Sources: Testimony of a French soldier who served in the Central African Republic, deployment in Bria (Haute-Kotto); Chapters 21 and 83 of this book (CAR, Bozizé, instrumentalized rebellion, mineral resources); ACLED data on the Bria conflicts 2013–2026; UN Panel of Experts report on the CAR, 2022.

Sources: Théophile EKA2, op-ed "Hangover!," Bangui, July 6, 2026; Chapters 21 and 83 of this book (G-16, instrumentalized rebellion, elite complicity); Chapter 14 (battle of information).

Sources: Diaspora Sango, op-ed on the Central African rebellion; citizen appeal text addressed to Martin Ziguélé, MLPC, Bangui, July 7, 2026; Chapter 21 of this book (Boganda, Bozizé, Raineteau, Sangocoin, G-16, CICUSAC, MPAL); Talitha Koum Centrafrique, February 11, 2022; MPAL, press conference, Bangui, November 3, 2025; ACLED data 2014–2026.

Sources: Nathalie Yamb, April 2025; Ndjoni Sango (Erick Ngaba), June 16 and 18, 2026; SWP Comment No. 19 report, Gerrit Kurtz / Wolfram Lacher / Stephan Roll, May 2026; Wikileaks, Clinton-Blumenthal

emails January 18, 2013; Panafrican Media TV / Nestor Podassé, June 2026; Linda Larbaoui, Panafrican Media TV, June 2026; Africa Intelligence, May 2025; MPAL press conference, Bangui, November 3, 2025; Talitha Koum Centrafrique, February 11, 2022; Lili Champagne, video March 2025; CICUSAC, Bangui, March 26, 2024; Mariam Cony, Bangui radio correspondent, June 2026; Katiba Institute, Kenya High Court; US State Department, official website; Moussa Sanou / Africa Geopolitis, June 2026; Pierre Mazeaud, Marcoussis, January 2003; Colonel Guby Diby Point, testimony; declassified DGSE note, May 9, 2006; ICC, Gbagbo acquittal, 2019; Hermann le Patriote, YouTube livestream, December 23, 2024.

Sources: International Criminal Court, arrest warrant against Joseph Kony, 2005, ongoing proceedings; withdrawal of the US military manhunt for Joseph Kony, 2017; unofficial sources on Kony's location in Haute-Kotto, CAR, to be corroborated; Chapter 21 of this book (mineral resources of Haute-Kotto, Bria).

PART V

THE PAN-AFRICAN AWAKENING

CHAPTER 22 — NKRUMAH, LUMUMBA, KEÏTA: THE FIRST WAVE

Accra, night of March 5 to 6, 1957. On the capital's old polo field, tens of thousands of people wait in the humidity. At midnight, the Union Jack comes down. A forty-seven-year-old man climbs to the podium, in tears — a former political prisoner turned Prime Minister. Kwame Nkrumah proclaims Ghana's independence, the first sub-Saharan African colony to break free of the British Empire. And he adds at once, before the crowd, that this independence will mean nothing until the entire African continent is free.

This sentence is a program. It is also, in retrospect, a political death sentence. This chapter holds to one simple idea: what the AES has been building since 2023 — the union of several states, a sovereign currency, a joint army — a first wave of African leaders attempted between 1957 and 1968. And almost all of them paid for it with their power or their lives.

Accra, capital of Africa

Nkrumah wastes no time. As early as 1958, he makes Accra the continent's political capital: the Conference of Independent African States in April, the All-African Peoples' Conference in December. It is there, in December 1958, that a thirty-three-year-old Congolese man, a postal clerk turned tribune, meets Nkrumah and leaves transformed: Patrice Lumumba.

That same year, Sékou Touré's Guinea votes no in the Gaullist referendum — preferring, in his famous phrase, poverty in freedom (as seen in Chapter 5). Paris withdraws, taking even the light bulbs with it. Nkrumah, for his part, extends a hand: in November 1958, Ghana and Guinea proclaim their union, a claimed embryo of the United States of Africa. In 1961, Modibo Keïta's Mali joins them: the Ghana-Guinea-Mali Union becomes the Union of African States. Three countries, three different colonial languages as inheritance, one single project. Sixty-two years before the Liptako-Gourma Charter, three African states had already signed a tripartite union.

In May 1963, in Addis Ababa, at the founding of the Organization of African Unity, Nkrumah argues for going further: a continental government, a common currency, a unified African military high command. The assembled heads of state choose the minimal option — an organization for cooperation among sovereign states, not a federation. Nkrumah leaves defeated. On February 24, 1966, while he is en route to Hanoi, the Ghanaian army and police overthrow him with, as is now widely documented, the benevolence of Western services. He will never see Ghana again. He dies in exile in 1972, a guest of Sékou Touré's Guinea.

Boganda: the name as a federal program

This gallery is missing a Central African face, and it is a veteran of Central African political life, Fidèle Gouandjika, who recalled its memory in a long account in Sango about the founding of his country. This face is Barthélemy Boganda's. A Catholic priest turned tribune, founder of the Movement for the Social Evolution of Black Africa (MESAN) and first president of the Grand Council of French Equatorial Africa, Boganda carries, in the late 1950s, the same dream as Nkrumah at the other end of the continent: not juxtaposed micro-states, but a federation. His formula is the "United States of Latin Africa" — the union of the AEF's four territories (Chad, Ubangi-Shari, Middle Congo, Gabon), eventually expanded to the continent's other Latin colonies. Against the balkanization planned in Paris, he sets up a single bloc large enough to carry weight.

This ambition is inscribed even in a name. When Boganda proclaims, on December 1, 1958, the "Central African Republic," he does not merely rename Ubangi-Shari: he deliberately chooses a federation's name — "Centrafrique" was meant to designate the core of a future regional bloc, not the boundaries of a single territory. The name was a program. It was never realized. On March 29, 1959, a few months before independence, Boganda's plane breaks apart in flight near Boukpayanga, on the way to Bangui. Suspicious traces were reportedly found in the wreckage; the investigation, conducted under French authority, was never conclusively settled, and suspicion of an attack has never been lifted — in the Central African Republic, this is a widely shared conviction that nothing official has confirmed or denied. What is certain is the result: without Boganda, the equatorial federal project dies out; in 1960, the four territories reach independence separately, exactly as Paris wished. The balkanization the AES is working today to undo, one man had tried to prevent before it even took hold. He did not have the time.

January 17, 1961

The Belgian Congo gains independence on June 30, 1960. The country then counts a handful of university graduates for millions of inhabitants — the numerical legacy of Belgian plunder, detailed in Chapter 9. Patrice Lumumba, elected Prime Minister, commits the unforgivable crime: he says publicly, on independence day itself, before King Baudouin, that colonization was a humiliation and not a civilizing work. And he intends for Katanga's mineral wealth to serve Congolese people.

What follows takes six months. Katanga's secession, backed by Belgian mining interests. His removal in September 1960. Arrest. On January 17, 1961, Lumumba is transferred to Katanga with two companions, Maurice Mpolo and Joseph Okito. They are tortured, shot that same evening, their bodies dissolved in acid. Lumumba was thirty-five years old and had remained in power for less than three months. Forty years later, in 2001, a Belgian parliamentary commission of inquiry would acknowledge Belgium's moral responsibility for the assassination; in 2022, the Belgian state would return to the family the only preserved relic — a tooth.

The message sent to the continent was crystal clear: an elected leader who claims his country's resources

for its people can be eliminated within six months, and it will take forty years for anyone to apologize.

Modibo Keïta, the Malian franc, and the FLN's dagger

Bamako, September 22, 1960: Mali becomes independent under the presidency of Modibo Keïta, teacher, socialist, pan-Africanist. Less than two years later, on July 1, 1962, he takes the step almost no francophone leader would dare after him: he leaves the franc zone and creates the Malian franc, printed sovereignly. A state that leaves the franc zone decides on its own currency, its reserves, and its credit, instead of depositing its reserves in Paris and letting another country guarantee — and therefore oversee — its monetary policy. The price is immediate: pressure, commercial suffocation, humiliating negotiations to partially rejoin the franc zone in 1967, at the cost of a fifty-percent devaluation.

Modibo Keïta's Mali was nonetheless no marginal actor. During the Algerian war, it had served as a rear base for the FLN fighting colonial France. As a sign of gratitude, an Algerian delegation had come to Bamako to present Modibo Keïta with a flag and a dagger (Nathalie Yamb — an episode recalled in Chapter 21, at the moment contemporary Algeria was turning its weapons against Mali). The dagger spoke of a fraternity of struggles. Today, by contrast, it speaks of everything the region has lost along the way.

On November 19, 1968, young officers led by Lieutenant Moussa Traoré overthrow Modibo Keïta. The monetary experiment is buried, Mali falls back into line. The first president of independent Mali dies in detention in Bamako on May 16, 1977, without trial.

THE FIRST WAVE — TIMELINE OF AN ELIMINATION

March 6, 1957: Ghana's independence, Nkrumah calls for the total liberation of the continent

November 1958: Ghana-Guinea Union, expanded to Mali in 1961

June 30, 1960: Congo's independence, Lumumba's speech before Baudouin

January 17, 1961: Lumumba assassinated in Katanga, at age 35

July 1, 1962: Modibo Keïta creates the Malian franc and leaves the franc zone

January 13, 1963: Sylvanus Olympio, creator of the Togolese franc, assassinated in Lomé

May 1963: in Addis Ababa, Nkrumah's continental plan is rejected

February 24, 1966: Nkrumah overthrown during a trip abroad

November 19, 1968: Modibo Keïta overthrown; he will die in detention in 1977

What the AES owes the dead

What was eliminated between 1961 and 1968 were not autocrats: they were projects — political unity,

sovereign currency, joint defense. Projects too dangerous to be left alive.

Reread the Liptako-Gourma Charter of September 16, 2023: a union of three states, full sovereignty over resources, a Unified Force established December 21, 2025, a common monetary project. It is, article by article, the Addis Ababa 1963 program — the one the heads of state had rejected during Nkrumah's lifetime. Malian Foreign Minister Abdoulaye Diop claims this explicitly: Article 180 of the Malian constitution adopted in 2023 reaffirms Mali's willingness to relinquish all or part of its sovereignty to achieve African integration, and it is Modibo Keita whom he cites as the doctrinal reference (Diop, international forum, 2023–2024). The AES does not present itself as a break from 1960. It presents itself as the resumption of a project interrupted by bullets.

Between the first wave and this one, however, one man tried to keep the flame alive alone, for four years, from the region's poorest country — and it is to him, to Ouagadougou, that we must now turn.

CHAPTER 23 — SANKARA WAS RIGHT

"Debt is a cleverly organized reconquest. We have been impoverished, put into conditions such that we are forced to go begging." — Thomas Sankara, OAU summit, Addis Ababa, July 29, 1987

Addis Ababa, July 29, 1987. In the great hall of the Organization of African Unity, heads of state are dozing under the chandeliers when a thirty-seven-year-old captain in a red beret asks to speak. Thomas Sankara, president of Burkina Faso, tells his peers what none of them dare to say: African debt cannot be repaid, it must not be repaid, because yesterday's colonizers have become today's creditors. He calls for a united continental front against payment. Then he adds, half-joking, half-prophetic, that if Burkina remains alone in refusing to pay, he will not be at the next summit. The room laughs.

Two and a half months later, he is dead.

Four years that disturb

To understand why this death is not a mere West African news item, one must measure what had happened between August 4, 1983 — the National Revolutionary Council's seizure of power — and this Addis Ababa speech. Four years. Captain Sankara renames Upper Volta, a colonial name, as Burkina Faso: the land of upright people. And he governs as no one had governed on the continent.

THE FOUR-YEAR RECORD (1983–1987)

2.5 million children vaccinated against measles, meningitis, and yellow fever

10 million trees planted against desert encroachment

Roads and railways built without outside aid

Balanced state budget, the president's own salary cut, ministers' spending trimmed

The debt? Repayable, he said, provided creditors came to Burkina to explain themselves how it had been incurred

This is, to this day, the most ambitious African sovereignty program ever carried out on the continent. Not proclaimed: carried out. Sankara refused conditional French aid the same way he refused luxury official cars — out of consistency, not posturing.

As early as October 4, 1984, from the podium of the United Nations General Assembly, he had already carried this message before the world: he spoke there on behalf of the dispossessed, attacked apartheid, and framed debt as the central instrument of postcolonial domination. An indebted country no longer needs to be

occupied, since every repayment deadline decides its schools, its hospitals, and its alliances in its place. One borrows to repay, one obeys to borrow. The creditor governs without soldiers.

Three years after New York, in Addis Ababa, he no longer asked to be heard: he asked to be joined. The united front against debt never formed. The summit's prophecy did.

October 15, 1987

Ouagadougou, October 15, 1987, early afternoon. A commando bursts into the Conseil de l'Entente, at the Maison du Peuple, where Sankara is holding a meeting. He is shot dead along with twelve of his companions. His friend, his brother-in-arms, the man in the next room, takes power that very day: Blaise Compaoré. He will reign for twenty-seven years, made respectable again overnight in the eyes of Western chancelleries, while the Sankara case slept in a drawer and his grave remained nearly clandestine.

It would take the popular uprising of October 2014 — the Burkinabé people driving out Compaoré — for justice to finally open. France then exfiltrates Compaoré to Abidjan, to his ally Alassane Ouattara, who will protect him from any extradition (Dr. Rufin Viclère Mabiala, pan-Africanist analyst). Judicial proceedings opened from 2015 onward exhume the body, gather testimony and evidence; some of this evidence implicates French intelligence agents. Paris will declassify three batches of archives, without lifting the most sensitive areas.

The trial opens in Ouagadougou on October 11, 2021 — thirty-four years after the fact. On April 6, 2022, Ouagadougou's military tribunal sentences Blaise Compaoré, in absentia, to life imprisonment for endangering state security and complicity in assassination, alongside General Gilbert Diendéré among others. Trying someone in absentia means trying someone absent: Compaoré, from Abidjan, never appeared, and Côte d'Ivoire never handed him over. The sentence is pronounced. It is not carried out. But for the first time, an African state has written into a judgment what an entire generation already knew: Sankara did not die of an "internal drama within the revolution." He was assassinated, and his assassin governed for twenty-seven years with the blessing of the region's order-keepers.

The legacy: from mausoleum to fatigues

In four years, without oil, without a port, without aid, one of the poorest countries in the world had vaccinated, reforested, fed, and turned itself around. It was precisely this record that became undeniable — and therefore unbearable. A leader who proves you can do better without obeying is more dangerous than an army.

Thirty-five years after the assassination, Burkina Faso has made Sankara a national hero, built him a

mausoleum on the very spot where he fell — and brought to power, in September 2022, another thirty-four-year-old captain. Ibrahim Traoré governs from the same palace. He quotes Sankara. He refuses conditional religious funding the way Sankara refused conditional French aid (as seen in Chapter 17). And the AES Unified Force institutionalizes at the regional scale what Sékou Touré had attempted nationally in 1958 and what Sankara had hoped for continentally in 1987. The seed took forty years to sprout. It is sprouting.

A remark, made by Nathalie Yamb, carries its full weight here and will return in Chapter 25: Sankara was military, not elected — and his four-year record surpasses that of most postcolonial African electoral democracies. The question of what a ballot box is worth without sovereignty is raised. We will not dodge it.

But before answering it, we must look at those who resurrected Sankara: because it was not governments that made him an icon — it was a generation not yet born in 1987, that carries his portrait on their phones, and of which a young girl from Tonka, one day in November, paid to learn what it still costs to speak freely in the Sahel.

The IPN Farafina: from Sankara to Traoré, Black consciousness as a political project

"The Institute of Black Peoples should be, in the consciousness of dispersed Black peoples, a reunifying symbol — that of their shared will to preserve their identities, their creative genius, and their dignity." — Thomas Sankara, IPN symposium, Ouagadougou, April 7–10, 1986

There are ideas that need half a century to mature. In 1986, Thomas Sankara brings together in Ouagadougou 34 countries, political, scientific, and academic figures from across Africa, the Caribbean, and the United States — including former Black Panther members — to found the Institute of Black Peoples (IPN). Eighteen months later, he was assassinated. The IPN survived on paper, dormant under Blaise Compaoré, forgotten by most. In 2025, Ibrahim Traoré revived it under the name IPN Farafina. It is the reactivation of a doctrine, not a mere institutional rebirth.

The Lagos Plan of Action against the Berg Report

To understand the IPN, one must go back to the pan-Africanism of the 1980s. Faced with formal independences that had not produced real development, African countries meet in Lagos in 1980 and adopt a plan of action built around four pillars: industrialization, food security, logistics and transport, science and technology. The reasoning is simple and sound: without industry, Africa will remain an exporter of raw materials and importer of finished goods — it will never speak as an equal.

The World Bank responds immediately. Economist Elliot Berg produces a report — translated into

French as an *accelerated development action plan for sub-Saharan Africa* — whose logic runs exactly the opposite way: liberalization, privatization, state withdrawal, export agriculture, openness to imports. It is the theoretical foundation of the structural adjustment programs that will impoverish the continent for two decades.

The Lagos Plan proposed sovereignty. The Berg Report imposed dependency. It is in this context — after watching SAPs destroy what African plans were trying to build — that Sankara launches the IPN. The economic battle had an ideological counterpart: the consciousness of Black peoples had to be rebuilt so that they would stop asking permission to develop.

The original IPN: three objectives

Sankara structures the IPN around three explicit objectives.

First objective: re-education and identity reconciliation. Educated Africans ask themselves what their civilization contributed to history. The answer is documented — ancient Egypt, African blast furnaces preceding the European industrial era, the Mali and Songhai empires, seed- and grain-preservation technologies. But this knowledge was erased by 1,400 years of trans-Saharan slave trade and 400 years of transatlantic slave trade, then by a century of colonization that organized forgetting as an instrument of domination. Someone who does not know what they were cannot build what they want to be.

Second objective: the fight against assimilation. Assimilation is no longer imposed from outside — it has been internalized. Africans buy skin-lightening products. Intellectuals measure their success by the quality of their French accent. Sons of the continent cross the Mediterranean at the risk of their lives to reach countries that once enchained them. The IPN does not fight other peoples — it fights the complex that makes Black people love only those who oppressed them and turn against those who resembled them.

Third objective: strengthening ties with the diaspora. Black consciousness is not built in isolation. It is built in the connection between Africa, the Caribbean, the Americas, the European diaspora. It is no accident that Sankara traveled to Harlem in 1984 — two years before the founding symposium. The shock of this encounter with the heirs of Black American struggles was the spark that turned an intuition into an institutional project.

The smothering: Compaoré, SAPs, and the La Baule speech

Sankara is assassinated on October 15, 1987. The IPN's constitutive assembly would not take place until 1990 — under the presidency of Blaise Compaoré, the man who ordered the murder. The coincidence is telling: Compaoré organizes the constitutive assembly to appear as the project's continuator, to pocket the political legitimacy and the international money that came with it — 286 million CFA francs from UNESCO for preparatory work, 780 million for the constitutive assembly — before methodically extinguishing what he had just formally inaugurated.

The context is decisive. 1990 is the year of the La Baule speech: Mitterrand makes French aid conditional on African "democratization" — that is, on normalizing relations with the Western system, on falling back in line with the SAPs. Structural adjustment programs turned education and culture into adjustment variables — the first to be sacrificed when budgets contract. The IPN, a pan-Africanist institution built on the idea that Africa must fund itself in order to think freely, was doomed the moment outside funding made its existence conditional.

The man was killed. His ideas had to be killed too. It is logical. It is methodical. It is what was done.

The resurrection: IPN Farafina, 2025

In 2025, Ibrahim Traoré revives the institution under the name IPN Farafina — Farafina means "Africa" in the Mandingo language. The steering council is installed by the Prime Minister with a mission letter organized around six axes:

- Promote the values of Black peoples — culture, languages, spirituality, arts, endogenous knowledge, historical heritage.
- Teach and spread the ideals of the progressive, popular revolution: social justice, sovereignty, dignity, work, integrity, solidarity, pan-Africanism.
- Make the IPN a framework for reflection, research, documentation, and dissemination on the identity, memory, education, and development of Black peoples.
- Promote pan-African, sovereignist ideological training grounded in scientific rigor and patriotic ethics.
- Contribute to the emergence of a Black consciousness in solidarity across the peoples of Africa, the Caribbean, the Americas, Europe, and the entire diaspora.
- Formulate guidance for public policy on education, culture, research, the promotion of national languages, and the integration of endogenous knowledge.

There is nothing racist in these six missions. There is no call to war. There is the elementary demand that the Black man stop being, to borrow Frantz Fanon's title, *a wretched of the earth*.

What the continuity means

IPN Farafina is not a mere repetition of the original IPN. The context has changed: globalization is a reality, the diaspora is more connected than ever, social media allows a circulation of ideas that 1986 could not have imagined. Traoré readapts the project — he wants the knowledge produced to immediately serve the industrial and agricultural revolutions underway, for doctrine to translate into public policy, not just seminars.

But the continuity is real on the essential point: it is still about producing endogenous knowledge so as to no longer depend on those who organized ignorance as an instrument of domination. It is still about raising youth in dignity rather than in a complex. It is still about refusing to let the tree — Joseph Ki-Zerbo's metaphor — be uprooted because it opened itself to all the world's winds.

What the Sankara → IPN → IPN Farafina chain of transmission demonstrates is that an idea assassinated along with its author does not die when it is right. It waits. It finds another bearer. It resumes its march.

Sources: Debate on IPN Farafina, Burkina Faso television, Question Majeure program, 2025; speech by Thomas Sankara at the IPN's founding symposium, Ouagadougou, April 7–10, 1986; Lagos Plan of Action (OAU, 1980); Elliot Berg Report, World Bank, 1981; speech by Burkina Faso's Prime Minister at the installation of the IPN Farafina steering council, 2025; Frantz Fanon, The Wretched of the Earth; Joseph Ki-Zerbo, À quand l'Afrique?; Aimé Césaire, Discourse on Colonialism.

CHAPTER 24 — CONNECTED YOUTH, THE DIASPORA ON THE FRONT LINE

Tonka, Timbuktu region, early November 2021. A young woman films her life with her phone: the market, the streets, the Malian soldiers she cheers on. Her name is Mariam Cissé. On TikTok, tens of thousands of people follow this daughter of the river who laughs on camera. Armed JNIM men come for her. The next day, they execute her in public, in Tonka's town square, before a summoned crowd. Her crime: having shown, having supported, having existed online.

The killers wanted to make an example. They manufactured a symbol. Mariam Cissé's murder turned Malian public opinion against JNIM more effectively than any government communication could have. Because in executing her, the armed group named its own real adversary: not an army, but a generation — one that films, posts, comments, compares. This chapter tells the story of that generation and its extension across the seas: the diaspora. Two fronts that neither Paris, nor the armed groups, nor even the Sahelian states had seen coming.

The youngest country in the world

The Sahelian population's median age is under 18. One out of every two Sahelians was not yet born when the Twin Towers fell, and was under ten when Operation Serval began. This youth has not known the Cold War or the La Baule conferences. It grew up with the internet: HDI rankings available online, images of Barkhane in retreat, the live signing of the Liptako-Gourma Charter. It has been able to compare, sixty years of "cooperation" in hand, promises against realities. It has chosen.

At the continental scale, more than 60% of the population is under 25: Africa is the youngest continent on the planet. This human reservoir is either the greatest geopolitical force of the 21st century or the greatest source of instability — depending on whether it is given schools or weapons. This decisive educational wager will be addressed in Chapter 27. What concerns us here is a political fact: for the first time, this youth has access to a space no one fully controls — the phone. Mariam Cissé is its martyr. The millions of accounts that relayed her death are proof of life.

The diaspora: from remittance to front line

They live in Paris, Geneva, Brussels, Montreal, London. They pay their taxes in Europe and send money transfers to Bamako, Ouagadougou, Niamey. And since 2020, they have been doing something their parents did not: they fight. Not with weapons — with analyses, YouTube channels, op-eds no one asked them to write.

The first front is financial. Remittances from African migrants to their countries of origin far exceed

the amounts of official development aid, according to the World Bank's own data — about \$40 billion a year to sub-Saharan Africa. The cousins of Montreuil and Montreal finance their countries more than all official donors combined, with no conditions, no political quid pro quo, no signing ceremony. The North's "generosity," dismantled in Chapter 9, weighs less than a money-transfer counter on a Saturday morning.

The second front is informational. Nathalie Yamb operates from Africa and stands up to French ambassadors on social media. Franklin Nyamsi, a Franco-Cameroonian philosopher, turns the Élysée diplomats' arguments back on them from Rouen. Jonathan Batenguène analyzes from Cameroon. These voices exist within the European media space itself and constitute within it a credible counter-narrative, in French, during prime digital hours. That the adversary takes this front seriously has been shown in Chapter 14: the 43rd BIMA's cyber school and its "e-patrollers" tasked with naming and targeting pan-Africanists, then the September 2025 tender to recruit African influencers against the AES. One does not budget a counteroffensive against a front that does not exist.

YOUTH AND DIASPORA IN NUMBERS

Median age in the Sahel: under 18 (UN data)

Over 60% of Africans are under 25

Diaspora remittances to sub-Saharan Africa: about \$40 billion per year — far above official development aid (World Bank)

The diaspora's compradors

The diaspora is not a monolith. It is crossed by the same fault lines as African societies, and it has its own compradors — its intermediaries of dependency, trained in France, based in France, whose careers rest on Franco-African networks that a sovereignist rupture would ruin. Hassoumi Massaoudou, a dignitary of the regime overthrown in Niamey, calls Nigerien popular mobilizations "choreographies bought for 1,500 euros" from an LCI set in Paris. He is himself part of the diaspora. He chooses the Élysée's narrative over his own people's — what Nathalie Yamb calls the "colonized complex": borrowing the adversary's categories, verdicts, and even self-contempt.

It must therefore be said: the diaspora can also be influenced, divided, instrumentalized — and it is, actively. And the AES states have not yet turned this force into an institution. A diaspora policy worthy of the name — investment mechanisms, dual nationality, remote civic participation — remains an open project, not an achievement. The power is there; the architecture is still missing.

What remains is the essential point. A generation half of which is not yet 18, that has made Sankara an icon and Mariam Cissé a martyr; a diaspora that sends more money than donors and produces its own narrative: this is the social base of the pan-African awakening. But a social base is not a political project. The real question

— the one the AES’s opponents ask, in good or bad faith, and one its supporters can no longer defer — lies elsewhere: what is this laboratory, run by soldiers no one elected, worth democratically and institutionally? It is to this question, without dodging it, that the next chapter is devoted.

CHAPTER 25 — THE AES, A PAN-AFRICAN LABORATORY

"We cannot fight injustice from outside by practicing injustice inside." — Thomas Sankara, 1984

On June 7, 2026, the African web catches fire. Yan Christian Bernard Vésilier, a DGSE agent infiltrated in Mali under diplomatic cover — a spy protected by a passport and an ambassadorial title that in principle made him untouchable — is sentenced to twenty years in prison for undermining Malian state security. The charges are heavy: organizing a coup intended to overthrow General Assimi Goïta, with the complicity of senior Malian officers arrested alongside him. After decades in which foreign agents caught red-handed at destabilization were quietly released within a few months, here is a firm, quantified, public conviction. The pan-Africanist networks' joy is immediate and massive.

This is precisely the moment to slow down. Because this chapter treats the AES for what it claims to be: a laboratory — pan-Africanism's full-scale test. And a laboratory is not judged by its celebrations. It is judged by its protocols, its controls, its acknowledged failures.

The Vésilier affair, or African-supervised justice

The most useful voice amid June 2026's celebration is not one of the AES's critics. It is one of its most steadfast allies, Nathalie Yamb:

"A forewarned African is worth a thousand. I wonder why Yan Christian Bernard Vésilier did not have a public trial. I wonder why the reason this expedited trial was not public was never communicated to the Malian people. And I wonder, finally, why the Malian officers arrested in this same affair were not tried and sentenced — or acquitted — at the same time as him."

— Nathalie Yamb, June 2026

Three silences. Three absences. Three alarm signals. The concern is not abstract: four DGSE agents arrested in Mali had already been held for a year, then released in exchange for an "arrangement" never made public — before a French security circle announced on a television set, in 2024, that the withdrawal of official armies would open up "more latitude to mount destabilization operations, this time more clandestine ones." Not a veiled threat: a program announcement. And regional memory retains the Zoe's Ark affair: in 2007, French child traffickers sentenced to eight years of forced labor by Chadian justice, repatriated by Nicolas Sarkozy "to serve their sentence" — and pardoned almost immediately.

Hence the framework Yamb sets: Vésilier should leave prison before 2046 only dead, or exchanged for

the handover — “not one, not two — all” — of the identified leaders of armed insecurity in the Sahel; and whoever frees him outside this framework would thereby mark themselves as an accomplice (Yamb, June 2026). Behind the harshness of the statement lies a doctrine: deterrence. As long as a spy caught in the act knows he will be released within the year in exchange for a quiet deal, espionage costs nothing — and what costs nothing continues. “When France, when Westerners see that their agents get caught and stay behind bars for the rest of their lives, they will start thinking twice,” Yamb sums up. Vésilier’s conviction is a first. It deserves praise. It deserves, even more, to be upheld.

What stands out here is less the verdict than the nature of the debate: the most demanding critique of Malian justice comes from the pan-Africanist camp itself. A laboratory that tolerates its own inspectors is starting to look like a laboratory.

The democratic question, without flinching

Let us come to the hardest question for any honest observer of the AES — the one this book has deferred until now in order to address it once, fully.

The governments of Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger are military. They did not come from elections. Timetables for transitioning to civilian institutions have been set, contested, repeatedly pushed back. These facts exist. They must be named, with the same rigor as every other fact in this book.

But honesty requires naming the rest too. The overthrown regimes were formal electoral democracies — regimes where people genuinely voted, but where the vote did not genuinely command anything. IBK was elected. Kaboré was elected. Bazoum was elected. And in these formal democracies, corruption was endemic, security forces did not protect the population, national resources remained captured by outside interests, and the people had no say over defense agreements that placed their country under foreign military tutelage. The ballot box was respected. Sovereignty was betrayed. It is this contradiction the military transitions exposed — by overturning it.

Nathalie Yamb formulates the criterion that shifts the debate: “What separates a good leader from a bad one is not how he came to power. It is his relationship to national sovereignty, to social justice, and to corruption. Sankara was military. Roosevelt was elected. Sankara’s four-year record surpasses the record of most postcolonial African electoral democracies.” There is no final blank check in this sentence: it is a reading grid. The author’s reading, openly held, is this: demanding immediate elections in countries at war, where enemy networks are active and substitute candidacies are financed from abroad, has less to do with democratic principle than with influence strategy.

The prosecution witness who argues for the defense

On this point, the most disturbing piece of evidence in the file comes neither from Bamako nor from Moscow. It comes from Mohamed Bazoum himself — Niger's deposed president, a declared opponent of the transitions — in his major interview with RFI and France 24. In defending the system, he confirmed, point by point, its diagnosis. These have been called the five involuntary confessions; here is the condensed version.

BAZOUZ'S FIVE INVOLUNTARY CONFESSIONS (RFI/France 24 INTERVIEW)

Jihadism is not religious: the recruited youth "has nothing to do with religion," he seeks a weapon, a motorbike, pride — religious rhetoric is reserved for the leaders.

Armed civilian militias are dangerous: "You're giving weapons to civilians you barely know... you can see the result" — validating the caution otherwise held against the transitions (Chapter 26).

Poverty and demographics are the root of recruitment — the analysis and its figures are detailed in Chapter 27.

The ruptures would have happened anyway: systemic corruption, security failure despite French and American allies, an entire neighborhood having gone under military leadership.

Wagner was present before the seizure of power: "Trojan horses" infiltrated, a party leader arrested — refuting the fable of a transition manufactured by Moscow, since Russian penetration existed under his own mandate, despite the French presence.

And the confession that crowns them all: "The people in villages who are victims of terrorism don't know there are French here in Niger, or Americans, or Russians." An elected president describing a foreign military deployment invisible to his own people — this is the very definition of confiscated sovereignty. Bazoum was neither incompetent nor cynical: his anti-corruption record was real, so were his boarding schools for girls. He managed dependency seriously. But no elected president in Niger could expel France and retake Imouraren — not for lack of will: because the system did not allow it. The AES is a revolution against the structural limit, not against the poor governance that the best comprador governance could not overcome. Bazoum proved it by living it.

Admitted fragilities, criteria set

The laboratory has also documented its own flaws — through its own leaders' voices. Choguel Kokalla Maïga, then Mali's prime minister, admitted it publicly: "Many of their networks have infiltrated the transition today." This admission is valuable precisely because it is dangerous: it says the sovereign project is real — and that it is fragile. The networks of dependency did not disappear with the overthrows; they reorganized within ministries, general staffs, business circles. The revolution will only be complete if the structures change, and if the new structures resist recolonization from within.

So, by what should the AES be judged? By three questions — not one less, not one more.

THE THREE-QUESTION TEST

Do the transitions produce institutions, or personal reigns?

Are fundamental rights respected outside of speeches?

Are minorities protected?

This third question is the heaviest: Chapter 26 will show how the precarization of Fulani communities manufactures fighters, and Yamb recalls that “minority protection” has also served, since the Yugoslav wars, as a lever for intervention and fragmentation. All the more reason, not less, to answer it: to defuse the weapon, the AES must treat its minorities with more justice than its adversaries treat it — that is the whole meaning of Sankara’s sentence placed at the head of this chapter. To these three questions, the answers are not final. The AES is under construction; its transitions are open processes, not fixed outcomes.

What remains is the conviction driving this laboratory, which Banda Kani puts in his own way: great transformations are never carried by the masses but by a vanguard — a small core that has disciplined its ego, subordinated self-interest to the cause, and advances “without being distracted by petty agitators and dividers” (Banda Kani, *Paroles Panafricanistes*, November 29, 2022). Goïta, Traoré, and Tiani see themselves as this vanguard. History will tell whether the vanguard founded institutions or merely reigned — that is exactly what the three questions will measure.

The laboratory is open; its results are not yet in. They depend on four very concrete tests — defeating insecurity without reproducing injustice, building an economy without being plundered, minting a currency without being strangled, choosing the right partners — and it is these four tests, tomorrow’s challenges, that occupy this book’s final part.

Ghana: heritage is not begged for, it is reclaimed

Two thousand. That is the number of historical objects and cultural property Germany and the Netherlands have agreed to return to Ghana. Masks, thrones, royal regalia, sacred instruments — looted during colonization, catalogued in European museums, displayed for a century and a half. Make no mistake: this is a political victory wrested away by an African diplomacy that decided to stop waiting, not a gesture of generosity, nor Europe’s belated awakening conscience.

Ghana did not beg. It waged a long diplomatic war. Accra compiled precise inventories of looted works, documented their provenance, their value, their significance to the communities of origin. Then it took the fight to the UN: a historic resolution adopted at the General Assembly turned the question from a bilateral matter in which the African state is always the petitioner into an international norm. Faced with this multilateral pressure,

Berlin and Amsterdam no longer had a choice.

Country | Action taken | Status

-
- Germany — Restitution of looted cultural property — Underway
|
 - Netherlands — Restitution of looted cultural property — Underway
|
 - Denmark — Official apology + funding to restore colonial castles (slave trade) — Completed
|
 - France — Under pressure — thousands of works at the Quai Branly — Ongoing
|
 - Belgium — Under pressure — Congolese heritage at Tervuren — Ongoing

The Danish apology comes with funding to restore Ghana's colonial castles — those fortresses from which millions of Africans were shipped to the plantations of the Americas. Repentance costs nothing. Reparation changes concrete things. Denmark did both. France and Belgium are now in the crosshairs.

Four lessons for the continent:

1 — Multilateralism is a weapon. Ghana did not negotiate bilaterally with each museum — it would have lost, one by one. It imposed an international norm. This is exactly the strategy the AES should apply on other files: uranium, debt, military bases.

2 — Inventory is a weapon. Without precise documentation — object names, removal dates, host collections — restitution stays abstract. Ghana did the work Europe hoped it would never do.

3 — Two thousand objects out of tens of thousands. The lines are moving, but only under pressure. As soon as it eases, European museums rediscover their arguments: "conservation," "universality of heritage" — so many formulas for saying African heritage belongs to humanity except to Africans.

4 — The logic is transferable. What Ghana achieved on cultural heritage, the AES can replicate on its natural resources: document extractive flows, build a coalition of the UN's 54 African members (28% of votes), name the norm — *"the price of €0.80/kg for uranium is a violation of peoples' right to dispose of their natural resources."*

What Ghana demonstrates is what Sankara put into words: sovereignty is not asked for in the dignity of a supplicant. It is wrested away through legal rigor and the solidarity of numbers. The Sahelian laboratory and the Ghanaian victory say the same thing through different paths — the balance of power, not the plea, is what

moves Europe.

PART VI — TOMORROW'S CHALLENGES

Up to now, this book has told a story of tearing away. What remains is to tell a story of building.

For breaking away is one thing; enduring is another. The AES has expelled armies, denounced agreements, retaken mines and words. But none of these acts feeds a child, secures a village, or stabilizes a currency. The chapters that follow leave the ground of observation for that of forecasting: the war that continues, the economy to be built, the currency to be invented, the new partners to be kept at arm's length, the old power reorganizing itself — and, at the end, the demanding list of what the Alliance must achieve in order not to become, in thirty years, one more memory.

The history of African ruptures is full of beginnings. It is stingier with tomorrows. It is to tomorrows that this part is devoted.

And the first tomorrow bears a name: security.

PART VI

TOMORROW'S CHALLENGES

CHAPTER 26 — SECURITY: WINNING WITHOUT BETRAYAL

"A soldier without political training is a potential criminal." — Thomas Sankara, October 2, 1983

Bamako, November 11, 2025. School gates open. Thousands of children head back to class after weeks of forced closure. In the streets, the lines outside gas stations are only just beginning to shrink. Mali's capital emerges from two months of strangulation — not military, but economic. For the first time in a long while, it was gasoline, not bullets, that nearly brought a Sahelian capital to its knees.

The blockade: war by asphyxiation

Since September 2025, JNIM — the Group for the Support of Islam and Muslims, the Sahel's main jihadist coalition — has imposed a methodical blockade on Mali's fuel supply chains. The targeted routes are the ones that keep the country running: convoys coming from Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, and Guinea. Sabotage strikes near Sikasso. Shortages spread to Bamako, Kayes, Ségou, Mopti, Gao. Schools close temporarily, until November 11, 2025 (Dr. Yves Ekoué Amaïzo, Afrocentricity Think Tank, November 29, 2025).

A fuel blockade is a weapon that does not target the army but daily life: without fuel, no more goods transport, no more generators, no more water pumps — an entire country slowing to a halt. It is economic warfare, not merely military. And its outcome says something essential about the balance of power.

JNIM BLOCKADE — TIMELINE

September 2025: methodical blockade of fuel convoys to Mali begins

October 29–30, 2025: a FAMa convoy breaks the blockade — immediate deterrent effect on the ground

November 9–12, 2025: peak of the security and energy crisis

November 11, 2025: Malian schools reopen

The blockade failed to bend the government. It solidified public opinion against JNIM.

The blockade failed — but not only because of the military convoys. JNIM made mistakes its adversaries could not have provoked on their own. The public assassination of Mariam Cissé, the young blogger from Tonka whose story we crossed in Chapter 24, turned Malian public opinion against the group more effectively than any government communication. "Asymmetric terrorism targeting civilians is a matter of strategic cowardice, which itself rests on instrumentalization from outside," Amaïzo sums up (November 29, 2025).

The AES has not made jihadism disappear. It has changed the rules of the game. It refuses the foreign military presence that claimed to fight it while letting it spread, and it chooses its own methods. The record,

compared to Barkhane's, remains to be built. But the dynamics are different — and the figures, once verifiable, will settle the matter.

The Unified Force: the tool of response

Faced with a threat that ignores borders, the AES has built the instrument that had been missing for ten years: a joint force. The AES Unified Force is established on December 21, 2025. It does not come from nowhere: the Yokoo 1 and 2 operations, cited by General Goïta, and the Tarha Nakal 2 exercises of May 2025 — which involved Chad and Togo — document a gradual, real, operational build-up.

Proof by fire arrives quickly. When the coordinated attacks of April 25, 2026 hit Mali, the response mobilizes 15,000 troops — and 800 fuel tankers moved from Niger to Mali. Interoperability works: the three armies now know how to fight together, resupply one another, and the lesson of the autumn blockade has been learned — logistics is a front in its own right.

A longer-term ambition remains, formulated within the Alliance itself: the true federal army will be the one trained in its own institutions — neither at Saint-Cyr, nor in Russian academies, but in AES military schools teaching the defense of the African people as central doctrine. The tool exists. The doctrine is being written.

Contempt for gifts: equipping without arming

In 2012, a French television report showed Malian soldiers so short of ammunition that they mimicked the sound of gunfire with their mouths. Nathalie Yamb sums up the scene in a stinging line: "For lack of sufficient ammunition, Malian soldiers have imagination." But the real question lies elsewhere: what had France been doing since 1960?

For the Franco-Malian defense agreement, signed as early as 1960 by Michel Debré and Modibo Keita — revised in 1985 — entrusted France, under its Article 3, with technical assistance: weapons, equipment, training. Sixty-five years of privileged "military cooperation." The result on the ground: an army that mimics gunfire for lack of bullets. The conclusion is inescapable: under-equipment was not a failure of the cooperation — it was its purpose. One does not train an army one wants to keep dependent.

The inventory of this "cooperation" verges on humiliation. A few documented examples of Western support to African armies:

<i>Donor / year</i>	<i>Military "gift"</i>
● France, 2025	5 bicycles given to the Gabonese police
● France, 2024	An inflatable dinghy for Cameroon
● France (Serval/Barkhane)	A loudspeaker for the Malian Armed Forces
● France, 2020	An ultralight aircraft (fit for scrap) for Burkina Faso
● Canada, October 2025	20 tents for the Beninese army — "solidarity against terrorism"

Bicycles, tents, a loudspeaker — while these same powers deliver Rafale jets, tanks, Caesar howitzers, and missile defense to Ukraine, and drones, pickup trucks, and Kalashnikovs reach terrorist groups. The contrast is not negligence: it is a hierarchy. You arm those you want to see win; you give bicycles to those you want to see lose.

The break from defense agreements with the West has reversed the curve. With Russia, China, Iran, and Turkey as partners, the Malian, Nigerien, and Burkinabé armies have registered rapid progress — helicopters, drones, armored vehicles, real training. And military sovereignty does not stop at purchasing: it aims at local manufacturing. In Niger, Lieutenant-Colonel Doudou Guédel's weapons prototypes open the way to producing ammunition and equipment on African soil. An army that manufactures its own bullets no longer mimics gunfire.

This distrust of Western power does not erase history: it summons it. At the Berlin Conference of 1884–1885, Russia was among the fourteen participants — but was the only one, or nearly so, to claim no African territory for itself. In 1889, when the privateer Nikolai Achinov tried to establish a colonial outpost in Djibouti, Tsar Alexander III disowned him and had him arrested for piracy. This memory — of a power that did not take part in carving up the continent — weighs today on the AES's partnership choices. It is no guarantee of Russian benevolence; it is a historical fact that Paris, for its part, cannot invoke.

The VDP: the double-edged weapon

It is in Burkina Faso that the Sahelian security strategy's riskiest gamble is being played out. The VDP — Volunteers for the Defense of the Homeland — constitute an innovation: a civilian militia integrated into the national security apparatus. Volunteer citizens, armed and supervised by the state, tasked with defending

their own villages where the army cannot be everywhere. Their operational effectiveness is documented.

And it is here that this book must pause, because history has already rendered its verdict on this type of arrangement. Raphaël Granvaud, in his investigation into France's wars in Africa, warns against counterinsurgency by militia: historically, community militias produce the conditions of their own failure, by radicalizing the very communities they targeted. The pattern holds true from 1950s Mau Mau-era Kenya to 1980s Philippines, by way of Algeria's harkis (Granvaud, *De l'huile sur le feu*, 2024).

The harshest diagnosis of the VDP comes from the transitions' own institutional opponent. Before his overthrow on July 26, 2023, asked about the strategy adopted in Burkina Faso, President Mohamed Bazoum stated: "If it were functional, it would have been our own option too... You're giving weapons to civilians you barely know... you let them loose, they can abuse it. Unfortunately, today we see the result." (Mohamed Bazoum, RFI/France 24 interview, 2023). When the overthrown head of state and the transitions' critics say the same thing, it is no longer a partisan opinion: it is a tactical fact that African leaders of every orientation recognize.

The trap of conflation

Because the danger of militias has a name, and that name is inscribed in the Sahel's recent memory. Self-defense militias created to protect settled communities — Koglweogo in Burkina Faso, Ganda Koy and Ganda Iso in Mali — produced the opposite of the intended effect. The Ogossagou massacre, in March 2019, killed 160 Fulani. Sobane-Da followed in June 2019, then Petelkolé in 2020. These massacres turned victims into fighters (ACLED, 2019–2023).

The mechanism is well known, and we detailed it in Chapter 25: a community is precarized by attacking its livestock, then armed intermediaries come offering weapons, money, and revenge. This mechanism is not religious. It is economic and social. Bazoum himself, in the same series of interviews, described the young Fulani herder tipped over the edge by suddenly possessing a weapon and a motorbike — recruitment born of misery, not conviction.

These massacres were not born of an outside decision: they were born of state failure. But their instrumentalization by powers that indiscriminately fund several sides is the variable that turns communal tension into structural war. Hence the warning from Choguel Kokalla Maïga, delivered before the press in Bamako: "Not all terrorists are Fulani and not all Fulani are terrorists. But there are people who sustain the conflation." And he extends the analysis: "Not all Tuareg and Arabs are terrorists and not all terrorists are Arab and Tuareg." (Azalaï Hotel, Bamako, October 19, 2024). He recalls that in Aguelhok, in 2012, the bodies of Arab and Tuareg fighters were disemboweled and filmed to terrorize communities: ethnic conflation is not a misunderstanding, it is a tool of psychological warfare.

Nathalie Yamb adds a geopolitical warning: "minority protection" has also, since the Yugoslav wars,

been a lever for intervention and fragmentation used against states. To resist it, the AES has only one defense: to demonstrate that it treats its minorities with more justice than its adversaries treat it.

Winning without betraying oneself

This is the AES's true security equation, and it holds in one sentence from Sankara, spoken in 1984: injustice from outside is not fought by practicing injustice inside. The Unified Force gives the Alliance the means for military victory. The VDP give it territorial coverage.

The AES's sovereign project cannot be assessed only against its outside adversaries. It must also be assessed against its own internal contradictions. The enemy within — ethnic conflation, doctrine-less militias, indiscriminate repression — can destroy in a single massacre what ten military victories built. Political discipline is a weapon as much as the rifle.

But no army, however federal, wins a war that the economy loses: it is in the fields, the factories, and the classrooms that what comes next is decided.

CHAPTER 27 — INDUSTRIALIZATION AND EDUCATION: THE WAR ECONOMY AND THE WEAPON OF MINDS

"The Empire is afraid of an armed Africa. It is even more afraid of an educated Africa."

When Cameroon built its pipeline, it discovered an absurdity: there were no welders trained to do the job on its own territory. Others had to be brought in from other African countries. A country rich in resources, but without the hands to extract them itself — this is the result of decades of education policy oriented toward training colonial civil servants rather than sovereign technicians. This anecdote contains the whole of this chapter: the AES's economic sovereignty will be decided as much in workshops and classrooms as in ministries.

The war economy: cutting extraction's pipes

Sanctions are an instrument of economic warfare. They follow a logic history constantly validates: they hit populations, rarely leaders, and generally accelerate the very project they were meant to block. Iran under sanctions for forty years, Cuba under embargo for sixty — the examples are well known. The AES's response to sanctions follows a similar logic: turning constraint into an accelerator.

The first act of this war economy went almost unnoticed by the general public, and yet it is one of the most structuring gestures of the entire rupture. On August 7, 2023, Burkina Faso denounces its tax treaty with France. The effect takes force on November 8, 2023. On December 5, 2023, Mali and Niger in turn denounce their own treaties (BOFiP, French tax administration, July 17, 2024). Three states, four months, one shared sovereign gesture.

A bilateral tax treaty allowed French multinationals to repatriate their profits — dividends, interest, royalties — while paying very little local tax. Denouncing it restores ordinary law: profits made in the Sahel are now taxed there as everywhere else. It is the legal removal of the instruments of extraction, not a mere political statement.

DENUNCIATION OF TAX TREATIES WITH FRANCE — AES SEQUENCE

August 7, 2023: Burkina Faso denounces the Franco-Burkinabé tax treaty

November 8, 2023: takes effect on the Burkinabé and French sides

December 5, 2023: Mali and Niger denounce their treaties

Consequence: end of exemptions on dividends, interest, and royalties — return to ordinary law

(Source: BOFiP, French tax administration, July 17, 2024)

Processing on-site: the local content rule

Keeping the tax revenue is not enough; the value itself must be kept. Mali showed the way by renegotiating its gold contracts — higher royalties and 35% mandatory local content, as we saw in Chapter 8. "Local content" is the requirement placed on mining companies to buy a share of their goods and services from national companies and to employ nationals: every ton of ore extracted then irrigates the country's economy instead of passing through without stopping.

Nationalization, which some liberal economists present as the radical option, is in fact the global norm. China nationalizes. The United States practices a structural protectionism that dares not speak its name. Norway nationalized its hydrocarbons and made it the world's largest sovereign wealth fund. The neoliberalism imposed on Africa — total free markets, privatizations, a ban on subsidies — is precisely what Western powers do not apply at home. "Nationalization is not just an alternative — it is the sovereign path to emancipation," sums up journalist Albert Anatole Ayissi (Paroles Panafricanistes). It creates direct and indirect jobs, generates a domestic market, and forces the opening of training programs suited to the country's real needs — which brings us back to the Cameroonian welders, and to school.

The AES's industrial project remains, as this book is being written, the least advanced of all: local processing of cotton, gold, and agricultural products is only just beginning, and the war absorbs a considerable share of budgets. It is the link on which all the others will depend.

Education as a weapon of sovereignty

Military sovereignty can be acquired in a few years. Economic sovereignty takes a generation. Sovereignty of the mind — the one that makes the first two durable — is built in classrooms. Colonial powers understood this: controlling a people's education is controlling its future. The AES has no more patient enemy than this legacy.

Demographics pose the challenge with brutal clarity: over 60% of the African population is under 25. This potential is either the greatest geopolitical force of the 21st century or the greatest source of instability. A young Sahelian out of school, with no prospects, is a target for jihadist recruitment. A young Sahelian who is educated, skilled, proud of their history, is a builder of sovereignty. The equation is that simple. Quantity, in this domain, eventually creates quality — provided it is directed toward real skills: engineers, doctors, technicians, researchers, welders capable of building the infrastructure Africa will have to erect over the coming decades.

Precedents exist. Zambia under President Hakainde Hichilema has shown that a courageous political choice can change a generation's trajectory: since 2021, primary and secondary education there has been free — written into law. Registration fees eliminated, exam fees abolished, uniforms made accessible, textbooks

provided; and above all, public schools have a legal obligation to turn no child away, even if the state has not yet paid the corresponding subsidies. This is not merely a political intention — it is a legal architecture that closes the door on exclusion. Benin made the same choice for girls' education through the final year of secondary school. These are political acts, not announcement effects: they cost money in budgets, infrastructure, teacher training. And they transform societies. "If decisions like these are not made, Africa will never take off," sums up Patient Parfait Ndoum. The Zambian reform also illustrates the spillover effect: when one country moves, others follow — exactly as the abolition of visas in Benin led Ghana, then the Republic of Congo, to open their borders in turn. An educational precedent can become a continental norm. "Free schooling must not be limited to simply removing fees," warns analyst Patient Parfait Ndoum. "Building classrooms, recruiting competent teachers, ensuring rigorous follow-up — that is what taking youth seriously means."

Girls' education is the most profitable lever of all. At every stage — from primary to middle school, middle school to high school, high school to university — a fraction of girls leave the system, pushed out by early marriage, domestic chores, unsafe commutes, hidden costs. Yet every additional year of a girl's education raises her future income by 10 to 20%, delays the age of first marriage, reduces infant mortality, and improves her family's health. Girls' education is not just a matter of justice: it is a macroeconomic lever of the first order.

What remains is the content of teaching, as decisive as access to it. Curricula inherited from colonization value rote recitation and the training of civil servants for an administration modeled on the metropole. They produce graduates who can neither repair an engine, nor farm land with modern methods, nor code, nor process a resource locally — consumers of foreign knowledge, not producers of local solutions. "Technical, scientific, and manual trade training must be integrated to raise a youth capable of meeting local and global economic challenges, valuing every form of intelligence," argues Ndoum. South Korea, Singapore, Germany built their power on this equal valuing of intellectual, technical, and manual intelligence. Africa does not have to reinvent this model; it has to apply it in proportion to its human resources. The vitality of these non-academic intelligences shows in a striking example: the sculptors of Foumban, in Cameroon, produce works whose structures encode mathematical properties — fractals — without ever having opened a geometry textbook. These forms of intelligence, shaped by centuries of observing nature and oral transmission, are as real as the ability to solve an algebraic equation. Reducing them to nothing under the weight of a system that measures intelligence only by rote recitation is deliberately amputating a society of its creative half.

Two inside enemies threaten this project. Corruption, first: diverted budgets, teaching posts sold, purchased diplomas — every corrupt act in education is a bullet fired into a people's future. Creeping privatization, second: for-profit schools, accessible only to well-off families, that answer to the global market rather than the nation's needs. Education is a sovereign function. When the state abdicates it, it abdicates its deepest sovereignty.

The AES's leaders have understood this, each in their own way: Assimi Goïta funds the translation and

distribution of pan-Africanist works in Malian schools; Ibrahim Traoré hammers the point that revolution without education reform remains a façade revolution. Sahelian youth is not waiting for speeches. It is waiting for schools, laboratories, workshops, well-trained and well-paid teachers.

Economic sovereignty will therefore be built tractor by tractor, workshop by workshop, school by school — before being built bill by bill; and it is precisely of the bill that we must now speak.

CHAPTER 28 — CURRENCY: BREAKING THE CFA CHAIN

"Currency is the mother of sovereignties. You cannot be sovereign if you have no currency." — Dr. Douma Jean-René, Panafrican Media TV, May 10, 2026

Bangui, July 3, 2022. From the presidential palace, Faustin-Archange Touadéra, a mathematics professor turned head of state, logs on to the first digital launch event for the Sango. The world watches, skeptical. Paris scrutinizes, hostile. Africa takes note. That day, the poorest of the francophone countries attempts something no franc-zone state had dared: to leap over the CFA franc. The experiment will fail. But it will leave the AES the most valuable lesson of its entire monetary strategy — and it is with this story that we must begin.

The Central African gamble: leaping over rather than confronting

Touadéra knew he could not fight the franc zone head-on: the agreements binding CEMAC to the BEAC, and the BEAC to the French Treasury, form a legal network capable of strangling any alternative national currency. African history is full of warnings — the Malian franc collapses in 1984 under speculation organized from Paris, forcing Bamako to partially rejoin the franc zone; Sékou Touré's Guinea, which dared say no in 1958, sees its fledgling currency torpedoed by counterfeit money. Monetary destabilization is a documented, repeated weapon.

The concrete constraint Touadéra had to leap over is also geographic. The Central African Republic is a landlocked country: the entirety of its foreign trade passes through the Cameroonian ports of Douala and Kribi. But Cameroon is itself a member of CEMAC and the CFA zone. This lock means that a Central African national currency — however sovereign in theory — would remain, in practice, subject to the CFA franc's exchange mechanisms on every import or export. According to Jean-Paul Bec's analysis (Festin Panafricain, 2024), this is precisely why the French "decided to make the Central African Republic a laboratory": the country's geography made it nearly impossible to free, whatever its leader's will. Touadéra responded to this double lock with a double strategy. On the security front first: faced with France's refusal to protect his government from armed groups, he turns to Russia — Africa Corps — a move that earns him immediate Franco-American diplomatic isolation but secures him a military presence answerable to no one but himself. On the monetary front next: leap over the CFA from above, via an asset beyond the reach of any central bank — bitcoin — allowing resource exports to be settled without going through franc circuits.

Hence the strategy of circumvention. On April 22, 2022, a law makes bitcoin the sole legal reference asset in the CAR. On June 27, the presidency announces the launch of the Sango for July 3. And a misunderstanding

must be cleared up here: the Sango is a digital ecosystem, not a currency, whose core is the "tokenization" of Central African natural assets. Tokenizing means turning a share of the subsoil — uranium, coltan, diamonds, oil — into digital titles recorded on a blockchain, that is, a ledger no one can falsify or confiscate: neither a banking network, nor a foreign central bank, nor a Paris court.

The stakes were clear, and economist Hamdi Mabrouk put it plainly as early as June 2022: "The question for the Central African Republic is not to fight against the CFA franc. The problem is that 50 to 85% of export revenue ends up in the French Treasury. How is Touadéra going to invest the \$42 billion he has promised if his revenue is confiscated at the source?" (Paroles Panafricanistes, June 2022). Settling exports in bitcoin meant having revenue land directly in Central African coffers, with no exchange commission or bank intermediary. "No country in the world controls bitcoin," Mabrouk argued. That was, in Bangui's eyes, its one decisive property: what no one controls, no one can freeze.

What the failure teaches

What follows is well known, and it must be told without indulgence. The Sango Coin, launched in 2022, is a technical failure. In 2025, its successor, the \$CAR, loses 90% of its value on the very day of its launch. International institutions, for their part, had not lifted a finger: zero support, zero encouraging statement — a silence that spoke volumes about the flows the arrangement threatened, but that was not enough to explain the failure on its own. Both attempts failed through haste, under sanctions, without technical infrastructure or international backing. A country whose budget largely depends on outside aid could not, alone, sustain such a rupture. Central African boldness opened the way; its solitude condemned it.

The AES drew the lesson. General Tiani states it with doctrinal precision: "Currency is a step in exiting colonization. At the right moment, we will decide." (RTN, February 12, 2024). Caution is not weakness. It is the memory of others' mistakes.

Amaïzo's sequence: sovereignty in order

For there is an order to things, and economist Yves Ekoué Amaïzo has articulated it better than anyone: "There is no sovereignty without military, territorial, then customs, fiscal, economic, monetary, and financial sovereignty." (Afrocentricity Think Tank, Africa Connect, January 18, 2024). One does not create a currency before securing the territory it is meant to serve, the customs that will protect it, and the economy that will carry it: currency is the roof of the house, not its foundation.

This sequence is not theory: it is the program the AES has been rolling out since 2023. The Liptako-Gourma Charter laid the first level, military and territorial. The denunciation of tax treaties, in 2023, laid the

second. The AES investment bank, decided in Niamey in July 2024, lays the third. Sovereign currency is the final level — and each step makes the previous one harder to reverse.

The next institutional step now has a date: an African Monetary Institute is announced for September 2026, in the wake of the meeting of African central bank governors in Dakar. A monetary institute is the embryo of a central bank: the body that prepares the statutes, issuance rules, and exchange mechanisms before a currency exists. The timing is not incidental: in May 2026, Bloomberg and Citigroup recommended a devaluation of the CEMAC zone's CFA franc — a signal, as analyzed by Jonathan Batenguène, that Paris itself could use devaluation as a pressure tool. The reminder of the CFA franc's full mechanism belongs to Chapter 7; let us retain the essential here: €17 billion in African reserves remain held in Paris today — it is with this money that France lends Africans their own savings, disguised as development aid. A currency whose exchange rate and rules are decided elsewhere is not a currency, it is a leash.

The Eco and ECOWAS: reform or substitution?

The AES's path to monetary sovereignty is not the only one open. To the west, ECOWAS has for several years been carrying another project: the Eco, a single currency for a zone of 350 million people. At the Macron-African diaspora meeting at the Élysée, Ghanaian President Nana Akufo-Addo defended its logic with figures: intra-African trade represents only 15% of the continent's total trade, versus 60% within the European Union. The Eco should make it possible to build a common market on the scale of the Treaty of Rome — starting with countries meeting the convergence criteria, with others joining progressively; criteria defined, central bank model settled, a steering committee named including Ghana, Nigeria, Côte d'Ivoire, and Niger ("La palabre intellectuelle," *Afrique Média*, 2019).

It is precisely in this context that Emmanuel Macron's statement at the same event should be read: there would be "no taboo" regarding the CFA franc, and France was ready to move forward — provided "stability" was preserved. The word immediately caught analysts' attention. The question: does "stability" mean a fixed peg to the euro maintained de facto, protecting French multinationals' interests in the zone? And Jean Sa-Pollo recalls the underlying power-balance logic: "If France gives way on the CFA franc, it's only because Africans fought for it" — not out of strategic generosity, but in anticipation of pressure becoming unmanageable.

Analyst Bastion Parfait Ngom advances the most structural thesis: France is not conceding monetary reform, it is trying to get ahead of it in order to control its shape. Pushing toward an Eco pegged fixed to the euro means leaping over the challenge to the CFA while preserving the mechanism's essence — external determination of the exchange rate, which protects French imports and penalizes African exports. "Real independence will only come if Africans are the sole masters of managing their currency, with no outside interference over the peg mechanisms" (Ngom, "La palabre intellectuelle," *Afrique Média*, 2019). Nigeria, Africa's largest economy,

would, in his view, impose strict conditions before any commitment: refusing to enter what would otherwise be a "rigged market."

Analyst Patrick Wangem shifts the focus to the real economy: the real question is not monetary in the first place, it is freeing up bank credit and strengthening local production to rebalance a structurally deficit trade balance. A new currency without productive transformation is an empty shell — and if CEMAC does not follow this dynamic, social tensions will build there until destabilization.

The Eco debate thus points, by another path, to the same conclusion as the AES's own: monetary sovereignty is not decided by the name or the logo, but by three conditions — control of the exchange rate, autonomy of credit policy, the capacity to turn natural resources into domestic investment. On these three conditions, Macron's "stability" version of the Eco satisfies neither the first nor the second. The diagnosis converges with Tiani's: currency is the roof. You do not lay it before you have the walls.

What to base the AES currency on

A sovereign currency will need to be backed by a real economy. That economy exists. Mali and Burkina Faso are Africa's leading cotton producers. Mali is the continent's third-largest gold producer. Niger holds the world's third-largest uranium reserves. The AES bloc produces about 230 tonnes of gold per year. Cotton, gold, uranium, Nigerien oil: the objective base is there — provided their exploitation benefits national budgets first, not the shareholders of Barrick, Endeavour Mining, or Orano.

The stakes of a sovereign AES currency

<i>Dimension</i>	<i>Reality</i>
● Assets	Uranium (Niger), gold (Mali), cotton (Mali, Burkina), oil (Niger) — backing the currency with real resources
● Prerequisites	An independent AES central bank, an inter-AES clearing system
● Lessons to heed	Sango Coin (2022, technical failure) and \$CAR (2025, -90% on launch day) — haste kills
● Risks	Transitional inflationary pressure, speculative attacks against the new currency
● Horizon	African Monetary Institute announced for September 2026

The risks are real and must be named: transitional inflation, speculative attacks, and the precedent of all those who paid with their lives for merely raising the idea of leaving the CFA — Olympio, Sankara, Gaddafi. The latter was not merely at the project stage: he had repatriated 120 tonnes of gold, committed more than \$20 billion to African economies between 2000 and 2010, and launched three institutions — the African Monetary Fund in Yaoundé, the African Central Bank in Abuja, the African Investment Fund in Tripoli — to establish an African gold dinar that would have made continental trade independent of the dollar and the CFA franc. The project was in its final phase in 2011. The gold was there. The institutions were ready. Gaddafi was eliminated. Chapter 7 told the correlation; it is not anecdotal: it is the rule. A counter-example does exist, however: Mauritania, which left the franc zone back in 1973, lives with its own currency. The AES, for its part, advances step by step, knowing that in this arena a single mistake can cost ten years.

The CAR showed that the CFA chain could be defied — and what it costs to do so alone and too fast. The AES has the critical mass Bangui lacked: three states, a customs area under construction, strategic resources. What remains is choosing the moment. "At the right moment, we will decide," says Tiani.

But no currency is born in a vacuum: it is born into a world — and that world, precisely, is in the process of changing masters.

CHAPTER 29 — THE MULTIPOLAR WORLD: PARTNERS OR NEW MASTERS?

Ankara, June 4, 2026. General Abdourahamane Tiani steps down the aircraft stairs for his first major official visit to Turkey. Recep Tayyip Erdoğan receives him with full honors. Three years earlier, the man leading the AES's final lock was portrayed in Western chancelleries as a pariah to be strangled by sanctions. Here he is, welcomed as a strategic partner by a NATO member. The scene sums up the shift: Africa's security market has become multipolar — and this is perhaps the most immediately concrete geopolitical transformation of the entire Sahelian rupture.

But the question must be asked, and asked head-on: the AES has replaced French partners with Russian, Chinese, and Turkish ones. Sovereignty requires checking whether these new partnerships do not reproduce the logics of domination they were meant to replace. This chapter proposes a criterion for judging this: reversibility. A partner can be dismissed. A master cannot.

AES Partnerships — Phase 2 (2022–2026)

Partner | Contribution | Posture

- Russia (Africa Corps, formerly Wagner) — Instructors, Mi-8/Mi-35 helicopters, ground presence — Interventionist, visible
- |
- China — Infrastructure, digital surveillance, trade agreements — Less interventionist
- |
- Turkey — Bayraktar TB2 drones, agreements with Mali and Niger — Discreet, delivery without conditions
- |
- BRICS — Delegation in Ouagadougou (June 2023), six weeks before the Nigerien transition — Alternative framework

Russia: the burdensome ally and the unexpected argument

Russian cooperation is the most visible: instructors, helicopters, ground presence inherited from the Wagner setup turned Africa Corps. The question of Russian dependency, indeed, is among the possible conditions for the AES's own failure, as we will see in Chapter 31.

Moscow has also brought the AES something unprecedented: a diplomatic sounding board. On June 16, 2024, Dmitry Medvedev takes the floor before UNESCO and calls the CFA franc "monetary neocolonialism." He quotes Sankara. He puts the extraction of African wealth at \$62 trillion between 1960 and 2018. The

analysis is not wrong because it comes from Moscow. But it is the first time an official from a power sitting on the Security Council has used this framework in an international session. The pan-Africanist narrative has entered great-power diplomacy.

Vladimir Putin himself formulated the Russian doctrine in one sentence, since picked up by French commentators themselves: "I don't need to wage war on the West. It's enough for me to free Africa, and the West will collapse on its own." The formula must be read for what it is — a strategic calculation openly stated by a foreign head of state, not a neutral prophecy — but its underlying analysis has been taken up, figures in hand, by voices located inside France itself. One commentator puts the cost of France's African retreat at €300 to 500 billion a year — an order of magnitude far above the €41.2 billion in cumulative French subsidiary revenue documented earlier in this book (Chapter 30), which signals a different methodology, presumably including the full range of indirect, financial, and strategic flows that official foreign-trade statistics do not capture. The point of comparison chosen is telling: this sum, he argues, represents more than twenty times French income-tax revenue — set against a French social system that already costs between €700 and 800 billion a year (30 to 35% of GDP) and public debt exceeding €3 trillion. Whether or not the exact figure can be verified changes nothing about what it reveals: for a segment of French opinion itself, the loss of Africa is no longer a diplomatic non-issue — it has become a question of national budgetary sustainability.

An exchange recounted by Sergey Lavrov, Russia's foreign minister, illustrates the same logic on the diplomatic front. About five years ago, during the changes of government in the Sahel — Mali in particular — Lavrov says he met, on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly, Josep Borrell (then the EU's chief diplomat) and French foreign minister Jean-Yves Le Drian. Mali was then at the center of the international agenda, and Moscow was accused by its interlocutors of "supporting a change of government" — an accusation to which Lavrov replies that the new Malian government had itself asked Russia for help reforming its security structures, and that Moscow merely responded to that request. The French and Spanish rejoinder, as Lavrov recounts it, deserves to be quoted in full, because it says everything about the relationship of ownership Paris maintains toward the continent: "You know very well that the Sahel and Africa in general are our zone, that of the European Union." His response: "I don't know. I know there were colonial possessions, that political independence was proclaimed, that colonization ended. There are concrete UN resolutions. I have not read anywhere that the former colonies were assigned to you in perpetuity, as countries where others no longer have the right to set foot. But there you have it, that was their philosophy, and it seems to already be, it seems to me, in the genes of our French colleagues, who judge everyone by their own standards." This Russian testimony, self-interested by construction, nonetheless overlaps with a fact documented elsewhere in this book: the French reflex of treating the Sahel as a zone of belonging rather than as a set of sovereign nations. It is in this context that Lavrov replies to remarks made by Emmanuel Macron accusing Russia of being "a true colonizer" in Africa — a rhetorical reversal Moscow does not hesitate to exploit, while itself accusing Ukrainian trainers

and instructors present on the continent of seeking to ally with forces opposed to legitimate governments in order to establish themselves as a political factor and create difficulties for countries close to Russia — an accusation that mirrors the one documented earlier in this book (Chapter 20) concerning Ukrainian trainers alongside armed groups in the Sahel.

Luc Michel — the committed source encountered in Chapter 11 — adds an operational detail whose independent verification remains to be done: Russia is said to have supplied the Malian army with satellite imagery for tactical use. If accurate, this point cuts against what ten years of French presence had not granted: not just equipment, but the capacity to see and target autonomously. The partnership that empowers, against the cooperation that maintains dependency.

China: the partner you can sanction

The clearest reversibility test was, paradoxically, undergone by China. In March 2025, Tiani expels three senior executives of the CNPC oil company. The grounds are documented: wage discrimination — Chinese expatriates earned \$8,000 a month, their equally qualified Nigerien counterparts, \$1,200. Shortly after, a Chinese hotel is closed for tax fraud. Beijing protests; the contracts continue. The lesson stands as a demonstration: AES sovereignty operates both ways, including against its non-Western partners. No pro-Russian or pro-Chinese position. A pro-African stance that chooses its partners without submitting to them. Traoré's refusal of Saudi financing for 200 mosques, recounted in Chapter 17, belongs to the same grammar.

The counter-example exists, and it illuminates the criterion by contrast. Mamadi Doumbouya's Guinea diversifies its partnerships — military agreements with Turkey, an opening toward Russia — and Paris worries about it. But analyst Albert Anatole Ayissi points to the structural factor: Doumbouya is a former French legionnaire, married to a French gendarme. "He cannot break away. He married France." (For You Media Africa). Diversification without rupture is only a marginal negotiation within an intact dependency. Goïta, Traoré, and Tiani broke away; Doumbouya negotiates. That is the whole difference.

Turkey: the partner who delivers before being paid

Back to Ankara, because the Turkish relationship is the one that pushes the logic of partnership-without-tutelage the furthest. At the heart of the alliance: the Bayraktar TB2 drone, designed by Baykar, a company founded by Erdoğan's family. It proved itself in Libya (2019–2020), in Nagorno-Karabakh (2020), and in Ukraine (2022), shifting the balance of power each time at a cost incomparably lower than Western systems. For armies facing mobile groups across immense desert spaces, this is a surveillance and precision-strike capability neither France nor the United States had really shared over decades of presence.

And then there is the method. "President Erdoğan personally asked Turkish defense industries to deliver military equipment to Niger even before payment, granting Niamey financial facilities," notes a strategic report on Turkey-Sahel relations (June 2026). The gesture carries considerable symbolic weight: France demanded political concessions before delivering; the United States conditions its aid on certifications; Turkey delivers first. The message: you don't have to mortgage your sovereignty to get what you need.

The agreements signed on June 4, 2026 cover five areas — defense, security, energy, training, and infrastructure. Cooperation had begun well before the summit: an enhanced intelligence and training operation as early as July 2024, a military and financial cooperation agreement in 2025, training of Nigerien pilots on the TB2 in Turkey. On the energy side, the TPAO company eyes the Agadem oil basin, long the reserved domain of Chinese and Western actors. In fairness: this "total approach" also aims to create a lasting technical and human dependency — the NATO model, without the political subordination. Niamey knows this, and is precisely multiplying its partners to avoid trading one dependency for another.

Erdoğan's own positioning is a model closely studied in the Sahel: a NATO member trading with Russia, a supplier to Ukraine keeping an open channel with Putin. This calculated ambiguity is not duplicity — it is sovereignty fully claimed. It is exactly what the AES seeks to build: choosing its partners according to its interests, with no predetermined allegiance to a bloc.

A dissenting voice deserves to be added to the file, if only to be weighed. Luc Michel — the committed source encountered in Chapter 11 — rejects this portrait wholesale: for him, Turkey remains "NATO's second power," and its African activism, under the mask of partnership, extends a neo-Ottoman project backed by the American umbrella; he goes so far as to present Ankara as a "sponsor" of jihadist networks in Libya and Syria. The thesis is radical and partisan, and it runs into a stubborn fact: it is the AES states themselves — sovereign, and precisely concerned not to trade one tutelage for another — who chose Ankara after evaluating it.

In the very debate where Michel lays this out, another African analyst answers him — and his argument overlaps with this book's. Turkey, he objects, cannot be reduced to a Western pawn: it buys Russian S-400 defense systems in defiance of NATO's directives; it is itself the target of Western monetary attacks that have halved its currency; and on African construction sites, it employs local labor where others import their own. Algeria itself, long wary, has come to terms with the Turkish presence in Libya — which helped contain Marshal Haftar's offensive, which had threatened Algiers. Above all, he concludes, these investments "are not made on a master-to-slave basis." That is exactly this book's criterion. That the Turkish relationship was born of an Erdoğan calculation does not disqualify it: it is judged by its reversibility and by its acts — by what Ankara actually delivers and under what conditions — not by the imperial genealogies its adversaries attribute to it.

The United States: pragmatism and the window

Washington is not Paris. The United States defends interests, not a symbolic system. The withdrawal from the 201 base at Agadez, in spring 2024, is negotiated, not imposed: the Americans leave without slamming doors, leaving open the possibility of other cooperation — even though this eviction, recounted in Chapter 18, represents an unprecedented loss of intelligence capacity in the region.

Nathalie Yamb, at the great Niamey debate, reads Trump's election as a "window of opportunity": the AES's traditional adversaries no longer form a united front, Europe is destabilized. But she warns: if this window is not exploited, Europeans will rearm and "go find the money elsewhere, and elsewhere means us." One date gives the warning a troubling edge: on April 23, 2026, the EU Council finalizes €90 billion for Ukraine, €60 billion of it for defense. Two days later: the April 25 attacks in Mali. The chronological coincidence is noted by several analysts. It does not constitute proof. It constitutes a question.

Iran at the World Cup: the weaponization of multilateralism

A case from outside the continent, but perfectly legible from Bamako or Niamey.

2026 World Cup, American territory. Iran is the only participating country forced to leave the United States after every match and return the day before the next one. Its base camp, initially planned in Arizona, is moved to Tijuana, Mexico, just before the tournament. After its first match in Los Angeles, the Iranian players fly back. A twenty-minute charter flight between Tijuana and Los Angeles: five hours of security checks and additional screening. Five hours of transit after an exhausting match, instead of a quick return to the hotel for muscle recovery.

The US Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) prevents FIFA organizers from processing transactions with Iranian residents: Iranian fans cannot buy official tickets. The team plays its matches in a stadium with no supporters who bought their seats through normal channels.

Mehdi Taremi, the national team's captain, spoke out at the end of the group stage:

"THEY DID EVERYTHING TO ELIMINATE US. From the start, we've been fighting AGAINST EVERYTHING. We can't even stay in the host country. For every match, we travel, we go through immigration checks again and again. We just want to send a message of peace. But in return, no one treats us with that same peace."

FIFA president Infantino had visited the team in the locker room after the first match with the words: "This is only the beginning." He knew. He did not protest publicly. He took no compensatory measure. His presence was the management of a conscience, not an act of support.

What Iran endures in sport is what the AES endures in economics and diplomacy — the same hands,

the same logics:

- Exclusion from institutions: OFAC blocks ticket purchases / ECOWAS suspends sovereignist states
- Asymmetric sanction: Iran penalized on American soil, allied countries welcomed without constraint / Mali sanctioned for its coup, Chad spared for the same
- Façade neutrality: FIFA "above geopolitical considerations" / ECOWAS "defender of democracy" — supposedly universal institutions that execute the policy of the strongest

And yet: against Belgium, one of Europe's best teams, 0–0, held by a goalkeeper's monumental saves. Against New Zealand: 2–2. Against Egypt, a decisive match: a goal in the last second — disallowed for a one-centimeter offside. Eliminated by a centimeter. After five hours of transit before every match. Resilience under maximum constraint sometimes produces maximum performance. It is a lesson the Sahel knows well.

BRICS: circumventing rather than fighting

What remains is the horizon. At the October 2024 BRICS summit in Kazan, twenty-four heads of state are confirmed, including Xi Jinping, Lula da Silva, and Massoud Pezeshkian. The AES countries are not members, but their trajectory points toward this alternative to the G7 and G20 as a reference framework. BRICS offers what all previous African ruptures lacked: an alternative system — banks, trade circuits, diplomatic bodies — that strips Paris and Washington of their monopoly over the rules of the game. Hegemony is not fought only with rifles. It is bypassed.

The verdict of this survey thus holds to the criterion set out at the opening. Chinese executives expelled without breaking the contracts; mosques refused to Riyadh; drones delivered with no political conditions; an American door closed with no one dead. For now, the AES's partnerships remain reversible — that is their difference from the tutelage they replace, and it is by this criterion that they must continue to be judged.

But while the Alliance chooses its new partners, the old power has not disappeared: it is reorganizing itself — and it is this metamorphosis we must now look squarely at.

CHAPTER 30 — FRANÇAFRIQUE 2.0: THE RECOMPOSITION OF DOMINATION

"Paris used to speak to Africa. Now it must persuade Africa." — Jonathan Batenguène, Panafrican Media TV, May 10, 2026

Conakry, winter 2025–2026. In the Guinean capital's hotel lounges, delegations follow one after another. In under six months, some fifty French companies make round trips between Conakry and Paris to position themselves on Simandou H2040, Guinea's program for gradually nationalizing its mineral resources — adding to the forty large French groups that have controlled the Guinean subsoil for decades (Albert Anatole Ayissi). The logic is transparent: when an African country announces it is taking back control of its resources, France no longer sends soldiers. It sends prospectors.

This is the whole thesis of this chapter: France is not disappearing from the continent. It is reorganizing itself — less military, more economic, technological, and cultural. The recomposition does not change the objective. It changes the instrument.

Pivot states: shifting the center of gravity

The first instrument of the recomposition is geographic. Driven out of the Sahel, French diplomacy invests in new relays: Kenya, Nigeria, the DRC, Côte d'Ivoire, Cameroon — tomorrow's "pivot states." The "Africa Forward" summit, held with Kenya in May 2026, is its showcase: same interests, new facade. These countries do not refuse domination; they negotiate their terms of participating in it — what Malcolm X called the "house slave." "France today is a label. It no longer belongs to itself. Imperialism, for its own survival, is ready to make concessions with states that would become pivot states," analyzes Jonathan Batenguène (Panafrican Media TV, May 10, 2026).

But even the traditional backyard is no longer secure: Banda Kani publicly calls on CEMAC and Paul Biya for Central Africa to invest alongside the Central African people in endogenous development structures. Contestation no longer comes only from the Sahel. It rises from within the very francophone space that remains in Paris's orbit. "France gives the illusion of having left while controlling the monetary and economic levers," sums up Charly Kengne (L'intermédiation de la servitude, March 17, 2026).

The French Wagner: preventive privatization of military neocolonialism

There is a third instrument of the recomposition that geopolitical analysis almost systematically overlooks, because it presents itself in market terms rather than strategic ones. In February 2019 — four years before the Sahel expulsions — a report by the École supérieure de la sûreté des entreprises (ESSE) calls for the creation of one or two large French private security and defense companies (ESSDs), endowed with enough financial capacity to “confront their foreign competitors.” The text is signed by ESSE’s director of development. The explicit target for development: West Africa.

Reading this report in 2019 is reading a contingency plan. France was not waiting for the expulsions to build its response: it was already building it. The privatization of the French military presence in Africa is not a post-Barkhane improvisation — it is a long-prepared architecture, whose first stones were laid before the Sahel had even announced its decision.

The report names the American reference model: Academi — the former Blackwater, the notorious PMC of Iraq and Afghanistan — bought and refounded within the Constellis group along with Triple Canopy and others. France wants its own Blackwater, for Africa. This is not a polemical formula: it is the analogy chosen by French private-security experts themselves.

The report’s most revealing admission concerns human resources: *“Anglo-Saxon groups have long remained consumers of specialized French or francophone resources. They freely recruited from the ranks of the Foreign Legion or special forces, without however developing a precise strategy for the French sector, contenting themselves with subcontracting to certain ESSDs, particularly in West Africa.”* Let us decode. The French taxpayer finances the training of legionnaires and special forces — among the best-trained in the world. These soldiers then go to work for American, British, or Canadian private companies, which deploy them *“particularly in West Africa.”* The state trains; the private sector exploits; Africa suffers. France subcontracts its own mercenaries to its own competitors — and now wants to reclaim them for itself.

The financial loop is closed by a detail the report mentions as anecdotal: French ESSDs win contracts to protect the European External Action Service (EEAS)’s diplomatic missions. European diplomacy subcontracts its security to former French soldiers. The EU thus indirectly finances French mercenarism in Africa — in the name of common foreign policy.

Ibrahim Traoré described this mechanism in his own words, at the January 13, 2025 flag-raising ceremony: *“They won’t leave certain countries. They’ve simply dissolved the setup. You won’t see them in bases anymore — but in the embassies, they’ll be there. They’ll form security companies to secure their companies operating in those countries. The soldiers will be there, but you won’t see them in uniform anymore, gathered in bases. That’s all it means.”* The Burkinabé captain describes in one minute the plan the ESSE was drafting in 2019. When the target names the trap with such precision, it means the trap is visible.

After 2023, this pattern stops being a project and becomes a reality. Driven out of Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger by sovereign decisions, France did not disarm — it changed uniforms. ESSDs are Barkhane without

the kepi. They operate from Benin, Côte d'Ivoire, Cameroon — the new pivot states — with the same ex-legionnaires, the same drones, the same intelligence networks. What Thomas Dietrich documented in July 2024 in Tourou (French soldiers present in Benin, EU-funded drones worth €11.7 million) is not an anomaly: it is the ESSD model in action, five years after the report that planned it.

Air France, or the corporation as a political weapon

The second instrument is commercial, and one case illustrates it in action. When Air France suspends its flights to Bamako, Ouagadougou, and Niamey to politically sanction the transitions, it uses a commercial license granted by these states to carry out a political action. A private company turns a landing right into a diplomatic lever — and reveals, in the process, that the boundary between corporation and state has never really existed in the Franco-African relationship.

Nathalie Yamb draws precise legislative proposals from this: requiring multinationals to post a bond equal to a year's revenue as a guarantee of non-interference in politics; revoking tax exemptions; having transition councils pass laws sanctioning foreign companies' intrusion into politics. For the reciprocity is real: according to economist Diop's estimates, Air France earned 500 million CFA francs a day on the Malian destination alone. These companies depend on Africa as much as Africa depends on them. Coming to make money, yes. Coming to destabilize, no. This legal framework does not yet exist. It is necessary.

Canal Plus Afrique illustrates the same logic in broadcasting. The group, owned by Vivendi, claims 9.7 million subscribers in Africa, coverage of 350 million viewers, and brand recognition above 96% in several markets on the continent. In Cameroon alone, its annual revenue is estimated at several tens of billions of CFA francs. Africa is not a secondary market for Canal Plus — it is one of the structural pillars of its business model. Yet for years, Canal Plus Afrique relegated national public channels to the margins of its bundles, or omitted them, in favor of its own content offerings. Why should channels financed by African taxpayers depend on a foreign operator's goodwill to be visible to their own population? Burkina Faso has just answered with a regulatory act: the Conseil supérieur de la communication (CSC) fined Canal Plus Afrique 50 million CFA francs for a serious breach of its legal obligations — failure to comply with mandatory and continuous broadcast of national public channels on its bundles. The fine says three things: that the national broadcast space is sovereign; that foreign commercial licenses carry enforceable counterparts; and that the balance of power between a private operator and a regulating state is reversible. Air France, Canal Plus: two French companies, two different sectors, one same logic — the commercial license granted by an African state can be withdrawn or sanctioned if the company oversteps into politics or neglects its legal obligations. A market of nearly a billion and a half people is a power, not a customer.

What the trade decline hides: the 2,421 subsidiaries

A 2025 report by the association Survie, titled *What remains of France's economic interests in Africa?*, allows a precise measurement of the gap between the narrative of French decline and the reality of its residual grip — a gap that is the keystone of the recomposition described in this chapter. On the purely commercial level, the finding is unambiguous: France's market share in sub-Saharan Africa fell from 15% in the late 1970s to 3% today, and France is now, for most of the subcontinent, only a secondary trading partner. This decline, the report specifies, predates Chinese competition: it results first from French deindustrialization itself, which reduced the metropole's direct needs for African raw materials — cotton, bauxite, iron ore — well before Asian products erupted onto the continent.

But foreign trade figures, the report warns, are "very imperfect" for measuring the reality of French interests: globalization has fragmented value chains to the point that Burkinabé cotton now becomes a t-shirt sold in Paris after passing through an Asian factory — never transiting directly through France, and therefore never appearing in its import statistics. To measure the real grip, one must look elsewhere: the fabric of subsidiaries. France displays a singularity neither Germany nor the Netherlands — bigger exporters to some African markets — possess: 2,421 French company subsidiaries operating in sub-Saharan Africa — six times more than German subsidiaries, nine times more than Dutch ones — generating an average of €41.2 billion in annual revenue, nearly four times the total value of French exports to the region. This revenue passes through no customs post, appears in no trade statistics, and yet it weighs directly on the African economies where these subsidiaries operate — before profits are repatriated to their parent companies.

This grip, which the report documents figure by figure, is concentrated almost exclusively in the former *pré carré*. The weight of these subsidiaries in national GDP reaches considerable levels: 16.3% in Gabon, 15.6% in Senegal, 13.2% in Congo, 12.4% in Burkina Faso, 11.6% in Côte d'Ivoire (2019–2021 data) — more than the weight of the informal sector in many of these economies, even as this same revenue represents only 2.3% of the total activity of French multinationals abroad. The asymmetry is total: what is marginal for Paris is overwhelming for Libreville, Dakar, or Ouagadougou.

Côte d'Ivoire and Senegal together illustrate the system's resilience in its sturdiest strongholds. They are the only two countries where French exports rise significantly in value over the last decade — +70% for Côte d'Ivoire between 2011 and 2021, while they fall 22% in Cameroon and 53% in Gabon and Congo over the same period. French subsidiaries' revenue grows just as much: +116% in Côte d'Ivoire, +36% in Senegal between 2010–2012 and 2019–2021, employing 35,000 and nearly 20,000 people respectively in 2020. Yet neither country accounts for more than 0.4% of the total revenue of French multinationals abroad. France is indispensable to these economies. These economies are incidental to France. This is very precisely the definition of an asymmetric relationship — and it is very precisely what explains why popular mobilizations, from the "Auchan

dégage” movement in Dakar in 2018 to the riots over Ousmane Sonko’s arrest in 2021, systematically target French brands: they are not abstract symbols, they are the daily infrastructure — water, electricity, telephony, retail — of a dependency that foreign trade statistics, on their own, never allow one to see.

The Francophonie: the last empire

The term “francophonie” was coined in 1883 by Onésime Reclus, a French geographer and former colonial soldier, in his work “France Algérie et colonies”: France’s survival and preeminence, in his view, depended on the expansion of its language — an expansion achievable only through the unreserved domination of other peoples. The word’s inventor laid out the institution’s truth from the start. Jonathan Batenguene, a sociologist at the University of Douala, notes that France then simply copied the British model: “The English in the 1930s created the Commonwealth after realizing that the dynamics of decolonization were inevitable and irreversible. They needed to prepare the consolidation of the Empire around a mutual understanding — a consensus around the English language, with rules set by the English but accepted by the community as being behind what everyone knows is England pulling the strings.” France picked up the same model in 1970. The underlying formula is borrowed from Rousseau: “The strongest is never strong enough to be always the master, unless he transforms strength into right, and obedience into duty.” One no longer strikes; one makes people want.

The third instrument is the oldest and most discreet: language. The French language in Africa is an architecture, not a mere inheritance — designed, funded, institutionalized to keep African elites within an intellectual sphere favorable to Paris after the colonial armies left. “The Francophonie will one day take over from colonization,” de Gaulle is said to have declared in 1966. What is established is what followed: four years later, Pompidou creates the Agency for Cultural and Technical Cooperation — the ancestor of the OIF — to make “linguistic cement” the mortar of the Franco-African bloc. Culture as a substitute for the army; and, at the United Nations, a reservoir of voices trained to think within French conceptual categories. Forty-nine OIF member countries represent forty-nine potential votes at the General Assembly. France’s “rank” — its claim to a Security Council seat — rests partly on this African multiplication. The Francophonie is a voting mechanism as much as a cultural space.

General Tiani goes further: in his view, the OIF is part of a “Sahel cell” created at the Élysée in 2024, with unlimited funds, waging an information war against the Sahel’s regimes. What is independently confirmed, however, is the response: the withdrawal of the three AES countries from the OIF in March 2025 — during Francophonie Week. The timing was the message.

Macron himself unwittingly confirmed this reading by adopting the phrase “Francophonie of reconquest.” The term says it all. One only reconquers what one has lost. The Francophonie is no longer just a shared cultural space — it is a territory to be retaken. The confession is in the military vocabulary.

The irony of history is that the instrument now escapes its designer. According to the 2014 Attali report, the number of French speakers could grow from 230 million in 2014 to 770 million in 2060 — 85% of them African. A “Francophonie without France,” developing autonomously from the former metropole. At the same time, France’s market share in French-speaking Africa has collapsed, from 11% to 5.5% in a decade.

<i>Indicator</i>	<i>Figure</i>
● French speakers in 2014	230 million
● Projected French speakers in 2060	770 million
● African share in 2060	85%
● France’s market share in francophone Africa (2010)	11%
● France’s market share in francophone Africa (2024)	5.5%

The Francophonie grows. French influence shrinks. The language outlives the empire that imposed it. The language remains. The French economy retreats. And when Macron declares in Djerba that “the Francophonie is the language of pan-Africanism” (November 19, 2022), he appropriates the very vocabulary of resistance — a sign, as Banda Kani had anticipated, that the semantic battle is lost for whoever must borrow their opponent’s words.

The reverse doctrine already exists: when Traoré has pan-Africanist works translated into Mooré and distributed them in villages, he asserts that French can remain a tool for international communication without remaining a tool of mental colonization — provided African languages stop being marginalized. One does not decolonize minds in two years of transition. But one can start.

Jonathan Batenguene describes the mechanism of intellectual alienation with a precision that goes beyond politics: it is the personality itself that is worked on. “An acceptance of domination has been built into you — a naturalization of domination. Right now, you feel like things are just normally that way” (Batenguene, Panafrican Media TV, June 2026). On the education front, the Jules Ferry model — cycles modeled on the French system, imposed on all member countries — has produced longer curricula than the Anglo-Saxon sys-

tem for less competitive results in terms of international integration. And it has marginalized the great African languages within their own school space: Bambara, Mooré, Hausa, Wolof — languages of tens of millions of people, vehicles of millennia-old cultures — were confined to the domestic sphere. The one notable exception: Swahili, which survived and thrived as a language of communication in East Africa. Everywhere else, the public language, the language of law, the language of the state: French. A population that can only access its own historical archives by going through translation into the colonizer's language is a population whose access to the past is controlled. On the academic front, francophone African researchers are systematically repositioned as commentators on Western science: "No matter how brave you are in Africa, you can only be aligned with the models of the two great francophone poles — France and Canada. We have professors who spend most of their time talking about other people's work rather than their own." Francophone intellectual cooperation, concretely, is a monopoly held by Paris and Toronto over the definition of what counts as legitimate knowledge in the francophone zone. The postdoc mechanism illustrates the chain: an African researcher sent to further their training in Brussels encounters work developed with little knowledge of the African terrain, but "subtly" applied to it — they come back adapting frameworks designed elsewhere. "It's the most dangerous pattern: people are manufactured and presented as figures of excellence, but who are in fact the epitome of the household help" (Batenguene).

The Rwandan case is the empirical demonstration that an exit is possible — and that Paris knows its price. After the 1994 genocide and French complicity exposed, Kigali left the Francophonie, joined the Commonwealth, and adopted English and Kinyarwanda as national languages. Paris's response was mechanical: to bring Rwanda back into the francophone orbit, France offered the OIF presidency to Louise Mushikiwabo, then Rwandan foreign minister. "Leaving the Francophonie is giving yourself the means to influence its rules. From inside, you can't change much" (Batenguene).

The master's language has become the freedman's weapon. Fanon wrote in French. Sankara spoke in French. The AES's leaders address in French the crowds that cheer them. This reversal is not paradoxical — it is the exact answer of peoples who understood the mechanism and decided to turn it around.

The proposed way out is programmatic, not catastrophist: a ten-year reform of education curricula toward national languages; African linguistics institutes to codify languages with strong dissemination potential — Bambara, Fulfulde, Swahili, Lingala; and a major effort to translate key scientific works into African languages, on the model of what Europe did during the Renaissance by translating Arab authors to bring forth European science in vernacular language. "For Greek to become Europe, Europeans had to translate Arab authors. That's the work the new African generation can set for itself" (Batenguene, Panafrican Media TV, June 2026). He attaches a direct geopolitical anchor to this: Mali, Guinea Conakry, Burkina Faso, and Niger — which share Bambara as a major language of communication — could build a linguistic federation that would be to the Sahelian space what the Francophonie was to France's backyard: a space of cultural sovereignty, but

this time in service of the peoples who speak it.

Montpellier 2021: civil society as an instrument

The method was not new. On October 8, 2021, in Montpellier, Emmanuel Macron had already held a "New Africa-France Summit" of an unprecedented kind: no African head of state invited, but a gathering of young people "from civil society," selected from across the continent. Officially, the point was to turn the page on "corrupt leaders" and reinvent a shared imaginary. In the National Assembly, a French deputy himself wondered whether Macron had "become the president of Africans." In Mali, the National Youth Council sent a letter to the French embassy disavowing those who had claimed to represent the country. The format — a French president speaking to a hand-picked "African youth," with no states present — foreshadowed, point for point, the Élysée diaspora summit four years later.

Not everything there was docile, however. A young Burkinabé woman delivered the president her "four truths," spinning a proverb about the cooking pot: you don't change dishes as long as the pot stays dirty — and the pot was *Françafrique*. Macron laughed from the stage, to applause. The laugh was itself an answer: contestation is heard, policy does not change. Another speaker reframed the stakes with a phrase that said everything about the shift in expectations — "you're not here to help us develop; we're here to co-develop." The only relationship this generation would now accept lay in that prefix: as equals, or nothing.

Luc Michel, already encountered in Chapter 11, offers a more radical reading, reported here with its activist charge. For him, Montpellier is the "French version" of a tried-and-tested American setup: "civil society" as a lever. He recalls the precedent of the August 2014 US-Africa Summit in Washington, where Obama received the heads of state — and where, on the sidelines, a counter-summit of African "civil society" was held. The mechanism, he argues, is that of "color revolutions" tested since Belgrade in 2000: financing and promoting youth groups presented as spontaneous, to weaken powers deemed unruly and prepare their replacement. One need not follow Michel all the way — his thesis is partisan and drifts, in places, into blanket denunciation. But its core meets, by another path, this chapter's central thesis: unable to send soldiers or receive presidents, one summons a chosen "civil society." The instrument changes; the goal — shaping the interlocutor rather than meeting one — remains.

This reading need not be taken on faith — except that an unimpeachable source corroborates it. The "black scenario" from *L'Express* mentioned in Chapter 12, drafted with some forty researchers, generals, and former intelligence officers, and which the weekly notes "overlaps with those the French military is already working on," lists the levers Paris keeps in hand for the post-rupture period. One of them is stated without detour: "the French are today conducting real underground efforts to maintain contact with the civil societies of the countries in question, so as, when the time comes, to once again become the preferred interlocutor." The

sentence does not come from a pan-Africanist pamphlet: it comes from establishment work, backed by the military and intelligence services. What Michel denounces as a maneuver, French expertise owns as a strategy. "Underground efforts," "preferred interlocutor": the vocabulary says it all. Civil society is not merely listened to — it is cultivated, behind the scenes, as the way back in.

A distinction remains to be drawn, since everything here hinges on the dividing line. Not every African civil society is a front: trade unionists, critical intellectuals, exiled oppositions such as those Tchicaya called for at the Élysée are its most living part. Michel's suspicion only holds for the manufactured showcases — the ones invited precisely because they will not carry the contradiction. The line is not "civil society against states"; it runs between voices that emanate from peoples and those summoned to stand in for them.

The diaspora summit, or the recycling of paradigms

Paris, 2025. Emmanuel Macron invites dozens of members of the African diaspora to the Élysée. Declared intention: "build a new pivot with Africa," finally break away from "old patterns." The analysis by Jean-Claude Félix Tchicaya, a researcher at the Institut de prospective et de sécurité en Europe (IPSE), is surgical — and all the more valuable because it does not come from the pan-Africanist camp: "This is already heard before in France, even at the Élysée, with Nicolas Sarkozy, François Hollande, who wanted to break away from *Françafrique*" (Tchicaya, IPSE, televised commentary, 2025). Same declared intention. Same structural obstruction. Different president, same words.

The first critique concerns the category itself. "Africa is 55 countries" — from Algiers to Cape Town — and yet it continues to be addressed as a homogeneous, racially defined entity. "It's the only territory, the only continent in the world that gets addressed this way": one does not speak "to Asia" or "to Europe" in this register. The essentialization is not a protocol oversight: it is the condition for the lecture. One cannot lecture 55 states with their geopolitical conflicts, their distinct economic trajectories, their internal oppositions. One can, however, lecture "Africa" — a single object, unified by the gaze that summons it. Macron declares he does not want to do this; he does it, because the structure of the relationship leaves him no other grammar.

The second critique concerns the room's composition. The invited diaspora was "handpicked" — a qualitative difference from Ouagadougou in November 2017, where Burkinabé students had directly confronted Macron. In Paris: no exiled opposition figures, no dissidents, no voices that "cannot precisely express their disagreement" from their country of origin. Yet these are precisely the actors who form the diaspora's most living political capital — those who paid with their freedom or their lives for "the wish to live in democracy in their country." Tchicaya explicitly pays them tribute, where the Élysée had simply set them aside. A summit on "the new Africa" whose most critical voices are absent is, structurally, a summit of the old Africa.

The third critique is perhaps the most revealing: among the guests, athletes and musicians. "Culture

matters, music and sport matter” — but “often people talk a little more about sport and music when it comes to Africa.” Inviting Australia or China with athletes would be inconceivable: one deals with their political and economic actors because one recognizes them as powers. The exclusion of African geopolitical actors in favor of the cultural showcase is not a casting accident: it is a sedimented mode of relationship. Talking to athletes is talking to individuals. Talking to economic and political actors is talking to a power — and that is precisely what Africa has become, at a time when the AfCFTA is building a common market of a billion and a half people, which Tchicaya compares to the Treaty of Rome as the founding moment of an autonomous continental economic space.

Tchicaya finally points to what the rhetoric of a “new start” carefully erases: “Leaving *Françafrique* also means leaving *Afrique-France* — because in the creation of *Françafrique*, there were as many Africans as French agreeing to set it up. So a reciprocal movement is needed.” *Françafrique* is not a system imposed on a passive Africa: it is a co-built system. Its deconstruction requires both parties to move simultaneously. A French president can summon the diaspora to the *Élysée*; that does not constitute a “reciprocal movement.” A real reciprocal movement would include African oppositions, trade unionists, critical intellectuals — and the recognition that the migrants arriving in the Mediterranean wearing orange life vests are, at least in part, the product of a French policy in Libya (Chapter 11): “Are we, France and Europe, not at all responsible, sometimes giving to Libya where there is slavery?” (Tchicaya, 2025).

Tchicaya’s analysis meets here this chapter’s central thesis: the recomposition does not change the objective. It changes the instrument. Yesterday soldiers; today athletes at the *Élysée*, a reformed Francophonie, more discreet companies. But in every case, an “Africa” summoned as an object — never met as a subject.

Arrogance as doctrine

What remains is the last instrument, the most revealing because it is involuntary: contempt. It is not an accidental feature of the Franco-African relationship. It is structural, repeated, institutionalized — its constancy over two centuries is itself a data point.

January 2025: before France’s ambassadors, Macron denounces “African ingratitude.” The word says it all. France expects gratitude from Africa — for what, exactly? For the foreign-exchange reserves captured since 1945? For Nigerien uranium bought below market price for sixty years? For jihadist zones tripled in seven years of Barkhane? Three heads of state respond publicly: Mahamat Déby, Ousmane Sonko, Ibrahim Traoré. Traoré’s response, on January 14, 2025, is the sharpest: “If he’s not an atheist, if he prays every time he wakes up, he should also pray to Africans, because it is thanks to our ancestors that France exists today. We are not human in his eyes.”

The contempt also flows through local relays — such as Hassoumi Massaoudou calling, on LCI, the

demonstrations of support for the CNSP "choreographies bought for 1,500 euros" (August 2, 2023), erasing in one sentence a popular mobilization without precedent in ten years. And it sometimes takes the form of condescension disguised as respect: "Africa doesn't need to be told what's good for it," Macron assures in Nairobi in May 2026 — while continuing to do exactly that.

Yet arrogance is the last refuge of those who have lost the balance of power but refuse to admit it. French institutions themselves have acknowledged it, as we saw in Chapter 15: dependency has reversed. *Françafrique* spits its last flames. But it spits.

Luc Michel — encountered in Chapters 11 and 29, with his acknowledged partisan charge — reads in this the behavior of a power that has not adjusted its attitude to its real rank: a superpower until Waterloo, a great power until 1940, a secondary power ever since — but a secondary power refusing to behave as such. The formula is militant in form, but it meets a more sober diagnosis that political science has long endorsed: since de Gaulle, France compensates through symbolic assertion for what it can no longer sustain through material means. And what Michel states as an accusation, General Lecointre has since confirmed in institutional language (Chapter 15): if Europe must one day "act as a political entity" and defend its interests "through the deployment of its armies," it is indeed because France, alone, no longer can. The form differs; the finding is the same. In Africa, this gap takes a particular shape. Michel sees simultaneously five fronts of Franco-Russian confrontation — Mali, the Central African Republic, Lebanon, Belarus, with the war in Ukraine as backdrop —, of which the Sahel is only one theater. Whether or not he is right on every detail, this framework illuminates something the word "ingratitude" cannot explain: a power sure of itself has no need for that word. It uses it because it needs Africa to remain what it no longer is.

The Nairobi sequence, May 2026, under the fact-check lens

Two speeches a day apart condense this entire chapter. On May 11, 2026, at the "Africa Forward" summit in Nairobi, then on May 12 in an interview — three weeks after the attack that killed Sadio Camara — Emmanuel Macron deploys the same communications offensive: presenting a defeat on the ground as a chosen transformation. Let us weigh it here against the facts already established in these pages. Let us begin with the interview, where he answers a simple question: in hindsight, what would you have done differently in Mali? His answer illustrates, in action, this book's central mechanism.

The first slippage is chronological. "France came in 2013 at President Keïta's request," Macron states. But *Serval* is launched on January 11, 2013; Keïta is not elected until August. The call comes from interim president Dioncounda Traoré — and above all, Raphaël Granvaud's investigation establishes that the Sahel plan, including its clandestine military component, was decided as early as 2008–2009 (Chapter 15). One does not "come at the request" of a setup prepared five years in advance: the January 2013 request supplied the legal

packaging for an already-planned presence.

The second slippage conceals the fire's origin. The heavily armed groups "coming from the north" in 2012 came out of the Libyan arsenals scattered after the 2011 Franco-NATO intervention (Chapter 11). France helped light the fire it then presents itself as having come to put out.

The third is the boldest: invoking the temporary fall of Kidal in April 2026 to indict the transition. This counts on the forgetting of two facts (Chapter 16). In May 2013, it was the French army itself that barred the Malian army from Kidal — the soldier turned away that day was named Assimi Goïta. And on November 14, 2023, it was the "coup-plotter" FAMa scorned by Macron who retook Kidal in under twenty-four hours — something Barkhane had not managed in ten years. The April 2026 fall does not indict the transition: it indicts the backers of an FLA that itself claims "good contacts with the Ukrainians, France, the United States" (Chapter 20).

The fourth reverses the security accusation: the transitions supposedly "preferred Russian militias to counterterrorism." But it is French chief of staff Burkhard who, behind closed doors in September 2024, places FAMa and Wagner in the same boat, admitting that France "has no camp of friends in Mali" (Chapter 15). And it was under Russian partnership that Kidal was retaken. The criterion is the result on the ground, not the partner's flag.

The fifth is a confession disguised as a grievance: "ingratitude." As stated above: arrogance is the last refuge of one who has lost the balance of power. Gratitude for what — uranium paid below market for sixty years, jihadist zones tripled in seven years of Barkhane (ACLED, Chapter 13)? As for "false information," on the decisive point it is the adversary who settles the matter: on May 9, 2026, a French security source confirms on RTL that "francophone ex-legionnaires are working with Ukraine's GUR." Macron loses his temper at the journalist; he does not deny the substance (Chapter 20).

The sixth is self-criticism calibrated to concede nothing essential: "we should have been more demanding on development" from the 2017 G5 Sahel onward. Macron admits an error of degree to silence the error of nature. As early as 2017 he acknowledged that without governance the war could not be won — and pursued it for seven more years. The Védrine report (2013) ranked pan-Africanism, not jihadism, among the threats (Chapter 15). The failure is not a lack of rigor: it is in the objective.

The seventh and last is this very chapter's thesis, spoken by the accused: "we rethought everything — partnership on equal footing, bases renamed with African names, co-management." Renaming a base, co-managing it, moving from soldier to trainer: this is the exact definition of recomposition. "On equal footing": the phrase is refuted by the ghost army rebuilt in Benin while the speech proclaims withdrawal (Chapter 20). And the decisive test remains reversibility (Chapter 29): the AES states did not renegotiate the French presence, they expelled it — proof it was not reversible through dialogue. The "equal footing" claimed in 2026 is the kind granted after being driven out.

THE MAY 12 INTERVIEW, UNDER THE FACT-CHECK LENS

"Came at Keïta's request" in 2013: Serval starts before Keïta's election; Sahel plan decided as early as 2008–2009 (ch. 15)

"Terrorists coming from the north": weapons from the Libyan arsenals of 2011, opened up by the Franco-NATO intervention (ch. 11)

Kidal blamed on the transition: barred to FAMa by the French army in 2013, retaken by FAMa in 2023 (ch. 16)

"Russian militias preferred to counterterrorism": it is General Burkhard who places FAMa and Wagner in the same boat (ch. 15)

"Ingratitude": confession of a lost balance of power; jihadist zones tripled in seven years of Barkhane (ch. 13)

"False information": ex-legionnaire/GUR support confirmed by a French security source on RTL, not denied (ch. 20)

"Partnership on equal footing, renamed bases": the very definition of recomposition; French presence expelled, not renegotiated (ch. 29)

What remains is the summit itself, and its most eloquent silence. Pressed by a journalist on the absence of Mali, Burkina, and Niger, Macron retorts that "West Africa will indeed be here" — Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire — and that "only three countries" are missing. The arithmetic masks the selection: adding up those present so as not to name what the withdrawal of the three states that precisely broke away means. But the most telling absence lies elsewhere. Cyril Ramaphosa's South Africa, initially officially invited, does not come. According to information Paris denies, Ramaphosa was reportedly disinvited under pressure from Washington — the Trump administration — with Kenya taking its place. The account is unverifiable at this stage and must be handled as such. But the hypothesis, true or false, points to a question the denial does not dissolve: a power forced to arbitrate the list of its own African guests according to American preferences would no longer be a first-rank power. This is very precisely the "secondary power" diagnosis raised above — no longer as a militant thesis, but as a hypothesis that a summit's guest list suddenly makes plausible.

Next comes the central denial: "I have never treated francophone Africa as my backyard," Macron repeats, dating his conversion to the 2017 Ouagadougou speech. The sentence is refuted by the very summit hosting it: seeking anglophone "pivot states" — Kenya, Nigeria — to make up for the lost francophone backyard is admitting there was a backyard, and that a successor is being sought for it. The denial contradicts itself in the very breath of the strategy it serves. Macron goes further: "We are the real pan-Africanists." One only proclaims oneself the legitimate holder of a word once one has lost it — this is the semantic defeat Banda Kani announced, already at work when Macron made the Francophonie "the language of pan-Africanism" in

Djerba in 2022. And the material reality persists beneath the renovated vocabulary: 2,400 French subsidiaries in sub-Saharan Africa, about €41 billion in annual revenue (2019–2021), profits massively repatriated to the metropole. The backyard one swears never to have possessed has an accounting ledger.

What remains is the most easily verifiable claim, and therefore the riskiest: "France no longer makes or unmakes governments — that's been over since 2017." Chapter 20 documented this down to the bone: Rémy Quignolot arrested in Bangui in 2021, Yann Vésilier detained in Bamako, the 5 billion CFA francs offered to Burkinabé soldiers for an overthrow in 2024, the ghost army rebuilt in Benin, the France-Ukraine-Sahel channel down to drones offered to Malian opponents in 2025. This claim is not false because pan-Africanists dispute it; it is false because Malian, Central African, and Burkinabé judges hold the agents, the briefcases, and the case files. Between "that's been over since 2017" and the facts lies the distance of a measurable lie.

Two final pieces, at last: one repeats a device already named, the other calls for nuance. The first: asked about the AES regimes' absence, Macron replies that one can be "in disagreement with the regimes — Traoré, Goïta" without being so "with the peoples," and announces he will address "civil society, including that of Sahel countries." This is, word for word, the instrument dissected above regarding Montpellier 2021: bypassing states one can no longer summon by addressing a handpicked "civil society," presented as the voice of the peoples. Nairobi invents nothing; the device is renewed at the continental scale. The second piece, on the other hand, is a real act: the day before the summit, a law on the restitution of cultural property to the African continent was enacted. This must be acknowledged without reservation — it is a concrete gesture, long promised and long deferred. But it must also be placed in context: restitution belongs to the cultural lever, the cheapest of the recomposition's instruments. Returning looted works commits neither the CFA franc, nor the mining contracts, nor the proxy war of Chapter 20. One can return masks and keep the rent. The gesture is right; it does not settle the account.

THE AFRICA FORWARD SUMMIT, UNDER THE FACT-CHECK LENS

South Africa absent: Ramaphosa disinvited in favor of Kenya, under American pressure according to sources Paris denies — a power that no longer arbitrates alone

"Never a backyard": the quest for anglophone "pivot states" confesses the lost backyard it seeks to replace

"We are the real pan-Africanists": the word is claimed once it has been lost (Banda Kani; Djerba, 2022)

"Neither making nor unmaking governments since 2017": refuted by Quignolot, Vésilier, the 5 billion Burkinabé francs, the ghost army (ch. 20)

"We love the peoples, not the regimes": the Montpellier 2021 "civil society" device, renewed at the continental scale

Cultural property restitution law: a real act, but the cheapest lever — commits neither the CFA franc, nor the contracts, nor the proxy war

What remains is a point Macron states without measuring its weight: "it's the Malian people who are suffering." That is true — and it is precisely what this book has documented from the start. But a people's suffering under the blows of armed groups equipped, informed, and recycled by outside networks (Chapter 20) is not an argument against its sovereignty: it is that sovereignty's most tragic justification. The Nairobi sequence is not an analysis of failure. It is failure telling itself one last story.

The four most dangerous years

The French recomposition fits into a broader, more perilous geopolitical moment. Donald Trump's arrival at the White House has reshuffled the cards: Europeans, Nathalie Yamb observes, "no longer have a say in what happens on their own continent." International law fades away; only the law of the strongest remains. And in this vacuum, Africa risks becoming the theater of the proxy war Washington will wage against China, once its relations with Russia have calmed. Her warning is blunt:

"If we don't close the door on the CFA franc, on the Francophonie, on the International Criminal Court, on the WHO, on the Paris Climate Agreement, on official development aid; if we don't unite to develop a vision of shared interests — not through the African Union, ECOWAS, and CEMAC, which are completely rotten instruments serving outside interests, but through new institutions — then the next four years will be the riskiest and most dangerous for us, and will mark the return of a violent and lasting colonization of Africa." — Nathalie Yamb

The accusation also targets African leaders themselves: "You let them come in and decide what should happen in our country. You are complicit. They are slaves like us, and you let them behave as masters." The diagnosis is relentless and spares no one: "In Africa, we have everything we need — except the right people in the right positions and the right mindset." The AES, she concludes, "shows in embryonic form what must be done." To the others, this order: "Fix your countries. Recess is over. Get to work, right now."

This call is a timetable, not a cry of despair. It sets a window — four years — and a list — six umbilical cords to be cut. The Sahelian rupture is, in this reading, only the beginning of a movement the rest of the continent will have to join, or regret.

Behind this facade of contempt, however, there is something else — a fear, deep and documented; and it is by anatomizing it that we discover what the AES must achieve in order to survive.

The paper border: €10,530 or nothing

Starting August 1, 2026, France requires every non-European student to prove they have €10,530 before

submitting a long-stay student visa application. Not to pay tuition fees — those come on top. Just to prove they have enough to live on.

In CFA francs: 6.9 million CFA francs. For a Malian, Burkinabé, or Nigerien student whose family earns on average a few hundred thousand francs a year, this sum represents years of accumulated family income.

This is a border closure through proof of wealth, not an administrative update.

The sorting is precise. A European student is not affected. A student from Dakar, Bamako, or Ouagadougou must present 6.9 million CFA francs or stay home. Students already present with a valid residence permit are “not immediately affected” — but these new requirements will apply upon renewal of their permit. A student in their first year of a master’s degree will, upon their permit’s expiration, have to prove they hold this sum. If they cannot: irregular status. Not because they failed, but because the rules changed under their feet. The retroactive withdrawal of a promise.

The final rule is stated with candor in official communications: even if you gather the full €10,530, nothing guarantees your application will be accepted. The money is a first filter. Consular discretion is a second. Together they form a selection system that does not need to state its real criteria in order to apply them.

The structural absurdity is total. France holds the CFA countries’ foreign-exchange reserves — €17 billion in African savings immobilized in Paris — imposes their currency, then demands their nationals prove they have enough money to enter its territory. France keeps Africa’s money and refuses entry to Africans who don’t have enough of it.

Meanwhile, its competitors are opening up: Russia multiplies state scholarships; China rolls out its HSK program; Turkey offers all-inclusive scholarships (Türkiye Burslari); Morocco rises in academic standing. France closes itself off at the precise moment alternatives become credible. Every African student who chooses Moscow, Istanbul, or Rabat over Paris is a political victory France inflicted on itself.

CHAPTER 31 — WHAT THE AES MUST ACHIEVE TO SURVIVE

Nairobi, May 11, 2026. "Africa Forward" summit. Before an assembly of African leaders, Emmanuel Macron acknowledges that France "no longer fully has the means" for a classic aid policy toward Africa. Then he lets slip a sentence none of his predecessors would ever have uttered: "If you fail, we have no chance." A French president tells Africa that France's future depends on Africa's future. This is the complete inversion of the balance of power as it has been presented since 1960. To understand what the AES must achieve, one must first understand this sentence — that is, anatomize a fear.

Anatomy of a fear

Behind the discourse of Western power, there is fear. Not of terrorists, nor even of Russia or China. A deep, structural fear: that of a world that no longer revolves around it.

The numbers set the frame. In 2025, the United States and Europe together account for only 9% of the world's population (UN data). Within a few years, Western countries will produce only about 40% of global wealth (IMF, World Bank). Europe depends on imports for more than 75% of its oil and gas (IEA); rare earths are 70% controlled by China (USGS); and Sahelian uranium fuels French nuclear plants — 20% of French nuclear electricity came from Niger, bought at €0.80/kg when the world market values it at \$200/kg. When Niger expels Orano after the 2023 coup, it is not just a diplomatic humiliation: it is a break in a supply chain France presented as a given. The West got used to paying for its resources below their real price — and it knows it cannot afford to pay their fair value. This is the fundamental fear. Everything else — bases, interventions, sanctions, proxies — is only its management.

Hence the AES-specific fear, which is the exact opposite of what is commonly believed: the West does not fear that the AES will fail. It fears that it will succeed. If the Confederation stabilizes its security and economy on its own, it inspires other countries — the sovereignist domino effect. If its mining renegotiation models spread, multinationals lose their rents. If the dollar loses, in the long run, its status as the world's exchange currency to BRICS, the United States loses its ability to fund its global military presence with no real quid pro quo. And Traoré identifies the ultimate threat: that Africans break free of "intellectual mimicry." An army can be defeated. A consciousness cannot be unlearned.

In the background, an undertow no one comments on enough: demographics. The West is aging, Japan and China face structural demographic crises, the Maghreb's birth rate is falling — and sub-Saharan Africa will make up 40% of the world's population by 2100, according to UN projections. No automatic advantage: a potential capacity, requiring institutions and economies capable of turning it into power. But in the long-term

balance of power, demographics silently redeal the cards that proxy wars are desperately trying to freeze.

The implicit roadmap

Nathalie Yamb frames the challenge with historical precision: the 1960s gave confiscated independences; the 1990s, a confiscated multipartyism; the 2020s are producing a sovereignism. "If it isn't given content, in thirty years there will again be new people on a new stage picking up this same torch." This sentence is the AES's implicit roadmap. It is not outside enemies that will kill the Alliance. It would be the internal institutional void.

Hence the two-part table that follows — probably the most important in this book, because it judges the AES not by its intentions, but by verifiable criteria.

Possible conditions for failure

- Personalization of power: transitions becoming permanent personal reigns, with no exit timeline.
- Military compradorism: uniformed elites reproducing the logics of the civilian elites they replaced.
- Russian dependency: replacing one tutelage with another, even under different terms.
- Internal fractures: violence against minorities, creating civil wars and breeding grounds for jihadist recruitment.
- Security failure: inability to protect populations beyond major cities.
- Economic failure: sanctions and poor management leading to a food crisis that delegitimizes the transitions.

Conditions necessary for success

- Scheduled democratic transition: clear timeline, civilian institutions, elections with real representativeness.
- Budget transparency: publication of accounts, fight against internal corruption.
- Monetary sovereignty: a credible transition strategy, with management of inflationary risks.
- Strategic diversification: not repeating with Moscow or Beijing what was done with Paris.
- Internal justice: protection of minorities, accountability of security forces.
- Diaspora mobilization: active investment and skills-return policies.
- Expanded military service: according to Nathalie Yamb, a tool of citizen consciousness-raising, not just defense.

- Permanent dialogue: keeping negotiation channels open even in wartime; "War does not preclude dialogue" (Patient Parfait Ndoum, For You Media Africa, June 8, 2026).

Three cross-cutting variables determine the outcome of all these scenarios. Real economic governance: do resources benefit populations, or do they feed a uniformed elite's rent? Freedom of expression: can civil societies criticize without being repressed? A gradual return to constitutionalism: do the transitions produce institutions or reigns? These three questions do not come from outside powers. They come from the Sahelian peoples themselves. That is their strength — and their hardest demand to keep.

The four levers of transformation

The Black Winter Ibrahim Traoré speaks of is not a metaphor — it is a program. To get through it, the AES must operate simultaneously four levers that the logic of dependency had, for sixty years, locked one after another.

Economy: controlling the subsoil. The first lever is the most visible, because it is the oldest. Mining contracts signed under *Françafrique* tutelage historically granted the state a share limited to 10% or less, against 90% for multinationals. Renegotiating these contracts — gold, uranium, oil — to reverse the ratio: this is the foundation. Added to this is the break from the CFA franc, seen not as a currency but as an instrument of economic captivity, in favor of a sovereign or common currency. The Confederation's Investment and Development Bank, whose capital exceeds 300 billion CFA francs, will need to be capitalized by the three states themselves, or risk falling back into the logic of conditionalities. And behind all this, food self-sufficiency: mobilizing the laboring masses — farmers, herders — into actors of a national defense that begins in the fields.

Military: from the professional army to the people in arms. The classic professional army, inherited from colonial structures, is no longer enough against an adversary playing on every front — diplomatic, informational, economic, proxy. The transitions' answer is the concept of a people's army: involving all able citizens in the defense of the territory, not as auxiliaries, but as conscious actors. The AES Unified Force, engaged in joint operations, must break the planned encirclement. And sovereignty of means — ensuring defense through one's own capabilities rather than through partners whose geostrategic interests diverge — is the *sine qua non* condition for this doctrine.

Cultural and cognitive: decolonizing mindsets. This, says Traoré, is "the hardest part of the struggle." The enemy that remains in minds after military bases have closed is harder to expel than soldiers. Breaking cultural and intellectual mimicry — returning to one's own sources and identities as instruments of resistance — is not a sentimental program: it is a strategy. It runs through popular education across all layers of society, to make citizens immune to fake news and informational subversion operations. The AES must also develop its own information channels, so as no longer to leave the field open to hostile narratives broadcast by media

headquartered in Paris or Washington.

Political and diplomatic: cohesion as a weapon. Any division between Bamako, Ouagadougou, and Niamey would be suicide, and concerted diplomacy an absolute necessity. But internal cohesion is not enough: partnerships must diversify toward a multipolar world — BRICS, Russia, China, Turkey — that offers exchanges based on mutual profit without conditions of interference. And for popular support to be lasting, some Sahelian voices call for rebalancing public spending toward social sectors — health, education — and for designing sovereignty inclusively, so internal fractures do not give outside maneuvers an opening.

These four levers are not operable sequentially. They form a system: controlling the subsoil finances the people's army; the people's army secures the fields that feed the cities; the cities, educated and informed, resist destabilization narratives; diplomacy, finally, negotiates from a reinforced position. The AES cannot choose only one or two. All four are needed, simultaneously, or none.

The African Union: the institution whose void the AES fills

"As long as the laboring masses have not grasped a concept, elites can keep speechifying in Addis Ababa, Abidjan, and Dakar. It will have no effect." — Chikouna Cissé, historian

The AES does not break with the idea of a continental organization. It breaks with an organization that betrayed that idea. This finding deserves support, not just assertion.

The African Union has set itself one of the most ambitious development programs in the world: Agenda 2063, with 14 flagship projects — an African space program, a continent-wide integrated high-speed rail network, a great African museum, a virtual and electronic pan-African university. Ask any ordinary African what Agenda 2063 is. They will not be able to answer. These projects exist in official documents. They do not exist in daily life. This is not a detail: it is the heart of the problem. A continental project that does not reach the farmer does not build a continent.

The operational record is severe. Since 2002, 23 successful coups on the continent — despite Article 4 of the Constitutive Act, which explicitly condemns them. Between 2021 and 2023: 93% of Assembly decisions were not implemented. The Commission's chairman, Moussa Faki Mahamat, admitted it himself. Texts are adopted, people applaud, they pose for the photo — then go home and act as if nothing had been signed. Every unimplemented decision is an abandoned population.

The specific cases are damning:

- Sudan: over 150,000 dead since 2023, the world's worst humanitarian crisis. The AU produced statements.

Nothing concrete.

- DRC: three decades of massacres in eastern Congo. Millions of cumulative deaths. Observation missions. No break.
- Burundi: in 2015, for once, the AU's Peace and Security Council adopts the principle of a protection force — MAPROBU. Then the heads of state enter the room and bury their own decision. Why? Because they fear the same mechanism might one day be invoked against them. The AU protects regimes, not peoples.

The founding contradiction dates back to 1963. From the OAU's very creation, two visions clash: the Casablanca group (Nkrumah) wants a strong political union, shared institutions, a common defense; the Monrovia group clings to national sovereignty — a position encouraged by the West to keep countries separated and exploitable individually. This fracture was never overcome. It is simply passed down from one generation to the next. The result: an AU that talks about integration and blocks any real integration. Divide and rule: a colonial doctrine turned into an imported African doctrine.

The budget says the rest. \$605 million for 2024, of which \$370 million (61%) is financed by outside partners — mainly the European Union and the United States. An organization two-thirds of whose budget comes from outside powers cannot seriously criticize European migration policy. Cannot denounce unequal trade agreements. Cannot support a rupture like the AES's without endangering its own funding. Financial dependency is political dependency.

And the double standard applies with documented regularity: Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger were sanctioned with markedly greater severity than that applied to Gabon or Chad. The variable is not the nature of the change in government — it is foreign policy. Those who break with Paris are sanctioned harder than those who violate their constitutions. The rule is transparent. It has just never been written into any official text.

There are only two serious options for the AU. Total refoundation: financial independence, elected institutions, real powers of sanction and intervention, a voice for peoples and not regimes. Or accepted dissolution: acknowledge failure and rebuild on new foundations, with states ready to genuinely move forward. The AES sketches, at its own scale and with its own contradictions, what the second option might produce. It is no accident that its founders do not refer to it as a model — they know its fragilities better than anyone. But it is a beginning.

Demographic sovereignty: who decides how many children a people has?

A video is circulating, accusing France, UNESCO, and the Bill Gates Foundation of having organized, via the The Challenge Initiative (TCI) program, a "hidden sterilization" of young Beninese girls. This accusation rests on a factual error: the contraceptive implant is not sterilization. It is reversible contraception — upon its

removal, fertility fully returns. Presenting the implant as sterilization is dangerous. It is precisely this kind of rumor that has caused vaccination campaigns to be boycotted in Africa, at the cost of thousands of children's lives. But behind the rumor, a perfectly well-founded question remains: who controls African demographics, and in whose service?

African suspicion is rooted in official documents, written in black and white. In 1974, the US National Security Council produces the NSSM-200 report, known as the "Kissinger report": *Implications of Worldwide Population Growth for U.S. Security and Overseas Interests*. This document, long classified, explicitly states that population growth in countries of the Global South threatens US access to raw materials, and recommends birth-control programs as an instrument of American national security.

<i>Documented fact</i>	<i>Significance</i>
● NSSM-200 / Kissinger report (1974)	Links Southern demographics to US security and raw materials
● Forced sterilizations in Peru, 1990s	~270,000 women, mostly Indigenous, under Fujimori
● Western discourse on Africa's "population bomb"	Recurrent in international institutions
● Massive foreign funding of family planning in Africa	Programs directed and financed from outside the continent

This is a declassified document, not a conspiracy theory. One concrete point deserves investigation: the implant is reportedly fitted free but removed for a fee. If this fact is confirmed, it constitutes a violation of informed consent. Contraception one cannot exit for lack of money is no longer quite a choice — it is a financial barrier to fertility.

The real question of sovereignty lies there: is the program run by Beninese people or imposed and funded from outside? Who sets the numerical targets for "contraceptive coverage," and in whose interest? Africa will be, by the mid-21st century, the youngest and most populous continent on earth. Neocolonialism does not need to sterilize in order to dominate. It only needs to decide in Africans' place what is good for them — the number of their children, the price of their fertility, the horizon of their youth. The Beninese fear used the wrong word. It said "sterilization" where it should have said "dispossession." But it is right on the essential point.

What the AES must achieve therefore includes a demographic dimension: not rejecting family planning, but bringing it back under sovereign control. No externally funded birth-rate program primarily serves the interests of the people concerned.

The starting point, not the finish line

To measure the distance traveled, one must recall the starting point. The status quo had a record: HDI rankings of 184th, 185th, and 189th out of 191; less than 20% access to electricity in the world's richest country in uranium. Sixty years of "cooperation" for this result. The AES breaks with this status quo. That is not enough to succeed — but it is necessary to begin. And beginning, after sixty years, is already a historic act.

The marching doctrine is stated by Choguel Maïga: "No one is going to inject us with the virus of defeatism. Soldiers strike the adversaries, diplomats negotiate, economic operators do their work. Everyone does their job." And he backs it with the hardest empirical argument to refute: "Mali negotiated for thirty years. Did that stop terrorism from spreading? Did it stop it from reaching Burkina or Niger, where it hadn't been?" (Bamako, October 19, 2024). Thirty years of negotiation produced the spread of jihadism. Rupture produced the retaking of Kidal.

Researcher Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou posed, as early as 2013, the question underlying this entire venture: "Can state sovereignty be reintroduced when it keeps being chipped away a little more?" (in *La Guerre au Mali, La Découverte*, 2013). The answer the AES has given since 2020 is no — sovereignty is not reintroduced through the channels offered by those who confiscated it. It must be wrested away. Ten years separate the diagnosis from the act.

The wresting-away has taken place. Consolidation remains to be done, and its criteria are now laid out, in black and white, verifiable by anyone — friend and adversary alike.

All that remains is to return to where it all began: in a villa in Niamey, before a whiteboard and five words.

The AES: geopolitical scandal and total sovereignty

"The homeland or death, we will win." — Ibrahim Traoré, captain, president of Faso

There are moments when world geopolitics reconfigures itself before our eyes and most commentators miss the event. The creation of the Confederation of Sahel States is one of those moments. It is not a minor regional episode: it is what some analysts no longer hesitate to call a geopolitical scandal — in the word's

original sense: a fact that overturns the established order, one that those who profit from that order refuse to look in the face.

The April 2026 offensive: imperialism's black hand

In April 2026, more than 3,000 fighters from JNIM (Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin) and the Azawad Liberation Front launch a coordinated offensive against Malian forces in the north of the country. It is one of the largest concentrations of jihadist forces ever observed in the region.

The Malian army, backed by the AES's unified force — including its 800 Nigerien elements mobilized in solidarity as of May 1 — aims to eliminate this "reaping terrorism" in order to guarantee calm in the territories claimed by the FLA. The official Malian toll reports more than 4,000 fighters neutralized.

But the question Western media avoid is that of origins: who arms these 3,000 fighters? Who informs them? Who pays them? Sahelian sources name what one of them calls "imperialism's black hand" — the networks that finance destabilization from outside, that supply intelligence on national armies' movements, that allow armed groups with no economic base of their own to maintain operational capacity on this scale.

This black hand is not a metaphor. It has addresses — documented in this book's preceding chapters.

The AES: an organization born from the experience of hell

Unlike the G5 Sahel — created under French impetus, financed by the European Union, dead of its own uselessness — the AES is an initiative of Africans who lived from the inside "the hell of collaborating with imperialism." They know what signing "phony colonial agreements" means: ten years of Barkhane presence that produced neither security nor development, but guaranteed resource access and the maintenance of dependencies.

The break from these agreements is not ideological in the sense of an imported doctrine. It is empirical: they tried the other path. It did not work. Not for the peoples — for the extractors, it worked very well.

This rupture's impact goes beyond Sahelian borders. The AES has restored something sixty years of neocolonialism had methodically destroyed: the proof that it is possible to live, govern oneself, and develop without Western tutelage. This proof — visible, concrete, embodied by men who have held power for three years — has a global psychological effect on what some are beginning to call "global Black pride."

The AES, currently a confederation, aspires to become a full federation. This is not a distant horizon — it is the architecture the Niamey Declaration began to sketch out.

Digital sovereignty: the invisible battle

One of the least covered aspects of the Sahelian rupture is technical — and it is fundamental. Burkina

Faso has repatriated and secured the entirety of its national data on its own soil.

This decision may seem administrative. It is strategic. Previously, storing or externally sharing computer data allowed adversaries to know, in real time, the movements of the Burkinabé, Malian, and Nigerien armies. Ten years of Barkhane and Serval operations were marked by total intelligence asymmetry: French armies saw everything, spied on everything — as the former Burkinabé minister quoted in Chapter 82 put it. National armies operated blind.

Digital sovereignty changes this equation. It does not solve everything. It removes one of the most critical leaks in operational security.

It is the same logic as monetary sovereignty, as military sovereignty: as long as a critical element of your infrastructure is controlled from outside, you do not govern — you administer for someone else's benefit.

The break with the Western democratic model

The Sahelian transitions are regularly attacked on the grounds of democracy. European Parliament resolutions, ECOWAS statements, NGO op-eds always ask the same question: when will there be elections?

The AES governments' answer is simple: no UN law imposes liberal democracy as a universal system of government. China develops according to its own model. India has a democracy deeply different from the Westminster model. North Korea chooses its own system — recognized or not, it is sovereign. International law enshrines the principle of self-determination, not Western-style multipartyism.

Reading the founding texts of international law is enough to answer this criticism: Western powers invoke these same texts when it suits them and ignore them when it is inconvenient.

The democratic critique is all the more inaudible coming from systems that supported Bozizé in the CAR, that blessed Déby's dynastic succession in Chad, that let the Gulf petromonarchies finance terrorism without a single Amnesty International resolution. The Western system does not defend democracy — it defends access to natural resources and uses democracy as a tool of legitimization or destabilization according to the needs of the moment.

Gaza, Congo, Sudan: these crises are managed or ignored depending on whether or not they involve resources and strategic allies. Selectivity is the system's true face.

Spiritual liberation: Cheikh Anta Diop was right

Cheikh Anta Diop put it with a precision history has confirmed: imperialism kills the mind first. The denial of African history, the erasure of precolonial civilizations, the construction of a narrative in which the African only exists from the moment the colonizer discovers him — all of this is a political project, not an academic error.

The chapter on IPN Farafina said it: the Black man became the graveyard of his own consciousness. His consciousness was buried within himself and he became the architect of his own backwardness. The rupture the AES carries out is therefore not only military, monetary, or institutional. It is a matter of memory. It says: we were here before you. We will be here after you.

This dimension is what geopolitical analysts systematically miss when they treat the Sahel as a mere security problem. Security is the emergency of the moment. Consciousness is the project of the generation.

Financial independence: reclaiming in order to finance

The final ambition is that of any authentic revolution: no longer depending on outside sources for one's own financing. The AES aims for a sub-regional organization entirely financed by reclaimed African resources — Nigerien uranium, Malian gold, Burkinabé manganese, hydrocarbons still to be developed.

\$300 million in uranium revenue marketed directly by Niger in 2025. \$500 million in oil revenue. These figures, never before seen in the Nigerien state's coffers since independence, are the concrete demonstration that economic sovereignty is not a utopia — it is a political choice.

When sovereignty generates resources, resources finance sovereignty. The virtuous loop is possible. It was made impossible for sixty years by design. It becomes possible again by decision.

Sources: JNIM/FLA offensive record, Mali, April 2026 (AES and ACLED sources); Nigerien solidarity, 800 elements, May 1, 2026; Burkina Faso national data repatriation (transition government sources, 2024–2025); Cheikh Anta Diop, Nations nègres et culture (1954); Niamey Declaration on the Confederation of Sahel States, July 2024; Niger post-transition revenue data (Nyamsi, December 2025); Chapters 82, 85, 89, 91 of this book.

CONCLUSION — RETURN TO THE NIAMEY VILLA

Niamey, June 2026. Heat falls on the city like a slab. It is five in the afternoon and the streets are starting to come back to life after the afternoon torpor — tea vendors, overloaded mopeds, children walking home from school in tight lines. The city hums with a new sound, hard to name: something between pride and expectation. Three years since Niger took back the keys to itself.

The villa still stands. Yantala district, behind its beige walls. It has changed tenants since the American military advisers packed up in the spring of 2024. No one knows exactly what it has become — an administrative apartment, a guesthouse for African delegations, maybe nothing in particular. What remains is the sentence. Five words traced on a whiteboard, long ago, in a meeting room in this villa or another, in this country or a neighboring one:

Peace, we can avoid it.

This book began with that sentence. It is time to return to it — not to condemn it, but to measure it against what it produced.

What a sentence can do

The authors of this sentence were not philosophers. They had not read Hegel or Fanon. They had budgets, org charts, strategic analysis grids. Their job was to keep states unstable enough to remain accessible, dependent enough to remain docile. The formula condensed a doctrine: managed disorder is cheaper than granted sovereignty.

This calculation rested on three assumptions. That Sahelian peoples had forgotten what had been taken from them. That no generation would arise with the tools to reclaim it. That the dependency system was too integrated, too deep, too widely rooted to be thrown into crisis by a handful of captains.

All three assumptions were wrong.

Memory recovered

The first lesson of these three years is simple: peoples do not forget. They wait.

They have not forgotten Samory Touré resisting French columns for sixteen years in the forests of Guinea, captured in 1898, dead in deportation in Gabon two years later — but never having signed a treaty of surrender. They have not forgotten Sékou Touré who, in 1958, answered General de Gaulle that Guinea chose “poverty in freedom rather than wealth in slavery,” and watched French officials leave taking even the light bulbs with

them. They have not forgotten Sankara — that thirty-seven-year-old captain who, in four years, vaccinated two and a half million children, planted ten million trees, and refused to borrow from those who had already taken everything. They have not forgotten that he died for it, on October 15, 1987, in a Ouagadougou hallway, on the orders of a friend.

They have not forgotten Thiaroye. On December 1, 1944, African riflemen who had just liberated France demanded their captivity pay. The French army had first disarmed them. It answered with weapons. Between 300 and 400 soldiers killed, their bodies thrown into mass graves. For 80 years, the official version spoke of "35 dead" in a "mutiny." The archives remain locked, the mass graves unopened, the men convicted in 1945 unrehabilitated. When Sahelian leaders speak of dignity as a founding principle of rupture, they are also speaking of Thiaroye. Memory is not nostalgia — it is a political argument.

This kind of memory is not taught in colonial schools. It is passed down by the fireside, in griots' songs, in the names given to children. It sleeps for a long time. And when it wakes, it knows exactly who it is.

The generation that films

The second lesson concerns a woman from Tonka whose name most Westerners have never heard.

Mariam Cissé filmed her life. The market, the street, the Malian soldiers she cheered on, her laughing face to the camera. On TikTok, tens of thousands of people followed her — this daughter of the river who existed online, in a country where existing online was still, for a woman, an act of bravery. JNIM executed her in public, in Tonka's town square, in November 2021. Believing they were making an example, they manufactured a symbol.

She had understood, before her killers, what the new Sahelian generation represented: not a youth with no past and no future, manipulated by social networks, ripe for any recruitment — but a generation that had the tools to compare, judge, and tell its own story. Over 60% of the African population is under 25. This youth was born with the internet. They saw the human development rankings, the maps of jihadist advance under French presence, the images of Barkhane in retreat. They did the math. The result held in a few words: sixty years of promises, zero.

This math did not produce resentment — well, not only that. It produced something more dangerous for those counting on their passivity: lucidity. And lucidity, once organized, becomes a political force.

What the data said before it was destroyed

Between the two lessons — memory and the generation that films — there is a truth the numbers make irrefutable.

At the turn of the 2000s, sixteen demographic and economic indicators compared across the African continent pointed to a single country at the top of nearly every ranking: Libya. Africa's highest life expectancy — over 75 years, when most African countries capped at 55. The highest human development index. The second-highest GDP per capita. Among the lowest infant mortality rates. Among the highest literacy rates. Among the strongest growth. No civil war between 1990 and 2000, while Algeria, Sierra Leone, Somalia, Rwanda, and Congo burned.

In March 2011, Sarkozy's France, with the United States and NATO, destroyed this country. The official argument: protecting civilians. The real result: the African country ranked highest on nearly every human development indicator became a slave market, a jihadist transit base, a fractured state with no central government. And 60,000 to 70,000 foreign fighters — expelled from Syria after al-Jolani's defeat — were redirected to the Sahel, fueling exactly the destabilization Barkhane claimed to fight.

The mechanics are visible. Nothing about them is accidental.

The architecture of rupture

The third lesson may be the most important for those observing the Sahel from outside with condescending distance: the AES is a project, not an emotional reaction.

Behind the coups, there was a doctrine. Behind the doctrine, a timetable. Behind the timetable, an architecture. The Liptako-Gourma Charter, signed September 16, 2023, takes up article by article the Addis Ababa 1963 program — the one the first generation's heads of state had rejected during Nkrumah's lifetime: union of three states, full sovereignty over resources, a common military force, a monetary project. Sixty years of waiting. African patience has a long memory.

Every act was calculated to make the previous one harder to reverse. The denunciation of tax treaties follows the expulsion of armies. The AES investment bank follows the denunciation of treaties. The Unified Force, established December 21, 2025, follows the bank. The monetary institute announced for September 2026 will follow the Force. The strategy was there before the coups. The coups executed it.

And the strategy held against pressures any observer would have predicted fatal. ECOWAS sanctions — not lifted for eighteen months. Diplomatic isolation. Economic blockade. Disinformation campaigns from the French embassy's social networks and the 43rd BIMA. The April 25, 2026 attack that cost Minister Sadio Camara his life. All of it held. Cracked, at times. Wavered. But held.

The CFA franc's closed loop

Chancelleries do not say it out loud, but Sahelian peoples understood it before economists documented

it: the Bank of France prints the CFA francs. The armed groups operating in the Sahel are paid in CFA francs. Conclusion: financing the destabilization of Mali, Burkina, and Niger costs Paris no real currency. Zero dollars. Zero euros. Zero yuan. The loop closes: a currency whose issuance Paris controls finances a war Paris appears not to finance.

That is why monetary sovereignty is not an ideological whim — it is a condition of security survival. And that is why leaving the CFA franc and creating a common AES currency cannot be separated from the military and political project: as long as the loop stays closed, blood flows for free.

What Macron said without meaning to

On May 11, 2026, in Nairobi, one moment unintentionally sums it all up. Emmanuel Macron addresses African heads of state gathered for "Africa Forward" — a summit with no Mali, no Burkina, no Niger. And he says: "If you fail, we have no chance."

A French president tells Africa that France's future depends on Africa's success. This is the complete reversal of the balance of power as it stood in 1960, in 1987, in 2013. For sixty years, Paris sent armies to ensure stability — that is, to keep in place governments that let resources flow out. Today, Paris tells these same resources: if you escape us entirely, we are the ones who go under.

He did not realize it. He was speaking of a shared future and a renewed partnership. He was saying, without knowing it, that the direction of dependency had reversed.

This does not mean Paris has given up. The recomposition is real — pivot states, a reformed Franco-phonie, cultivated civil societies, military proxies, unchanged influence networks. The chapter of domination is not closed. It is being rewritten. But it is being rewritten under pressure, under constraint, grudgingly — and that is a difference that matters.

When the prophets of doom wake up

On July 6, 2026, Théophile EKA2 writes a piece about those who woke up with a hangover. For weeks, they had been announcing FACA's rout, the advance of armed groups to the gates of Bangui, the collapse of the Central African Republic. Some awaited these tragedies with barely concealed impatience. They celebrated defeat before it even existed. They popped the champagne before the fighting was over.

On July 6, 2026, the Central African Republic was still standing.

This scene — the prophets of doom souring, the pseudo-analysts forced to reckon with a reality that contradicts their predictions — repeats itself across the whole region. It says something essential about the nature of the ongoing battle: it is not only a military battle. It is a battle of narratives. And in that battle, those

who bet on collapse lost the first round.

This does not mean victory is secured. It means defeat is no longer inevitable.

The villa is empty. The sentence is not.

Someone, in this Niamey villa, once traced five words on a whiteboard. Those five words were a program for governing Sahelian populations. A program that worked, decade after decade, because the conditions for its operation were maintained: dependent states, comprador elites, foreign armies, captive currency, confiscated memory.

These conditions have changed. Not all of them. Not everywhere. Not permanently. Jihadism keeps killing civilians in villages whose names will never appear in Parisian newspapers. The military transitions have not yet produced the institutions they promised. The three questions remain open: will the transitions produce institutions or personal reigns? Will fundamental rights be respected outside of speeches? Will minorities be protected?

These questions do not belong to those who ask them from outside to slow the movement down. They belong to the Sahelian peoples themselves — who ask them, who demand them, who will measure the answers. Nathalie Yamb, condemned to travel no more by European sanctions that froze her bank accounts and cut off her digital subscriptions, keeps asking these questions from her Swiss apartment. Choguel Maïga asks them from Bamako. Thousands of others ask them from villages with no electricity and slums with no running water.

The laboratory is open. The results are not in.

What only history can settle

Niger exported the uranium that runs EDF's reactors for sixty years, and its people had no electricity. Then, in December 2025, the transition government announced \$300 million in uranium revenue marketed directly — bypassing Orano — and \$500 million in oil revenue collected in cash. These \$800 million, sources note, "had never before been seen in the Nigerien state's coffers since independence." This is the simplest, most verifiable, most implacable statement in this entire book. No rhetoric about cooperation, stability, or ingratitude touches it. It is an accounting fact: Orano paid €0.80/kg for ore the world market valued at \$200/kg. For 1,440 tonnes in 2022, France paid €1.2 million — while Niger lost €287 million a year. This uranium supplied 20% of French nuclear electricity. The country that lit up France did not have electricity. No rhetoric touches that.

The rupture began because men and women decided that this fact was intolerable. Not inconvenient. Not regrettable. Intolerable. And that it had to be wrenched out of the normalcy sixty years of habit had locked it into.

Ibrahim Traoré revived the Institute of Black Peoples — IPN Farafina — that Sankara had founded in 1986 and that Compaoré had methodically extinguished after assassinating him. Six missions: promote the values of Black peoples, teach sovereignist ideals, produce endogenous knowledge, ideologically train youth, build a shared Black consciousness across Africa, the Caribbean, and the diaspora, guide public policy. This program is not against anyone. It is for something: that the Black man stop being, to borrow Fanon's phrase, a wretched of the earth.

Is the AES the first stone of a genuine African sovereignty, or one more spark in a long night? Only history can settle that. It is still being written — in the villages of Liptako, in the transitional government's meetings in Bamako, in Burkinabé national data now stored on Burkinabé soil and no longer accessible to the armies that once spied on their movements, in Malian schools where children learn their history in their own language, in Nigerien mines where the question of uranium's price is at last being asked by those who have the right to ask it.

The Niamey villa is empty. The sentence died with the project that invented it.

But the just peace — the one that does not require injustice as its condition — is not yet built. It cannot be avoided. It will not be given. It will be built, like everything that lasts, by those who pay its price and carry its demand.

"Let us stay vigilant." — General Abdourahamane Tiani, November 13, 2025

TIMELINE — FROM THE PARTITION OF AFRICA TO THE ALLIANCE OF SAHEL STATES

Africa's history is an architecture, not an accident. Here are the building's stones — and the first cracks that split it apart.

1884–1885 — Berlin Conference: fourteen European powers carve up Africa. Not a single African at the table. The continent is sliced with a ruler, peoples ignored, kingdoms erased. This is the official starting point of an organized plunder that never really stopped.

1900 — The French law on colonial financial autonomy requires colonized peoples to fund their own administration. The colonizer does not just take — it makes the occupied pay for the cost of their own occupation.

1945 — Creation of the CFA franc (December 26). A currency of confiscated sovereignty, pegged to Paris, managed from Paris, for Paris's benefit. A golden leash around sixteen nations' necks.

1957 — Kwame Nkrumah's Ghana becomes the first colonized sub-Saharan African country to gain independence. The same year (law of January 10), France creates the Common Organization of Saharan Regions (OCSR) to organize the Sahara's subsoil on the eve of independence. The form is released — the substance is kept.

1958 — Sékou Touré's Guinea votes "no" in de Gaulle's referendum (September 28). Immediate reprisals: the French leave, taking pens, files, and light bulbs with them. The punishment is exemplary — and the message is clear for the others.

1960 — "Year of Africa": seventeen countries gain independence, including Mali, Niger, and Upper Volta (future Burkina Faso). Formal independences. Real dependencies. The flags change. The structures stay.

1961 — Assassination of Patrice Lumumba (January 17). The Congo's first free prime minister dies with Belgian poison in his veins and Congolese uranium in the crosshairs. The CIA and Brussels organized the operation. The world knows. No one is tried.

1963 — Assassination of Sylvanus Olympio, Togo's first president. He wanted to leave the CFA franc and create a national currency. He is shot the day after his decision. The coup's perpetrator will be welcomed in Paris.

1968 — Overthrow of Modibo Keita in Mali. Another African socialist who wanted economic independence. Neutralized. Africa learns that emancipation has a price.

1971 — Cogema (later Areva, then Orano) sets up its uranium mines in Arlit, Niger. For fifty years, Niger will be one of France's main uranium suppliers — and one of the poorest countries in the world. The soil is rich. The people starve.

1983–1987 — Thomas Sankara's presidency in Burkina Faso; assassinated October 15, 1987. Four years to transform a country. Literacy, health, food sovereignty, refusal of colonial debt. Blaise Compaoré — with Paris's backing — puts a bullet through Africa's most dangerous idea.

1994 — Devaluation of the CFA franc. Overnight, the savings of millions of Africans lose 50% of their value. Decided in Paris. Announced in Dakar. Populations were not consulted.

2011 — NATO intervention in Libya; the fall and death of Muammar Gaddafi; dispersal of arsenals into the Sahel. An operation presented as humanitarian produces one of the major geopolitical catastrophes of the 21st century. Libyan weapons flood the Sahel. Chaos settles in for decades.

2012 — Collapse of northern Mali; proclamation of Azawad. Direct and predictable consequence of Libyan destabilization. The France that lit the fire in Libya arrives the following year as a firefighter in Mali.

2013 — Operation Serval (January). French intervention in Mali, welcomed by Sahelian peoples. Ten years later, those same peoples will demand these same soldiers' departure.

2014 — Launch of Operation Barkhane (August). Nine years, several billion euros, thousands of soldiers — and insecurity that expands every year. When African states demand accountability, Paris responds by accusing them of ingratitude.

August 18, 2020 — First military transition in Mali (Kati); Assimi Goïta comes to power. Mali takes its destiny into its own hands. The West cries coup. Malians celebrate in the streets.

January–September 2022 — In Burkina Faso, Damiba overthrows Kaboré (January), then Captain Ibrahim Traoré overthrows Damiba (September). The wave does not stop. African youth has decided.

August 2022 — Expulsion of Barkhane from Mali. French soldiers who presented themselves as liberators leave like expelled occupiers. That is what they were.

July 26, 2023 — Military transition in Niger; General Tiani takes charge of the CNSP. Third domino. Third country freed from neocolonial clientelism. ECOWAS brandishes its ultimatum. Niger does not yield.

September 16, 2023 — Signing of the Liptako-Gourma Charter: birth of the Alliance of Sahel States. Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger seal their union. It is no longer three separate countries that can be isolated, sanctioned, threatened one after another. It is a bloc.

November 14, 2023 — The Malian Armed Forces retake Kidal. The symbol-city, held by armed groups since 2012, is liberated. What ten years of French presence had not managed, FAMa achieves.

January 28, 2024 — Withdrawal of Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger from ECOWAS. End of an organi-

zation that had become, in their view, an instrument of pressure serving Paris. The heads-of-state club loses its most courageous members.

March–spring 2024 — Departure of the last French and American forces from Niger; closure of the Agadez base. Two military empires pack up. Territorial sovereignty is not negotiable.

July 6, 2024 — Proclamation of the Confederation of Sahel States (Niamey summit). Integration deepens. A political project, not just a defense alliance.

July–August 2024 — Defeat at Tinzawaten; Ukrainian military intelligence acknowledges support to the attackers; joint referral to the UN Security Council by the three AES states (August 19). The proxy war is exposed. Kyiv admits what Paris still denies.

March 2025 — Withdrawal of the AES from the International Organization of the Francophonie. The French language is not the issue. The cultural domination the OIF instrumentalizes, is.

September 22, 2025 — Withdrawal of the three states from the International Criminal Court. An institution that has never tried a Westerner for crimes in Africa is not a court of justice. It is a tribunal of domination.

December 21, 2025 — Establishment of the AES Unified Force. The three countries equip themselves with a shared military tool. Collective African defense stops being a pious wish.

April 25, 2026 — Coordinated attacks on Bamako, Kati, Kidal, Gao, and Sévaré; death of General Sadio Camara. The AES's military architect falls in combat. The Sahelian forces' response is immediate and determined.

May 9, 2026 — RTL France reports the cooperation of ex-legionnaires with Ukrainian military intelligence against Mali. What was dismissed as a conspiracy theory a few months earlier is confirmed by a major French mainstream outlet. The masks fall.

June 7, 2026 — 5th anniversary of General Assimi Goïta's inauguration; inauguration of the Maison des Pupilles de la République in Bamako. Conviction of agent Yann Vésilier to twenty years in prison in Mali. The Malian transition builds and judges. Two acts of sovereignty in a single day.

GLOSSARY OF ACRONYMS

Acronyms are the mask of power. Behind every acronym hides an institution, a logic, a balance of power. This glossary names them unambiguously — so the reader knows exactly what they are reading when the powerful speak among themselves.

ACLED — Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (database on armed conflicts). One of the few independent sources quantifying violence in crisis zones.

AES — Alliance of Sahel States (Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger). Born September 16, 2023, from the Liptako-Gourma Charter. The first sovereign African bloc to emerge from popular military transitions.

AOF — French West Africa. The administrative colonial empire that structured the exploitation of West Africa for a century. Officially dissolved in 1960. Structurally perpetuated by Françafrique.

ODA — Official development aid. What is called "aid" is often an instrument of control, conditionality, and economic return to donors. France recoups in contracts what it pays out in ODA.

AQIM — Al-Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb. Sahelian jihadist organization born of Algeria's GSPC. Partly financed by ransoms paid by Western governments — including France — for the release of their nationals.

BCEAO — Central Bank of West African States. Monetary institution of the WAEMU zone. Headquartered in Dakar but its policy is pegged to Paris. In 2022 and 2023, it froze the accounts of the Malian and Nigerien states on outside instruction.

BEAC — Bank of Central African States. CEMAC zone's equivalent of the BCEAO. Same architecture of dependency.

BIMA — Marine Infantry Battalion. French military unit pre-positioned in Africa. One of the instruments of the permanent French military presence on the continent.

BRICS — Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa (and new members). Alternative bloc to the Western order. Several African states, including those of the AES, look to this pole as a horizon for strategic reorientation.

ECOWAS — Economic Community of West African States. Sub-regional organization that has become, according to AES leaders, a club of heads of state serving outside interests. In 2023, it brandished the military option against Niger. Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger left it in January 2024.

CEMAC — Economic and Monetary Community of Central Africa. Central African monetary zone

using the BEAC CFA franc.

CFA — African Financial Community (monetary zone). Currency created December 26, 1945, by colonial France. Guaranteed by the French Treasury, managed according to rules set in Paris. Of 609 loans granted by the IMF to Africa since independence, 200 went to the 14 CFA countries — a third of all loans. No CFA-zone country has left the least-developed-countries category since 1971.

ICRC — International Committee of the Red Cross. Humanitarian organization whose presence in conflict zones sometimes provides useful cover for interests beyond aiding the wounded.

CNSP — National Council for the Safeguard of the Homeland (Niger). Governing body of the Nigerien transition arising from July 26, 2023. Led by General Abdourahamane Tiani.

CNPC — China National Petroleum Corporation. Chinese state oil company. Present in Niger for developing the pipeline to Benin — one of the transition's strategic stakes.

COS — Special Operations Command (France). French special forces deployed in Africa under official and unofficial operations. Present in the Sahel well before public mandates.

ICC — International Criminal Court. Since its creation, it has exclusively prosecuted Africans. No Westerner has been tried for their crimes in Africa. The United States, China, Russia, India, and Israel are not members. The AES withdrew from it on September 22, 2025.

DGSE — General Directorate for External Security (France). France's foreign intelligence service. Present in Africa in functions that go far beyond intelligence — up to organizing destabilizations and maintaining influence networks.

UAE — United Arab Emirates. Increasingly destabilizing actor in African conflicts, notably in Sudan and Libya, according to the SWP report of May 2026.

EHM — Economic Hit Man (per John Perkins). Term designating economic agents — often tied to international financial institutions — tasked with indebting Global South states to keep them under control.

PMC — Private security and defense company. Euphemism for contracted mercenaries. The West has extensively used these structures to outsource its wars in Africa while maintaining a facade of non-intervention.

FAMa — Malian Armed Forces. Mali's national army, rebuilt and strengthened since the 2020 transition. Retook Kidal in November 2023, liberating what ten years of French presence had failed to hold.

FLA — Azawad Liberation Front. Tuareg armed group. Azawad, according to André Bourgeot of the CNRS, is "a political fabrication" — a territory drawn up in offices, not in hearts.

IMF — International Monetary Fund. Born of the 1944 Bretton Woods agreements. A tool of economic conditionality. Has imposed an average primary surplus of 1.8% on CFA countries, compressing public investment and blocking development.

RSF — Rapid Support Forces (Sudan). Paramilitary militia involved in Sudan's civil war. Backed by outside actors including the United Arab Emirates.

GSPC — Salafist Group for Preaching and Combat. Algerian organization that transformed into AQIM. The genealogy of Sahelian jihadism runs through this group — and through the interventions that dispersed Libyan weapons in 2011.

GUR — Ukrainian military intelligence. Acknowledged in August 2024 providing support to the attackers during the defeat at Tinjawaten against FAMA.

HRW — Human Rights Watch. Human rights organization whose reports on the Sahel systematically follow the Western narrative — while documenting real facts. To be read with the same critical eye applied to any positioned source.

HDI — Human Development Index. UN measure of population well-being. CFA-zone countries display some of the lowest HDIs in the world — despite some of the richest subsoils.

JNIM — Group for the Support of Islam and Muslims (Sahelian jihadist coalition). Jihadist coalition led by Iyad Ag Ghali. Indirect beneficiary of ransoms paid by Western governments.

MINUSMA — United Nations Mission in Mali. Present from 2013 to 2023. Its departure was demanded by Mali's transition government, which deemed its presence counterproductive and opaque.

MNLA — National Movement for the Liberation of Azawad. Tuareg armed group that proclaimed Azawad's independence in 2012 in the wake of Libyan destabilization.

MPSR — Patriotic Movement for Safeguard and Restoration (Burkina Faso). Governing body of Burkina Faso's first transition, led by Damiba in January 2022, before Captain Ibrahim Traoré's arrival in September 2022.

OCRS — Common Organization of Saharan Regions (French law of January 10, 1957). Created by France to secure control of the Sahara's natural resources before granting political independence. A tactic seventy years old.

OIF — International Organization of the Francophonie. Cultural institution used as a vector of French political influence. The AES withdrew from it in March 2025 — not to reject the French language, but to refuse the instrument of tutelage it had become.

NATO — North Atlantic Treaty Organization. Western military alliance. Its 2011 intervention in Libya produced a collapsed state, an uninterrupted civil war, and arsenals scattered across the entire Sahel.

UNDP — United Nations Development Programme. Producer of the HDI. Its data confirms the structural failure of the development model imposed on African countries under Western financial tutelage.

CAR — Central African Republic. A country with an exceptional subsoil (uranium, oil, diamonds, gold),

kept in poverty and instability by decades of French interference. Chose to diversify its partnerships toward Russia and Rwanda.

SWP — Stiftung Wissenschaft und Politik (German Institute for International and Security Affairs). Influential think tank. Its May 2026 report (Kurtz, Lacher, Roll) documents the destabilizing role of the United Arab Emirates in African conflicts.

VDP — Volunteers for the Defense of the Homeland (Burkina Faso). Armed civilian auxiliaries integrated into Captain Ibrahim Traoré's security strategy. The expression of a popular defense that no longer relies solely on foreign soldiers.

AfCFTA — African Continental Free Trade Area. Pan-African economic integration project. Potentially transformative — provided the rules are not dictated by outside interests that have every reason to keep African markets fragmented and dependent.

INDEX OF FIGURES

This book summons the living and the dead, executioners and resisters, witnesses and accomplices. Here they are named — so that no one can hide behind the anonymity of "decision-makers" or "chancelleries."

Cross-references indicate the chapters where each figure is cited or analyzed.

Avé, Anne-Sophie — former French ambassador to Mali; doctrine of "cognitive dissonance." A French diplomat who theorized the manipulation of perceptions at the very moment Paris was losing Mali. ch. 14.

Ayissi, Anatole — journalist and pan-Africanist analyst; UN official for Central Africa. One of the most documented voices on Central African and Sahelian geopolitics. ch. 7, ch. 8, ch. 21, ch. 27, ch. 29, ch. 30.

Banda Kani — Cameroonian pan-Africanist analyst. Systematic dissector of domination mechanisms. His knowledge of *Françafrique* influence networks is unmatched in the pan-Africanist landscape. ch. 3, ch. 10, ch. 12, ch. 14, ch. 19, ch. 20, ch. 25, ch. 30.

Bazoum, Mohamed — president of Niger (2021–2023), overthrown July 26, 2023. Freed terrorists arrested by the Nigerien army. Denied the existence of *Françafrique* that Macron himself acknowledged. Wrote his distress op-ed in the *Washington Post* — for Americans, not for his own people. ch. 10, ch. 18, ch. 25, ch. 26.

Belhadj, Abdelhakim — Libyan jihadist leader, military governor of Tripoli after 2011. Direct product of the Western intervention in Libya. Living proof that the humanitarian operation armed those it claimed to fight. ch. 11.

Benoist-Méchin, Jacques — French writer, author of *Un printemps arabe* (1959). ch. 11.

Boganda, Barthélemy — founder of the Central African Republic, theorist of the "United States of Latin Africa," died March 29, 1959. His plane exploded a few months before independence. Assassinated because his project of African unification was a real threat to the colonial order. ch. 22.

Bokassa, Jean-Bedel — former Central African head of state installed by France. Emblematic figure of *Françafrique*: a brutal man whom Paris armed, supported, then dropped once he became embarrassing. ch. 8, ch. 15.

Bongo, Omar — president of Gabon, figure of *Françafrique*. Forty-two years in power, with Paris as permanent godfather. Gabonese oil financed French presidential campaigns for decades — Robert Bourgi confirms it. ch. 6.

Bourgi, Robert — lawyer, intermediary of the Élysée's "briefcases." Publicly admitted to carrying suit-

cases of cash between African presidents and the Élysée. A confession that should have detonated like a bomb. It was buried within two days of media coverage. ch. 6.

Burkhard, Thierry — French chief of the armed forces general staff. Acknowledged, in closed-door testimony before the National Assembly (September 2024), the failure of French commitments in the Sahel. A belated candor, shielded by secrecy. ch. 15.

Camara, Sadio — Mali's defense minister, the AES's military architect, killed April 25, 2026. The man who built the Sahel's collective defense capacity. His assassination during the coordinated attacks of April 25, 2026 did not stop the machine he had set in motion. ch. 14, ch. 16, ch. 20.

Chassaigne, André — French deputy, denouncer of interventions in Africa. In December 2013, he tallied the fiftieth French military intervention in Africa since independence. A dissident voice within the system itself. ch. 3, ch. 8, ch. 13, ch. 15.

Cheikh Anta Diop — Senegalese historian and physicist (1923–1986). Proved through science what colonial ideology denied: the depth and antiquity of African civilizations. Founder of a school of thought that runs through all of contemporary pan-Africanism. ch. 2, ch. 6.

Chirac, Jacques — president of the French Republic (1995–2007). Declared that Africa "is not ready for democracy." Perpetuated *Françafrique* while publicly denying its existence. Prologue, ch. 6.

Cissé, Boubou — former prime minister of Mali, opponent of the transition. ch. 10, ch. 16.

Cissé, Mariam — Malian blogger assassinated by JNIM. ch. 24, ch. 26.

Compaoré, Blaise — president of Burkina Faso (1987–2014), implicated in the assassination of Thomas Sankara. Ruled Burkina Faso for twenty-seven years with Paris's blessing. In exile in Côte d'Ivoire since 2014, wanted by Burkinabé justice. ch. 6, ch. 10, ch. 23.

Damiba, Paul-Henri Sandaogo — leader of Burkina Faso's first transition, January 2022. Overthrown by Ibrahim Traoré in September 2022, judged too lukewarm in the break with Paris. ch. 17.

De Gaulle, Charles — French president, architect of *Françafrique*. Designed the system of cooperation agreements and secret pacts that perpetuated colonial domination under the guise of independence. ch. 5, ch. 30.

Dietrich, Thomas — French investigative journalist. Author of *L'armée fantôme de Paris* (2024). Documented the residual French military presence in Benin and the 43rd BIMA's cyber school. ch. 14, ch. 20.

Diop, Abdoulaye — Mali's foreign minister. Spokesman for Malian sovereign diplomacy on the international stage. ch. 10, ch. 19, ch. 22.

Doumbouya, Mamadi — Guinea's transitional president. ch. 15, ch. 29.

Déby, Idriss — president of Chad, died April 2021. Killed in an obscure operation the day after his

re-election. His son succeeded him — a dynastic coup France supported without flinching. ch. 21.

Déby, Mahamat — Chad's transitional president. Son of the previous one, come to power through military succession — the exact type of "transition" France supports when it holds the strings. ch. 21, ch. 30.

Foccart, Jacques — the Élysée's "Mister Africa" under de Gaulle and Pompidou. The operational architect of Françafrique. Orchestrated coups, ran parallel networks, organized the elimination of inconvenient leaders. His shadow still looms over African chancelleries. ch. 5, ch. 6, ch. 13.

Gbagbo, Laurent — former president of Côte d'Ivoire. Acquitted by the ICC in 2019 of all charges after eleven years of proceedings. The only person to have resisted Operation Licorne and the French landing — and come out alive. ch. 6, ch. 14.

Goïta, Assimi — Mali's transitional president. The man of August 18, 2020. Expelled Barkhane, drove out MINUSMA, retook Kidal, built the AES. ch. 4, ch. 16, ch. 19, ch. 20, ch. 25, ch. 26, ch. 27, ch. 29.

Granvaud, Raphaël — researcher with the Survie association, author of *De l'huile sur le feu* (Lux Éditeur, 2024). Rigorously documented the legal fabrication of Operation Serval, the role of private security companies, and aid-influence mechanisms. ch. 5, ch. 13, ch. 14, ch. 15, ch. 26.

Haftar, Khalifa — Libyan officer turned opposition figure, strongman of Cyrenaica after 2014. A CIA product, recycled as a Libyan warlord after 2011. ch. 11.

Hollande, François — French president (2012–2017), initiator of Serval. Launched the Malian intervention with no clear mandate, resulting in ten years of quagmire and a total reversal of Sahelian opinion against Paris. ch. 13, ch. 15.

Iyad Ag Ghali — JNIM emir. Jihadist leader whose rise is directly tied to the 2011 Libyan destabilization and to ransoms paid by Western governments. ch. 13, ch. 20, ch. 21.

Juillet, Alain — former DGSE intelligence director. Himself diagnosed the decline of French influence in Africa — from inside the apparatus that organized it. ch. 15.

Kaboré, Roch Marc Christian — president of Burkina Faso, overthrown January 2022. Unable to protect Burkinabé populations from jihadist insecurity despite nine years in power. The people rendered their verdict. ch. 10, ch. 17, ch. 25.

Gaddafi, Muammar — Libyan leader (1969–2011). Killed October 20, 2011, sodomized with a bayonet during his capture. A man whose "crimes" were inventoried in three weeks by Washington and Paris, and whose country is still in civil war fifteen years after his death. ch. 7, ch. 11, ch. 28.

Keïta, Ibrahim Boubacar (IBK) — president of Mali, overthrown August 2020. ch. 16, ch. 25.

Keïta, Modibo — first president of independent Mali (1960–1968). Socialist, pan-Africanist, sovereignist. Overthrown by a Paris-backed coup after refusing neocolonial alignment. ch. 5, ch. 7, ch. 19, ch. 21, ch. 22.

Lecointre, François — chief of the French armed forces general staff (2017–2021), grand chancellor of the Legion of Honor. Reportedly stated, per a single source yet to be confirmed: "we do not go to war for democracy but for France's interests." ch. 15.

Le Floch-Prigent, Loïk — former CEO of Elf. Confirmed that the oil company was an armed wing of France's African policy — financing campaigns, corrupting leaders, propping up friendly regimes. ch. 6.

Lissouba, Pascal — former president of Congo-Brazzaville. Overthrown by Denis Sassou Nguesso with Elf-backed militia support in 1997. Direct witness to France's oil wars in Central Africa. ch. 6.

Lumumba, Patrice — first prime minister of the Congo, assassinated in 1961. The CIA, MI6, and the Belgian government planned and carried out his elimination. He wanted Congolese resources to serve the Congolese people. This project was unacceptable. ch. 5, ch. 9, ch. 20, ch. 21, ch. 22.

Macron, Emmanuel — president of the French Republic. Himself acknowledged the existence of a "rent-seeking logic" in Franco-African relations. Drew no political consequence from it. Supported the dynastic coup in Chad. Had Nathalie Yamb sanctioned by the EU for having "driven France out of Africa." ch. 7, ch. 10, ch. 13, ch. 14, ch. 15, ch. 17, ch. 18, ch. 20, ch. 21, ch. 30, ch. 31.

Mansa Musa — emperor of Mali in the 14th century. His fortune in gold was such that his 1324 pilgrimage to Mecca caused inflation across the entire Mediterranean basin. What Africa was before colonization is not a myth — it is history. ch. 1.

Maïga, Choguel Kokalla — former prime minister of Mali. Denounced France's abandonment of Mali from the UN podium in September 2021. A voice of rupture within the continuity of sovereignist discourse. ch. 10, ch. 12, ch. 13, ch. 16, ch. 17, ch. 20, ch. 25, ch. 26, ch. 31.

Medvedev, Dmitry — Russian official, denouncer of the CFA franc at UNESCO. ch. 11, ch. 29.

Michel, Luc — pro-Gaddafi militant, host of the European network of Libyan revolutionary committees. A committed source, to be read as such — but documented and cross-checkable on essential facts. ch. 11, ch. 15, ch. 29, ch. 30.

Mobutu Sese Seko — dictator of Zaire (1965–1997). Thirty-two years of dictatorship backed by Washington and Paris because he delivered Congolese copper, cobalt, and uranium. Textbook portrait of the "friendly dictator." ch. 6, ch. 10.

Mohamedou, Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould — professor of international relations in Geneva. Analyzed as early as 2013 the normalization of Western interventionism in the Sahel and the genealogy of Sahelian jihadism. Introduction, ch. 10, ch. 12, ch. 13, ch. 16, ch. 31.

Nkrumah, Kwame — first president of Ghana, theorist of pan-Africanism. Saw before anyone else that political independence without economic independence was mere theater. Overthrown in 1966 with the CIA's blessing while visiting Hanoi. ch. 3, ch. 5, ch. 7, ch. 11, ch. 21, ch. 22.

Nyamsi, Franklin — Franco-Cameroonian philosopher. Radical thinker on the contemporary African condition. ch. 8, ch. 24.

Olympio, Sylvanus — first president of Togo, assassinated January 13, 1963. Wanted to create a national Togolese currency. Shot the day after his decision by mercenaries led by Gnassingbé Eyadéma — who would then be backed by Paris for thirty-eight years. ch. 5, ch. 7, ch. 22, ch. 28.

Ouattara, Alassane — president of Côte d'Ivoire. Came to power in 2011 after a post-election crisis that killed over 3,000 people, with direct military backing from Operation Licorne. Announced with Macron in 2019 a "reform" of the CFA franc — a decision made without consulting the African central banks concerned. ch. 10, ch. 16, ch. 20, ch. 23.

Perkins, John — author of *Confessions of an Economic Hit Man* (2004). Described from the inside the mechanisms of deliberately indebting Global South states to keep them under control. ch. 9.

Pérouse de Montclos, Marc-Antoine — French researcher, specialist in Sahelian conflicts. ch. 15.

Pondi, Jean-Emmanuel — Cameroonian political scientist, author of *Vie et mort de Mouammar Kadhafi*. ch. 11.

Saif al-Islam Gaddafi — son of Muammar Gaddafi, head of the regime's "liberal" wing in 2011. Proposed a negotiated ceasefire on February 25, 2011 — three weeks before the military intervention. The offer was ignored. ch. 11.

Samory Touré — founder of the Wassoulou Empire, resistance fighter against colonization. Fought the French army for sixteen years in what is now Guinea, Mali, and Côte d'Ivoire. A precedent of resistance the Sahelian transitions have not forgotten. ch. 4, Conclusion.

Sankara, Thomas — president of Burkina Faso (1983–1987), figure of pan-Africanism. Repaid African debt before the OAU by explaining it was colonial. Refused instrumentalized international aid. Was assassinated October 15, 1987 with the complicity of Blaise Compaoré and Paris. Thirty-eight years later, he remains the political reference of an entire African generation. ch. 7, ch. 9, ch. 10, ch. 17, ch. 20, ch. 21, ch. 23, ch. 24, ch. 25, ch. 26, ch. 28, ch. 29, Conclusion.

Sarkozy, Nicolas — French president (2007–2012). Ordered the intervention in Libya in 2011. Launched French strikes on March 19 — three hours before the official start of hostilities, triggering a coalition crisis. Indicted in France over illegal Libyan financing of his presidential campaign. ch. 6, ch. 11, ch. 14, ch. 25.

Soro, Guillaume — former Ivorian rebel leader. Led an armed rebellion (2002–2011) that killed over 100,000 by some estimates. Lives in exile in Niger since 2019, sentenced in absentia to 20 years in prison in Côte d'Ivoire. ch. 10.

Sékou Touré, Ahmed — first president of Guinea, author of the 1958 "no." The only African leader to say no to de Gaulle to his face. Guinea paid for that boldness immediately — and paid for it for decades. ch. 5,

ch. 7, ch. 9, ch. 22, ch. 23, ch. 28, Conclusion.

Talon, Patrice — president of Benin. ch. 9, ch. 10, ch. 20.

Tiani, Abdourahamane — Niger's transitional president, head of the CNSP. Central figure of the Sahelian geopolitical shift. Expelled French forces, closed the American base at Agadez, built the AES. Introduction, ch. 5, ch. 6, ch. 7, ch. 10, ch. 12, ch. 14, ch. 16, ch. 17, ch. 18, ch. 19, ch. 20, ch. 21, ch. 25, ch. 28, ch. 29, ch. 30, Conclusion.

Touadéra, Faustin-Archange — president of the Central African Republic. First university professor to lead the CAR. Democratically elected. Diversified the country's partnerships toward Russia and Rwanda given traditional partners' inability to secure the territory. ch. 28.

Traoré, Ibrahim — Burkina Faso's transitional president. Africa's youngest head of state. Expelled French forces, renationalized resources, revived an openly Sankarist rhetoric. The reference point of an entire generation. ch. 4, ch. 9, ch. 12, ch. 13, ch. 14, ch. 17, ch. 19, ch. 23, ch. 27, ch. 30.

Turpin, Frédéric — historian, biographer of Jacques Foccart (*dans l'ombre du pouvoir*, CNRS Éditions, 2015). Documented Françafrique's secret apparatus with an academic rigor that makes denial impossible. ch. 5, ch. 6, ch. 13.

Yamb, Nathalie — pan-Africanist geopolitical analyst. First Swiss citizen sanctioned by the European Union — officially for anti-Russian sanctions, really for her work denouncing neocolonial domination in Africa. Her accounts were frozen, her income cut off, her travel blocked. She continues. ch. 5, ch. 8, ch. 9, ch. 10, ch. 13, ch. 14, ch. 16, ch. 18, ch. 21, ch. 22, ch. 23, ch. 24, ch. 25, ch. 26, ch. 29, ch. 30, ch. 31.

Younes, Abdel Fattah — Gaddafi minister who defected to the insurgents, assassinated July 2011. ch. 11.

Yusov, Andriy — spokesman for Ukrainian military intelligence. Acknowledged in August 2024 Ukrainian support to the attackers during the defeat at Tinzawaten against FAMa. ch. 20.

METHODOLOGICAL NOTES & SOURCE CORPUS

"Rigor is not the privilege of those who dominate. It is the weapon of those who resist."

This book rests on a corpus of more than 130 sources covering the period 2013–2026.

The reading principle is constant: a claim gains its value when it is corroborated by sources positioned on opposite sides of the conflict. When a pan-Africanist analysis and an institutional, academic, or judicial French source say the same thing, the fact stops being an opinion. This book calls this convergence. Where it is lacking, the claim is presented as a hypothesis, never as a certainty.

Three preliminary clarifications

On vocabulary. The word "putsch" is absent from this book. Changes of government are designated by the terms the countries concerned use themselves: "military transition," "transitional authorities," "seizure of power." This choice is not indulgence — it is a refusal to import the lexicon of only one side. Naming things with the occupier's words is already ceding the occupier the ground.

On committed sources. The pan-Africanist analysts cited here — Nathalie Yamb, Banda Kani, Franklin Nyamsi, Jonathan Batenguene, Anatole Ayissi, Dr. Yamb Ntimba, Bertrand Tatsinda, Siké Doumbé, Jules Domche, Charly Kengne, and others — are parties to the debate they describe. This status does not invalidate their statements: it frames them. The same principle applies, symmetrically, to French sources engaged in the conflict: statements from the Ministry of the Armed Forces, Élysée declarations, remarks by an ambassador such as Anne-Sophie Avé are also the words of a party. Rigor is not judged by a source's geographic origin, but by its position relative to the facts it reports.

On limitations. Some of the facts recounted here are recent — the events of 2026 in particular (the April 25 attacks, RTL's May 9 revelations, the Vésilier affair, Human Rights Watch's April report, Lafarge's conviction). They are dated and referenced, but recent history remains subject to revision: some of these pieces will be completed, nuanced, or contested. Passages resting on a single source or an uncorroborated testimony are flagged as such in the text. The reader is invited to read them for what they are: elements to be confirmed, not verdicts.

French critical and investigative sources

Raphaël Granvaud, *De l'huile sur le feu* (Lux Éditeur, 2024, Dossiers noirs / Survie collection) — Operation Sabre, the legal fabrication of Serval, the aid-influence mechanism, the role of private security companies. The reference work in French on the hidden workings of French military interventions in Africa.

Thomas Dietrich, *L'armée fantôme de Paris* (2024) — residual French presence in Benin, the 43rd BIMA's cyber school. Field documentation on the parallel networks that survive official withdrawals.

Pierre Péan, *Carnages* (Fayard, 2010) — the architecture of secret wars in the Great Lakes. A French investigative journalist who spent his career documenting what official diplomacy denied.

RTL France, George Malbruno (May 9, 2026) — ex-legionnaires and Ukrainian intelligence in operations against Mali. Confirmation by a major French mainstream outlet of what Sahelian authorities had been asserting for months.

Le Monde / Jérémie Baruch (April 10, 2018) — the Elf affair.

Le Parisien / Ronan Folgoas (May 21, 2023) — the Quignolot affair, the Élysée's Africa cell.

France Inter / Élodie Guéguen (May 26, 2023) — the Castel group, the anti-terrorism prosecutor's office.

Mediapart, Fanny Pigeaud — how the CFA franc functions. Precise analyses of monetary mechanisms that defenders of the status quo prefer to keep in the shadows.

L'Express (2024) — Mali collapse "black scenario" drafted with some forty experts; the Libya-Sahel lineage, the doctrine of "underground efforts" toward civil societies. A document that unwittingly reveals the mindset of French strategic circles.

André Bourgeot (CNRS) — "Azawad is a political fabrication." A CNRS geographer confirming what Sahelian powers assert: the Tuareg territorial claim was instrumentalized, not spontaneous.

Thomas Porcher (PSB Paris) — sharing of oil revenue in Congo.

French institutional sources (the adversary's own words)

These sources are declared adversaries in the conflict this book describes. They are cited precisely because they confirm, despite themselves, what this book asserts.

French parliamentary commission on France-Africa relations — "We need Africa more than it needs us." A parliamentary admission official diplomacy hurried to bury.

General Thierry Burkhard, chief of the armed forces general staff — closed-door testimony, National Assembly, September 2024. Acknowledged the failure of commitments in the Sahel — shielded by the secrecy of closed session.

Alain Juillet, former DGSE intelligence director — diagnosis of the decline of French influence. From inside the apparatus.

General François Lecointre, former chief of the armed forces general staff (2017–2021) — “the failure of our commitments in the Sahel”; “we do not go to war for democracy but for France’s interests” (remarks reported via a single source, to be confirmed).

Anne-Sophie Avé, former ambassador to Mali, Africa director at the Quai d’Orsay — doctrine of “cognitive dissonance.” A theory on manipulating perceptions that says everything about the mindset of French diplomacy in Africa.

Védrine Report (2013) — pan-Africanism identified as a “threat.” Hubert Védrine, former foreign minister, explicitly ranks pan-Africanism among the dangers to be contained. This is a confirmation.

André Chassaigne, deputy, National Assembly (December 2013) — the 50th French intervention, the CAR’s role.

French Court of Auditors (2020) — the cost of Operation Barkhane. Official figures on a commitment whose security record was catastrophic.

BOFiP, French tax administration (July 17, 2024) — denunciation of tax treaties by the AES states. The French fiscal technocracy documents, without commenting on it, the sovereign disengagement of Sahel countries.

Transparency note. Two quotes attributed to French leaders that circulate in public debate — the phrase attributed to Nicolas Sarkozy on “European civilization” and the one attributed to Charles de Gaulle (1966) about the Francophonie “taking over from colonization” — have no verifiable primary source to date. They are flagged as such in the body of the text and should not be presented as established.

Academic and international sources

Mohammad-Mahmoud Ould Mohamedou, “Le nouveau grand jeu des puissances occidentales au Sahel,” in Michel Galy (ed.), *La Guerre au Mali*, La Découverte, 2013 — genealogy of Sahelian jihadism, normalization of interventionism. One of the earliest and most accurate analyses of what was to come.

SWP (German Institute for International and Security Affairs), *Comment* No. 19, May 2026 (Kurtz, Lacher, Roll) — the destabilizing role of the United Arab Emirates. A Western, non-pan-Africanist source confirming Gulf powers’ involvement in African conflicts.

Frédéric Turpin, *Jacques Foccart, dans l’ombre du pouvoir* (CNRS Éditions, 2015). The reference biography of Françafrique’s operational architect — documented, rigorous, damning.

John Perkins, *Confessions of an Economic Hit Man* (2004). First-hand testimony on the mechanisms of deliberately indebting Global South states.

UNDP (Human Development Index), World Bank, ACLED (2015–2022), the French High Committee for Nuclear Transparency, UNCTAD. Quantitative data allowing measurement of the real impact of the policies denounced in this book.

Clinton/Blumenthal emails (January 18, 2013, WikiLeaks) — the Algerian agreement with Belmokhtar. Declassified US State Department documents, file F-2014-20439, published July 1, 2016.

EU Council (April 23, 2026). Global Slavery Index (2023). Africa Intelligence.

Pan-Africanist and African sources

Nathalie Yamb (Afrique Résurrection chronicles, the great Niamey debate); Dr. Yamb Ntimba (pyramid of domination); Franklin Nyamsi; Jonathan Batenguène; Anatole Ayissi (also a UN official for Central Africa); Banda Kani; Dr. Yves Ekoué Amaïzo (Afrocentricity Think Tank); Siké Doumbé; Jules Domche (Vox Africa); Charly Kengne; Paul Elvira; Dr. Douma Jean-René; Fridolin Ngoulou, Jean Ngbandi (Oubangui Médias); Ndjoni Sango.

Testimonies cited via these sources: Loïk Le Floch-Prigent, Pascal Lissouba, Mamadou Koulibaly, Robert Bourgi, Jean-Bedel Bokassa.

These voices are not peripheral sources — they are at the heart of this book. They speak from inside a reality that Parisian experts observe from afar.

Primary sources from the AES and neighboring authorities

Liptako-Gourma Charter (September 16, 2023); speeches by General Abdourahamane Tiani (RTN, February 12, 2024; November 13, 2025; Télé Sahel interview); statements by Assimi Goïta (retaking of Kidal, November 14, 2023; establishment of the Unified Force, December 21, 2025; ORTM, May 10, 2026); by Captain Ibrahim Traoré (2023; response to Macron, January 14, 2025); by Choguel Kokalla Maïga (UN, September 2021; Bamako, October 19, 2024); by Abdoulaye Maïga (UN, September 2022); by Abdoulaye Diop, Mali's foreign minister; joint statement by the three AES ministers (August 19, 2024); CNSP statement on the Agadez base (RTN, March 16, 2024); Sylvie Baipo Témon, CAR foreign minister (October 2021).

These documents are the words of the actors of change — unfiltered, not reinterpreted by chancelleries with an interest in distorting them.